

Installation Guide

This document covers everything needed to set up the toolchain and environment for Elder Wilds. The section index and project scope live in [modlist.md](#).

Pre-Installation: Steam, Skyrim, And Creation Kit

Steam & Skyrim Setup

1. Install Steam and Skyrim SE/AE outside **Program Files**, ideally under a shallow path such as `C:\Games\Skyrim Special Edition`.
2. Confirm the game is on runtime `1.6.1170`. The **Anniversary Upgrade** is not used.

Configure Steam

- **Disable the Steam Overlay:** In Steam, go to **Steam > Settings > In-Game** and uncheck "Enable the Steam overlay while in-game." Alternatively, disable it per-game: right-click **The Elder Scrolls V: Skyrim Special Edition** in your library, select **Properties**, and uncheck "Enable the Steam Overlay while in-game."
- **Update-proof Skyrim:** In Steam, right-click **The Elder Scrolls V: Skyrim Special Edition > Properties > Updates**, set **Automatic Updates** to **"Wait until I launch the game."** Updates will not trigger when launching through MO2 via SKSE. If an update slips through, use the [Skyrim downgrade patcher](#) to roll back.

Vanilla Skyrim First Launch

Launch Skyrim Special Edition through Steam to open the default launcher: click **Options**, select the **Ultra** preset, set **Aspect Ratio** and **Resolution** to your monitor's optimal values, set **Antialiasing** to **Off** (prepares for Community Shaders), ensure **Windowed Mode** is unchecked, click **OK** to save, and exit the launcher.

Install The Creation Kit

- **Skyrim Special Edition: Creation Kit** (https://store.steampowered.com/app/1946180/Skyrim_Special_Edition_Creation_Kit/): Download and install via Steam. Launch the Creation Kit through Steam to allow the **Scripts** folder to extract (automatic on first launch). Exit once loaded. Download the pre-made `CreationKitCustom.ini` and extract it to the Skyrim root folder. This configures the CK to allow multiple masters and load DLC content. If the CK crashes on first launch, add an [outbound firewall rule](#) for `CreationKit.exe`.
- **Creation Kit Platform Extended** (<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/71371>): Download **CK Platform Extended 0.6-b550** and extract directly into the main Skyrim Special Edition folder — NOT into a sub-folder.

Create Modding Folders And Install Core Tools

Create a separate modding path with sub-folders (e.g., `C:\Modding` and `C:\Modding\Tools`) and install the tools from the toolchain list below into `C:\Modding\Tools`.

FOMOD Plus Installation

Install **FOMOD Plus - A Mod Installation Overhaul for Mod Organizer 2** (<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/141001>) after MO2 setup: extract the archive contents directly into your MO2 installation folder, merging the `plugins` folder. Restart MO2 — FOMOD Plus activates automatically, adding a **FOMOD** column in the left pane and a **FOMOD** tab on the right pane.

Core Setup Goals

- Build and maintain **Elder Wilds** through **Mod Organizer 2** with clean separators and reproducible generated output
- Keep the setup aligned to Steam runtime `1.6.1170`
- Separate source mods, generated outputs, patches, and downloads clearly enough that rebuilds and troubleshooting stay manageable

Recommended Base Toolchain

- **Mod Organizer 2** as the main mod manager and profile system
- **SKSE64** and **Address Library for SKSE Plugins** as the runtime baseline
- **SSEEdit** for conflict review, patch inspection, cleaning guidance, and record-level troubleshooting
- **Wrye Bash** for later leveled-list and compatibility review where it still adds value
- **Synthesis** for selective patcher-based automation once the stack is stable enough to justify it
- **Cathedral Assets Optimizer** for asset cleanup and conversion tasks when a mod actually needs it
- **BethINI Pie** for baseline INI management and graphics/settings normalization
- **Skyrim Special Edition: Creation Kit** for resaving LE plugins to SE format; used alongside **Creation Kit Platform Extended** for stability
- **xLODGen**, **TexGen**, and **DynDOLOD** for terrain/object/tree distant detail workflow
- **BodySlide** and **Outfit Studio** for the chosen body pipeline
- **Pandora Behaviour Engine Plus** for animation behavior generation

Mod Organizer 2 Setup

- Follow STEP's standalone-folder approach: keep the game under a shallow custom path such as `C:\Games\Steam\steamapps\common\Skyrim Special Edition` and keep modding tools under a separate path such as `C:\Modding\Tools`.

- Install **Mod Organizer 2** as a standalone application under **C:\Modding\Tools\Mod Organizer** rather than inside the game folder.
- On first launch, create a **global instance**, select the **Steam Skyrim Special Edition** install, and name the instance something obvious like **Elder Wilds 1.6.1170**.
- If MO2 prompts for profile settings during instance creation, tick every box so the profile keeps its own **INI** files and game-specific settings.
- Connect MO2 to Nexus during first launch and let MO2 handle **nxm** links.
- In **Settings > Workarounds**, tick **Enable archives parsing (experimental)** so MO2 reports asset conflicts more reliably.
- Create at least one clean working profile before major category testing, and keep separators aligned to this repo's structure in **separators.md**.
- Keep generated outputs in their own enabled mods, never mixed into source mod folders.

Output Mods To Create In MO2

Before registering tools, create these empty mods in MO2 under the **Output** separator:

- **xEdit Output**
- **SKSE Scripts**
- **SKSE Output**
- **BodySlide Output**
- **Pandora Output**
- **Grass Cache Output**
- **Terrain LOD Output**
- **TexGen Output**
- **DynDOLOD Output**
- **Occlusion Output**
- **Synthesis Output**
- **Bashed Patch Output**

SKSE64 Installation

- Follow STEP's split install pattern for **SKSE64** on Steam runtime **1.6.1170**: install the two root files into the Skyrim game folder, but manage the **Data** portion through MO2 as its own mod.
- Use the current AE **1.6.1170** build of **SKSE64**, not an older AE build and not a GOG/VR variant.
- Copy **skse64_loader.exe** and the matching **skse64_1_6_1170.dll** from the archive into the Skyrim root folder next to **SkyrimSE.exe**.
- In MO2, create an empty mod named **SKSE Scripts**, then copy the archive's **Data\Scripts** folder into that mod so the script portion stays visible and manageable in the left pane.
- If an **SKSE\skse.ini** is needed later, place it inside the **SKSE Scripts** mod rather than writing directly into the game folder. Minimal modern baseline:

```
[General]
ClearInvalidRegistrations=1

[Display]
iTintTextureResolution=2048
```

- Register **skse64_loader.exe** in MO2 as the **SKSE Skyrim Launcher** executable and launch the game through that entry after the vanilla initialization step.
- Community troubleshooting on **r/skyrimmods** still clusters around the same mistakes: wrong runtime build, root files copied into the wrong folder, scripts not installed as a mod, or launching outside MO2. Guard against those explicitly.

Register Tools In MO2

- Open MO2's executable editor from the gear icon and add each tool with **Add from file...**
- Tick **Use application's icon for desktop shortcuts** for each entry so shortcuts remain readable.
- For tools that generate files, tick **Create files in mod instead of overwrite** and point them at the correct output mod.
- Arrange the executables in a stable order so the dropdown reflects the real workflow instead of becoming random over time.

MO2 Executable Reference

Tool	Executable	Arguments	Output Handling	Notes
BethINI Pie	Bethini.exe	none	none	Run through MO2 so it edits the active profile INIs instead of global game INIs.
LOOT	LOOT.exe	--game="Skyrim Special Edition"	none	If LOOT fails through MO2,

Tool	Executable	Arguments	Output Handling	Notes
				use --single-process --game="Skyrim Special Edition".
SKSE Skyrim Launcher	skse64_loader.exe	none	SKSE Output	Use this to launch the game after the root files are in the game folder and the SKSE Scripts mod is enabled.
xEdit	xEdit.exe	-SSE -IKnowWhatImDoing -AllowMasterFilesEdit	xEdit Output	Main conflict review and manual patching entry.
xEditQuickAutoClean	xEditQuickAutoClean.exe	-SSE	xEdit Output	Only use for plugins LOOT explicitly flags for cleaning.
xLODGen	xLODGenx64.exe	-lodgen -SSE -o:"DriveLetter:\Modding\Tools\xLODGen\xLODGen_Output"	Terrain LOD Output	Replace DriveLetter with the actual drive letter used for the modding folder.
TexGen	TexGen64.exe	-SSE	TexGen Output	Keep output isolated and pack it into the dedicated mod immediately after generation.
DynDOLOD	DynDOLODx64.exe	-SSE	DynDOLOD Output	Keep output isolated and enable DynDOLOD.esm / DynDOLOD.esp after generation.
Wrye Bash	Wrye Bash.exe	none	dedicated patch/output mod if used	Register only if the list still needs a Bashed Patch or leveled-list review pass.
Synthesis	Synthesis.exe	none	dedicated patch/output mod if used	Give it its own output mod once the final patcher set is known.
BodySlide	BodySlide x64.exe	none	dedicated body/output	Run through MO2 so mesh

Tool	Executable	Arguments	Output Handling	Notes
			mod	output respects the active profile and selected body stack.
Pandora	Pandora Behaviour Engine Plus.exe	none	dedicated behavior/output mod if needed	Run through MO2 so behavior generation sees the real virtualized animation stack.

MO2 Operating Rules

- Launch the game through **SKSE**, not through Steam or the stock launcher, after the vanilla initialization step is complete.
- Run **LOOT** before gameplay tests and before any major cleaning or conflict-review pass.
- Use **xEditQuickAutoClean** only for plugins LOOT explicitly marks as needing cleaning.
- Use **xEdit** after each major category to review conflicts instead of waiting until the whole list is assembled. The **Patching Technique And Strategy** section in **modlist-foundations.md** defines the workflow to follow from the first mod.
- Treat the **Overwrite** folder as a failure state; if files appear there, either move them into the proper output mod or fix the executable configuration that produced them.
- Rebuild generated outputs after major changes to bodies, animations, grass, LOD, or other systems that produce artifacts.
- Document manual fixes, custom arguments, and tool-specific decisions directly in this repository so the plan stays reproducible.

FILE: modlist.md

Elder Wilds

Target build: Skyrim Special Edition / Anniversary Edition runtime **1.6.1170** via Steam

Scope notes:

- No paid Anniversary Edition Creation Club content
- Research categories are organized around five pillars: modern graphics, expanded systems, modernized UI, immersive world scale, and third-person-first gameplay. The entire modlist is designed to be completely played in third-person with a gamepad — no interaction should require first-person or keyboard/mouse alone.
- This modlist is also built around **Legacy of the Dragonborn** as a major collection, museum, and patch-ecosystem pillar rather than treating it as an optional side add-on

Installation

The full setup and installation guide (Steam config, MO2 setup, SKSE, tool registration, operating rules) lives in **install.md**.

Research Workflow

- Work through one category at a time
- For each category, define goals, constraints, candidate mods, compatibility risks, and acceptance criteria
- Do not lock final picks until foundations, graphics baseline, animation framework, and UI framework are validated together
- Prefer mods with active maintenance, clear Steam **1.6.1170** support, strong patch ecosystem, and stable load-order behavior

Section Index

The file **separators.md** is the canonical ordered reference for **Mod Organizer 2** separators.

- **Foundations** → [Foundations and Compatibility](#)
- **Graphics** → [Graphics Pipeline](#) (parent overview)
 - **Graphics** – [PGPatcher](#) → [PGPatcher](#)
 - **Graphics** – [Community Shaders](#) → [Community Shaders](#)
 - **Graphics** – [Textures & Meshes](#) → [Textures & Meshes](#)
 - **Graphics** – [Lighting](#) → [Lighting](#)
 - **Graphics** – [Weather & Water](#) → [Weather & Water](#)
 - **Graphics** – [Terrain & Flora](#) → [Terrain & Flora](#)

- Graphics – Characters & Creatures → [Characters & Creatures](#)
- Graphics – LOD & Distant Detail → [LOD & Distant Detail](#)
- UI → [Modernized UI](#)
- Animations → [Animations and Movement](#)
- Third-Person → [Third-Person Gameplay](#)
- Expanded Systems → [Expanded Systems](#) (parent overview)
 - Expanded Systems – Character & Progression → [Character & Progression](#)
 - Expanded Systems – Magic & Perks → [Magic & Perks](#)
 - Expanded Systems – Survival & Needs → [Survival & Needs](#)
 - Expanded Systems – Crafting & Economy → [Crafting & Economy](#)
 - Expanded Systems – Followers & Reputation → [Followers & Reputation](#)
- World Feel → [Immersive Scale and World Feel](#)
- World Content → [World Content](#)
- NPCs → [NPCs](#)
- Enemies & Creatures → [Creatures and Enemies](#)
- Audio → [Audio and Feedback](#)
- Survival & Combat → [Survival, Difficulty, and Balance](#)
- Legacy of the Dragonborn → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- Testing & Curation → [Modlist Curation Rules and Testing Plan](#)
- Performance → [Performance and Technical Workflow](#) (parent overview)
 - Performance Strategy → [Performance Strategy](#)
 - Optimization & Configuration → [Optimization & Configuration](#)
 - Tool Pipeline → [Tool Pipeline](#)
 - Bashed Patch & Synthesis Configuration → [Bashed Patch & Synthesis Configuration](#)
 - Testing & Maintenance → [Testing & Maintenance](#)
- Adult Content → [Adult Content](#)
- Voicing → [Main Character Voicing](#)

FILE: modlist-foundations.md

Foundations and Compatibility

Baseline

Install all core libraries and frameworks upfront — they are non-negotiable dependencies for virtually every mod in the list. Bulk-install prevents missing-master errors and lets every subsequent section work against the real framework stack.

SKSE & Scripts → [Foundations - SKSE & Scripts](#)

- **SKSE64** — Script extender; required by almost every SKSE plugin. [Nexus](#)

Core Libraries → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)

- **Address Library for SKSE Plugins** — Universal SKSE plugin compatibility layer for 1.6.1170. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)
- **USSEP** — Foundational record patch. Requires the four free CC masters — no paid AE Upgrade needed. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)
- **SSE Engine Fixes** — Critical engine-level stability and bug fixes. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)
- **SSE Display Tweaks** — Mandatory display and frame-pacing control. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)
- **Scrambled Bugs** — Collection of low-level engine tweaks. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)
- **powerofthree's Tweaks** — SKSE plugin tweak framework used as hard dependency by many modern mods. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)
- **powerofthree's Papyrus Extender** — Extended Papyrus scripting functions. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)
- **PapyrusUtil** — Papyrus array/map utilities. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)
- **JContainers** — JSON data storage for Papyrus. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)
- **Keyword Item Distributor (KID)** — Distributes keywords to items without patching. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)
- **Spell Perk Item Distributor (SPID)** — Distributes spells/perks to NPCs dynamically. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)
- **Base Object Swapper (BOS)** — Swaps base objects via rules without direct overrides. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)
- **Crash Logger SSE AE VR** — Crash dump logging for diagnosing CTDs. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)
- **SkyPatcher** — SKSE-based vanilla record patcher; hard requirement of several NPC/AI mods. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)
- **Dual Casting Fix** — Fixes dual-casting perk application; required by Blade and Blunt. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)
- **Andrealphus' Papyrus Functions** — Extended Papyrus function library; required by Dragon War. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)
- **ConsoleUtilSSE NG** — Console command access from Papyrus; required by Dragon War and several animation behavior mods. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)
- **Kris's Papyrus Extender** — Additional Papyrus functions; required by Bathing in Skyrim. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)
- **Animation Queue Fix** — Animation-stack stability for heavy OAR/behavior loads. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)
- **Papyrus Tweaks NG** — Script-engine performance optimization; widely adopted baseline. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)
- **Lexicon SKSE** — Custom scripted function engine; required by Actor Value Generator. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)

- **Actor Value Generator** — Custom actor value creation; required by Classic Attributes. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)
- **XEMI Utility** — Custom collision primitives; required by FYX - Nordic Doors and Traps Collisions. → [Foundations - Core Libraries](#)

Mesh & Texture Fixes → [Foundations - Mesh & Texture Fixes](#)

- **Particle Patch** — Particle shader/LOD corrections, compatible with Community Shaders. → [Foundations - Mesh & Texture Fixes](#)
- **Assorted Mesh Fixes** — Corrections for common visual mesh errors. → [Foundations - Mesh & Texture Fixes](#)
- **Flickering Meshes Fix** — Resolves distant-object mesh flicker in landscape transitions. → [Foundations - Mesh & Texture Fixes](#)

Official Masters Cleanup

Clean all six-plus vanilla masters before installing any mod — they ship with ITM records and undeleted deleted references that cause spurious LOOT warnings and reproducible CTDs. Use [xEditQuickAutoClean](#) on each file individually, collect cleaned `.esm` files into a [Cleaned Vanilla Masters](#) MO2 mod, and restore originals from [xEdit Backups](#) back into `Data\`.

Which Masters To Clean

- `Skyrim.esm`, `Update.esm`, `Dawnguard.esm`, `HearthFires.esm`, `Dragonborn.esm`
- All Creation Club `.esm` files shipped with 1.6.1170 (`ccbgssse001-fish.esm`, `ccqdrsse001-survivalmode.esl`, `ccbgssse037-curios.esl`, `ccbgssse025-advdsgs.esm`, etc.)

Do not clean `_ResourcePack.esl` — it contains no ITM or UDR records.

Procedure

1. **Create output mod:** In MO2, create empty mod named [Cleaned Vanilla Masters](#) under [Output](#) separator. Leave disabled.
2. **Run LOOT:** Sort plugins, apply, close.
3. **Clean each master individually:** For each `.esm` file, select [xEditQuickAutoClean](#) from MO2 executables, check ONLY that master, click OK, wait for completion, close.
4. **Move cleaned files:** Open `Skyrim Special Edition\Data`, locate cleaned masters (recent mod date), move them into `Mod Organizer 2\mods\Cleaned Vanilla Masters\`. Keep only `.esm` files; delete `.backup/` `.bak` files.
5. **Restore originals:** Copy `.esm` files from [xEdit Backups](#) folder back into `Data\`.
6. **Enable and verify:** Enable [Cleaned Vanilla Masters](#) in MO2. Run LOOT again — no masters flagged.

Notes

- Cleaning `Update.esm` is standard despite some mod-author cautions; USSEP's records win over cleaned originals in the load order.
- Never clean a third-party mod's plugin unless LOOT explicitly flags it — many mods ship ITMs intentionally for compatibility.
- [Cleaned Vanilla Masters](#) must remain enabled for the entire playthrough.

Patching Technique And Strategy

Adopt the canonical [xEdit](#) mod-by-mod patching workflow ([Method](#) by [Elminster](#), documented by [elwaps](#)): install one mod at a time, run [xEdit](#) in `-veryquickshowconflicts` mode, resolve only the conflicts the new mod introduces, use per-pair patches and [ModGroups](#) to keep the tree clean. Reserve [Bashed Patch](#) and [Synthesis](#) for the categories they genuinely own.

Cyclic Workflow

Repeat these steps for every new mod:

1. **Install and place.** Guess a good load-order position. Heuristic: mods that make the most changes to the game world go early; narrow/local edits go late.
2. **Run xEdit with `-veryquickshowconflicts`.** Register xEdit in MO2 with `-veryquickshowconflicts` as the executable argument. Right-click the right pane → [Hide no conflict and empty rows](#).
3. **Try load order first.** Move the mod up or down if that resolves most visible conflicts; re-run xEdit.
4. **Identify bad conflicts.** A conflict matters only if the loser was supposed to win. Good example: add-on overwriting base mod values is intended. Bad example: localization overwriting region names, or a later mod silently resetting a water type.
5. **Build a per-pair patch.** Right-click the conflict winner → [Copy as override into...](#) → `<new file>.esp [Template] ESL`. Name explicitly (e.g., `LoreRim_x_RWT.esp`). Drag missing fields from the loser into the new record. Accept master addition. Run [Add Masters...](#) for every referenced mod. Save into the [Patches](#) separator.
6. **Build per-pair ModGroups.** One [ModGroup](#) per conflicting pair — never a mega-group. After xEdit closes, move `*.ModGroup` files from `MO2 overwrite` into the source mod's own MO2 folder so deactivating the mod removes its ModGroup.
7. **Re-open xEdit and confirm zero visible conflicts.** Non-empty left pane means a patch or ModGroup is missing.

Starting State

Begin from a clean load order (`Skyrim.esm`, `Update.esm`, three DLCs) plus USSEP. USSEP ships a premade ModGroup since xEdit 4.1.7 — keep it rather than rebuilding.

Cleaning Discipline

After installing a new mod and before running `-veryquickshowconflicts`, run LOOT. If it flags the mod for cleaning, run **Quick Auto Clean** then **Check For Errors**. Red errors are a signal to reconsider the mod, not to clean harder. QAC only removes ITM/UDR records; a QAC-clean mod that still misbehaves needs manual xEdit review.

Triaging xEdit Warnings

Red errors first, yellow warnings grouped by record type, blue informational notes last.

ESL-Flagged Patches

Always create patches via `<new file>.esp [Template] ESL` so they occupy the 4096 light slot and not a regular plugin slot. Never manually re-flag ESP→ESL unless the mod author or xEdit explicitly says to.

Clipping Resolution

After resolving conflicts in xEdit, walk affected cells with **More Informative Console**. Find clipping objects by RefID, copy as override into a patch, set record flag to **Initially Disabled**.

Notes

- A Bashed Patch or Synthesis output that absorbs every decision hides which mod controls a record and makes bisection impossible. Keep them scoped.
- A patch made before a target mod updates silently becomes stale. Date-stamp patches and re-run xEdit after every source-mod update.
- Patches that copy a record from a downstream plugin inherit that plugin's unresolved conflicts. Read the master chain.
- xEdit normal mode writes whatever state is currently loaded — never use it to save. Save only in fast mode.
- Orphaned `*.ModGroup` files left in **M02 overwrite** become invisible garbage. Always move them into their source mod's M02 folder.
- Promote tiny per-pair patches into themed region/feature patches when the count becomes unmanageable, but keep the merge explicit — never let Bashed Patch absorb them silently.
- Heavy Synthesis patcher chains produce files that take longer to rebuild than the modlist took to assemble. Keep patcher counts modest and name outputs by date.
- Deliberately test that disabling one upstream source mod cleanly stops its ModGroup and dependent patches from being useful instead of producing new conflicts.

ESP To ESL Conversion

Converting an ESP to an ESL-flagged ESP frees a regular plugin slot (limit 254) by moving into the 4096 light-plugin address space. Essential past ~150 plugins. Wrong conversion silently corrupts form references.

What Makes A Plugin Convertible

- **Form count:** Must contain fewer than 2048 new record forms. SSEEdit shows the count in **File Header → Record Header → HEDR → Number of Records**.
- **No new CELL/WRLD/NAVM/NAVI records** — these use form IDs as persistent workspace identifiers; compacting orphans references.
- **No QUST or DIAL overrides with hard-coded form ID references** — check **VMAD** script sections; when in doubt, do not convert.
- **Trivially convertible:** Bodyslide outputs, SKSE plugin dummy ESPs, texture-replacer ESPs with zero new records — safe to flag ESL immediately.

Automated Discovery

1. **Built-in script (first pass):** Find ESP plugins which could be turned into **ESL.pas** — ships with SSEEdit. Load full load order, right-click any plugin → **Apply Script....** Reports every plugin passing the <2048 new-records test without dealbreaker records.
2. **Fractal's ESP-ESL Finder v1.1 (Nexus)** — improved built-in script with formatting and a **NOCELLS** variant for conservative results.
3. **ESLify (Nexus)** — batch-convert **.bat** wrapper. Only use after manually verifying candidates.
4. **SSEEdit Script - Header Change to Version 1.71 (Nexus)** — updates plugins from header 1.70 to 1.71 to unlock the full 4095-record range per light plugin (1.6.1130+ engine fix). Run after adding new plugins so the load order is homogeneous.

Safe Conversion (Low Risk)

For trivially convertible plugins:

1. Right-click plugin in SSEEdit → **Compact Form IDs for ESL**.
2. Right-click → **Set Is-Esl Flag (only ESL flag — do not set ESM flag)**.
3. Save. Re-sort with LOOT in M02.

Full Conversion (SSEEdit Workflow)

For plugins that interact with other mods:

1. Load plugin + dependencies in SSEEdit. Apply **Hide no conflict and empty rows**.
2. Right-click → **Compact Form IDs for ESL**. If count is zero, skip to step 4.
3. **Check for broken references after compacting:**

- Run **Check for Errors** on the plugin (catches broken internal refs).
 - For external refs: load full load order, select converted plugin, right-click → **Referenced By** → **Apply as filter**. Check whether any records use pre-compact form IDs.
 - Script alternative: **List records referencing specific plugins.pas** (ships with SSEEdit) reports every cross-reference.
4. Right-click → **Set Is-ESL Flag** (ESL only, not ESM).
 5. Save. Re-sort with LOOT in MO2.

Red Lines

- **Never convert plugins with CELL/WRLD/NAVM/NAVI records** without verifying every cross-reference manually.
- **Never convert mid-playthrough** — existing save references to the plugin's forms are invalidated.
- **Never convert a plugin that another mod lists as a master** without verifying the dependent mod does not hard-code to-be-compact form IDs.
- **ESL-flagged plugins still count toward the 4096 light-plugin limit.** Some engine operations degrade when too many light plugins contribute records to the same scene.
- **xEdit's compaction warning** only catches direct form-ID mismatches within the loaded set, not indirect breaks through Papyrus or unloaded plugins. Read it carefully and abort if it reports issues.

Recommended Candidates

- Bodyslide outputs, texture-replacer ESPs, SKSE plugin dummies
- Single-weapon/armor/spell mods with <50 new records and no scripts/quests
- Crafting recipe-only ESPs
- Patches created during the mod-by-mod workflow (always use **[Template]** ESL)

Plugins To Never Convert

- Major quest mods (Legacy of the Dragonborn, Interesting NPCs, Vigilant)
- City/settlement overhauls with new CELL or WRLD records
- Overhauls with new dialogue branches or follower framework quest aliases
- Any plugin LOOT or SSEEdit flags as not ESL-safe

Targeted Bugfix Mods → **Foundations - Targeted Bugfixes**

Baseline

- **Fuz Ro D-oh - Silent Voice (Nexus)** — subtitle safety for unvoiced dialogue content. → **Foundations - Targeted Bugfixes**
- **Actor Limit Fix (Nexus)** — crowded scene / facial animation reliability. → **Foundations - Targeted Bugfixes**
- **Equip Enchantment Fix (Nexus)** — enchantments dropping off while equipped. → **Foundations - Targeted Bugfixes**
- **NPC AI Process Position Fix - NG (Nexus)** — NPC processing state after waiting/fast travel. → **Foundations - Targeted Bugfixes**
- **Simple Offence Suppression (Nexus)** — accidental hostility from stray hits. → **Foundations - Targeted Bugfixes**
- **Bug Fixes SSE (Nexus)** — meh321 SKSE plugin; fixes crafting-menu, perk-application, and water-behavior engine bugs not covered by SSE Engine Fixes. → **Foundations - Targeted Bugfixes**
- **Navigator - Navmesh Fixes (Nexus)** — follower pathing / NPC navigation in complex worldspaces. → **Foundations - Targeted Bugfixes**
- **Barter Limit Fix (Nexus)** — merchant gold cap overflow. → **Foundations - Targeted Bugfixes**
- **Mum's the Word NG (Nexus)** — worthless stolen-item tagging. → **Foundations - Targeted Bugfixes**
- **Regional Save Names (Nexus)** — save labeling for testing hygiene. → **Foundations - Targeted Bugfixes**
- **Better Jumping SE (Nexus)** — consistent jumping control. → **Foundations - Targeted Bugfixes**
- **LeveledList Crash Fix (Nexus)** — leveled-list crash protection for heavy content stacks. → **Foundations - Targeted Bugfixes**
- **Explosion Collision Fix (Nexus)** — prevents explosion-force spells from launching large objects into the player's camera. → **Foundations - Targeted Bugfixes**

Not Installed

- **I'm Walkin' Here NG with Pets (Nexus)** — ally/pet body-blocking fix. → **Foundations - Targeted Bugfixes**
- **Bard Instrumentals Mostly - Sing Rarely (Nexus)** — repetitive tavern singing. Not needed — other bard mods make this unnecessary. → **Audio - SFX & Ambience**

TODO

- **Alt-Tab Stuck Key Fix (Nexus)** — keyboard input bugfix for stuck modifier keys after alt-tab. → **Foundations - Targeted Bugfixes**

FILE: modlist-graphics.md

Graphics Pipeline

MO2 Separator: **Graphics**

Overview

This section owns the full graphics rendering pipeline for **Elder Wilds**: from the post-process shader framework through textures, lighting, weather, water, terrain, characters, and distant detail. Each pillar of the pipeline lives in its own sub-file.

The pipeline is designed to be evaluated in order — each stage depends on the one before it. Do not jump ahead to textures or characters before the Community Shaders framework and its addon modules are locked.

Pipeline Order

Stage	File	Category
1	Graphics - PGPatch	PGPatch — parallax/PBR mesh generation
2	Graphics - Community Shaders	Community Shaders — post-process framework and addon modules
3	Graphics - Textures & Meshes	Textures & Meshes — all surface-level asset replacement
4	Graphics - Lighting	Lighting — interior, exterior, and effect lighting
5	Graphics - Weather & Water	Weather & Water — atmospheric and liquid rendering
6	Graphics - Terrain & Flora	Terrain & Flora — ground surfaces, grass, trees
7	Graphics - Characters & Creatures	Characters & Creatures — body, skin, hair, creature textures
8	Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail	LOD & Distant Detail — far-field rendering

Key Principles

- PGPatcher runs after the texture and mesh stack is stable → Graphics - PGPatcher
- Community Shaders is the universal post-process baseline; no ENB is used → Graphics - Community Shaders
- All texture and shader choices must be evaluated for third-person readability at 4K
- Performance budgeting for the pipeline is owned by modlist-performance.md → Performance
- Visual coherence rules (no mixing low-res and high-res in the same category) are owned by modlist-curation.md → Testing & Curation

FILE: modlist-graphics-pgpatcher.md

PGPatcher

MO2 Separator: Graphics → Graphics - PGPatcher

PGPatcher Workflow → Graphics - PGPatcher

PGPatcher is a post-installation patcher that generates parallax and PBR-compatible meshes from the installed texture and mesh stack. It must run after the main texture, mesh, parallax, and PBR candidate set is mostly chosen so it works against a stable asset baseline.

Baseline

- **PGPatcher (Nexus)** — Post-installation parallax/PBR mesh generator. Keep its output in its own generated MO2 folder, separate from source mods. → Graphics - PGPatcher
- Run after installing or changing PBR texture packs, parallax-enabled textures, or major mesh/parallax support mods. → Graphics - PGPatcher
- Let the generated patch load after the source texture and mesh mods it supports. → Graphics - PGPatcher
- Re-run whenever a major landscape, architecture, ruins, or clutter texture pack is replaced. → Graphics - PGPatcher
- Only keep the generated output if it produces a visible improvement without new artifacts. → Graphics - PGPatcher
- Hard requirement for mods such as **Steel Armor Redone - PBR and Complex Material**. → Graphics - PGPatcher

Alternatives

- Skip route: rely on hand-authored parallax meshes from individual texture packs and skip the post-processing patcher entirely.

Notes

- Running PGPatcher before the texture stack is stable means regenerating the patch each time a texture mod changes.
- Generated output can conflict with hand-authored parallax meshes — always test before committing the generated patch.

FILE: modlist-graphics-shaders.md

Community Shaders

MO2 Separator: [Graphics](#) → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)

Community Shaders Core Setup → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)

This section owns the graphics-framework decision for the shader-first visual stack. The goal is to build modern visuals around [Community Shaders](#), then layer materials, lighting, weather, water, and distant detail on top of that baseline.

Baseline

- **Community Shaders (Nexus)** — Core framework. → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- Validate [SKSE64 \(Nexus\)](#), [Address Library for SKSE Plugins \(Nexus\)](#), [Luma Utility \(Nexus\)](#), and any current page-listed prerequisites before judging later graphics layers. → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- Record baseline performance before installing add-ons so later module decisions are measured against a real control point.

Alternatives

- Non-CS alternatives (ENB) are out of scope unless the project abandons the shader-first direction entirely.

Notes

- Some CS features are much heavier than the core framework itself.
- Older ecosystem pages may refer to legacy behavior or outdated version requirements.
- A shader-first stack still needs discipline; enabling every feature is not the same as building a coherent visual direction.

Community Shaders Add-Ons And Required Features → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)

This section decides how aggressive the first CS feature layer should be. It should improve shadowing, wetness, water response, and material depth without front-loading the whole performance cost of the section.

Baseline

- Use the CS main download (v1.7+) and enable core modules via FOMOD at install time. Install optional plugins separately.
- Start with the **conservative tier**: Screen Space Shadows, Grass Lighting, Water Effects, Wetness Effects.
- Promote to the **balanced tier** (add Terrain Shadows) only after trees, grass, weather, water, and LOD choices are stable enough that the extra depth is worth measuring.
- Treat **SSGI and Subsurface Scattering** (high-end tier) as optional luxury features, not a baseline requirement.
- **Embers XD (Nexus)** — The fire-and-ember category answer (140K+ endorsements). Install after the main lighting overhauls so it can inherit their campfire and hearth placements. → [Graphics - Lighting](#)
- **Skylighting** (separate download) — Sky-driven ambient occlusion. Pairs cleanly with the conservative tier. Worth including on the conservative baseline for an authentic grim-dark look. → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- **Skyrim Upscaler - DLSS FSR2 XeSS (Nexus)** — Only if real performance testing proves it is needed. → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)

Alternatives

- Core features are bundled in the CS main download (~70 MB). Enable/disable modules in the CS FOMOD.
- Optional plugins (separate downloads): [Cloud Shadows](#), [Hair Specular](#), [HDR](#), [SSGI](#), [Skylighting](#), [Terrain Helper](#), [Terrain Blending](#), [Terrain Variation](#), [Upscaling](#), [Wetness Effects](#). → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- Conservative tier: Screen Space Shadows, Grass Lighting, Water Effects, Wetness Effects.
- Balanced tier: Conservative set plus Terrain Shadows.
- High-end tier: Balanced set plus Subsurface Scattering, SSGI.

Graphics Testing Protocol

Recommended Tool Stack

- Performance capture: [PresentMon](#) → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- Analysis and graphing: [CapFrameX](#) → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- Record keeping: Markdown table in this repo first, spreadsheet only if comparison volume becomes large
- Visual comparison: fixed test saves plus matching screenshot captures

Test Scene Rules

- Use the same character save for all graphics testing.
- Use the same location, camera angle, field of view, and time of day for each comparison pass.
- Keep one indoor test cell and at least two outdoor test cells: forest and open landscape.
- Record weather state for every run.
- Add or remove only one graphics variable at a time when possible.

Suggested Metrics To Record

- Average FPS
- 1% low FPS
- Frame-time consistency notes
- VRAM pressure notes if visible from monitoring tools
- Shader artifacts, flicker, ghosting, water issues, grass mismatch, or shadow instability
- Subjective visual verdict: keep, retest, or reject

Suggested Markdown Table Format

Date	Build	Test Area	Weather/Time	Mod Change	Avg FPS	1% Low	Visual Notes	Decision
YYYY-MM-DD	Steam 1.6.1170	Falkreath Forest	Overcast / 3 PM	Added Grass Lighting	00	00	Better depth, no flicker	Keep

Notes

- Module stacks that look good in isolation can still fight later weather, water, or lighting winners.
- Measuring several shader changes at once makes later decisions impossible to trust.
- Screenshot appeal can hide long-session readability or frame-time problems.

Parallax Framework Dependencies → Graphics - Community Shaders

Auto Parallax and Complex Parallax Materials form the parallax rendering layer that bridges Community Shaders' parallax support with mesh and texture mods downstream.

Baseline

- Install **Auto Parallax** (Nexus) and **Complex Parallax Materials** (Nexus) as infrastructure before adding parallax-enabled textures or meshes. CPM hard-depends on Auto Parallax. Install only after the texture stack is mostly chosen but before PGPatcher runs. → Graphics - Community Shaders

Notes

- Without Auto Parallax, Complex Parallax Materials will not function — both must be present.
- Installing too early means regenerating parallax data after texture changes; install after the main texture stack is locked.

Physically Based Rendering (PBR) Support → Graphics - Community Shaders

PBR is an adoption strategy layered on top of Community Shaders, not a separate renderer choice. The real decision is how selectively the list should use PBR-ready materials and conversions.

Baseline

- Use the **balanced PBR option** with a broad AIO base plus targeted terrain and rock overrides.
- **Vanilla PBR AIO** (Nexus, 11.5 GB) — Primary base covering all architecture, clutter, actors, and dungeons with vanilla-faithful art direction. → Graphics - Community Shaders
- **Faultier's PBR Landscapes 4k** (Nexus, 3.0 GB) — Fills the terrain gap that VPBR leaves. → Graphics - Community Shaders
- **Enhanced Rocks and Mountains - Complex Material and PBR** (Nexus) — Modern rock/mountain overhaul. Load after VPBR so it overrides VPBR's mountain textures. Install both main files (meshes then textures, choose PBR in FOMOD). → Graphics - Community Shaders
- **Tomato's PBR Whiterun** (Nexus) — Optional specialist Whiterun override. Install 2k, skip 4k. → Graphics - Community Shaders
- **Tomato's PBR Farmhouses 2.0** (Nexus) — Optional farmhouse override. Install Grey 2K variant. → Graphics - Community Shaders
- Community Shaders ships **Dynamic Cubemaps** and **Image-Based Lighting (IBL)** as standard features. Verify that the chosen PBR texture set takes advantage of both before adding extra reflection or cubemap mods. → Graphics - Community Shaders

Alternatives

- Minimal PBR: enable support but only use a few showcase conversions.
- Full PBR push: broad world coverage with much higher maintenance and consistency risk.

Priority Coverage

Priority 1 Areas

- City architecture seen constantly in travel and third person
- Farmhouses and rural buildings
- Nordic ruins and dungeon stonework
- High-visibility clutter and props

Priority 1 Mods

- Broad coverage base: **Vanilla PBR AIO** (Nexus, 11.5 GB) — Converts all vanilla architecture, clutter, actors, statues, dungeons, and food to PBR materials. True to vanilla aesthetic with improved normals, parallax, and material response. Requires Community Shaders, SMIM, and PGPatcher. → Graphics -

Community Shaders

- Landscape terrain: **Faultier's PBR Landscapes 4k** ([Nexus](#), 3.0 GB, separate file from Faultier's AIO) — Terrain at 4k, mountains at 8k. Do NOT install **Faultier's Skyrim AIO** alongside VPBR. → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- Mountain and rock meshes: **Enhanced Rocks and Mountains - Complex Material and PBR** ([Nexus](#)) — Install both main files: **ERM - Enhanced Rocks and Mountains** (meshes) then **ERM - Textures** (choose PBR in FOMOD). Do NOT install **Blended ERM** (non-PBR). → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- Optional Whiterun override: **Tomato's PBR Whiterun v1.2.PBR** ([Nexus](#)) — Install 2k (735.5 MB), skip 4k (2.0 GB). Optional add-ons: **Improved Dragon Carvings** (beta, 2k) and **PBR Talos**. Layered over VPBR. → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- Optional farmhouse override: **Tomato's PBR Farmhouses 2.0** ([Nexus](#)) — Install **Grey - 2K** (84.2 MB), skip 4k. Optional **WSU PBR Farmhouse windows patch** if Window Shadows Ultimate is in the lighting stack. → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)

Priority 2 Areas

- Select landscape regions with a strong material identity
- City sets from settlement overhauls that survive later testing
- Broader regional packs that fill obvious gaps

Priority 2 Candidate Mods

- Landscape testing option: **A Cathedralist's PBR Landscape** ([Nexus](#)) → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- Broader landscape option: **TomatoRim PBR Landscapes AIO** ([Nexus](#)) → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- City-overhaul support: **PBR textures for The Great Cities Collection** ([Nexus](#)) → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- Discovery hub for later expansion: **PBR Hub** ([Nexus](#)) → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)

Areas To Defer For Now

- Full-world landscape replacement
- Low-visibility assets that add patching and VRAM cost without changing moment-to-moment feel much
- Niche regional conversions before the core city, dungeon, and farmhouse look is settled

Working Rollout Order

1. Install **Vanilla PBR AIO** as the broad PBR base covering architecture, clutter, actors, and dungeons. → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
2. Install **Faultier's PBR Landscapes 4k** to fill the terrain gap that VPBR leaves. → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
3. Install **Enhanced Rocks and Mountains - Complex Material and PBR** after VPBR so its rock and mountain textures override VPBR's included mountain textures. → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
4. Optionally install **Tomato's PBR Whiterun** and **Tomato's PBR Farmhouses 2.0** after VPBR where Tomato's specialist treatment improves on the base. → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
5. Run PGPatch last — all PBR texture mods above require it to render correctly in-game. → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
6. Only after the core stack passes visual and performance review, test optional landscape additions such as **A Cathedralist's PBR Landscape** or **TomatoRim PBR Landscapes AIO**. → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)

Notes

- VPBR is newer (March 2026) than Faultier's PBR Skyrim (established v3.0) — single-point-of-failure risk if abandoned. Active development so far (v1.0 → v1.32 in ~2 months).
- Faultier's PBR Landscapes 4k + ERM cover VPBR's landscape gap; Faultier's PBR Armors and Clothes covers the gear gap.
- VPBR includes mountain textures that must be overridden by ERM. Load ERM after VPBR.
- Do NOT install **Faultier's Skyrim AIO** alongside VPBR — they conflict on the same texture paths.
- PBR ambition can outrun the rest of the stack if weather, trees, water, and lighting are not held to a similar quality bar.

Candidate TODO Additions → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#), [Graphics - Lighting](#), [Graphics - Weather & Water](#), [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)

Textures, Clutter & Meshes → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)

- **Racemenu Enhancer** ([Nexus](#): <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspicealedition/mods/182536>) — character creation RaceMenu enhancer → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- **Visual Animated Enchants** — weapon enchantment VFX replacer → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- **Apophysis Dragon Priests Masks** — dragon priest mask retexture → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- **Runed Nordic Weapons** — Nordic weapon mesh/texture replacer → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- **Elven Armor replacer glow** — Elven armor retexture with glow maps → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- **Elsopa Iron weapons redone** — iron weapon retexture → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- **Ennead Banners and Shields** — banner/shield retexture → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- **Elsopa Quivers Redone** — quiver retexture → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- **Believable greatswords sheathed** — greatsword sheath mesh fix → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- **ElSopa - HD Medieval anvil** — anvil retexture → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- **Elsopa Grindstones** — grindstone retexture → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- **Renthal Workbench** — workbench retexture → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- **VFX Edit AIO - Spells Retexture** — spell visual effect retexture → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- **JFresh's Mead Stein** — mead stein retexture → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)

- SD's Horn Candles — candle retexture → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- JS Dragon Claws — dragon claw retexture → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- Skyrim remastered soul gems — soul gem retexture → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- Rally's Market Stalls — market stall retexture → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- KanJS Spell Tomes Animated — animated spell tome mesh replacer → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- Alt Markarth Forge — Markarth forge retexture → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- HD Unique Handmade signs — inn/shop sign retexture → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- Stay Arrows Stay — keeps arrows lodged in bodies and world → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- One Quiver to rule them all — quiver attachment positioning fix → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- Nordic Windhelm / Tomato's Windhelm (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/174492>) — Windhelm city retexture with PBR/Complex Material → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- Distinguished Drapery (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/173894>) — curtain/hanging fabric retexture → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- The Mists of Blackreach (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/179487>) — Blackreach mist/fog VFX → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- Better Wine Labels - Vanilla and LoTD (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/34698>, PBR Patch: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/175588>) — wine bottle label retexture with LoTD support → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- Diverse Windmill Sails - BOS (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/121759>) — windmill sail variety via Base Object Swapper → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- Diverse Foods - BOS (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/91599>) — food variety via Base Object Swapper → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- Diverse Candles - BOS (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/94369>) — candle variety via Base Object Swapper → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- Better Pelts and Hides (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/87277>) — pelt/hide retexture → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- Fluffy Hanging rabbits (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/89148>) — hanging rabbit mesh retexture → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- FrankBlack's Honey in a Jar (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/104496>) — honey jar retexture → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- slightly Better Nordic Henges - BOS (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/97162>) — Nordic henge visual upgrade via BOS → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)

Lighting → [Graphics - Lighting](#)

- KD Realistic Fireplaces — fireplace visual upgrade → [Graphics - Lighting](#)
- EmbersXD Torch Edit (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/134219>) — torch visual edit for Embers XD → [Graphics - Lighting](#)

Weather & Sky → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)

- Draco's fantasy auroras — aurora/sky visual replacer → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)
- Draco's moons — moon visual replacer → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)

Flora & Landscape → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)

- Flora Additions - Water Plants — water plant flora additions → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- Bigger trees — tree size multiplier → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- Grassreach - Blackreach Grass (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/179420>) — Blackreach grass mod → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- Freak's Floral Solstheim (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/138161>) — Solstheim flora replacer → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- Road texture options: Simplest Roads (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/111255>), Simple Complex Parallax Roads (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/173826>), Blended Roads (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/8834>) — road texture alternatives; Blended Roads already baseline candidate → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)

FILE: modlist-graphics-textures.md

Textures & Meshes

MO2 Separator: [Graphics](#) → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)

Mesh Improvements And Parallax Support → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)

Improve shape quality and silhouette readability without turning the mesh stack into an unmaintainable conflict swamp. The best outcome is a hybrid stack: stable baseline mesh improvements, targeted fixes where they matter, and parallax support only where the chosen textures actually benefit from it.

Baseline

- **Static Mesh Improvement Mod (SMIM)** ([Nexus](#)) — Core mesh foundation. → [Graphics - Community Shaders](#)
- **Unofficial Material Fix** ([Nexus](#)) — After SMIM. Corrects material records for the Community Shaders PBR pipeline (21k endorsements). → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)
- **Simplicity of Snow** v0.26 ([Nexus](#)) — Main file only (32.8 MB). Skip Parallax Meshes and patches for mods not in the list. → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)
- **FYX - Nordic Doors and Traps Collisions** ([Nexus](#)) — Collision geometry fix. Requires **XEMI Utility** ([Nexus](#)). → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)
- **Stockades of Skyrim 3D** ([Nexus](#)) + **FYX - 3D Stockades** ([Nexus](#)) — 3D stockade walls and barricades. Stockades first as base layer, FYX overwrites. → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)
- **Flame VFX Edit** ([Nexus](#)) — Mesh-only fire spell effect improvement, CS-compatible. → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)
- **Glorious Doors of Skyrim (GDOS) SE** ([Nexus](#)) — Higher-detail door meshes across all architecture types. FOMOD: choose **2K textures**, install **all door categories**, include **Splendid Mechanized Dwemer Door** (ESL). → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)
- **Security Overhaul SKSE** series — **Lock Variations** ([Nexus](#)), **Regional Locks** ([Nexus](#)), **Lock Add-ons** ([Nexus](#)), **Some More Locks** ([Nexus](#)), **Extra Locks** ([Nexus](#)), **PBR** ([Nexus](#)). Choose 2K texture options where offered — locks are examined up close and 4K is wasted VRAM. → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)
- **Snazzy Furniture and Clutter Overhaul (SFCO)** ([Nexus](#)) — Adds clutter objects, geometry, and variety beyond VPBR base textures. → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)
- **Snazzy City series** — Whiterun AIO ([Nexus](#)), Windhelm AIO ([Nexus](#)), Solitude AIO ([Nexus](#)), Markarth AIO ([Nexus](#)), Riften AIO ([Nexus](#)), Falkreath AIO ([Nexus](#)), Dawnstar AIO ([Nexus](#)), Winterhold AIO ([Nexus](#)), Towns and Settlements ([Nexus](#)), Misc Locations ([Nexus](#)), Player Homes ([Nexus](#)) — City-by-city clutter improvements via Base Object Swapper. → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)
- **Mesh replacer series** — **V.A.E.R.** ([Nexus](#)), **Thrones Expanded** ([Nexus](#)), **Rustic Repose** ([Nexus](#)), **Use Those Blankets** ([Nexus](#)), **Sleipnir Beds** ([Nexus](#)), **The Royal Seat** ([Nexus](#)), **Divide and Conquer** ([Nexus](#)), **Oddments and Miscellanea** ([Nexus](#)), **Utenlands Nordic Tents** ([Nexus](#)), **Redoran Reverie** ([Nexus](#)), **HF's Archery Target Remodel** ([Nexus](#)), **Diverse Grindstones** ([Nexus](#)), **Blary's Booksets** ([Nexus](#)), **ElSopa Misc Ruins Redone** ([Nexus](#)), **Snazzy Orc Chests** ([Nexus](#)). All mesh-only, no ESP or BOS-based. → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)

Use the PGPatch workflow in → [02a](#) for late-stage parallax generation rules.

Alternatives

- **High Poly Project** ([Nexus](#)) — Optional; only keep if the extra geometry earns its conflict cost. → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)
- **RUSTIC CLUTTER COLLECTION** ([Nexus](#)) — Higher-resolution diffuse/normal replacer for existing clutter. May be redundant with VPBR's own clutter coverage — evaluate side-by-side. → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)

Notes

- High Poly Project can add overlap and complexity for surprisingly small on-screen gains.
- Parallax can look excellent on some surfaces and broken on others if support is inconsistent.
- Snow, rock, landscape, and water meshes should not be finalized independently of the texture and water winners.

Unique Entity Replacers → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)

This subsection owns model and texture upgrades for unique named entities or one-of-a-kind objects — characters, corpses, and set-piece models not covered by broad creature, skeleton, or texture overhauls. The goal is to close visual gaps that generic replacer packs leave open, without swelling into a full NPC-beautification project.

Baseline

- **Night Mother** ([Nexus](#)) — High-quality model and texture replacer for the Night Mother's corpse. ESL-flagged, zero script or record conflicts. → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)
- **Skyking Signs** ([Nexus](#)) — Sign texture and mesh replacer with wind-sway, wood materials, no ESP. Optional companion: **Skyking Unique Signs** ([Nexus](#)). → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)
- **Skyland Imperial and Nordic Tents** ([Nexus](#)) — 4K tent texture replacer with new mesh for the large Nordic fur tent. No ESP. → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)

Notes

- Unique entity replacers are generally safe. Verify Night Mother does not conflict with any lighting or interior overhaul that modifies the sanctuary cell.
- Do not let this subsection grow into a general NPC or creature overhaul — those tracks are already owned by → [NPCs](#).

Blood, Decals, And Combat Visual Effects → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)

This subsection owns the in-world visual effects that fire when combat happens: blood pools, persistent decals, and lingering marks that make fights leave visible traces. Kept separate from lighting/weather/texture subsections because combat effects are event-driven overlays, not ambient worldstate. Also separate from hit-reaction and stagger ownership in → [modlist-third-person.md](#) and → [06](#) — the hit moment is their decision, the visual aftermath is this one's.

Baseline

- **Dynamic Bloodpool Framework** ([Nexus](#)) — Blood and decal framework. Lock in only after weather and lighting baselines are stable, because blood decals need to read correctly under both daylight and the chosen night-darkness setup. → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)

- **Dragon Breath VFX Edit (Nexus)** — Dragon-combat VFX companion. Replaces vanilla dragon breath projectile and impact effects with higher-fidelity visuals (fire, frost, shock). Mesh replacer only, no ESP. → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)

Alternatives

- **Improved Sparks (Nexus)** — Realistic orange spark effects on metal impacts and grindstones. FOMOD with spark-density options (1X-20X). → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)
- **Lightning VFX Edit (Nexus)** — Lightning bolt VFX replacer. Mesh replacer only, no ESP. → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)
- **Dynamic Footprints SKSE (Nexus)** — Persistent footprint decals on snow, mud, sand, and other ground surfaces. Add after blood/decals baseline is stable. → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)

Notes

- Blood and decal frameworks can interact poorly with Community Shaders weather mods that handle screen-space wetness and surface effects. Verify under the locked weather baseline.
- Persistent blood decals can create frame-rate or memory pressure in long combat sessions. Check MCM for decal lifetime and density settings.
- Blood pools can look out of place in snowy regions if the framework does not handle surface-specific blending.
- Keep ownership scoped to the persistent-decals-and-pool layer, not the hit-effect layer.

Book and Paper Visual Overhauls → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)

This subsection owns visual upgrades for books, notes, and paper items — the most-read world objects in the game. Texture and mesh improvements here make reading feel more tactile and library exploration more rewarding without changing any gameplay records.

Baseline

- **Book Covers Skyrim (Nexus)** — Core book-cover texture replacer. Gives every book in Skyrim a unique hand-crafted cover texture instead of the vanilla cover-swapping system. 200K+ endorsements; the definitive book-visual mod. → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)
 - **Main file:** [Book Covers Skyrim](#) (the base mod). Choose the **Main Files** download (not the USSEP Update variant).
 - **Book Covers Skyrim Enhanced Textures (Nexus)** — Higher-resolution texture upgrade for the book covers. 2K/4K options. Install after the base mod and overwrite. → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)
 - **Book Covers Skyrim - SkyPatched (Nexus)** — SkyPatcher-based forward-port that resolves conflicts with other mods editing the same book records without needing a traditional patch. Choose **Recommended Main File**. → [Graphics - Textures & Meshes](#)

Notes

- Book Covers Skyrim has a USSEP Update variant (mod 50615) that forwards USSEP changes. If USSEP is in the load order (it is, via [modlist-foundations.md](#)), use the SkyPatched variant instead — it handles USSEP forwarding + broader compatibility.
- The Enhanced Textures pack is optional but recommended for 4K displays. At 2K the base BC7 textures from the main mod are adequate.
- Verify compatibility with any mod that touches book inventory records (e.g., Unread Books Glow). The SkyPatched variant resolves most record-level conflicts.
- The base mod is large (~600 MB for 2K). Evaluate whether unique book covers earn their visual weight versus the 600 MB of VRAM and disk space.

FILE: modlist-graphics-lighting.md

Lighting

MO2 Separator: [Graphics](#) → [Graphics - Lighting](#)

Lighting Overhaul Strategy → [Graphics - Lighting](#)

Build lighting as a coherent layer that supports the shader-first visual direction, stronger world scale, and third-person readability. Interior mood matters, but so do readability, compatibility cost, and coherence with the final weather route. The baseline is a Community Shaders-native stack with much lower patch burden than the LUX family.

Baseline

- **CS Light (Nexus)** + **True Light (Nexus)** + **Window Shadows Ultimate (Nexus)** — CS-native interior and exterior lighting stack. Lower patch burden than LUX, purpose-built for Community Shaders. → [Graphics - Lighting](#)

True Light version pin: Use **v3.4.1**. v3.5.x has a known bug where ground illumination breaks on Lanterns of Skyrim II lampposts (lamps light up but ground stays dark). Do not upgrade until the fix is confirmed.

True Light FOMOD: select the **Exterior mode** option — attaches bulbs to existing exterior meshes (braziers, campfires, torches, lanterns) via Light Placer. This replaces Lux Orbis's exterior lighting role.

Also install (separate downloads): [Ambient Templates for Lighting Mods \(Nexus\)](#) — required by the CS-native stack.

- **Based Lighting Configs (Nexus)** — Community Shaders lighting configuration presets. Standardizes CS lighting tone and behavior across interiors and exteriors. → [Graphics - Lighting](#)
- **Standard Lighting Templates - SLT (Nexus)** — Standardized light template records. Replaces the template-level work that Lux, ELFX, and other lighting overhauls normally do at the per-cell level. Works as a foundation layer under CS Light + True Light. → [Graphics - Lighting](#)
- **Luminous Atronachs (Nexus)** — Adds self-illumination to flame, frost, and storm atronachs via particle lights. CS-compatible elemental creature VFX that makes atronachs read as light sources in dark environments. Layer on top of the CS-native lighting stack. → [Graphics - Lighting](#)
- **Dynamic Interior Ambient Lighting (DIAL) (Nexus)** — CS-native ambient template adjuster based on time of day and location. Plays well with any lighting overhaul. → [Graphics - Lighting](#)

Alternatives

- **Relighting Skyrim SE (Nexus) + Luminosity Lighting Overhaul (Nexus)** — Lightweight vanilla-plus approach. Lowest patch footprint. Falls back if the CS-native stack fails compatibility testing. → [Graphics - Lighting](#)
- **ELFX Shadows (Nexus)** — Strong alternate route if the CS-native stack proves insufficient for interior mood. Hard-requires base [Enhanced Lights](#) and [FX \(Nexus\)](#). → [Graphics - Lighting](#)
- **iLuminous Elementals (Nexus)** — Adds light to elemental creatures and spell effects. Alternative to Luminous Atronachs if a broader elemental-light approach is preferred. Layer on top of chosen lighting route. → [Graphics - Lighting](#)
- **Window Shadows RT - Updated (Nexus) / Ambiance (Nexus)** — Supporting/fallback interior shadow mods, not primary picks. → [Graphics - Lighting](#)

Notes

- The CS-native stack has a significantly lower patch burden than LUX — ~35-55 total patches vs LUX's ~80-120 across the Patch Hub.
- CS Light + True Light + WSU relies on Light Placer non-shadow-casting bulbs — test together before locking to verify light leaks and shadow-caster limits are acceptable.
- WSU can hit shadow-caster limits and flicker in certain interiors — monitor during playtesting.
- Very dark interiors can look impressive in screenshots and feel worse in long play sessions.
- Choosing lighting before weather is settled can produce a mismatched overall visual tone.
- True Light author is doing a major rework — monitor for a post-v3.5.x release that fixes the LoS II lamp post bug.
- SLT provides template-level standardization that reduces the need for per-cell light record patching — verify it does not conflict with CS Light's own template expectations.

FILE: modlist-graphics-weather.md

Weather & Water

MO2 Separator: [Graphics](#) → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)

Weather And Atmosphere → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)

Weather should be chosen as part of the Community Shaders presentation layer, not as an isolated plugin choice. The target is a grounded but modern visual tone that preserves forest, mountain, and travel readability in third person.

Baseline

- **NAT.CS III (Nexus)** — Primary CS-native candidate. Works on the conservative CS stack (no SSGI requirement). → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)
- **Azurite III CS (Nexus)** — Primary CS-native candidate. Requires the balanced CS add-on tier or higher (SSGI, Screen Space Shadows, Grass Lighting, Wetness Effects). → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)

Start with both NAT.CS III and Azurite III CS as candidates and test side-by-side.

Alternatives

- **Raid Weathers CS (Nexus)** — Gameplay-clarity alternate route. Requires base [RAID Weathers \(Nexus\)](#). → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)
- **Vanilla Weathers for CS (Nexus)** — Vanilla-plus CS-native option; adjusts vanilla weathers for CS tonemapping and volumetric lighting without adding new weather records. Has a True Storms patch. → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)
- **Obsidian Weathers and Seasons (Nexus) / Obsidian CS (Nexus)** — Fallback benchmarks, not main recommendations. → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)
- **Cathedral Weathers and Seasons (Nexus)** — Fallback benchmark. → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)
- **Azurite Weathers III - Enhanced (Nexus) / Skydramus CS Presets (Nexus)** — Later tuning layers, not the first decision. → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)

Notes

- A weather setup that looks stunning in screenshots can flatten gameplay readability in forests, storms, or dusk travel.
- Overly aggressive fog, contrast, or dark nights can work against third-person exploration and combat.
- Preset stacking can make the final visual chain harder to reason about if weather, CS options, and external presets all push tone differently.

Water Visuals → Graphics - Weather & Water

Treat water as a full visual stack: base water look, Community Shaders water features, mesh support, foam behavior, and waterfall presentation. The target is cold, readable, grounded water that holds up in motion during travel.

Baseline

- **Water Effects - Community Shaders (Nexus)** — Baseline shader feature layer. CS 1.5.2+ also ships a **Unified Water** module — evaluate whether it replaces the need for a standalone water base. → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)
- **A Water Made For CS in mind (Nexus)** — Primary base-water candidate for testing. → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)
- **Splashes Of Skyrim (Nexus)** — Baseline inclusion, not optional. SKSE plugin for water impact effects (arrows, spells, shouts); CS 1.4.1+ includes CS-specific FPS optimizations. → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)
- **Loki's Wade In Water (Nexus)** — Water-interaction layer for wading. Mesh and animation replacer, no ESP, compatible with all water bases and Community Shaders. → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)

Alternatives

- **Simplicity of Sea (Nexus)** + **Simplicity of Sea - Color and Transparency Tweaks (Nexus)** — Main alternate comparison. Color/transparency tweaks can also be used standalone as a lightweight adjustment. → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)
- **Realistic Water Two SE (Nexus)** — Legacy baseline, not first pick. → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)
- **Water for ENB (Nexus)** — Legacy baseline, not first pick. → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)
- **FYX - Water Mesh Optimization** — Only add if it clearly improves shorelines, water edges, or performance with chosen setup. → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)
- **Natural Waterfalls (Nexus)** — Evaluate only after main water base is selected. → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)
- **Rally's Water Foam (Nexus)** — Evaluate only after main water base is selected. → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)
- **Water Debris (Nexus)** — Optional water-surface VFX (floating debris). Evaluate after main water base is stable. → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)
- **Underwater Bubbles - SKSE Plugin (Nexus)** — Optional underwater VFX. No ESP, complements water-surface stack without touching water records. → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)

Notes

- Water can look strong in still shots and distracting in motion if foam, reflections, or wave response are overdone.
- Water tone can clash badly with the chosen weather route.
- Mesh fixes and waterfall add-ons can help one setup and hurt another.

Sky, Stars, And Auroras → Graphics - Weather & Water

This subsection owns the cosmic visual layer: night-sky stars, aurora rendering, and sky-dome enhancements. It supports the "big, awe-inspiring world" pillar directly because the vanilla night sky is one of the flattest areas in the worldspace. Kept separate from weather because sky-dome work is about clear-night rendering and long-horizon reads, not precipitation and overcast coverage.

Baseline

- **AURORA S.E. (Nexus)** — Aurora baseline. Adds proper northern-lights aurora rendering (6.4K endorsements). One of the few mods that genuinely upgrades the night vista without bloating the weather or lighting layer. → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)

Keep the discipline-first route alive if the weather mod's bundled star/sky textures already read as strong as the project's lighting setup can support. Reserve the deferred full sky-dome overhaul branch if playtesting later shows the night sky needs more investment.

Alternatives

- **Rally's Celestial Canvas (Nexus)** — Complete night-sky overhaul: auroras, galaxy, stars, and constellations with hand-drawn textures (8K galaxy, 4K stars, 1K constellations). → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)
- **Realistic Galaxy (Nexus)** — Galaxy texture replacer. → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)
- **Ultra Hi-Res Nightsky (Nexus)** — High-resolution galaxy texture using Hubble imagery, up to 16K. → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)
- **Worlds Behind Glass - Telescopic Night Sky Overhaul (Nexus)** — High-res night sky for use with telescope mods. → [Graphics - Weather & Water](#)

Notes

- Aurora mods can look out of place in non-northern settings; verify behavior in southern holds before locking.
- Sky-dome edits can fight with weather mods that also tweak the night sky. Resolve by giving the aurora mod load-order priority for night-sky changes.
- Strong auroras require a real night-darkness baseline from → [14](#); if the night is too bright, the aurora will not read.

FILE: modlist-graphics-terrain.md

Terrain & Flora

MO2 Separator: [Graphics](#) → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)

Terrain, Roads, And Snow → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)

Treat terrain, roads, and snow as one connected presentation layer instead of three isolated texture choices. This layer has to stay coherent with Community Shaders, PBR support, rock meshes, weather, and later LOD generation.

Baseline

- Use the balanced route: strong landscape and mountain materials, restrained roads, and snow chosen for coherence under CS.
- **Better Dynamic Snow SE (Nexus)** and **Better Dynamic Ash SE (Nexus)** — Snow-and-ash multistage accumulation layer. Both work with [Simplicity of Snow](#) and the chosen snow texture baseline; the [BDSPatcher](#) Synthesis patcher handles mod-added objects automatically. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)

Alternatives

- Conservative route: stable landscape base, simpler road setup, reliable snow consistency.
- Feature-rich route: more dramatic road and worldspace edits with higher patch cost.

Candidate Stack

Landscape And Terrain

- [Skyking Fantasia Landscapes \(Nexus\)](#) → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- [Atlantean Landscape - Majestic Edition \(Nexus\)](#) → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- [Atlantean Landscape - Complete - Complex Terrain Parallax \(Nexus\)](#) → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- [A Cathedralist's PBR Landscape \(Nexus\)](#) → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- [TomatoRim PBR Landscapes AIO \(Nexus\)](#) → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- [Vanaheimr - Landscapes - AIO - Complex Material - PBR \(Nexus\)](#) — Comprehensive landscape retexture with Complex Material and PBR pipeline support. Evaluate alongside Cathedralist and TomatoRim candidates. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- [Enhanced Rocks and Mountains - Complex Material and PBR \(Nexus\)](#) — Primary mountain and rock identity in place of Majestic Mountains. 3.5K endorsements, PBR/CS-native. No plugins, ships with Complex Material support. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- [Enhanced Rocks and Mountains - Fix and Addon \(Nexus\)](#) — Extends ERM coverage to underground spaces and Whiterun Skyforge. Drop the Majestic Mountains stack entirely (author inactive since June 2022, mesh misses snow coverage on rock piles). → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)

Roads

- [Blended Roads - Light Plugin \(ESL\) \(Nexus\)](#) → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- [HD Remastered Blended Roads - 8k 4k 2k 1k \(Nexus\)](#) — HD hand-made rework of Blended Roads surface textures. Choose 2K for performance, 4K for the visual sweet spot. Requires Blended Roads as base. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)

Snow And Support

- [Simplicity of Snow \(Nexus\)](#) → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- [Nordic Snow \(Nexus\)](#) → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- [Nordic Snow - Complex Material \(Nexus\)](#) → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- [Hyperborean Snow SE - 8K \(Nexus\)](#) — Comparison snow candidate, not a locked baseline. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- [Better Dynamic Snow SE \(Nexus\)](#) — Multistage snow accumulation with terrain-blended coverage. Works alongside Simplicity of Snow. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- [Better Dynamic Ash SE \(Nexus\)](#) — Same multistage logic for Solstheim's ash. Companion to Better Dynamic Snow SE. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- [Enhanced Rocks and Mountains - Complex Material and PBR \(Nexus\)](#) → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)

Notes

- Snow can look good in isolation and fail once mixed with mountains, roads, and weather-heavy scenes.
- Heavy terrain parallax can look impressive up close while adding artifact risk or visual noise in motion.

Flora Visuals → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)

Flora is the ground-level readability layer between terrain materials and later tree coverage. It should improve grass density, wildland texture, and plant variety without making traversal unreadable or turning grass support into constant patch work.

Baseline

- Use the mixed route: readable general grass coverage with selective density boosts and better close-range plants.
- **Skoglendi - A Grass Mod (Nexus)** — Baseline grass. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- **Merethic Grasslands (Nexus)** — Supporting grass variety enhancer; pairs with Skoglendi for northern grassland texture. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- **Origins Of Forest - 3D Forest Grass (Nexus)** — Main density enhancer, only if forests still feel too sparse after terrain and tree choices are clearer. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- **Mari's flora (Nexus)** — Supporting plant replacer. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- **Freak's Floral Meadows (Nexus)** — Comprehensive meadow flower replacer. No ESP. Evaluate as density upgrade. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- **Freak's Floral Solstheim (Nexus)** — Solstheim ash-covered grass/flora replacer with Cathedral-inspired density. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)

- **Flora Orientalis (Nexus)** and **Waterplants (Nexus)** — To satisfy Vinland Grass Patch dependencies and mixed-route coverage targets. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- **Cathedral - 3D Stonecrop (Nexus)** and **DrJacopo - 3D Tundra Shrubs (Nexus)** — 3D plant mesh replacers (no ESP). → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- Full Cathedral 3D series: [Cathedral - 3D Clover Plant](#), [Cathedral - 3D Deathbell](#), [Cathedral - 3D Dragons Tongue](#), [Cathedral - 3D Lavender](#), [Cathedral - 3D Thistle](#), [Cathedral - 3D Snow Berries](#) — Mesh-only (no ESP, no patch requirements). → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- **Cathedral PBR Plants (Nexus)** — PBR texture layer for the Cathedral 3D plant series. Requires original Cathedral plants and PGPatcher. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)

Alternatives

- Controlled baseline: one strong grass mod plus selective plant replacers and minimal support patches.
- Dense forest-floor route: baseline grass plus extra undergrowth and forest clutter for maximum wilderness feel.
- **Folkvangr - Grass and Landscape Overhaul (Nexus)** — Main heavier alternate. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- **Vinland Grass Patch - Skoglendi - Flora Orientalis - Folkvangr (Nexus)** and **QW's Grass Patch 2** — Only after the final grass combination is narrow enough to justify patch-hub planning. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)

Environment-Plant Optional Additions

- **Grumbledook Ivy (Nexus)** — Extensive ivy overhaul via Base Object Swapper. Hand-sculpted meshes/textures with wind animations, 1K/2K/4K. Hard-requires BOS. Requires CS compatibility consideration if using PBR variant. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- **Grumbledook Ivy - Additions (Nexus)** — Companion optimization/patch collection: removes unused vertices (halving mesh count), fixes collisions, adds seasonal support. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- **Grumbledook Swordferns - Optional PBR (Nexus)** — New meshes and textures for swordferns with optional PBR, snowy variants, extra variation via BOS. Hard-requires BOS; PBR variant requires CS. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)

Treat the Grumbledook series as visual polish, not a baseline requirement. They layer cleanly on the existing flora stack via BOS (no cell-record edits). Evaluate after main grass, 3D plant replacer, and tree choices are locked.

Notes

- Grass that looks strong in screenshots can make traversal and combat readability worse in practice.
- Layering multiple grass and plant mods creates real patch and cache maintenance cost.
- Forest-floor enhancers can become too dense once weather fog and heavy tree coverage are added.

Tree Overhauls For Dense Forests → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)

Trees are the main large-scale world-shaping layer for wilderness mood, canopy silhouette, and perceived regional scale. This subsection decides how dense and dramatic forests should become without creating a worldspace patch nightmare or making exploration unreadable.

Baseline

- Use the dense modern forest route, but keep one lower-maintenance fallback alive until LOD and traversal readability are tested.
- **Traverse the Ulvenwald - 3.3 - Trees and Forests of Skyrim (Nexus)** — Main dense-forest candidate. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- **Tomato's PBR Vanilla Trees (Nexus)** — PBR tree texture option for vanilla tree models; can be layered under whichever tree overhaul wins testing. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)

Alternatives

- **Happy Little Trees (Nexus)** — Safer fallback baseline. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- **Fabled Forests (Nexus)** and **Nature of the Wild Lands (Nexus)** — Stronger transformation routes to compare only if Ulvenwald misses the right balance. → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)
- Lower-maintenance baseline: improved tree models with lighter ecosystem burden.
- Extreme wilderness route: highly transformed forests with the highest compatibility cost.
- Support signals: [Happy Little Trees PBR \(Nexus\)](#), [Fabled Forests - Ulvenwald - Compatibility Patch \(BOS\) \(Nexus\)](#). → [Graphics - Terrain & Flora](#)

Notes

- Dense tree overhauls can make roads, structures, and combat spaces harder to read in motion than they appear in screenshots.
- Heavier worldspace tree edits create clipping, blocked sightlines, floating objects, and broad patch debt with settlement or roadside mods.
- A tree overhaul that looks excellent nearby can still fail if its distant silhouette is weak.

FILE: modlist-graphics-characters.md

Characters & Creatures

MO2 Separator: [Graphics](#) → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)

Character, Skin, And Creature Visuals → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)

This subsection covers the baseline visual treatment for player bodies, skin textures, and common creature visuals before later NPC-specific overhauls are chosen. The target is a grounded modern look that holds up in third person without drifting into overly glossy, doll-like, or hyper-stylized presentation.

Baseline

- Use the modular modern route: clear female body base, clear male body base, separate skin textures, and a restrained creature baseline.
- **CBBE** — Female body base. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Keep body bases, skin textures, and creature visuals as separate decisions.
- Treat **High Poly Head 1.4** as a supported face-mesh branch rather than a mandatory baseline.
- Delay heavy NPC beauty decisions until `modlist-npcs.md` so this layer stays focused.
- Use **Faultier's PBR Armors and Clothes** as the primary gear PBR layer. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Treat **Steel Armor Redone - PBR and Complex Material** as an optional PBR armor upgrade (requires CC Alternative Armors - Steel Soldier and PGPatcher). → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)

Alternatives

- Conservative route: body bases plus lighter skin upgrades, creature visuals kept closer to vanilla.
- High-maintenance beauty route: aggressive body, skin, and NPC beauty layering with far higher refit and compatibility cost.

Recommended Body And Skin Baselines

- Female body base: **CBBE NSFW - Caliente's Beautiful Bodies Enhancer (Nexus)** → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Female body extension and preset ecosystem: **CBBE 3BA (3BBB) (Nexus)** → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Male body base: **Highly Improved Male Body Overhaul - HIMBO (Nexus)** → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Female skin: **BnP - Female Skin (Nexus)** → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Male skin: **BnP - Male Skin (Nexus)** → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Character creation framework: **RaceMenu SE (Nexus)** → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Supported high-resolution face branch: **High Poly Head 1.4 SE** — Official Google Drive mirror: https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1V_jcYzwTiKnSv8Dbv-7Z0hh9SWbkn6Bi → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- If using High Poly Head 1.4, pair with [Expressive Facegen Morphs SE](#), [Expressive Facial Animation -Female Edition-](#), and [Expressive Facial Animation -Male Edition-](#). → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Chosen female preset: **FitnessGoal CBBE 3BA 3BBB Bodyslide Preset for Modest Players (Nexus)** → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)

Face Mesh Branch Notes

- [High Poly Head 1.4](#) still has current ecosystem support: used in at least one current Wabbajack compilation with a whitelisted Google Drive source, and current `r/skyrimmods` usage shows it remains relevant. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Treat it as a player-face and selective NPC-support branch, not as proof that the whole modlist should pivot into a full beauty-overhaul stack.
- The strongest modern alternative found was [Alternate High Poly Head](#), but that mod still depends on the original [High Poly Head 1.4](#) package rather than replacing it outright. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Because headpart mismatches, facegen conflicts, and vampire edge cases are still common, keep downstream patching expectations documented in `modlist-performance.md`. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)

BodySlide And Outfit Studio Install, Setup, And Configuration

- **BodySlide and Outfit Studio (Nexus)** → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Install as a normal mod in MO2. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Register `BodySlide x64.exe` in MO2 as an executable so all output is generated through the active profile and virtual file system. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Keep CBBE, CBBE 3BA, HIMBO, the chosen preset, and any later body-aware armor/outfit mods installed before building meshes. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Create a dedicated MO2 output mod such as [BodySlide Output](#) and direct all generated meshes there. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Keep [BodySlide Output](#) in the `Output` separator. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)

Recommended Setup Order For Elder Wilds

1. Install CBBE NSFW. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
2. Install CBBE 3BA (3BBB) after CBBE. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
3. Install HIMBO. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
4. Install BodySlide and Outfit Studio. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
5. Install FitnessGoal preset. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
6. Install OBody NG and all body-variety preset packs after body bases, before first BodySlide build. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
7. Install selected skin textures after body bases if the skin package expects a specific layout.
8. Install any armor/clothing packs needing body refits before first BodySlide build.
9. Add and enable the empty [BodySlide Output](#) mod before generating anything. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)

Recommended BodySlide Configuration

- Run BodySlide through MO2, not from the game folder directly.

- Set output path to the dedicated [BodySlide Output](#) mod location.
- For female meshes, select the [FitnessGoal CBBE 3BA 3BBB](#) preset, not the plain default CBBE shape. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- For male meshes, choose the intended HIMBO preset before batch building. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Use Batch Build once the baseline armor/clothing set is stable enough to avoid constant rebuild churn. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- If multiple body variants appear, choose the option matching the active CBBE 3BA and HIMBO ecosystems.
- Rebuild after installing or replacing major armor packs, outfit conversions, or body-shape presets.

3BA And Preset-Specific Notes

- The chosen female body path is CBBE NSFW plus CBBE 3BA plus the FitnessGoal preset. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Do not batch build female outfits against plain CBBE if the actual in-list preset requires 3BA/3BBB. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- When armor mods offer both CBBE and 3BA/3BBB options, choose the 3BA/3BBB path.
- Keep the female body stack consistent across body base, preset, and outfit conversions.

Outfit Studio Guidance

- Treat Outfit Studio as the exception tool for fixing or converting problem outfits, not as a default for every armor. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Use it when a chosen armor/clothing mod does not match the active CBBE or HIMBO setup cleanly.
- Keep edited/converted outfit output separate from the original source mod when practical.
- Document manual outfit fixes so future rebuilds do not depend on memory.

Recommended Creature Baseline

- **Bellyaches Animal and Creature Pack SSE** ([Nexus](#)) → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)

Body Variety And Distribution

Body variety distributes different BodySlide presets across NPCs so the world does not look like every female and male share the same body shape. It is a distribution layer on top of the body and BodySlide pipeline already established above.

Baseline

- **OBody NG** ([Nexus](#)) — Core distribution layer. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- **Real Body - 3BA (3BBB) CBBE Bodyslide Presets** ([Nexus](#)) — Curated semi-realistic 3BA presets designed for OBody distribution. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- **Realistic Racial Body Diversity - OBody NG Config** ([Nexus](#)) — Per-race body distribution (broader Nords, leaner Elves, heavily built Orcs). Covers both CBBE 3BA and HIMBO. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Individual presets to broaden variety: [Rugged Body - 3BA](#), [Skinny Berry - 3BA](#), [Realistic chubby and curvy body - 3BA](#). → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Male variety: **HIMBO SliderPresets Pack 02** ([Nexus](#)) — 10 presets for male body diversity. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)

Alternatives

- OBody NG is the only maintained OBody version that works with both OStim and standalone.
- Additional male presets: [The Common Guy - SerketHetyt's HIMBO Preset](#), [Greek God -- HIMBO Bodyslide Preset](#) (adult-content page; review before adding).

Notes

- OBody NG requires building all included presets in BodySlide with [Create Morphs](#) ticked — larger batch build and more generated meshes.
- Every additional preset pack increases BodySlide build time. Keep pack size intentional.
- OBody NG works with CBBE 3BA and HIMBO but may need config adjustment if other body mods are added.
- The FitnessGoal preset remains the player-character default; OBody distributes additional presets only to NPCs.

Clothing And Armor Texture Upgrades

- **Immersive Fur Garments** ([Nexus](#)) — Adds new fur garments to leveled lists. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- **Immersive Fur Garments - SPID** ([Nexus](#)) — SPID-based distribution addon replacing the original plugin. ESL-flagged. Install both base mod (meshes/textures only, delete .esp) and SPID addon. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- **Faultier's PBR Armors and Clothes** ([Nexus](#), 2.9 GB) — Complete PBR retexture of all vanilla armors, weapons, and clothes. Requires Community Shaders and PGPatcher. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- **RUSTIC CLOTHING - Special Edition** ([Nexus](#)) — Higher-res clothing textures. Test for style consistency before including. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- **Dwemer Armors and Weapons Retexture SE** ([Nexus](#)) — Gear-side companion to VPBR's Dwemer ruin textures. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- **Steel Armor Redone - PBR and Complex Material** ([Nexus](#)) — PBR retexture of the CC Steel Armor set. Requires CC Alternative Armors - Steel Soldier, Community Shaders, and PGPatcher. Optional. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)

Notes

- Body-base choices can create a large armor-refit and outfit-conversion workload later.
- Choosing a 3BA/3BBB preset increases female outfit compatibility requirements compared with plain CBBE. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Letting BodySlide output overwrite source mods makes later auditing and rebuilds much harder.
- Skin mods that look strong in screenshots can still appear too polished or glossy in actual gameplay lighting.
- High Poly Head 1.4 adds headpart and facegen complexity, especially with vampire fixes, NPC overhauls, and custom presets.
- Letting this section expand into full NPC beautification duplicates later planning work.

Hair, Eyes, And Beards → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)

This subsection owns the per-character face assets: hairstyles, eye textures, and beard options. It ensures character close-ups match the grim-dark tone without pulling in full NPC face-gen overhauls that belong in [modlist-npcs.md](#).

Baseline

- **KS Hairdos SSE (Nexus)** — Community-canonical high-quality hair pack (141K endorsements). → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- **Eyes Nouveaux (Nexus)** — Khisartin-style eye textures fitting the grim-dark tone. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- **LDD Clean Cubemap for Eyes 4K (Nexus)** — Cleaner eye cubemap textures. Stacks on top of the eye-texture baseline. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Keep the beard decision minimal; vanilla beards work well with the chosen body and face mesh stack.

Alternatives

- **The Eyes Of Beauty SSE (Nexus)** — Long-standing community-standard eye texture replacer. Alternative to Eyes Nouveaux if the visual direction prefers its established look. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Discipline-first route: rely on vanilla hair and eye textures entirely.

Notes

- High-poly hair can clash with extreme lighting and shadow setups; verify KS Hairdos works cleanly with the CS-native lighting stack and the chosen shadow mod. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Eye textures that lean too stylized look out of place; pick a realistic pack matching the grim-dark tone.
- Hair assets are common in NPC-overhaul conflicts; check for hair-distribution patches when [modlist-npcs.md](#) is active.
- Adding a beard pack without testing the beard mesh creates obvious neck clipping under most lighting.

Skeleton And Bone Replacers → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)

This subsection owns visual upgrades to in-world skeleton and bone assets: skulls, bone piles, and skeleton models in dungeons, nordic ruins, draugr crypts, and dragon priest rooms. Kept separate from the rigged skeleton baseline in [modlist-animations.md](#).

Baseline

- **Skeleton Replacer HD - SE (Nexus)** — Replaces all skeleton and human-bone models/textures with high-resolution versions (9,894 endorsements, PraedythXVI). Choose the **2K** main file — skeletons are medium-scale clutter, not hero assets, and 4K is wasted VRAM. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- **Skeleton Replacer HD - Mesh Patches for Various Mods (Nexus)** — Only if the modlist includes a creature or content mod that needs a mesh patch. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)

Alternatives

- Discipline-first route: rely on vanilla skeleton assets and skip dedicated replacer, since most skeleton models are seen briefly during dungeon traversal.

Notes

- Skeleton Replacer HD can conflict with creature mods that ship their own skeleton/bone assets. → [Graphics - Characters & Creatures](#)
- Some vanilla draugr and dragon priest models have unique assets the mod can override; verify unique visual elements are preserved.
- High-resolution bones can look out of place in a dungeon that has not received matching texture work.

FILE: modlist-graphics-lod.md

LOD & Distant Detail

MO2 Separator: [Graphics](#) → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)

LOD Generation And Distant Detail → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)

Distant detail determines whether *Elder Wilds* feels large and coherent during travel instead of collapsing into obvious pop-in and flat backgrounds. This section covers both the visual target and the practical generation workflow for terrain, trees, objects, town silhouettes, grass cache, and occlusion output.

Baseline

- Use the balanced route: strong object and tree LOD quality with targeted support mods where they materially help.
- Make [DynDOLOD](#)-based distant detail the assumed standard. → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
- Add support mods only where they visibly improve the chosen tree and texture stack instead of collecting every possible LOD add-on.
- Judge distant detail from actual travel routes, mountain overlooks, and city approaches rather than static showcase shots.

Alternatives

- Conservative route: clean functional distant detail with limited extra support layers.
- High-end route: aggressive polish with extra texture upgrades, tree-specific optimization, and stricter regeneration discipline.

Required Tools And Dependencies

Core Support Mods

- [DynDOLOD Resources SE 3](#) ([Nexus](#)) → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
- [DynDOLOD DLL NG](#) ([Nexus](#)) → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)

Optional Distant Detail Support

- [HD LODs Textures SE](#) ([Nexus](#)) → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
- [Happy Little Trees DynDOLOD Optimizations](#) ([Nexus](#)) → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)

Core Workflow Dependencies

- [No Grass In Objects](#) ([Nexus](#)) → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
- [Worldspaces with Grass SSEEdit Script for No Grass In Objects](#) ([Nexus](#)) → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
- [Grass Cache Fixes](#) ([Nexus](#)) → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
- [xLODGen Resource - SSE Terrain Tamriel](#) ([Nexus](#)) → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)

Build Order And Configuration

DynDOLOD Setup And Configuration Instructions

- Install [DynDOLOD Resources SE 3](#) and [DynDOLOD DLL NG](#) as normal mods in MO2. → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
- Install [No Grass In Objects](#), [Grass Cache Fixes](#), and [xLODGen Resource - SSE Terrain Tamriel](#) as support content where applicable. → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
- Keep TexGen, DynDOLOD, and xLODGen registered as MO2 executables, not mixed into normal mod folders. → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
- Treat the Nexus-linked xLODGen Resource as support content; the actual xLODGen tool remains part of the external tools chain. → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
- Treat occlusion as generated output, not as a separate mod pick.
- Create dedicated MO2 output mods before generation begins:
 - [Grass Cache Output](#) → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
 - [Terrain LOD Output](#) → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
 - [TexGen Output](#) → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
 - [DynDOLOD Output](#) → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
 - [Occlusion Output](#) → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
- Keep generated outputs in the [Output](#) separator. → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
- Do not generate final outputs until the main tree, terrain, snow, flora, and large worldspace visual picks are mostly stable. → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)

Run Order

1. Confirm load order and conflict resolution first.
 2. Generate grass cache through the [No Grass In Objects](#) workflow. → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
 3. Install/update [Grass Cache Output](#). → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
 4. Run xLODGen for terrain LOD once terrain and snow are stable enough. → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
 5. Install/update [Terrain LOD Output](#). → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
 6. Run TexGen. → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
 7. Install/update [TexGen Output](#). → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
 8. Run DynDOLOD. → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
 9. Install/update [DynDOLOD Output](#). → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
 10. Generate occlusion data near the end and keep it in [Occlusion Output](#). → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
- Re-run relevant generated layers whenever a major tree overhaul, large architecture change, landscape shift, grass change, or LOD-relevant texture pack is replaced.

Recommended Starting DynDOLOD Configuration

- First pass target: balanced, stability-first output rather than maximum visual range.

- Use **High** as the starting preset if the setup is already graphics-heavy; move above only after checking travel performance and distant coherence. → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
- Generate both object and tree LOD on the first real pass so forest silhouette quality can be judged early.
- Keep large-reference and ultra-aggressive options off for the first pass unless a chosen mod explicitly requires them.
- Use the first pass to answer: do distant trees match the chosen overhaul, do mountain/road/city approach views feel coherent, and is the performance cost acceptable in real travel scenes?
- If using Happy Little Trees, test baseline output first, then compare Happy Little Trees DynDOLOD Optimizations. → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
- If using heavier tree overhauls (ULvenwald, Fabled Forests, Nature of the Wild Lands), prioritize clean transitions and stable horizons before chasing longer range. → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)

Baseline Starting Profile For Elder Wilds

- Preset target: **High** → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
- Quality target: balanced object and tree LOD with stable travel performance
- First-pass goal: believable distant forests, readable city approaches, clean mountain silhouettes
- Keep optional LOD texture upgrades and tree-specific optimization mods disabled at first

Grass Cache And Occlusion Notes

- Use No Grass In Objects only after the main grass/flora direction is narrow enough that cache generation is not immediately obsolete.
- Keep Grass Cache Fixes as part of the serious grass-cache path. → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
- Use Worldspaces with Grass SSEEdit Script if the final setup needs tailored worldspace grass support. → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
- Treat grass cache as invalid whenever the winning grass combination, landscape coverage, or major worldspace edits change materially.
- Regenerate occlusion near the end of a major graphics pass, after grass, terrain LOD, and DynDOLOD inputs are stable.
- Keep occlusion output separate from all other generated mods so stale occlusion data is easy to identify and replace.

Validation

- No missing distant objects, giant billboard errors, or broken tree lines
- Near and far tree silhouettes transition cleanly during normal travel
- City approaches, mountain overlooks, and forest horizons look coherent under the selected weather and lighting route
- Generated outputs are enabled in MO2 and load after the source mods they depend on
- Old generated outputs are replaced when the visual stack changes, rather than left active by accident

Notes

- Strong near-field visuals can still look broken in motion if distant terrain and tree lines do not match them.
- Optional LOD texture and tree-optimization add-ons can create extra maintenance burden for limited payoff.
- Generating too early produces stale outputs that quietly poison later comparisons.
- Partial rebuild habits can leave mismatched terrain, tree, and occlusion outputs active at the same time.

Rebuild Rules

- Rebuild grass cache if the grass baseline changes, major flora layering changes, or worldspace edits materially affect grass placement.
- Rebuild terrain LOD if landscape, snow, mountain, or terrain-color direction changes in a way that affects distant ground presentation.
- Rebuild TexGen and DynDOLOD if tree overhauls, large architecture changes, major LOD-support mods, or visual worldspace edits change. → [Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](#)
- Refresh occlusion whenever major worldspace edits or the final distant-detail pass changes enough to affect visibility and culling behavior.
- If multiple major visual categories change together, prefer a clean full rebuild of generated outputs instead of partial guesswork.

FILE: modlist-ui.md

Modernized UI

MO2 Separator: [UI](#) → [UI - Framework & HUD](#), [UI - Inventory & Items](#), [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)

UI Framework Prerequisites → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

The base menu and interface framework that the rest of the UI stack builds on — infrastructure decisions are made here without collapsing HUD styling, inventory redesign, map replacements, or controller support into one giant UI choice.

Baseline

- **SkyUI (Nexus)** — Non-negotiable baseline for the entire UI stack. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **Oathvein UI (Nexus)** — Locked visual direction. Grim-dark presentation matches the project tone; cleaner dependency chain than Norden UI (no Extended UI requirement); general-purpose dark fantasy fits Skyrim's identity better than Vel'dun UI's focused Morrowind-inspired Dunmer theming. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

- **UIExtensions (Nexus)** — Support infrastructure for later mods, not a competing UI identity. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **Constructible Object Custom Keyword System (COCKS) (Nexus)** — Keyword-based category infrastructure for crafting-menu readability. Locked alongside framework picks. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **MCM Helper (Nexus)** — Persists MCM settings across saves and new games. Hard dependency of True Directional Movement, Compass Navigation Overhaul, and others. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **Stay At The System Page NG (Nexus)** — Keeps the System page open after loading a save so the player can continue navigating without reopening the menu. Most noticeable on gamepad. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **ImGui Icons (Nexus)** — Icon font resource for Dear ImGui-based mods. Required dependency for Dialogue History and any other ImGui-based UI mods. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

Alternatives

- **Norden UI (Nexus)** — Modern-rustic visual overhaul by the same author (Nithog), but depends on Extended UI which has no official SE port. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **Vel'dun UI (Nexus)** — Morrowind-inspired dark-elven UI by Nithog; too narrow a thematic fit for Elder Wilds. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **Prisma UI (Nexus)** — Next-gen web-UI framework that replaces SkyUI rather than extending it. Incompatible with Oathvein UI and most UIExtensions-based mods. Documented for projects pursuing the framework-replacement path. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

Notes

- Visual-theme choices get mistaken for infrastructure requirements too early.
- A highly stylized framework can look distinctive while weakening readability in ordinary play.
- TrueHUD is scoped to combat-feedback gameplay/UI boundary, not a framework decision.

HUD Overhaul → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

The main on-screen HUD layer: health, stamina, magicka, target readability, and permanent interface structure during ordinary play.

Baseline

- **SkyHUD (Nexus)** — Baseline HUD layout framework. Handles widget positioning, visibility control, and style consistency across screen sizes. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **TrueHUD (Nexus)** — Dedicated combat-feedback companion by the same author as True Directional Movement. Provides actor info bars, boss bars, player widgets, and recent-loot logging. Feature-complete (last updated December 2023). → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **Casting Bar (Nexus)** — Focused cast-and-draw timing companion for spells, shouts, and bow draw. Solves a real readability gap without becoming another full HUD framework. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **Floating Damage (Nexus)** — Optional combat-feedback overlay for damage numbers above hit targets. Useful for build-testing but potentially at odds with minimal-HUD presentation. Install only after playtesting confirms acceptable visual noise. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **QuickLoot IE - A QuickLoot EE Fork (Nexus)** — Container and corpse loot window that opens on interact rather than requiring the full inventory menu. Fork of QuickLoot EE with improved controller support, configurable placement, and better third-person readability. Essential for third-person gamepad parity — no more menu navigation for routine loot. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
 - **Main file: QuickLoot IE** (SKSE plugin). One main file; FOMOD with placement presets.
- **Oxygen Meter 2 (Nexus)** — Swimming HUD widget that displays a breath meter when underwater. SKSE plugin, configurable position and opacity. Essential for underwater exploration (Depths of Skyrim, More Underwater Treasures) where drowning awareness matters. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
 - **Main file: Oxygen Meter 2** (the base plugin).
 - **Oxygen Meter 2 - Lung Shaped (Nexus)** — Cosmetic replacer changing the breath meter to a lung-shaped icon. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
 - **Oxygen Meter 2 - Fixes and Additions (Nexus)** — Bugfixes and feature tweaks for the base mod. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **Detection Meter (Nexus)** — Stealth HUD widget. Displays a visible detection meter when sneaking, showing how close the player is to being detected. Configurable position. Pairs with Realistic AI Detection (RAID) for full stealth feedback. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
 - **Main file: Detection Meter** (the base plugin).
 - **Detection Meter - AE Support (Nexus)** — AE compatibility update for the base mod. Required for 1.6.1170. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **STB Widgets (Nexus)** — Lightweight modular widget pack for Skyrim SE/AE. Provides configurable on-screen widgets (clock, time, compass-free direction indicator, stat bars). SKSE plugin with MCM. Complements the SkyHUD + TrueHUD baseline without replacing it. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **Follower Stats (Nexus)** — MCM-based follower stat tracking. Displays combat stats, skill levels, kill counts, and attribute readouts for active followers. Pairs with Nether's Follower Framework. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **Tween Menu Overhaul (Nexus)** — Main-menu and tween-menu (loading screen) visual overhaul. Replaces the static main menu with dynamic backgrounds, improved tween-menu transitions, and cleaner layout. Complements the Oathvein UI direction. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
 - **Main file: Tween Menu Overhaul** (SWF replacer).
 - **Tween Menu Overhaul Improved (Nexus)** — Updated version with additional tween-menu scenes and improved transitions. Install instead of the original. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **RUMINATE - Frost and Snow - Main Menu Video Pack (Nexus)** — Main menu video replacer with frost-and-snow themed cinematic. Fits the grim-dark Nordic exploration tone. Chosen over Fantasy Main Menu Video Replacer (169600) for tonal consistency. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **Dynamic Location Pop-ups (Nexus)** — Location discovery notification. Displays a modern pop-up banner when discovering new locations, showing the location name on-screen. Complements the exploration and discovery pillars. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **Complete Controller Setup (Nexus)** — SKSE-based controller configuration tool. Provides button-remapping, radial-menu tuning, and third-person camera preset profiles specifically designed for gamepad play. Supports per-profile saves. Completes the third-person gamepad parity pillar by closing controller-configuration gaps the vanilla game cannot address. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

Alternatives

- **Stats Tracker Menu - STM (Nexus)** — Stats-overlay companion. Brand new (v1.0.1, May 2026) with very low community signal. Lock only after playtesting confirms no conflict with SkyHUD widget positioning or TrueHUD combat feedback. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

Notes

- Combat-feedback widgets can take over the whole HUD philosophy if not kept scoped.
- Avoid stacking too many narrow overlays until the screen feels busier instead of clearer.
- Compass density, marker philosophy, and minimal-HUD experimentation are deferred to the dedicated subsection.

Inventory And Item Card Improvements → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)

Item lists, sorting, weight/value scanning, and item-card readability during ordinary looting and inventory management.

Baseline

- **moreHUD SE (Nexus)** — Mandatory baseline. Broader item-information layer outside pure inventory lists. → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)
- **moreHUD Inventory Edition (Nexus)** — Mandatory baseline alongside moreHUD SE. Extends readability into inventory views used constantly during normal play. → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)
- **Inventory Interface Information Injector (Nexus)** — Lightweight SKSE plugin by M8r98a4f2 (same author as moreHUD). Adds value, weight, and stat-per-weight columns to inventory views without touching SkyUI layout or making invalidation calls. → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)
- **I4 Weapon Icons Overhaul (Nexus)** — Replaces all weapon category icons with hand-crafted icons by komegaki. Covers 30+ categories including mod-added types. Depends on Inventory Interface Information Injector. → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)
- **I4 Armor Icons Overhaul (Nexus)** — Replaces armor icons with higher-fidelity hand-crafted icons by komegaki. Covers light armor, heavy armor, clothing, shields, and jewelry. → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)
- **I4 Shout Icons Overhaul (Nexus)** — Replaces shout and dragon language icon textures with higher-fidelity versions by komegaki. → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)
- **The Handy Icon Collection Collective (THICC) (Nexus)** — Large-scale icon resource with thousands of high-fidelity icons. Optional icon variety on top of the I4 family — zero plugin overhead, purely additive. → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)
- **Favorites Menu Effects Description (Nexus)** — Adds effect descriptions to items in the favorites/quick-access menu. Shows potion effects, enchantment summaries, and spell descriptions without opening the full inventory. SKSE plugin, no ESP. Essential for gamepad play where tooltip inspection is slower. → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)
- **B.O.O.B.I.E.S (aka Immersive Icons) (Nexus)** — Icon overhaul for SkyUI. Replaces vanilla item icons with higher-quality, more distinctive icons for weapons, armor, potions, ingredients, scrolls, and miscellaneous items. 28K+ endorsements, actively maintained. → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)
 - **Main file: B.O.O.B.I.E.S** (the base mod). Use the FOMOD installer to select resolution (2K recommended) and coverage.
 - **B.O.O.B.I.E.S (aka Immersive Icons) - POTIONS (Nexus)** — Dedicated potion bottle icon add-on with distinctive shapes and colors matching the potion effect. Install after the base mod. → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)
- **Phenomenally Enriched and Nuanced Ingredients for SkyUI (P.E.N.I.S. for B.O.O.B.I.E.S.) (Nexus)** — Ingredient icon pack for B.O.O.B.I.E.S. Replaces all ingredient icons with hand-crafted variants matching the B.O.O.B.I.E.S style. → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)
- **Aura's Scrumptious Supplement (A.S.S. for B.O.O.B.I.E.S.) (Nexus)** — Food and drink icon add-on for B.O.O.B.I.E.S. Replaces food, drink, and cooking-ingredient icons to match the B.O.O.B.I.E.S style. → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)
- **Rotols More Icons (Nexus)** — Additional icon coverage for items B.O.O.B.I.E.S does not cover: quest items, DLC-specific gear, and mod-added equipment. Designed as a companion to B.O.O.B.I.E.S. → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)

Alternatives

- **SkyUI Item Card Fixes (Nexus)** — Cleaner, narrower comparison if the main pain point is item-card presentation rather than more information. → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)
- **Aura's Inventory Tweaks (Nexus)** — Organizational comparison if the final UI direction needs stronger sorting and icon structure. → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)
- **Weapon Stat Viewer V2 (Nexus)** — Weapon-stat overlay companion. Surfaces weapon damage numbers in real time for comparing without opening menus. Lock only if SkyUI + Oathvein UI renders it cleanly. → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)
- **Enchanted Icon Overhaul (Nexus)** — Adds distinct icons for learned, artifact, and learnable enchantments. Depends on Dynamic Inventory Icon Injector. Evaluate after core inventory stack is stable. → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)

Notes

- Inventory readability can be over-solved by stacking too many overlapping micro-fixes; more information can slow scanning instead of speeding it up.
- Weapon Stat Viewer V2 (447 endorsements) is relatively new — verify it does not conflict with the chosen UI framework before treating it as locked.
- Dynamic Inventory Icon Injector (Nexus) is the mandatory utility dependency if Enchanted Icon Overhaul is selected.

Map Improvements → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)

World-map framework and the map art layered on top of it — deliberate travel planning and geographic readability.

Baseline

- **Flat World Map Framework (FWMF) (Nexus)** — Non-negotiable foundation for the map direction. → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)
- **Local Map Upgrade (Nexus)** — Local-map companion for interior and close-range navigation. → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)
- **Skyrim and Solstheim Paper Maps by Mirhayasu for FWMF (Nexus)** — Strongest first-pass paper-map art. Looks purposeful without making the map harder to read. → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)

Alternatives

- **Immersive Paper Map (3rd Edition) (Nexus)** — Moodier, more stylized paper-map comparison. → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)
- **Skyrim Paper Map by FreelanceCartography for FWMF (Nexus)** — More explicitly cartographic comparison. → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)
- **Legendary Map (Nexus)** — High-fidelity hand-painted world-map replacer. Replaces the vanilla world-map texture with a richly detailed painted map. Compatible with FWMF. → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)
- **HD Local Map (Nexus)** — Higher-resolution local map textures for interior and exterior cells. Improves local-map readability over vanilla at 4K. Complements Local Map Upgrade. → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)

Notes

- Easy to choose map art for style while losing navigational readability.
- FWMF is the framework; the key question is which world-map art sits on top of it.
- Local-map improvements and world-map overhaul solve different problems — keep them distinct.

Magic And Journal Improvements → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)

Reading comfort, text-heavy menu flow, and spell-adjacent menu usability outside the world map.

Baseline

- **Convenient Reading UI - SE (Nexus)** — Start here. Improves the reading-comfort part most likely to be felt in normal play without overcommitting to speculative spell-menu surgery. → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)
- **Wider MCM Menu for SkyUI (Nexus)** — Practical support fix if the expanding UI and gameplay stack makes configuration menus feel cramped. → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)
- **Modern Wait Menu (Nexus)** — Replaces the vanilla wait-menu slider with a modern clock-face interface showing time-of-day, hour selection, and weather preview. SKSE plugin, no ESP. Gamepad-friendly radial selection makes it a strong fit for the third-person parity pillar. → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)
- **Completionist - Skyrim Completion Tracker (NG) (Nexus)** — MCM-based quest, item, location, book, and shout completion tracker. Automatically tracks discovered vs. undiscovered content across Skyrim, DLC, and mod-added content via its patcher framework. 6K+ endorsements, actively maintained (v5.0.0.3, April 2026). → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)
 - **Main file:** [Completionist](#) (the base mod). Install the main file and run the Automated GUI Patcher.
 - **Completionist Addons (Nexus)** — Adds tracking support for popular mod-added content. Install after the base mod. → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)

Notes

- MCM support fixes can be mistaken for broader journal or spell-menu design answers.
- Revisit spell-menu-specific improvements only if playtesting reveals a clear unresolved pain point.

Dialogue UI Improvements → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)

Conversation readability, response selection clarity, and the overall feel of moment-to-moment dialogue interaction.

Baseline

- **Better Dialogue Controls (Nexus)** — Strongest first-pass pick. Addresses the most fundamental dialogue friction without forcing a large stylistic commitment. → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)
- **Better MessageBox Controls (Nexus)** — Natural companion if the same interaction awkwardness shows up in message boxes. → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)
- **Dialogue History (Nexus)** — Dialogue readability companion. Adds a scrollable history log of past dialogue lines, accessible via configurable keybind. Essential for gamepad play where dialogue can advance faster than comfortable reading. → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)

Alternatives

- **Dialogue Interface ReShaped (Nexus)** — Presentation-forward route if testing shows visual dialogue flow is the bigger problem. → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)
- **Convenient Dialogue UI - SE (Nexus)** — Cleaner dialogue presentation route, same conditions as above. → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)
- **Smart Talk (Dialogue Menu Enhancer) (Nexus)** — Dialogue UI enhancer. Highlights quest-related options, reorders dialogue choices, adds natural pauses, and supports gamepad-friendly skip. SKSE plugin, no ESP. Complements Better Dialogue Controls by improving the content and flow of dialogue rather than just its input handling. 5.5K endorsements. → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)
 - **Main file:** [Smart Talk](#) (SKSE plugin + optional MCM plugin). One main file.

Baseline Additions (From TODO)

- **Improved Alternate Conversation Camera (Nexus)** — Dialogue camera baseline. Improves the third-person conversation camera with better framing, zoom, and letterbox support. v1.2.0, SKSE plugin, 12 files available. Test for Community Shaders letterbox conflict — the mod's own letterbox settings require a game restart on change and may overlap with Community Shaders cinematic effects. → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)

Notes

- Subtitle safety and unvoiced-dialogue handling belong in [modlist-foundations.md](#) (Targeted Bugfix Mods) with [Fuz Ro D-oh - Silent Voice](#).
- Visual novelty can be mistaken for actual dialogue usability.

- IACC's letterbox feature and Community Shaders potential overlap should be verified during playtesting before locking. If conflict emerges, run IACC without the letterbox setting or disable Community Shaders' cinematic letterbox.

Controller-Friendly UI Support → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

How comfortable the UI stack feels on a gamepad once the base framework, HUD, inventory, map, journal, and dialogue layers are in place.

Baseline

- **Skyrim SE Controller Interface Fix** ([Nexus](#)) — Strongest first-pass baseline. Improves controller friendliness without forcing the stack to reorganize around a larger system. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **Show Player In Menus** ([Nexus](#)) — Locked third-person-UI companion. Renders the player character in inventory, magic, and crafting menus for real-time gear change previews. Essential for the full third-person gamepad parity pillar. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

Alternatives

- **Gamepad Plus Plus** ([Nexus](#)) — Broader comparison if testing shows the list needs a more assertive controller-input answer. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **Wheeler - Quick Action Wheel Of Skyrim** ([Nexus](#)) — Deliberate quick-access branch if controller play benefits from a radial interaction layer. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
 - **WHEELER - Refined** ([Nexus](#)) — UI polish and preset pack for Wheeler. Updated visuals, better controller support, and optimized preset layouts. Install on top of the base mod. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

Notes

- Dialogue readability, inventory clarity, and map/journal ownership are owned by their own subsections; this section answers controller comfort across those layers, not replacing their decisions.
- Controller awkwardness can be over-solved by stacking too many overlapping input layers.

UI Scaling For Ultrawide And High Resolution → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

How well the chosen UI stack holds up on large modern displays — 16:9 4K HDR is the actual baseline target, with ultrawide as secondary.

Baseline

- **Sovngarde - Mist's Font Replacer** ([Nexus](#)) — Stronger first-pass candidate. Directly addresses large-display text readability without pretending the main problem is ultrawide support. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

Alternatives

- **Complete Widescreen Fix for Vanilla and SkyUI** ([Nexus](#)) — Secondary compatibility branch if the list later needs ultrawide layouts. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

Notes

- Ultrawide support can be treated as the default problem when the actual baseline display is 16:9 4K.
- Font or scaling adjustments can fight the chosen Oathvein UI tone if not judged in context.
- Keep the chosen Oathvein UI direction, SkyHUD, inventory improvements, and dialogue/map changes restrained enough that the UI remains readable at 4K without immediately stacking scaling fixes.

Compass, Markers, And Minimal HUD Options → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

How much navigational information stays on screen during ordinary play: compass behavior, marker density, and whether the HUD fades away unless needed.

Baseline

- **Compass Navigation Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Strongest first-pass baseline. Answers the actual navigational layer directly instead of jumping to a hide-the-HUD philosophy. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **CoMAP - Common Marker Addon Project** ([Nexus](#)) — Natural marker-side companion for cleaner marker consistency across the FWMF paper-map ecosystem. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

Alternatives

- **Immersive HUD - iHUD Special Edition** ([Nexus](#)) — Deliberate minimal-HUD branch. Only add if testing shows reduced on-screen persistence materially improves exploration tone. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **MiniMap** ([Nexus](#)) — Very optional. Minimaps reduce the need to read the environment (at odds with the grim-dark exploration pillar); low endorsement count (7,761), last updated May 2021, with occasional crash reports on 1.6.1170. Test before locking. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

Notes

- Minimalism itself can be mistaken for better usability.
- Stacking a minimap alongside Compass Navigation Overhaul creates redundant navigation information on screen.
- Existing ownership boundaries with SkyHUD (HUD layout), FWMF (map), and TrueHUD (gameplay feedback layer) remain intact.

Crafting Menu Improvements → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)

The UI side of crafting: category clarity, menu scan speed, recipe browsing, and whether crafting stations feel readable and organized during normal use.

Baseline

- **Constructible Object Custom Keyword System** ([Nexus](#)) — Strongest first-pass baseline. Directly improves the Constructible Object Menu and is built to support a broader modded crafting ecosystem. → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)

Alternatives

- **SkyUI - Vanilla Crafting menu** ([Nexus](#)) — Meaningful fallback only if the project prefers vanilla-style split categories and is not using a heavier recipe footprint that benefits from stronger category handling. → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)

Notes

- Keep this subsection focused on menu structure and readability; crafting balance, enchanting rules, and NPC-crafting philosophy belong in [modlist-expanded-systems.md](#).
- A vanilla-style fallback can pair poorly with a large recipe footprint.

Loading Screens → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)

What players see during area transitions — purely cosmetic, no scripts or worldspace edits.

Baseline

- **The Elder Scrolls Legends - Loading Screens** ([Nexus](#)) — Locked baseline. 110 high-quality lore-friendly artworks from TES: Legends. Purely asset-based with zero compatibility concerns — no vanilla records touched. Install at 100% frequency in 16:9 with Fixed Height border setting. → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)

Notes

- At 100% frequency, vanilla lore loading tips are suppressed. The text variant includes lore-friendly descriptions alongside the art.
- Some Legends artworks are wider than 16:9; the Fixed Height border setting crops sides but no critical content is lost.
- The text-free variant removes Legends card-game UI text for players who want only the artwork.

Accessibility And Readability Improvements → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

Final pass on general UI legibility and comfort: readable text, sane menu density, configuration clarity, and ease of use over long sessions.

Baseline

- **Sovngarde - Mist's Font Replacer** ([Nexus](#)) — Strongest first-pass accessibility candidate for the 16:9 4K HDR target. Prefer Bold V8.9 first, fall back to the light variant only if bold feels too heavy in the Oathvein UI direction. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **Wider MCM Menu for SkyUI** ([Nexus](#)) — Narrower support answer when the main friction lives in configuration readability rather than ordinary in-game interface. → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

Notes

- Start with the discipline-first route (current SkyUI + Oathvein UI stack) and apply targeted readability support only where playtesting shows a real weakness.
- A final accessibility pass should not relitigate decisions earlier UI subsections already settled.
- Subtitle safety and unvoiced-dialogue handling stay in [modlist-foundations.md](#) (Targeted Bugfix Mods) with Fuz Ro D-oh - Silent Voice.

Optional HUD → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

Experimental or unproven UI mods tracked for potential inclusion if playtesting validates them.

Baseline

- **Skyrim Party Sheet - Follower and Player HUD** ([Nexus](#)) — Persistent HUD overlay for player attributes and active follower info. Active development (v2.7, updated June 2026) with 1,084 endorsements. Keep as "very optional — research before installing." → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

Notes

- Do not include in the locked modlist until playtesting confirms no conflict with TrueHUD widget positioning, Oathvein UI visual styling, or Nether's Follower Framework.
- Overlapping HUD widgets can create visual conflicts with TrueHUD, SkyHUD, and Floating Damage.
- If accepted later, place in HUD Overhaul subsection as a companion to TrueHUD for follower-status visibility.

Candidate TODO Additions

Framework & System UI → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

- **Character Menu SE** — character appearance menu enhancer → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

- **Kill feed (Nexus)** — enemy kill notification feed → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **SKSE Menu Framework (Nexus)** — menu framework SKSE plugin → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)
- **Auto Input Switch (Nexus)** — auto-detect controller vs KB+M input → [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

Inventory → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)

- NOTE: MoreHUD covers this? **Unread books glow redone (Nexus)** — unread book visual highlight → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)
- **Show Player In Inventory (Nexus)** — player model in inventory menu → [UI - Inventory & Items](#)

HUD, Map & Dialogue → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)

- **Pastel Map Markers (?)** — optional map marker recolor → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)
- **Smart Talk (Dialogue Menu Enhancer) (Nexus)** — dialogue menu categorization → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)
- **Quest Journal Overhaul (Nexus)** — quest journal visual overhaul → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)
- **Even Better Quest Objectives SE - EBQO SE (Nexus)** — quest objective clarity → [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)

FILE: modlist-animations.md

Animations and Movement

MO2 Separators: [Animations - Framework](#), [Animations - Movement & Idles](#), [Animations - Combat](#), [Animations - Interactions & Traversal](#), [Animations - Creatures](#)

Pandora Framework And Prerequisites → [Animations - Framework](#)

Baseline

- **Pandora Behaviour Engine Plus (Nexus)** — Single behavior-generation owner. Register as dedicated MO2 executable; keep generated output in a separate mod (e.g., [Pandora Output](#)). → [Animations - Framework](#)
- **Universal Behaviour Runtime - Auto Skeleton Patch (Nexus)** — Runtime skeleton patching for XPMSE. Do NOT tick the Pandora XPMSE patch checkbox; the runtime patch is more stable. → [Animations - Framework](#)
- **A-Pose Bug Fix - Universal Behavior Runtime (Nexus)** — Runtime A-pose interception and LE animation backward compatibility via JIT HKX conversion. Protects against animation-loading edge cases. → [Animations - Framework](#)

Notes

- Validate the current Pandora install guide and requirements tab during setup.
- Skipping [Auto Skeleton Patch](#) with XPMSE causes skeleton blending issues (casting, blocking, bow, freezing, CTDs).
- Leaving old generated output active or mixing generators makes debugging much harder.
- Validate generator baseline before adding large locomotion, combat, or creature packs.

Skeleton And Behavior Prerequisites → [Animations - Framework](#)

Baseline

- **XP32 Maximum Skeleton Special Extended - XPMSE (Nexus)** — Single skeleton baseline. → [Animations - Framework](#)
- **CBPC - Physics with Collisions (Nexus)** — Default first-pass physics for CBBE 3BA. → [Animations - Framework](#)
- **FSMP - Faster HDT-SMP (Nexus)** — SMP coverage alongside CBPC. Running both layers is standard for 3BA: CBPC handles broad collision, SMP handles finer mesh deformation. Required by OStim and some outfits/creature features. → [Animations - Framework](#)

Alternatives

- **XPMSE Fixed Scripts (Nexus)** — Companion script fix applied over XPMSE. → [Animations - Framework](#)
- **ConsoleUtilSSE NG (Nexus)** — Keep available for script-dependent ecosystem pieces that still expect it. → [Animations - Framework](#)

Notes

- Body, outfit, and animation mods can appear clean while disagreeing on skeleton assumptions underneath.
- Locking into SMP-first too early adds performance cost before the payoff is proven.

Parkour, Climbing, And Free-Form Movement → [Animations - Interactions & Traversal](#)

Baseline

- **SkyParkour v3 - Procedural Parkour and Climbing Framework (SPPF) (Nexus)** — Procedural parkour and climbing: vault, climb, traverse environmental geometry. Most-endorsed parkour framework on Nexus (10,112 endorsements, v3.5.4). → [Animations - Interactions & Traversal](#)

Alternatives

- **SkyClimb (Nexus)** — Climbing-first alternative built around EVG Animated Traversal. Narrower scope, but not cumulative with SkyParkour — pick one. → [Animations - Interactions & Traversal](#)
- **Discipline-first route** — Rely on vanilla climbing + TDM + sprint/jump only, no dedicated parkour framework.
- **Deferred high-commitment branch** — Adopt parkour only after the movement and animation stack is stable.

Companion Candidates (evaluate after baseline is locked)

- **Beam Walking Assist (Nexus)** — Balance assist for narrow beams/ledges. Add only if real traversal testing shows beam-walking is annoying. → [Animations - Interactions & Traversal](#)
- **RaySense - Jumping over obstacles (Nexus)** — Contextual jump-over triggered by obstacle height. Complementary to SkyParkour, not competing. Limited community track record (901 endorsements). → [Animations - Interactions & Traversal](#)
- **RaySense - Edge Lookdown (Nexus)** — Look-down animation at cliff edges. Add only if edge-drop moments are a noticeable part of travel. → [Animations - Interactions & Traversal](#)
- **Inertia - Physical Movement Response System (Nexus)** — Body lean, momentum, weight for third-person movement. Evaluate after core movement baseline is locked. → [Animations - Interactions & Traversal](#)

Notes

- SkyClimb and SkyParkour are competing traversal owners, not harmless companions.
- Parkour can expose navmesh gaps in older worldspace content — test against locked worldspace picks.
- Tune MCM to match survival/travel pacing so parkour doesn't trivialize early exploration.
- This subsection owns vertical/lateral movement; dodge, sprint, and camera belong in [modlist-third-person.md](#).

Locomotion → [Animations - Movement & Idles](#)

Baseline

- **Leviathan Animations II - Male Idle Walk And Run (Nexus)** — Grounded third-person male locomotion. → [Animations - Movement & Idles](#)
- **Leviathan Animations II - Female Idle Walk And Run (Nexus)** — Grounded third-person female locomotion. → [Animations - Movement & Idles](#)

Alternatives

- **Vanargand Animations II - Male Idle Walk And Run (Nexus)** — Main male-side alternative if Leviathan reads too heavy for the final travel tone. Pick one after real travel testing. → [Animations - Movement & Idles](#)
- **Conditional Armor Type Animations (Nexus)** — Armor-state variation. Add only after base locomotion feel is accepted. → [Animations - Movement & Idles](#)
- **EVG Animated Traversal (Nexus)** — Belongs in the interaction/traversal bucket, not core locomotion. → [Animations - Movement & Idles](#)

Notes

- A locomotion set can look good in isolation but feel heavy/floaty/theatrical during long play sessions.
- Pick one male locomotion owner after testing — mixing Leviathan and Vanargand II without a clear winner makes the stack feel stitched together.

Idle Animations → [Animations - Movement & Idles](#)

Baseline

Keep idle posture aligned with the Leviathan locomotion choice. Conservative route: let locomotion carry most of the movement identity.

Alternatives

- **Goetia Animations - Female Idle Walk And Run (Nexus)** — Lighter female locomotion alternative if Leviathan reads too heavy. → [Animations - Movement & Idles](#)
- **Dynamic Female Weather Idles (Nexus)** — OAR-based idle replacer for female characters. Adds weather-aware idle animations: shivering in cold rain/snow, shielding eyes from bright sun, wiping sweat in heat. Pure visual flavor, no gameplay impact. Complements the survival/weather stack by making the player character react believably to the environment. → [Animations - Movement & Idles](#)
 - **Main file:** [Dynamic Female Weather Idles](#) (OAR condition-based). Download the main file; supports all weather mods.
- **Goetia Animations - Male Idle Walk And Run (Nexus)** — Broader locomotion alternate, not an idle-only pick. → [Animations - Movement & Idles](#)
- **Conditional Armor Type Animations (Nexus)** — Equipment-conditional variation; add only after base stance is accepted. → [Animations - Movement & Idles](#)

Notes

- Separate idle packs can drift from the locomotion tone and make the stack feel stitched together.
- Female-focused idle mods can overcorrect into posed behavior that fights the grounded direction.

Combat Animation Packs → [Animations - Combat](#)

Baseline

- **Precision - Accurate Melee Collisions** (Nexus) — Accurate melee collision detection. → [Animations - Combat](#)
- **SCAR - Skyrim Combos AI Revolution** (Nexus) — NPC-side attack variety. Add after Precision baseline is proven. → [Animations - Combat](#)
- **Animated Armoury - OAR** (Nexus) — 12 new weapon types with attack animations. Requires **Animated Armoury - DAR Version** (Nexus) for meshes/collision/leveled lists. Install DAR first, then OAR overlay. Run Pandora after. → [Animations - Combat](#)
- **No Spinning Death Animation LITE** (Nexus) — Replaces spinning death with simple ragdoll. Compatible with all packs. → [Animations - Combat](#)

High-Commitment Route (evaluate later)

- **MCO ADXP - Modern Movement Combat Overhaul** (Nexus) — Full MCO route. Treat as a system-level decision, not a standalone mod. → [Animations - Combat](#)
- **Animation Motion Revolution** (Nexus) and **Payload Interpreter** (Nexus) — Required MCO support mods. → [Animations - Combat](#)

Support Mods (install per-package as needed)

- **Iframe Generator RE AE Support** (Nexus) — Iframe utility for advanced combat animation packs. Install only when a pack explicitly lists it. → [Animations - Combat](#)

Notes

- Valhalla Combat belongs in [modlist-third-person.md](#), not here — keep animation and gameplay-rule decisions separate.
- MCO can pull the list toward action-combat identity before the gameplay plan is settled. Evaluate deliberately.
- SCAR and attack-framework layering complicate debugging if the baseline animation stack is unstable.

Non-Combat Interaction Animations → [Animations - Interactions & Traversal](#)

Baseline

- **Immersive Interactions - Animated Actions** (Nexus) — Everyday contextual actions baseline. → [Animations - Interactions & Traversal](#)
- **Go to bed** (Nexus) — Sleep-focused companion for survival/camping/roleplay bed-use. → [Animations - Interactions & Traversal](#)

Alternatives

- **Animated Interactions SKSE** (Nexus) — Higher-fidelity pickups, looting, doors. Can coexist with Immersive Interactions only if overlapping actions are deliberately disabled. → [Animations - Interactions & Traversal](#)
- **Take a Seat - New Sitting Animations** (Nexus) — OAR-based sitting variety for chairs/benches/beds. Add after Go to bed is proven. → [Animations - Interactions & Traversal](#)
- **EVG Animated Traversal** (Nexus) — Curated expansion; must justify marker coverage and complexity. → [Animations - Interactions & Traversal](#)
- **Beginner Bard Animations** (Nexus) — Skill-based playing animations for Skyrim's Got Talent. Requires OAR. → [Animations - Interactions & Traversal](#)

Notes

- Contextual interaction mods can become repetitive if triggers are too slow or too frequent.
- Animated Interactions SKSE overlaps enough with Immersive Interactions that it needs conscious tradeoff documentation, not silent stacking.
- Sleeping/interaction animations feel out of place if the list doesn't emphasize downtime/camping/taverns.

Conditional Animation Systems → [Animations - Framework](#)

Baseline

- **Open Animation Replacer** (Nexus) — Single condition framework owner for the animation stack. → [Animations - Framework](#)

Alternatives

- **EVG Conditional Idles** (Nexus) — Let it prove condition-driven flavor value before layering additional situational packs. → [Animations - Framework](#)
- **Conditional Armor Type Animations** (Nexus) — Armor-state variation. Add only after locomotion/idle baseline is stable. → [Animations - Framework](#)
- **Unique Jarl Throne Sitting Animation (OAR)** (Nexus) — Per-Jarl sitting animation. Clean add-on once OAR baseline is proven. → [Animations - Framework](#)

Notes

- Older DAR assumptions are legacy compatibility context, not the framework direction for Elder Wilds.
- Conditional systems become hard to reason about if multiple packs try to own similar states (injured, relaxed, weapon-drawn).
- Keep ownership disciplined: the more conditional logic added, the more important clear ownership becomes.

Camera-Aware Animation Support → [Animations - Framework](#)

Baseline

Keep perspective support minimal unless the list expects meaningful hybrid-perspective play. Broad camera framework decisions belong in [modlist-third-person.md](#).

Alternatives

- **Improved Camera SE (Nexus)** — Animation-side perspective foundation. Use only if hybrid perspective is a real part of the playstyle. → [Animations - Framework](#)
- **Comprehensive First Person Animation Overhaul - CFPAO (Nexus)** — Optional first-person polish. Only if testing shows meaningful time in first person. → [Animations - Framework](#)

Notes

- First-person polish is wasted complexity if the list rarely leaves third person.
- Perspective mods can expose clipping, weapon-position, and camera-body mismatches not visible in third person.

Creature Animations → [Animations - Creatures](#)

Baseline

Curated wilderness-threat route. Prioritize memorable encounters over completeness.

- **New Creature Animation - Giant (Nexus)** — Shapes third-person combat readability. → [Animations - Creatures](#)
- **New Creature Animation - Werewolf (Nexus)** — Memorable encounter impact. → [Animations - Creatures](#)
- **New Creature Animation - Falmer (Nexus)** — Dungeon-focused follow-up once baseline direction is proven. → [Animations - Creatures](#)

Notes

- Creature packs create more debugging overhead than humanoid packs — validate individually.
- Validate per-pack combat-animation support dependencies rather than assuming baseline-safe.
- Keep layer small and intentional; don't over-invest in rare/novelty types.

Animation Conflict Management → [Animations - Framework](#)

Strict ownership route: one clear owner per layer, change one category at a time, regenerate, test, document.

Owners

- **Behavior generation:** Pandora only.
- **Skeleton:** XPMSSSE only.
- **Conditional selection:** Open Animation Replacer only.

Workflow

- Keep Pandora output isolated in a dedicated MO2 output mod.
- Record which mods rely on generation, which on OAR, and which are pure presentation-side companions.
- Test changes in repeatable scenarios: town walking, idle downtime, dungeon corridors, uneven outdoor combat, interaction-heavy interiors, at least one creature encounter.

Notes

- Animation conflicts often look like camera, combat, or skeleton bugs until ownership is checked.
- Mixed generated output hides whether a problem is from load order or stale behavior files.
- The more systems added in [Third-Person Gameplay](#), the more expensive it is to clean up unresolved ownership mistakes from this section.

Candidate TODO Additions

Idles & Expressions → [Animations - Movement & Idles](#)

- [Poses, Actions and Musical](#) — idle/pose animation pack → [Animations - Movement & Idles](#)
- [More Tavern Idls - Immersive](#) — tavern idle animation additions → [Animations - Movement & Idles](#)
- [Headtracking and Emotions](#) — NPC headtracking and facial expression improvements → [Animations - Movement & Idles](#)

Combat Animation → [Animations - Combat](#)

- [Smooth block animation](#) — block animation replacer → [Animations - Combat](#)
- [Weapon Trails](#) — weapon trail VFX → [Animations - Combat](#)
- [Killmove fixes](#) — killmove camera/animation fix → [Animations - Combat](#)
- [Goetia Animations - Magic Spell Casting](#) (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/70204>) — magic cast animation pack → [Animations - Combat](#)
- [Diverse NPC Movesets](#) (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/141893>) — gives NPCs varied combat stances, movesets, and animations based on their class, skills, and faction. Uses SCAR and OAR conditions. → [Animations - Combat](#)

Movement & Parkour → [Animations - Interactions & Traversal](#)

- [Smooth Jump animation](#) — jump animation replacer → [Animations - Interactions & Traversal](#)
- [Just Shields on your back / Weapons on Back AiO](#) — shield/weapon placement (choose one) → [Animations - Interactions & Traversal](#)
- [Walk Speed Tuner](#) — movement speed adjustment → [Animations - Interactions & Traversal](#)

- [Dova Jump](#) (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/125550>) — jump height/behavior tweak → [Animations](#) - [Interactions & Traversal](#)

Creature Animation → [Animations](#) - [Creatures](#)

- [Troll - MCO](#) (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/175250>) — troll MCO animation → [Animations](#) - [Creatures](#)

FILE: modlist-third-person.md

Third-Person Gameplay

MO2 Separators: [Third-Person - Camera & Movement](#), [Third-Person - Combat & Targeting](#), [Third-Person - Mounted](#)

Third-Person Camera Framework → [Third-Person - Camera & Movement](#)

Baseline

- [SmoothCam](#) (Nexus) — Main third-person camera framework. → [Third-Person - Camera & Movement](#)

Alternatives

- [Customizable Camera](#) (Nexus) — Leaner fallback if SmoothCam feels too elaborate. → [Third-Person - Camera & Movement](#)
- [True Directional Movement](#) (Nexus) — Governs movement and targeting, not the camera framework itself. → [Third-Person - Camera & Movement](#)
- [Improved Camera SE](#) (Nexus) — Perspective support, not the main third-person framework. → [Third-Person - Camera & Movement](#)

Notes

- A good preset can hide weak underlying camera behavior — judge the framework, not the preset.
- Over-tuned cameras look impressive in clips but become tiring in normal play.
- Keep framework, targeting, movement, and perspective decisions separate.

Camera Presets And Shoulder Switching → [Third-Person - Camera & Movement](#)

Baseline

Restrained centered-to-light-offset baseline. Shoulder switching is a support feature for visibility problems, not the main camera identity.

Notes

- Aggressive over-the-shoulder framing creates visibility issues in interiors, dungeons, and melee encounters.
- Shoulder switching that feels mandatory too often is a symptom of poor baseline framing.
- Community presets are reference material, not baseline recommendations — judge with real play context.

True Directional Movement → [Third-Person - Camera & Movement](#)

Baseline

- [True Directional Movement - Modernized Third Person Gameplay](#) (Nexus) — Modern 360-degree character-relative movement. → [Third-Person - Camera & Movement](#)

Notes

- Core value: freer facing, cleaner traversal, better animation-stack alignment.
- Do not let target lock, boss framing, or crosshair behavior define this decision yet.
- Feels great in open traversal but may feel awkward in tight interiors, stairs, or precision positioning.

Target Lock And Targeting Behavior → [Third-Person - Combat & Targeting](#)

Baseline

- **TDM** as the targeting-behavior owner. Keep lock-on restrained — it's an optional combat-readability tool, not the permanent default. → [Third-Person - Combat & Targeting](#)
- [TrueHUD](#) (Nexus) — Optional feedback companion for target-state clarity. Add only if testing shows it materially helps. → [Third-Person - Combat & Targeting](#)

Notes

- Overusing lock-on makes combat feel narrower and more repetitive.
- Weak target selection/switching makes even a good camera and movement baseline feel unreliable.
- TrueHUD can create the illusion of a solved targeting system when the underlying behavior is still awkward.

Dodge, Sprint, And Movement Responsiveness → [Third-Person - Camera & Movement](#)

Baseline

- **TK Dodge RE - Script Free (Nexus)** — First dodge candidate. Tactical repositioning tool, not the center of combat pacing. → [Third-Person - Camera & Movement](#)

Alternatives

- **TK Dodge SE (Nexus)** — Legacy fallback reference only. → [Third-Person - Camera & Movement](#)
- **Dodge for all (Nexus)** — Newer multi-author option (v1.1.2, May 2026). Too early for baseline — low community signal. Revisit when it has a real track record. → [Third-Person - Camera & Movement](#)

Notes

- A dodge system can make combat feel twitchier and less grounded than intended.
- If dodge is too strong, it trivializes spacing and undermines other readability goals.
- The dodge ecosystem has overlapping variants — pick one owner and don't stack.

Hit Reactions, Stagger, And Impact Feedback → [Third-Person - Combat & Targeting](#)

Baseline

- **Valhalla Combat (Nexus)** — Main gameplay-side comparison point for hit feedback and stagger. → [Third-Person - Combat & Targeting](#)
- **Precision** (from [modlist-animations.md](#)) — Adjacent support layer for contact feel, not a full impact-readability answer.

Notes

- Too much stagger flattens combat pacing; too little leaves even good animations unsatisfying.
- Camera, animation timing, collision, and gameplay rules all affect impact feel — ownership blurs quickly.
- Keep scoped to impact feel; deeper combat-rule decisions belong in the next subsection.

Third-Person Combat Systems → [Third-Person - Combat & Targeting](#)

Baseline

Balanced modern route: Valhalla Combat as the gameplay-rules framework. Keep MCO ADXP as the ambitious alternative to compare against, not an automatic lock.

- **Valhalla Combat** — Gameplay-rule framework. → [Third-Person - Combat & Targeting](#)
- **MCO ADXP - Modern Movement Combat Overhaul (Nexus)** — Ambitious alternative. Re-evaluate deliberately. → [Third-Person - Combat & Targeting](#)
- **SCAR** (from [modlist-animations.md](#)) — NPC-side attack variety, tracked from the animation section.

MCO Route Support (only if MCO is chosen)

- **Knockback SKSE (For BFCO and MCO Users) (Nexus)** — Physics-based knockback for power attacks. → [Third-Person - Combat & Targeting](#)

Alternatives

- **RaySense - Cover Animation (Nexus)** — Wall-flatten animation during third-person sneaking. Add only if stealth is a meaningful playstyle. → [Third-Person - Combat & Targeting](#)

Notes

- A full modern combat stack can pull the list toward aggressive action-game identity before the project is settled on tone.
- Overlapping combat layers become hard to debug once dodge, lock-on, stagger, collision, NPC behavior, and animation changes all land together.
- Carry forward MCO prerequisite/support context from [modlist-animations.md](#) rather than treating it as a standalone toggle.

Crosshair And Aiming Behavior → [Third-Person - Combat & Targeting](#)

Baseline

Disciplined aiming route: keep crosshair behavior restrained and readable. Camera framing is the baseline aiming context — poor framing masquerades as poor aiming.

Alternatives

- **Better Third Person Selection - BTPS (Nexus)** — Optional companion if object-selection/interaction reliability is part of the usability problem. Not a combat-aiming fix. → [Third-Person - Combat & Targeting](#)
- **TrueHUD** — Optional clarity aid for aiming readability. Only if testing shows material improvement. → [Third-Person - Combat & Targeting](#)
- **Ricochet - Arrow Physics Framework (Nexus)** — Arrow ricochet/deflection physics. Lock in only if archery is a meaningful part of the combat style. → [Third-Person - Combat & Targeting](#)

Notes

- Don't overcorrect weak aiming with HUD noise instead of fixing camera and targeting first.
- Crosshair tuning can inherit assumptions from the heavier combat route and feel wrong if the project later chooses a more grounded direction.
- Visual styling and broader HUD philosophy belong in `modlist-ui.md`.

Horse Camera And Mounted Controls → `Third-Person - Mounted`

Baseline

- **Press H to Horse** (`Nexus`) — Actively maintained modern horse overhaul (TateTaylorOH, updated May 2026). Few vanilla record edits, designed for compatibility. → `Third-Person - Mounted`
- **Horses Simply Turn Better** (`Nexus`) — Free add-on regardless of overhaul choice. Sharpens turning radius, designed for TDM. → `Third-Person - Mounted`

Alternatives

- **Convenient Horses** (`Nexus`) — Broad overhaul but last updated Jan 2022 (3.5yr stale). No longer actively maintained. → `Third-Person - Mounted`
- **Simplest Horses (and other mounts)** (`Nexus`) — Lightweight drop-in if full overhaul feels like scope creep. SPID+MCM, very compatible. → `Third-Person - Mounted`

Notes

- Judge mounted play on travel readability, steering confidence, and camera coherence with the on-foot direction — not feature count.
- Horse overhauls can reach well beyond camera into followers, inventory, behavior, and immersion systems.
- Mounted play can feel improved in calm travel but break down during combat or cramped terrain.

Candidate TODO Additions

Combat Gameplay → `Third-Person - Combat & Targeting`

- `Eviscerate` — combat gore/dismemberment gameplay → `Third-Person - Combat & Targeting`
- `Cinema - Dynamic Combat Letterbox` — dynamic letterbox during combat → `Third-Person - Combat & Targeting`
- `Parry for All` — universal parry/block mechanic → `Third-Person - Combat & Targeting`
- `Deadly spell impact` — spell impact visual/audio feedback → `Third-Person - Combat & Targeting`

Mounted → `Third-Person - Mounted`

- `HorsePower - Modernized horse riding` — modern horse riding overhaul → `Third-Person - Mounted`

FILE: modlist-expanded-systems.md

Expanded Systems

MO2 Separator: `Expanded Systems` → `Expanded Systems - Character & Progression`, `Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks`, `Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs`, `Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy`, `Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation`

Overview

This section owns the gameplay systems that expand Skyrim beyond its 2011 baseline: character creation, progression, magic, perks, survival, crafting, economy, followers, and social systems. Each pillar of the Expanded Systems section lives in its own sub-file.

The system is designed to be evaluated in order — progression choices (races, standing stones, perks) come before magic, survival, crafting, and social systems that build on them.

Sub-Files

Area	File	Separator	Topics
Character & Progression	<code>Character & Progression</code>	<code>Expanded Systems - Character & Progression</code>	Alternate starts, races, standing stones, traits, religion, vampire/werewolf/shouts
Magic & Perks	<code>Magic & Perks</code>	<code>Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks</code>	Perk overhauls, magic expansion, stealth/detection
Survival & Needs	<code>Survival & Needs</code>	<code>Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs</code>	Survival frameworks, hygiene, death alternative
Crafting & Economy	<code>Crafting & Economy</code>	<code>Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy</code>	Alchemy, cooking, smithing, enchanting, economy, artifacts, weapons, armor, clothing

Area	File	Separator	Topics
Followers & Reputation	Followers & Reputation	Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation	Crime/reputation, follower frameworks, romance/marriage

Key Principles

- Simonrim progression family (Adamant, Mysticism, Thaumaturgy, etc.) is the default baseline; EnaiRim (Ordinator, Apocalypse, etc.) is the high-expression branch → Expanded Systems - Character & Progression, Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks
- Survival, difficulty, and balance interactions across the full load order are owned by modlist-survival-combat.md → Survival & Combat
- All system choices must be evaluated for third-person gamepad usability and compatibility with the Legacy of the Dragonborn museum pillar → Legacy of the Dragonborn

FILE: modlist-expanded-character.md

Character & Progression

MO2 Separator: Expanded Systems → Expanded Systems - Character & Progression

Part of the Expanded Systems section. See also: UI - Inventory & Items (Magic & Perks), UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus (Survival & Needs), 06d (Crafting & Economy), 06e (Followers & Reputation).

Character Creation And Starting Choices → Expanded Systems - Character & Progression

This subsection decides how Elder Wilds begins: a grounded alternate start, a classic utility-first start, a more configurable route, or a more abstract sandbox opening. The decision should improve replayability and roleplay expression without pre-answering later race, progression, religion, survival, or follower choices.

Baseline

- **Alternate Perspective - Alternate Start (Nexus)** — Main baseline candidate. → Expanded Systems - Character & Progression
- **Dealing with Backstories (Nexus)** — Origins-and-starting-stats companion that generates background-driven starting skills, bonuses, drawbacks, and gear instead of just moving the player to a different start cell. → Expanded Systems - Character & Progression
- **Take Notes - Journal of the Dragonborn SSE (Nexus)** — Low-risk roleplay-sheet companion. Gives the player a persistent in-game journal without rebalancing the character. → Expanded Systems - Character & Progression
- **Roleplaying In Skyrim - Origins (Nexus)** — Optional character-background companion for origin-driven flavor and optional bonuses based on character history. Requires SKSE and Papyrus Ini Manipulator. Soft-requires Actor Value Generator and SkyUI. → Expanded Systems - Character & Progression

Alternatives

- **Alternate Start - Live Another Life (Nexus)** — Conservative fallback comparison if the more immersive route is harder to justify in the final stack. → Expanded Systems - Character & Progression
- **Skyrim Unbound Reborn (Alternate Start) (Nexus)** — Configurable middle-ground route if the list wants more setup freedom without moving fully into sandbox-start territory. → Expanded Systems - Character & Progression
- **Realm of Lorkhan - Freeform Alternate Start (Nexus)** — Deliberate freeform branch. Not the default baseline. → Expanded Systems - Character & Progression

Notes

- Start frameworks can carry world-state assumptions that ripple into later quest, city, survival, or follower decisions.
- Dealing with Backstories must be judged against the chosen race, standing-stone, perk, and survival stack instead of being treated as a harmless flavor add-on. → Expanded Systems - Character & Progression
- Take Notes only earns a slot if the list expects real roleplay or long-form character journaling rather than a pure action-combat playstyle. → Expanded Systems - Character & Progression
- A more immersive start loses value quickly if it adds onboarding friction without materially improving the early-game tone.
- A more abstract start can undermine world coherence if it feels like a detached configuration room.
- This subsection gets muddy if race, perk, religion, or survival decisions leak into it too early.

Race, Standing Stone, And Progression Overhauls → Expanded Systems - Character & Progression

This subsection decides how strongly race traits and standing stones should shape long-term character identity. The goal is to choose one clear progression philosophy before perks, magic, alchemy, and religion build on top of it.

Baseline

- **Aetherius - A Race Overhaul (Nexus) + Evenstar - Minimalistic Standing Stones of Skyrim (Nexus)** — Main baseline. Balanced modern route. → Expanded Systems - Character & Progression

- **Roleplaying in Skyrim - Classic Attributes (Nexus)** — Optional attribute-depth companion adding 10 classic RPG attributes that govern various traits and mechanics. Requires [Actor Value Generator](#) from section 01. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)
- **Roleplaying in Skyrim - Races (Nexus)** — Optional biological race overhaul based on physiological differences. Requires SKSE, KID, and SPID. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)
- **Roleplaying in Skyrim - Lineages (Nexus)** — Optional subrace expansion adding 4 subraces per vanilla race with unique abilities and roleplay-encouraging rewards. Supplements [Races](#). Requires SKSE, KID, SPID, and [Papyrus Ini Manipulator](#). → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)
- **Roleplaying in Skyrim - Standing Stones (Nexus)** — Optional standing stone overhaul making the 13 stones feel more impactful for the Dragonborn. Requires SKSE, [aTweaks and Utilities](#), KID, [Perk Entry Point Extender](#), and [SkyUI](#). → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)
- **Roleplaying in Skyrim - Birthsigns (Nexus)** — Optional birthsign reintroduction with monthly waxing/waning effects, as an alternative or supplement to the standing stone choice. Requires SKSE, KID, and [Papyrus Ini Manipulator](#). → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)
- **Roleplaying in Skyrim - Useful MiscStats (Nexus)** — Optional misc-stat progression layer making miscellaneous stats meaningful for character building. Requires [Actor Value Generator](#) from section 01. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)
- **Roleplaying in Skyrim - Skill Based Stat Growth (Nexus)** — Optional stat-progression where Health, Magicka, and Stamina grow as skills develop. Requires SKSE and [Papyrus Ini Manipulator](#). → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)

Alternatives

- **Morningstar - Minimalistic Races of Skyrim (Nexus) + Evenstar** — Restrained fallback if the final list wants less systemic pressure. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)
- **Imperious - Races of Skyrim (Nexus) + Andromeda - Unique Standing Stones of Skyrim (Nexus)** — High-expression comparison route. Not the default baseline. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)

Notes

- Race and stone overhauls can quietly pre-decide too much of the character-building experience before perk and magic systems are chosen.
- A very expressive route can push the list toward optimization-heavy play even if the broader project wants a more immersive tone.
- A very light route can undershoot if later systems assume stronger identity hooks.
- Mixing progression philosophies later can create a stack that is individually interesting but mechanically incoherent.
- Judge race and stone picks as a pair so the progression baseline stays easy to explain.

Character Traits And Identity Hooks → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)

This subsection owns opt-in character-defining quirks that shape a run from the start without replacing the broader race, perk, and standing-stone progression stack. The goal is stronger roleplay identity and replayability, not a giant second character-build framework.

Baseline

- **Biggie Traits (Nexus)** — Main traits-layer option. Adds immediate run-defining tradeoffs in a compact form, closer to Fallout-style traits than to a total rules rewrite. Cleaner fit than heavier custom-class frameworks. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)
- **Pumping Iron - Dynamic Muscle Growth (Nexus)** — Optional cosmetic-progression companion. Character muscles visually grow based on combat skill increases and sleep. Purely cosmetic; no gameplay impact. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)

Alternatives

- **Minimalist route** — Leave identity mostly to race, standing stones, perks, and self-imposed roleplay.

Notes

- Trait systems can quietly duplicate what race, perk, religion, or survival choices are already trying to do.
- If the best traits are too obviously optimal, the whole idea collapses into routine min-maxing instead of character identity.
- [Biggie Traits](#) has no listed hard dependencies, so its value comes entirely from design fit and clean behavior. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)
- Traits should sharpen character identity and replayability, not replace the race-and-perk decisions owned above.
- Judge traits on whether they create distinct runs and memorable constraints without forcing gimmick play.

Religion Or Roleplay Systems → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)

This subsection decides how much explicit spiritual identity and day-to-day roleplay texture [Elder Wilds](#) wants: a light faith layer, a modern religion framework aligned with the current progression stack, or a heavier deity-centered system that becomes a defining part of character identity.

Baseline

- **Pilgrim - A Religion Overhaul (Nexus)** — Main baseline. Fits the current Simonrim-leaning progression family without making religion the dominant system. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)

Alternatives

- **Trua - Minimalistic Faiths of Skyrim (Nexus)** — Restrained fallback if the list wants faith flavor without much system weight. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)
- **Wintersun - Faiths of Skyrim (Nexus)** — High-expression route if [Elder Wilds](#) decides religion should become a much stronger roleplay and progression pillar. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)

Notes

- A very light religion route can undershoot and leave roleplay identity too close to vanilla.
- A heavy deity-centered framework can make religion dominate character identity so strongly that other systems feel secondary.
- Survival, economy, and follower expectations can drift into this section if faith routines are not scoped carefully.
- Mixing multiple faith philosophies too casually can make the overall roleplay layer incoherent.
- Judge candidates by ordinary play rhythm: prayer habits, shrine relevance, exploration texture, and whether faith makes the world feel richer during normal travel and downtime.

Race-Specific Overhauls → Expanded Systems - Character & Progression

This subsection owns dedicated overhaul mods for vampire, werewolf, and shout gameplay — three character-identity systems that vanilla Skyrim leaves shallow or repetitive, and that the broader progression stack does not fully cover. These picks complete the EnaiRim suite begun with [Andromeda](#) (standing stones, locked above). [Sacrosanct](#), [Growl](#), and [Thunderchild](#) are all by EnaiSiaion, share the same design philosophy, and pair with [Andromeda](#) to form the character-systems half of the EnaiRim ecosystem alongside the Ordinator-based perk baseline.

Baseline

- **Sacrosanct - Vampires of Skyrim (Nexus)** — Vampire overhaul. Overhauls vampirism progression, feeding, powers, and NPC vampire behaviour with 4 feeding tiers and unique blood-power effects keyed to vampiric age. Community-canonical (133K endorsements). → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)
- **Growl - Werebeasts of Skyrim (Nexus)** — Werewolf overhaul. Overhauls beast-form progression, perks, feeding mechanics, and totems with 5 werebear varieties and a dedicated perk tree. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)
- **Thunderchild - Epic Shouts and Immersion (Nexus)** — Shout overhaul. Adds 19 new shouts (57 new words), meditation mechanics, shout-aware equipment, a recognition system, and boss encounters tied to the Thu'um. Completes the EnaiRim character-systems suite alongside [Andromeda](#), [Sacrosanct](#), and [Growl](#). → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)

Alternatives

- **Discipline-first route** — Rely on vanilla vampire, werewolf, and shout systems without dedicated overhaul mods. Only viable if [Elder Wilds](#) decides these systems do not need dedicated attention, though the total-category-gap argument is hard to justify for a list built on "modern mechanics" and "lots of new content".

Notes

- All three are by EnaiSiaion, designed to work together, and require no cross-patching. Compatibility with [Ordinator](#), [Andromeda](#), [Apocalypse](#), and the broader EnaiRim ecosystem is guaranteed by design.
- [Sacrosanct](#) and [Growl](#) interact with [Heart of the Beast](#) (werewolf transformation audio) in section 10. Place transformation-sound replacers after the transformation-system mods in load order.
- [Thunderchild](#) adds 19 new shouts that interact with shout-audio mods ([Airgetlam - Shouts SFX](#)) from section 10. Verify shout-sfx replacements apply to Thunderchild's new shouts, not just vanilla ones.
- All three add spells, powers, and mechanics that [Ordinator](#)'s perk trees must coexist with. Verify Ordinator's enchantment-tree and speech-tree adjustments do not conflict with Sacrosanct's blood powers or Thunderchild's shout meditation. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)
- Vampire feeding interacts with the crime-and-reputation baseline ([Skyrim Reputation](#) from [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#)). Test feeding in cities to confirm guard behaviour and bounty tracking remain coherent.
- [Thunderchild](#)'s boss encounters may overlap with encounter-zone or world-content mods from [modlist-world-content.md](#). Verify new word-wall guardians do not duplicate vanilla boss spawns. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)

Experience and Leveling → Expanded Systems - Character & Progression

This subsection owns how the player gains levels and skill points. Instead of the vanilla sleep-to-level model, [Elder Wilds](#) uses Experience (discovery-based leveling) paired with Static Skill Leveling Rewritten (cooldown-gated skill advancement) to make progression feel earned through exploration and deliberate practice rather than grinding.

Baseline

- **Experience (Nexus)** — Core leveling framework. Character levels are gained through exploration, quest completion, combat, and discovery rather than skill increases. This decouples character level from skill grinding. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)
 - **Main file: Experience** (the base .esp). Install the main file only.
 - **Experience - Synthesis Patcher (Nexus)** — Required Synthesis patcher that generates experience-point values for all mod-added quests, locations, and enemies in the load order. Run during the patcher chain in → 14d. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)
- **Experience - MCM (Nexus)** — MCM configuration menu for Experience. Allows tuning XP rates, per-activity values, and toggle per-source. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)
- **Static Skill Leveling Rewritten (Nexus)** — Skill-leveling companion. Adds a cooldown-based system where skill increases are gated by real time or in-game actions, encouraging organic skill use over grind-spamming. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)
 - **Main file: Static Skill Leveling - ESL**, the ESL-flagged plugin.
 - **Static Skill Leveling Rewritten - Simple Preset (Nexus)** — Recommended preset with tuned cooldown values. Install after the base mod. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)
- **No Startup Quest XP - Patch for Sunhelm and more (Nexus)** — Prevents XP from startup quests (Unbound, etc.) when using Experience + an alternate start mod. Complements Alternate Perspective from the Character Creation subsection. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)

- **Skyshards (Nexus)** — Discovery-layer addition. Scatter 60+ glowing shards across Skyrim that grant experience when collected. Gives exploration a tangible, repeatable reward for straying off the main path. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)
 - **Main file: Skyshards** (the base mod). Recommend the ESL-flagged version.
 - **Skyshards - CS Light Addon (Nexus)** — Community Shaders light addon. Adds a subtle emission glow to skyshards, making them visible in dark interiors without being garish. Requires Community Shaders (→ 02b). → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)
 - **Skyshards - Keep it Moving (Nexus)** — Prevents the skyshard-collection notification from stopping player movement. QoL patch for third-person gamepad play. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)

Alternatives

- **Discipline-first route** — Rely on vanilla sleep-to-level progression. Avoids the patcher requirement but discards the exploration-focused progression model that anchors the "big, dark, awe-inspiring world" pillar.
- **Static Skill Leveling - Custom Preset** — Use the base mod without the Simple Preset if tuning the cooldowns manually is preferred. → [Expanded Systems - Character & Progression](#)

Notes

- Experience's Synthesis Patcher must be re-run whenever the load order changes (new quest, location, or creature mods added).
- Static Skill Leveling Rewritten's cooldown system may feel restrictive during heavy gameplay sessions; the Simple Preset mitigates this. Tune via the preset's .ini if needed.
- Skyshards placement may clip with city overhauls, new-lands mods, or landscape edits. Verify in-game after the world-content stack is locked.
- All four mods are ESL-flagged or lightweight, adding minimal plugin pressure.

FILE: modlist-expanded-magic.md

Magic & Perks

MO2 Separator: [Expanded Systems](#) → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)

Part of the [Expanded Systems](#) section. See also: [UI - Framework & HUD](#) (Character & Progression), [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#) (Survival & Needs), [06d](#) (Crafting & Economy), [06e](#) (Followers & Reputation).

Perk Overhaul Compatibility → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)

This subsection chooses the perk philosophy that the rest of [Expanded Systems](#) must live with. The goal is to decide how much rules density and specialization pressure the list actually wants once race and standing-stone choices are already in place.

Baseline

- **Adamant - A Perk Overhaul (Nexus)** — Main baseline. Balanced modern route. → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)

Alternatives

- **Vokrii - Minimalistic Perks of Skyrim (Nexus)** — Restrained comparison if [Adamant](#) still feels more system-forward than the final tone wants. → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)
- **Ordinator - Perks of Skyrim (Nexus)** — High-complexity branch if the list decides perks should become one of the dominant sources of build identity. → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)

Notes

- A dense perk framework can dominate the entire character-building experience and make later systems feel secondary.
- A restrained perk framework can make the overall list feel under-committed if other expanded systems also land on the conservative side.
- Mixing perk philosophy poorly with race, stone, and later magic choices can create a stack that is busy but not coherent.
- Compare perk candidates against the already-preferred race-and-stone direction so the full progression stack stays coherent.

Magic System Expansion → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)

This subsection chooses the spell-system philosophy for [Elder Wilds](#): how broad, readable, and build-defining magic should feel once the race, standing-stone, and perk baseline are in place. The goal is to pick one clear magic direction that complements the progression stack instead of overwhelming it.

Baseline

- **Mysticism - A Magic Overhaul (Nexus)** — Main baseline. Balanced modern route. → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)
- **Triumvirate - Mage Archetypes (Nexus)** — Locked companion spell pack. Adds identity-driven archetype spells (Cleric, Druid, Shadow Mage, Shaman, Warlock) by EnaiSiaion that complement whichever primary overhaul is chosen without overriding its core spell list. Each archetype is self-contained and can be engaged with or ignored. → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)
- **Strange Runes (Nexus)** — Locked magic-visual companion. Adds floating Nordic runes during spell charging with zero gameplay or balance impact — a visual feedback upgrade that makes spellcasting feel more modern and reads clearly in third-person. Compatible with all primary spell overhauls; no record

conflicts. → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)

Alternatives

- **Odin - Skyrim Magic Overhaul (Nexus)** — Moderate expansion route. Comparison if [Mysticism](#) feels too restrained for the final identity. → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)
- **Apocalypse - Magic of Skyrim (Nexus)** — High-expression route for maximum spell variety and magical experimentation. → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)
- **Lost Grimoire SSE (Nexus)** — Standalone spell-pack adding 115+ lore-friendly spells across all schools with matching scrolls and staves. Compatible with any primary overhaul. → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)
- **Elemental Mastery Magic (Nexus)** — Spell-school specialization pack adding elemental specialization mechanics and tiered mastery bonuses for Destruction and Alteration mages. → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)
- **Immersive Illusion Spells (Nexus)** — Illusion expansion adding new illusion-spell types and mechanics beyond the basic fear/calm/frenzy trinity. → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)
- **360 Ward (Nexus)** — Ward-mechanics expansion allowing wards to block attacks from any direction. Significant third-person gameplay improvement — wards become usable while moving and turning. → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)
- **Sanguine Symphony (Nexus)** — Blood-magic spell pack adding spells that cost Health instead of Magicka, unlocking a separate magic ecosystem for hybrid builds. Compatible with all primary spell overhauls. → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)

Notes

- A very large spell ecosystem can dominate progression and make race, perk, and religion choices feel secondary.
- Layering multiple spell packages too casually turns this subsection into a compatibility problem instead of a clean design decision.
- A restrained spell overhaul can undershoot the [Expanded Systems](#) pillar if too many adjacent systems also land on conservative choices. → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)
- Mixing a high-volume magic package with a more restrained perk philosophy can make the overall progression stack feel internally inconsistent.
- [Mysticism](#) and [Odin](#) should be treated as competing primary overhauls, not a default combined baseline; if the list later explores combined setups, that should be a deliberate compatibility project. → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)
- Choose one primary magic overhaul first and only then decide whether extra spell volume is actually needed.

Stealth And Detection → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)

This subsection owns the modern-mechanics pillar's stealth side: how Skyrim's detection system should be recalibrated, and whether the player should gain better stealth tools without replacing the existing perk, magic, and combat layers. Detection is a moment-to-moment mechanical layer; reputation and guard pressure are social and world-reaction layers. It stays separate from NPC AI overhauls (in [modlist-npcs.md](#)) and from the targeted bugfix bucket in [modlist-foundations.md](#).

Baseline

- **Realistic AI Detection (RAID) (Nexus)** — Detection-recalibration baseline. Script-free (23.8K endorsements), recalibrates the detection formula (line of sight, lighting, distance, sneaking skill, race) without rewriting the AI itself. The cleanest way to make Skyrim's stealth feel modern without dragging in a stealth overhaul that would fight the perk and combat layers. → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)

Alternatives

- **Discipline-first route** — Rely on the perk overhaul and targeted bugfix mods from [modlist-foundations.md](#) for detection edge cases. Valid when the project wants a lighter systems footprint. → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)
- **Deferred high-commitment branch** — Add a full stealth-toolkit overhaul only if real playtesting proves detection still feels too forgiving or too punishing after the perk and bugfix layers are in place.

Notes

- Detection recalibration can make some encounter zones feel too easy or too hard if it interacts with encounter-zone or difficulty mods from [modlist-survival-combat.md](#); verify across hold capitals, wilderness, and dungeon encounters. → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)
- A detection overhaul can make stealth-only play too dominant if it stacks with a perk overhaul that already buffs sneak; check the perk mod's sneak tree for conflicts.
- Detection changes can affect follower behavior; verify follower behavior under RAID if the chosen follower framework exposes detection settings.
- **RAID** last updated April 2022 — script-free means less breakage risk, but verify detection feels right against the chosen perk overhaul. → [Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks](#)

FILE: modlist-expanded-survival.md

Survival & Needs

MO2 Separator: [Expanded Systems](#) → [Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs](#)

Part of the [Expanded Systems](#) section. See also: [UI - Framework & HUD](#) (Character & Progression), [UI - Inventory & Items](#) (Magic & Perks), [06d](#) (Crafting & Economy), [06e](#) (Followers & Reputation).

Survival Systems → [Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs](#)

This subsection decides how much day-to-day bodily upkeep [Elder Wilds](#) actually wants: enough hunger, fatigue, cold, weather, disease, and wilderness friction to support roleplay and travel texture, or a heavier survival framework that becomes one of the list's central systems. This section owns the baseline survival direction; [modlist-survival-combat.md](#) still owns later survival-compatibility, difficulty-pressure, and balance interactions.

Baseline

- **Starfrost - A Survival Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Main baseline. Fits the Simonrim-aligned progression family that the rest of [modlist-expanded-systems.md](#) already leans toward. → [Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs](#)

Alternatives

- **SunHelm Survival and needs** ([Nexus](#)) — Practical comparison route if [Starfrost](#) proves too tightly tuned or too dependent on the Simonrim ecosystem. → [Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs](#)
- **Last Seed - Survival Needs and Diseases** ([Nexus](#)) — Heavier classic route if the list decides survival should become one of its dominant identities. → [Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs](#)
- **Frostfall - Hypothermia Camping Survival** ([Nexus](#)) with **Campfire - Complete Camping System** ([Nexus](#)) — Harsh wilderness route for maximum survival weight. → [Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs](#)

Notes

- A heavy survival system can dominate pacing and crowd out other expanded systems.
- A very light survival setup can undershoot the immersive-travel pillar if later world-scale and downtime decisions expect more texture.
- Cold, disease, food, sleep, and camping systems can blur together and make ownership between survival, cooking, roleplay, and religion harder to read.
- If the survival baseline fights the intended third-person travel rhythm, the result may feel dutiful rather than immersive.
- Judge survival primarily on travel texture, downtime rhythm, and world feel rather than on maximum hardship alone.

Roleplay Upkeep And Hygiene → [Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs](#)

This subsection owns the lighter day-to-day body-maintenance layer that sits between full survival needs and pure visual flavor. The goal is to add believable downtime rituals and world-living texture without turning hygiene into a second dominant survival framework.

Baseline

- **Bathing in Skyrim - Renewed** ([Nexus](#)) — Leading hygiene-and-downtime route. Fits the living-the-world pillar better than older bathing mods because it is actively maintained, heavily customizable, and technically modernized around SKSE plus Papyrus-extender dependencies. Treat as a roleplay-support system, not as the main survival baseline. → [Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs](#)

Alternatives

- **Minimalist route** — Leave hygiene implied through inns, rivers, and roleplay without a dedicated system.

Notes

- Hygiene can become fussy busywork if configured too aggressively.
- [Bathing in Skyrim - Renewed](#) touches equipment handling, overlays, follower participation, and optional integrations — needs stricter discipline than a simple immersion add-on. → [Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs](#)
- Only hard runtime requirements should be treated as mandatory for the baseline install.
- For target Steam runtime [1.6.1170](#), the listed [Backported Extended ESL Support](#) requirement does not apply and should not be installed. → [Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs](#)

Death Alternative System → [Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs](#)

This subsection owns what happens when the player falls in combat: whether death is the only outcome, or whether a modern death-alternative system can create memorable setbacks and emergent storytelling instead of a reload screen. The goal is to add consequence and narrative texture to defeat without making every lost fight a permanent character-ending event.

Baseline

- **Shadow of Skyrim - Nemesis and Alternative Death System** ([Nexus](#)) — Locked death-alternative baseline. Upon defeat, the player respawns at the nearest safe location with debuffs and the enemy who defeated them gains a name, buffs, and persistent world presence. Defeating that nemesis later restores lost progress. Creates personal antagonists from organic gameplay. Fits the "modern mechanics" and "living the world" pillars. → [Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs](#)

Alternatives

- **Discipline-first route** — Rely on the vanilla death-and-reload loop.

Notes

- Death-alternative systems interact with every combat mod in the list. Verify [Shadow of Skyrim](#) does not conflict with [Valhalla Combat](#), [Precision](#), [TK Dodge](#), or any combat-animation mod from [modlist-animations.md](#). → [Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs](#)
- The nemesis system adds persistent NPCs and effects; verify save file size remains reasonable over long playthroughs with multiple nemeses active. → [Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs](#)
- Death-alternative mods can create edge cases with scripted-death sequences in quests. Check compatibility with [Alternate Perspective](#), [Wyrmswooth](#), [The Forgotten City](#), and major quest mods from [modlist-world-content.md](#). → [Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs](#)
- Confirm compatibility with Steam [1.6.1170](#) and the SKSE plugin stack from [modlist-foundations.md](#). → [Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs](#)

FILE: modlist-expanded-crafting.md

Crafting & Economy

MO2 Separator: [Expanded Systems](#) → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

Part of the [Expanded Systems](#) section. See also: [UI - Framework & HUD](#) (Character & Progression), [UI - Inventory & Items](#) (Magic & Perks), [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#) (Survival & Needs), [06e](#) (Followers & Reputation).

Alchemy Overhaul → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

This subsection decides whether alchemy is a disciplined support system for potions, poisons, and ingredients or a much larger rework that also starts reshaping cooking and survival-adjacent loops. The goal is to choose one clear alchemy philosophy before moving into cooking, crafting, and economy decisions that depend on it.

Baseline

- **Apothecary - An Alchemy Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Main baseline. Balanced modern route. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

Alternatives

- **Complete Alchemy and Cooking Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Large integrated comparison if [Elder Wilds](#) decides alchemy and cooking should become a major combined pillar. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Alchemy Potions and Food Adjustments** ([Nexus](#)) — Lighter fallback if the modern overhaul route proves to be more system weight than the list needs. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

Notes

- A very large alchemy package can quietly absorb cooking and food design, leaving the next subsection little room to decide anything.
- A restrained alchemy overhaul can undershoot the [Expanded Systems](#) pillar if too many adjacent systems also land on conservative choices. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- Potion, poison, and ingredient balance can become hard to reason about if the list mixes multiple overlapping consumable philosophies.
- Treat large food-and-cooking coverage as a deliberate expansion choice, not something that should quietly hitchhike into the alchemy baseline.

Cooking Systems → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

This subsection decides whether food and cooking are mostly ambient support for travel and downtime or a more deliberate progression-and-preparation layer in their own right. The goal is to choose a cooking baseline that complements the survival decision without making cooking entirely dependent on a heavy needs framework.

Baseline

- **Gourmet - A Cooking Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Main baseline. Balanced modern route. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

Alternatives

- **Complete Alchemy and Cooking Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Integrated comparison if the list later decides alchemy and cooking should be tightly fused. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Alchemy Potions and Food Adjustments** ([Nexus](#)) — Lighter fallback if the modern cooking route turns out to be more system weight than needed. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Mealtime - A Food and Recipe Mod** ([Nexus](#)) — Recipe-density companion if [Gourmet](#)'s recipe scope feels too narrow after playtesting. Adds new foods and recipes while sticking close to vanilla ingredient logic. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

Visual Companions

- **Hyper Realistic Cooked Beef** ([Nexus](#)) and **Hyper Realistic Bread** ([Nexus](#)) — Mesh/texture-only replacers for cooked-beef and bread models. Zero plugin overhead. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Skyrim 3D Cooking** ([Nexus](#)) — Replaces cooking pot, oven, and food-prep meshes with higher-detail 3D versions. Mesh-only, zero plugin overhead. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

- **Realistic HD Food Remastered (Nexus)** — Replaces vanilla food textures with higher-resolution, photorealistic versions covering bread, meat, fruits, vegetables, and prepared dishes. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

Notes

- Cooking can become too dependent on the survival framework and stop making sense as its own system.
- A very large cooking package can quietly absorb alchemy and economy ownership.
- A very light cooking layer can make inns, food, and downtime loops too forgettable to justify separate attention.
- Judge cooking on inns, camps, home bases, travel prep, and downtime rhythm rather than on recipe volume alone.

Smithing And Crafting Expansion → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

This subsection decides what crafting is supposed to do in *Elder Wilds*: lightly improve the vanilla smithing loop, become a broader rules-and-materials framework, or shift more responsibility toward NPC services and roleplay texture.

Baseline

- **Ars Metallica - Smithing Enhancement (Nexus)** — Player-crafting baseline. Handles smithing XP, tanning, mining, and basic crafting-loop improvements without heavy rules restructuring. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Honed Metal - NPC Crafting and Enchanting Services (Nexus)** — Locked NPC-service companion. Lets the player pay smiths and enchanters to craft, temper, enchant, and recharge items, making town services and gold economy matter without replacing the player crafting loop. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Thaumaturgy - An Enchanting Overhaul (Nexus)** — Simonrim-aligned enchanting overhaul that rebalances enchantment effects, costs, and progression. Designed to pair with *Mysticism* and *Adamant* baselines, closing the Simonrim crafting loop. Prerequisite for artifact-overhaul content. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

Alternatives

- **Complete Crafting Overhaul Remastered (Nexus)** — High-complexity comparison if *Elder Wilds* decides material logic and crafting rules should become a major progression pillar. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Summermyst - Enchantments of Skyrim (Nexus)** — Optional enchantment variety companion adding ~140 new enchantment effects to loot. Sits alongside *Thaumaturgy* rather than replacing it. Needs compatibility verification against *Thaumaturgy*, *Adamant*, *Mysticism*, and the chosen artifact overhaul before locking. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

Notes

- A very large crafting framework can quietly absorb economy and loot-balance ownership before those sections have a chance to make their own decisions.
- A very light crafting route can leave smithing too forgettable to justify separate attention within *Expanded Systems*. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- Mixing player-centric crafting expansion with strong NPC-service assumptions can produce an incoherent progression loop.
- *Ars Metallica* and *Honed Metal* serve different purposes and should be locked together as complementary rather than competing.

Economy And Loot Balance → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

This subsection decides what economy and loot are supposed to feel like in *Elder Wilds*: a lightly rebalanced merchant-and-pricing layer, a more deliberate loot-distribution framework, or a harsher scarcity-driven progression model.

Baseline

- **Trade and Barter (Nexus)** — Main baseline. Merchant-pricing route. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **C.O.I.N. - Coins of Interesting Nature (Nexus)** — Lightweight economic texture layer adding regional coin variety without touching prices or loot distribution. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **C.O.I.N. - Treasury Exchange (Nexus)** — Currency exchange companion adding mechanical purpose to C.O.I.N. by letting merchants convert coin types. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Roleplaying in Skyrim - Encounter Zones (Nexus)** — Optional encounter zone overhaul reworking all encounter zones for realism and variety with a randomizer. No hard requirements; ESL flagged. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Roleplaying in Skyrim - Evolving Economy (Nexus)** — Optional dynamic pricing layer where barter costs fluctuate based on resources, season, Civil War, reputation, and distance. Requires SKSE, *Papyrus Ini Manipulator*, and *powerofthree's Papyrus Extender*. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Roleplaying in Skyrim - Loot Overhaul (Nexus)** — Optional rarity-driven, contextually-aware loot overhaul with equipment breakage and de leveled artifacts. Requires SKSE, *Papyrus Ini Manipulator*, and *SkyUI*. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Narrative Loot (Nexus)** — Optional environmental-storytelling layer adding 1,629 lore-friendly miscellaneous items to loot lists for world-building texture. Does not change economy balance, prices, or weapon/armor distribution. Stacks cleanly with *Trade and Barter*, *C.O.I.N.*, or any other economy baseline. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

Alternatives

- **Open World Loot (Nexus)** — Deliberate structure-focused comparison if the project wants loot progression and encounter rewards to feel more curated. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **MorrowLoot Ultimate (Nexus)** — Heavy scarcity comparison only if the list truly wants rare-item access and de leveled loot as a defining identity pillar. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

Notes

- A heavy loot-distribution framework can quietly absorb crafting and progression ownership before later sections decide.
- A pricing-only route can undershoot if loot progression remains too close to vanilla.
- Harsh scarcity can make exploration, crafting, and reward pacing feel punitive rather than immersive.
- Treat pricing changes and loot-distribution changes as related but distinct philosophies.
- **Barter Limit Fix** belongs in `modlist-foundations.md` (Targeted Bugfix Mods), not as the economy-framework answer. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

Artifact And Unique Item Overhauls → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

This subsection owns the unique-item and artifact content packs that add depth to the named items the player finds in the world: Daedric artifacts, dragon priest masks, unique weapons, and miscellaneous quest items. **Elder Wilds** treats these mods as a separate ownership layer from crafting because artifact overhauls change what named items are, not how the player makes generic items. The right baseline is balanced-and-lore-friendly — these mods should make discoveries feel meaningful without breaking the loot ladder.

Baseline

- **Reliquary of Myth - Artifacts of Skyrim** ([Nexus](#)) — Artifact-stat and effect baseline. Rebalances nearly all of Skyrim's legendary artifacts with unique enchantments, new stats, and lore-friendly effects. Canonical mid-size artifact overhaul (12K endorsements, last updated March 2025). → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **ArteFakes - Unique Artifacts Replacer** ([Nexus](#)) — Model-replacement companion. Swaps the actual 3D models of unique items for higher-detail versions. Stacks cleanly with **Reliquary of Myth** (stats vs meshes). → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Konahrik's Accoutrements** ([Nexus](#)) — Dragon-priest-specific companion. Upgrades named Dragon Priest encounters with new gear, masks with their own stat curves, and harder fights. The only one that adds new encounters and the only one the Legacy of the Dragonborn museum integration cares about directly. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Unique Items Tweaks - Improved Miscellaneous Artifacts** ([Nexus](#)) — Gap-filler improving miscellaneous artifacts **Reliquary of Myth** does not cover. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Artificer - An Artifact Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Simonrim-aligned alternative to **Reliquary of Myth**. Requires **Thaumaturgy** and **Mysticism** as prerequisites (both locked). Prefer if full Simonrim ecosystem coherence and the most recently maintained option (last updated April 2026) matter more. Choose one artifact overhaul baseline — not both. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

Alternatives

- **Discipline-first route** — Rely on vanilla artifact stats. Vanilla artifacts are functional but very front-loaded toward late-game Daedric items.

Notes

- Stacking **Reliquary of Myth** with **ArteFakes** and **Unique Items Tweaks** touches every unique-item record in the game. They are designed to stack, but verify the Synthesis patcher chain in **14d** does not re-balance the same records. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Konahrik's Accoutrements** adds new Dragon Priest encounters that may not be patched into Legacy of the Dragonborn's display system. Check the **LoTD Patches (Official)** hub in `modlist-lotd.md` for an integration patch. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- Artifact overhauls that rebalance too aggressively can break encounter expectations. Verify Wuuthrad, Mehrunes' Razor, and the Gauldur weapons feel right before lock-in.
- **Unique Items Tweaks** overlaps lightly with **Reliquary of Myth** on a small number of records. Verify with a Bashed Patch run. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

Weapon Pack Additions → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

This subsection owns the weapon content packs that add new named and leveled-list weapons to the world: swords, axes, maces, bows, and specialty weapons that fit vanilla's medieval-Nordic aesthetic. It is kept separate from **Smithing And Crafting Expansion** (crafting system) and the weapon-quality-overhaul layer in `modlist-survival-combat.md` (balance). This subsection owns content variety. The right baseline is "more variety without diluting the loot ladder".

Baseline

- **Heavy Armory - New Weapons** ([Nexus](#)) — Content-variety baseline. Adds 150+ lore-friendly weapons across 11 new types (halberds, spears, glaives, shortswords, quarterstaves, mauls, hatchets, clubs, long maces, shortspears, tridents) with OAR-compatible custom animations for polearms and leveled-list integration. Actively maintained (v6.1.6, 16.8K endorsements). → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **LeanWolf's Better-Shaped Weapons SE** ([Nexus](#)) — Mesh-quality companion upgrading the silhouette of vanilla weapons. Stacks cleanly with **Heavy Armory** (different records). → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Legendary Skyrim Crossbows and Bows SSE** ([Nexus](#)) — Specialty route for crossbow-and-bow archetype. Adds new crossbow and bow models with named and unique variants. Lock only if ranged combat is a viable build path. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

Alternatives

- **Immersive Weapons** ([Nexus](#)) — Legacy comparison for maximum raw weapon count (230+). Unmaintained since April 2018. Synthesis patcher chain in **14d** has explicit **Bash Tags** for it. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Discipline-first route** — Rely on vanilla weapons only.

Notes

- **Heavy Armory** uses standard leveled-list integration and does not require synthesis patcher intervention the way **Immersive Weapons** does. A dedicated **Heavy Armory - Adamant Addon** (mod 144316) provides Simonrim-aligned perk integration. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **LeanWolf's Better-Shaped Weapons** can conflict with **Unique Items Tweaks** and **Reliquary of Myth** on unique-weapon records. Verify model swaps do not affect the visual identity of iconic unique items. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Legendary Skyrim Crossbows and Bows** makes crossbows a meaningful archetype — **modlist-survival-combat.md** difficulty decisions need to account for ranged damage output. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- All three weapon mods add new models — **Pandora** and **BodySlide** rebuild triggers in 14d fire whenever any of them is updated. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

Armor Pack Additions → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

This subsection owns the armor content packs that add new named and leveled-list armors to the world: light, heavy, and specialty armors that fit the medieval-Nordic aesthetic of vanilla Skyrim. The right baseline is the same as the weapons subsection: more variety without diluting the loot ladder.

Baseline

- **Immersive Armors (Nexus)** — Content-variety baseline. Adds 200+ new armors (light, heavy, mage, fur, leather) with leveled-list integration. Canonical armor content pack (206K endorsements). Synthesis patcher chain in 14d has explicit **Bash Tags** for it. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **NordwarUA Total Armor and Weapon Compilation (Nexus)** — Vanilla-armor model overhaul compiling six NordwarUA mods. Standardizes cubemaps and removes stat changes, providing a visual upgrade without NPC balance changes. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Common Clothes and Armors (Nexus)** — Light-armor-diversity companion adding clothing-and-light-armor variants for bandits, sellswords, and travelers. The clothing-side companion to **NordwarUA**. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Bandolier - Bags and Pouches Classic (Nexus)** — Carry-capacity utility layer. Adds bags, pouches, and bandoliers with MCM configuration. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Immersive Armors Retexture and Mesh Fixes SE (Nexus)** — Required visual companion. Fixes broken meshes, outdated textures, and UV maps for IA sets. Foundation that other IA mesh mods build on. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Immersive Armors - SSE CBBE 3BA BodySlide (Nexus)** — BodySlide files for all female IA outfits. Standalone conversion that replaces IA's original female meshes. Choose one female conversion path — do not stack with the Retexture and Mesh Fixes mod's bundled CBBE meshes. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Immersive Armor HIMBO Conversion V2 (Nexus)** — BodySlide conversion of all IA armors for HIMBO. Designed to stack on top of the Retexture and Mesh Fixes mod. Includes CBBE compatibility patch. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Immersive Armors - Realistic Armors replace SE by Xtudo (Nexus)** — Optional art-direction patch swapping 10 IA sets for NordWarUA's Realistic Armors. Addresses "too much The Witcher" criticism. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

Stack order for a full IA visual pipeline: **Immersive Armors** → **Immersive Armors Retexture and Mesh Fixes SE** → (optional) **IA - Realistic Armors replace by Xtudo** → (optional, choose one female path) **IA CBBE 3BA BodySlide** OR the CBBE compatibility patch bundled with **IA HIMBO Conversion V2** → (optional, if male body) **IA HIMBO Conversion V2**. Run BodySlide after all IA mods are installed, then rebuild all IA batches.

Alternatives

- **Discipline-first route** — Rely on vanilla armor sets only.

Notes

- **Immersive Armors** is approaching a decade unmaintained (last updated November 2016) — verify game version compatibility before locking. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **NordwarUA Total Armor** standardizes cubemaps across all six sub-mods — any mod that depended on the original cubemaps needs re-testing. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Common Clothes and Armors** adds clothing to NPC leveled lists. If **Armor and Clothing Extension** is also in the list, verify NPCs look right after both are active. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Bandolier** changes the inventory system — carry-weight design needs to account for additional slots. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- The Retexture and Mesh Fixes mod and the CBBE 3BA BodySlide conversion are **not** stackable for female meshes. The Retexture and Mesh Fixes author explicitly warns against mixing. The HIMBO Conversion V2 avoids this conflict because it is designed to stack on top of the Retexture and Mesh Fixes mod.
- The Realistic Armors replace mod requires **Realistic Armor** (36151) as a hard dependency alongside **Immersive Armors**. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- All IA companion mods add new models — **Pandora** and **BodySlide** rebuild triggers in 14d fire whenever any of them is updated. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

Clothing And Wardrobe Extensions → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

This subsection owns the clothing content packs that add new clothing, cloaks, and wearable non-armor items to the world: common clothes, noble clothes, cloaks, and backpacks. The right baseline is "more wardrobe variety without making every NPC a fashion show".

Baseline

- **Armor and Clothing Extension (Nexus)** — Clothing-diversity baseline. Adds lore-friendly clothing options and NPC-appropriate attire (35K+ endorsements). Requires **RUSTIC CLOTHING - SE** (section 02) and **SkyUI** (section 01) — both already locked. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Common Clothes and Armors (Nexus)** — Common-cloth variety companion pairing with ACE to give bandit-and-sellsword archetypes real visual variety. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

- **Sforzinda Imitations (Nexus)** — Handmade-outfit branch for curated boutique clothing. Not automatic baseline coverage but the cleanest verified addition for distinct crafted outfits. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Cloaks of Skyrim (Nexus)** — Cloak-slot addition. Adds 100+ new cloaks for player and NPCs via SPID distribution. The most visually impactful wearable slot in third-person. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Colovian Noble Clothes (Nexus)** — High-status clothing pass adding noble and Imperial-themed clothing. Pairs with Beyond Skyrim content. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- **Knapsack Backpacks SE (Nexus)** — Carry-and-wearable utility adding backpacks with MCM configuration. Cosmetic companion to [Bandolier](#) (armor subsection). → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

Alternatives

- **Discipline-first route** — Rely on vanilla clothing only.

Notes

- [Armor and Clothing Extension](#) requires [RUSTIC CLOTHING - SE](#) and [SkyUI](#) — both already in the list. Verify load order keeps [RUSTIC CLOTHING](#) above ACE. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- [Common Clothes and Armors](#) is referenced in both this subsection and the armor subsection above. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- [Sforzinda Imitations](#) is a curated boutique pack — treat as an explicit add-on branch, not automatic baseline coverage. If it pulls the list toward a boutique-fantasy wardrobe tone, cut it. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- [Cloaks of Skyrim](#) adds 100+ new cloak items. If [modlist-third-person.md](#) adds a custom cloak-slot overhaul, verify the two stack cleanly. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- [Colovian Noble Clothes](#) is a smaller mod with less community-maintenance footprint — verify the mod page for known issues before locking. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)
- [Knapsack Backpacks SE](#) (cosmetic) and [Bandolier](#) (inventory) can stack, but verify the inventory UI does not show duplicate bag icons. → [Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy](#)

FILE: modlist-expanded-followers.md

Followers & Reputation

MO2 Separator: [Expanded Systems](#) → [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#)

Part of the [Expanded Systems](#) section. See also: [UI - Framework & HUD](#) (Character & Progression), [UI - Inventory & Items](#) (Magic & Perks), [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#) (Survival & Needs), [06d](#) (Crafting & Economy).

Crime, Reputation, And Social Systems → [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#)

This subsection decides how much the world should notice what the player does socially: whether reputation should quietly shape reactions across the province, whether stealth and criminal behavior should gain more expressive tools, or whether city-side suspicion and guard behavior should become more active.

Baseline

- **Skyrim Reputation (Nexus)** — Main baseline for reputation. → [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#)
- **The Choice is Yours (Nexus)** — Roleplay-facing companion for stricter control over quest auto-start pressure in a content-heavy run. → [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#)
- **To Your Face SE - AE - VR (Nexus)** — Low-drama social-polish companion if normal city and tavern play still feels too noisy from vanilla greeting behavior. → [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#)
- **Steal off Scoundrels - Pickpocketing Criminals is Not Stealing (Nexus)** — Optional lightweight SKSE plugin preventing pickpocketing from being flagged as stealing when the target is a criminal (bandits, forsworn, etc.). No ESP, no conflicts. → [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#)

Alternatives

- **Suspicious City Guards (Nexus)** — More focused comparison if the main goal is grounded urban tension around suspicious behavior. → [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#)
- **Book Of Shadows - Behaviour Based Stealth Additions (Nexus)** — High-expression branch if the project wants crime and stealth to become a much larger playstyle pillar rather than a world-reaction layer. → [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#)

Notes

- A very light social-response layer can undershoot and leave crime and reputation too close to vanilla.
- A stealth-heavy crime toolkit can make one playstyle dominate a subsection that should still support broader roleplay.
- City suspicion systems can become annoying if they create constant friction without enough payoff.
- Targeted fixes like [Simple Offence Suppression](#) belong in [modlist-foundations.md](#) (Targeted Bugfix Mods), not as the social-system answer. → [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#)
- Keep stealth-expression tooling separate from broader world-reaction goals so this subsection does not become a stealth overhaul by accident.

Followers And Companion Systems → Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation

This subsection decides how **Elder Wilds** wants companions to function at the systems level: whether follower management should be modern and flexible, whether a lighter older framework is enough, or whether the project wants a more intervention-heavy companion-control layer.

Baseline

- **Nether's Follower Framework (Nexus)** — Main baseline. Modern flexible route. → [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#)

Alternatives

- **EFF - Extensible Follower Framework (Nexus)** — Classic comparison if the project wants a simpler established management route. → [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#)
- **Amazing Follower Tweaks SE (Nexus)** — Heavy-management branch if the list truly wants follower control and party behavior to become a more dominant systems pillar. → [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#)

Notes

- A very light or dated framework can undershoot and leave companions awkward to manage once the list grows.
- A heavy follower-control framework can make party management dominate ordinary play more than intended.
- Generic follower frameworks can conflict with custom companions that are better left outside them.
- Keep follower-framework choice separate from later custom-follower picks; this subsection owns party-management philosophy, not named companion selection.

Romance, Marriage, And Companionship → Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation

This subsection owns the SFW romance and marriage layer: how marriage mechanics should be expanded, how dialogue with spouses and romance interests should feel modern, and which opt-in quest-driven romance arcs the list should support. The chosen baseline is fade-to-black, not explicit content. It is a systems-and-dialogue layer, not a follower-content layer — custom named followers belong in `modlist-npcs.md`.

Baseline

- **Relationship Dialogue Overhaul - RDO SE (Nexus)** — Dialogue-expansion baseline. Adds 5,000+ fully-voiced new lines for vanilla NPCs, followers, and spouses using original voices. Community-canonical (137K endorsements), fully SFW, most compatible choice (dialogue only, no mechanics). → [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#)
- **Amorous Adventures** (clean variant) (Nexus) — Opt-in romance-quest route. Clean build ships as fade-to-black, fitting the SFW rule. Adds fully voiced romance arcs for Lydia, Serana, Elisif, and other marriage-eligible NPCs. Lock only the clean variant. → [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#)
- **Marriage Mod - To Have And To Hold (Nexus)** — Marriage-machinery expansion supporting up to 11 simultaneous spouses, divorce and remarriage, enhanced wedding ceremony, and dynamic events tied to player progress. → [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#)
- **Serana Dialogue Add-On (Nexus)** — Best-in-class single-companion expansion. Adds 7,000+ new fully-voiced lines for Serana plus new story arcs, romance progression, and quest commentary. Complements RDO (51K endorsements). → [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#)

Alternatives

- **Discipline-first route** — Rely on vanilla marriage mechanics. Only if **Elder Wilds** explicitly decides romance is out of scope.

Notes

- The wrong Amorous Adventures variant breaks the SFW rule. The download must be the clean build, not the explicit build.
- Marriage-machinery mods can conflict with each other; do not stack **To Have And To Hold** with another multi-spouse mod. → [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#)
- Romance dialogue expansion can conflict with custom-voiced follower mods from `modlist-npcs.md` that replace the same NPC's voice. → [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#)
- Romance quest mods add non-trivial content that should be reviewed against the quest section in `modlist-world-content.md` to avoid doubling up on a single NPC's quest line. → [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#)
- Marriage events triggered by **To Have And To Hold** can fire during unintended moments if not configured; check MCM for event timing and cooldown settings. → [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#)

FILE: modlist-world-feel.md

Immersive Scale and World Feel

MO2 Separator: `World Feel` → `World Feel - Timescale & Travel`, `World Feel - Soundscapes`, `World Feel - Nights & Wildlife`, `World Feel - Cities & Landmarks`

Timescale And Calendar Adjustments → World Feel - Timescale & Travel

This subsection owns how quickly days pass, whether routine actions consume believable chunks of time, and how clearly the calendar or season layer supports the feeling that Skyrim has real passing days. It should strengthen day rhythm without turning into schedule micromanagement.

Baseline

- **Time Flies SE (Nexus)** — Makes ordinary play loops feel more grounded without turning the subsection into abstract clock tuning. → [World Feel - Timescale & Travel](#)
- **Seasonal Calendar (Nexus)** — Narrow companion if the final weather-and-season direction makes explicit calendar readability worthwhile. → [World Feel - Timescale & Travel](#)
- **Seasons of Skyrim SKSE (Nexus) + Turn of the Seasons (Nexus)** — High-commitment seasonal-world branch. Mature framework (v1.8.6, last updated June 2025, AE 1.6.1130+ compatible) with dramatic seasonal world changes. Cost: 4× DynDOLOD generation passes, 4× grass caches, and a meaningful patch footprint (exterior lighting, grass stack, tree mods). Only adopt if the project owns that LOD-generation workflow — if the list already runs DynDOLOD for 4K, the additional passes are the main extra cost. → [World Feel - Timescale & Travel](#)

Alternatives

- **Dynamic Timescale - Remade (Nexus)** — Environment-aware time shifts instead of direct action-time costs. Weaker grounding for routine actions than the action-time route. → [World Feel - Timescale & Travel](#)

Notes

- Slowing time can make ordinary play feel dutiful instead of immersive.
- Using multiple pacing systems at once makes it harder to understand why time feels right or wrong.
- **Seasons of Skyrim SKSE** multiplies LOD generation work and interacts with tree overhauls, grass mods, and road mods. Not a casual add-on; it is a workflow commitment. → [World Feel - Timescale & Travel](#)
- Preserve boundaries with later travel rules, survival pacing, night visibility, and graphics-side weather decisions.

Travel Pacing And Carriage Fast Travel Rules → [World Feel - Timescale & Travel](#)

This subsection owns how much friction, structure, and world texture sits between major locations once the player is ready to move across Skyrim. It should decide whether the list strengthens vanilla carriage and ferry travel, expands stop coverage, or keeps map fast travel available but costly.

Baseline

- **Carriage and Ferry Travel Overhaul (Nexus)** — Improves the vanilla public-travel layer directly without forcing a harsher fast-travel philosophy. → [World Feel - Timescale & Travel](#)
- **Carriage Drivers Are Alive (Nexus)** — Carriage-driver character layer: names, schedules, and dialogue make the carriage loop feel inhabited rather than mechanical. Complements the overhaul. → [World Feel - Timescale & Travel](#)
- **Carriages and Stables Dialogue Bundle (Nexus)** — Dialogue companion adding bribes, rumors, and destination chat. Stacks cleanly with **Carriage Drivers Are Alive** (one adds character records, the other adds dialogue). → [World Feel - Timescale & Travel](#)

Alternatives

- **Carriage Stops of Skyrim (Nexus)** — Route-coverage expansion if travel infrastructure itself should feel broader. More infrastructure but less direct improvement to the existing layer. → [World Feel - Timescale & Travel](#)
- **Fast Travel Cost (Nexus)** — Economic-pressure branch if map fast travel should remain available but no longer consequence-free. Solves a cost problem rather than a travel-structure problem. → [World Feel - Timescale & Travel](#)
- **Campfire (Nexus)** — Complementary camping-and-rest branch affecting travel pacing through campsite planning and field cooking. Already in the expanded-systems survival conversation; relevant here as a travel-pacing tool regardless of which survival framework is selected. → [World Feel - Timescale & Travel](#)
- **Journeyman - A Fast Travel Overhaul (Nexus)** — Fast-travel friction layer by Simon Magus. Restricts fast travel unless the player has crafted or purchased a Travel Pack (leather + leather strips + firewood + torch). A compromise between full fast-travel removal (survival-mode approach) and unrestricted map-clicking — travel remains possible but requires preparation. Built-in support for COCKS and I4; optional Survival Mode-only mode. Fits the "living the world" pillar without forcing a no-fast-travel commitment. → [World Feel - Timescale & Travel](#)
 - **Main file:** **Journeyman** (the SKSE plugin + ESP). One main file; no optional variants needed.

Notes

- Travel can become more expensive or restricted without becoming more interesting.
- Stacking multiple travel-policy mods makes it hard to tell which one is really setting pace.
- Gold pressure can be used to solve a route-coverage problem that actually needs better travel infrastructure.
- **Carriage and Ferry Travel Overhaul** last updated November 2020; verify AE 1.6.1170 compatibility as the mod predates the Anniversary Edition.
- Keep this subsection focused on travel structure and carriage/ferry policy rather than survival maintenance from [modlist-expanded-systems.md](#) or map ownership from [modlist-ui.md](#).

Encounter Spacing And Wilderness Feel → [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#)

This subsection owns how busy, calm, or deliberately spaced wilderness travel feels between destinations. It should decide whether roads and wilds feel more alive through additional encounters, reactive events, or larger faction-patrol presence without drifting into wildlife ecology or roadside clutter.

Baseline

- **Extended Encounters (Nexus)** — Broad wilderness and road activity while staying lightweight and centered on ordinary travel. → [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#)

Alternatives

- **Radiance Encounters (Nexus)** — Reactive world-event route if encounter texture should lean more into world reactivity and consequences. → [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#)
- **Immersive Patrols SE AE (Nexus)** — Faction-patrol route if civil-war-adjacent movement should become a much more visible part of wilderness travel. → [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#)

Notes

- Normal travel can become a stream of interruptions instead of a better-paced wilderness experience.
- Stacking several encounter systems makes the world feel busier than intended.
- Faction patrols can be used to solve an ambient-spacing problem they were never meant to answer.
- Keep this subsection separate from wildlife ecology, roadside clutter, and broader survival friction.

Soundscape And Ambient Audio → [World Feel - Soundscapes](#)

This subsection owns the ambient sound texture of the world: what roads, settlements, wilderness, and interiors sound like during ordinary exploration. It should make the world feel sonically alive without turning every space into constant audio clutter or absorbing the broader audio section.

Baseline

- **Sounds of Skyrim Complete SE (Nexus)** — Directly targets roads, wilderness, dungeons, and settled spaces as part of one exploration-facing ambient project. → [World Feel - Soundscapes](#)

Alternatives

- **Acoustic Space Improvement Fixes (Nexus)** — Narrower comparison if the real weakness is inconsistent interior ambience and reverb treatment rather than world quietness. → [World Feel - Soundscapes](#)
- Discipline-first: keep the current sound stack restrained if playtesting shows the world already sounds readable enough. → [World Feel - Soundscapes](#)

Notes

- More sounds can produce a noisier world instead of a better soundscape.
- A narrow interior-acoustics fix can be chosen when the real problem is a flat outdoor soundscape, or vice versa.
- Keep broader audio-overhaul ownership out of this section — that belongs in [modlist-audio.md](#).

City Size, Outskirts, And Population Feel → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)

This subsection owns how large, inhabited, and spatially convincing cities feel during ordinary play: arriving at gates, moving through main streets, and judging whether settlements feel too small, too empty, or too overbuilt. It should stay separate from roadside clutter, later world-content population additions, and the graphics-side city or road compatibility burden already tracked in [modlist-graphics-shaders.md](#).

Baseline

- **Spaghetti's Cities - AIO (Nexus)** — Makes cities feel denser and more inhabited without immediately turning into a giant patch-management project. → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)

Alternatives

- **Dawn of Skyrim (Director's Cut) SE (Nexus)** — Stronger city-core expansion if major holds still feel too thin. Last updated June 2020; narrower compatibility with newer city and worldspace mods. → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)
- **JK's Skyrim (Nexus)** — Heavier all-in-one transformation. Only if the list truly wants city transformation to become a much louder identity pillar and is prepared for the broader compatibility pressure. → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)

Notes

- A large city overhaul can be chosen because it is famous rather than because the cities actually need that much transformation.
- A lighter density pass may solve the real problem more cleanly than a heavier worldspace edit.
- Compatibility cost with roads, lighting, snow, trees, and LOD can be underestimated.
- Keep broad population additions for later world-content or NPC ownership instead of solving emptiness only by stacking more residents here.

Roadside Clutter, Ruins, And Landmark Density → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)

This subsection owns the small-to-mid-scale worldspace texture between major destinations: roadside objects, old ruins, ancient remnants, signposts, and minor landmark presence. It should make the world feel richer to cross without collapsing into city overhauls, wildlife ecology, or broad world-content expansion.

Baseline

- **Ancient Land (Nexus)** — Adds visible static worldspace flavor and distant landmark presence without turning into a heavy settlement-overhaul or content-expansion project. → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)

- **Point The Way (Nexus)** — Road guidance and signposting for clearer travel legibility. → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)
- **Ryn's Standing Stones (Nexus)** — Locked standing-stone landmark baseline. Each of the 13 stones becomes a unique environmental setpiece with custom meshes, landscape work, and environmental storytelling — compatible with any standing-stone perk overhaul (world geometry only, no gameplay effects). → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)

Alternatives

- **Interesting Roads (Nexus)** — Lighter roadside variety if the world mainly needs more visual variety rather than overt ancient-landmark identity. Last updated November 2020; asset-only, low compatibility risk. → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)
- **Giant Crab Shells - Mihail's Shards of Immersion (Nexus)** — Roadside-beauty addition. Ancient giant crab shells along the northern coast and Solstheim with loot/enemy encounters. Fits the "big, awe-inspiring world" pillar. 789 endorsements, ESL-flagged. → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)

Notes

- Weak travel texture can be over-solved with too many worldspace edits at once.
- Dramatic screenshots can make a broad landmark mod look more necessary than it is in normal play.
- Compatibility pressure with roads, landscape, snow, lighting, and LOD can climb quickly.
- Keep broader new-settlement, quest-location, or population additions for later world-content ownership.

Wildlife And Creature Ecology → [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#)

This subsection owns the living-animal side of world feel: how varied wildlife is, how predators and prey feel in the landscape, and whether creatures contribute to a believable ecological texture rather than existing only as random combat spawns. It should make wilderness travel feel biologically alive without collapsing into creature-animation ownership, encounter-density spam, or broader NPC and world-content scope.

Baseline

- **Animallica SE - Skyrim Wildlife Overhaul (Nexus)** — Makes Skyrim feel more biologically varied and alive during ordinary travel without assuming the subsection should become primarily about harsher combat behavior. → [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#)
- **Butterflies Land True (Nexus)** — Lightweight insect-behavior layer. Makes butterflies land on surfaces rather than hovering indefinitely. No scripts, ESL-flagged, ~1 KB. → [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#)

Alternatives

- **One With Nature - Dynamic Animals and Creatures SE (Nexus)** — Creature relationship tuning and ecological feel rather than raw wildlife variety. Last updated September 2019; script-heavy — verify AE compatibility and confirm no save-bloat risk before adopting. → [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#)
- **Savage Skyrim (Nexus)** — Heavier danger-and-behavior route. Only if the list truly wants wilderness creatures to become much more threatening as part of the world-feel identity. → [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#)
- **Frogs - Mihail Monsters and Animals (Nexus)** — Lightweight creature ambient addition. 4 frog variants, new food item (frog legs), ESL-flagged, 2,986 endorsements. → [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#)

Notes

- Weak wilderness feel can be over-solved by piling on more creature content than the world actually needs.
- Ecology tuning can drift into encounter-density or combat-balance ownership.
- Heavier danger-oriented creature behavior can overpower the calmer ecological texture this subsection is supposed to judge.
- Keep creature-animation ownership in [modlist-animations.md](#), encounter-density ownership earlier in this section, and broader world-content additions in later sections.

Road Network And Surface Overhaul → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)

This subsection owns the physical road network: whether the roads themselves feel like built infrastructure or just a painted texture on the ground. It is separate from roadside landmark density and from road-texture ownership in [modlist-graphics-shaders.md](#). This section is about road presentation at the mesh and geometry level, not surface materials.

Baseline

- **Blended Roads - Light Plugin (ESL) (Nexus)** — Locked baseline. Seamless road-to-terrain texture blending with no worldspace edits, no patch requirements, and no grass-cache regeneration. Best visual improvement-to-complexity ratio for this stack. → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)
- **Interesting Roads (Nexus)** — Lightweight roadside character addition (barrels, carts, signs). Asset-only, no patching required. → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)
- **Point The Way (Nexus)** — Navigational signposting at junctions. Asset-only, no patching required. → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)

Alternatives

- Discipline-first: let [modlist-graphics-shaders.md](#) texture replacers carry all road visual improvement with no extra geometry or object additions. → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)

Notes

- [Blended Roads - Light Plugin](#) is a visual improvement, not a road geometry overhaul. Roads will not read as deliberately constructed infrastructure the way authored road meshes would achieve. → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)

- Roadside object mods ([Interesting Roads](#), [Point The Way](#)) stack additively with city overhauls but may clip with mod-added structures near road edges. Visual concern, not gameplay. → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)
- Heavier option rejected:** [Northern Roads](#) (authored road meshes, full network overhaul) was evaluated and rejected due to the patch burden at this modlist's complexity level — the official patch collection alone covers six major mods, and every new content mod that touches roads creates another unresolved conflict. If the project later decides it wants authored road geometry, adopting it retroactively requires re-generating grass caches, adding the full patch collection, and resolving any new content mod conflicts that have accumulated since the lock-in. → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)
- Road surface texture quality is still owned by [modlist-graphics-shaders.md](#) ([Blended Roads](#) handles blending, not surface material). → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)

Environmental Atmosphere: Wind And Dynamic Effects → [World Feel - Soundscapes](#)

This subsection owns how wind, atmospheric movement, and dynamic environmental effects make the world feel physically alive during ordinary exploration. It should add perceptible world-layer motion — wind through trees and grass, dynamic cloth physics, and airborne particle behavior — without collapsing into weather-system ownership or graphics-side shader territory.

Baseline

- Dynamic Wind Framework - SKSE Plugin** ([Nexus](#)) — Infrastructure baseline. Enables weather-aware wind physics for trees, grass, and environmental elements. Requires Address Library for SKSE Plugins (already in the foundation layer). → [World Feel - Soundscapes](#)
- Dynamic Wind - Skyrim** ([Nexus](#)) — Required data companion. Provides Skyrim-specific wind profiles tied to weather and location cells. → [World Feel - Soundscapes](#)
- Particle Wind - SKSE Plugin** ([Nexus](#)) — Particle-level companion. Makes dust, leaves, snow, and ash particles respond to wind direction in real time. By the same author as Dynamic Wind Framework; integration expected to be clean. → [World Feel - Soundscapes](#)
- Realistic Boat Bobbing SE** ([Nexus](#)) — Optional water-surface companion. Boats bob with idle animations that were shipped but never enabled in vanilla. Purely cosmetic. → [World Feel - Soundscapes](#)
- Realistic Boat Bobbing SE - BOS Edition** ([Nexus](#)) — Extends boat-bobbing to mod-added boats. Requires [Base Object Swapper](#) and the base mod. → [World Feel - Soundscapes](#)
- R.A.S.S. - Rain Ash And Snow Shaders** ([Nexus](#)) — Optional environmental-visual companion. Applies visible rain droplets, snow accumulation, ash particles, and frost shaders to player and NPCs during appropriate weather. Visual-only, no gameplay changes. 33K+ endorsements. → [World Feel - Soundscapes](#)

Notes

- R.A.S.S. + Community Shaders coexistence:** [Community Shaders](#) includes its own [Wetness Effects](#) module. R.A.S.S. applies droplets to actor surfaces; CS Wetness applies environmental wetness to terrain and objects, so they should coexist without visual conflicts. Verify in testing that the combined output does not create double-wetness artifacts or performance issues. If conflicts arise, disable CS Wetness Effects or R.A.S.S. accordingly. → [World Feel - Soundscapes](#)
- Dynamic wind is a visual-enhancement layer, not a gameplay system. If performance is a concern, it is the easiest subsection to skip.
- Verify the framework works cleanly with the chosen tree mod, grass stack, and ENB/community shader before locking. Last updated May 2026.
- Keep this subsection separate from broader weather-system ownership (belongs in [modlist-graphics-shaders.md](#)'s Weather and Lighting subsection) and from graphics-side cloth physics (belongs in [modlist-graphics-shaders.md](#)'s physics decisions).

Night Darkness And Visibility Balance → [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#)

This subsection owns how dark Skyrim nights should feel during ordinary travel and what kind of visibility support still keeps that darkness readable rather than annoying. The goal is to make nighttime travel feel more consequential and atmospheric without collapsing into broader weather, lighting, or survival-overhaul ownership handled elsewhere.

Baseline

- Weather/shader darkness** — Darkness baseline comes from the weather mod and ENB/Community Shaders pair selected in [modlist-graphics-shaders.md](#) first. If nights still need more punch after that stack is locked, add **Simply Darker Nights (SSE)** ([Nexus](#)) as a simple image-space overlay, but verify it is not redundant. → [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#)
- Lanterns of Skyrim II** ([Nexus](#)) — Road and settlement exterior lighting placement layer. v4.3 (November 2025), merged Tamriel Master Lights for full road + settlement coverage. Lighting-framework-agnostic — places lantern meshes and light records, with the CS-native True Light + CS Light handling actual bulb illumination on top. FOMOD patch hub covers ~30-50 patches (JK's Skyrim, 3DNPC, Campfire, and more) vs Lux Via's ~80-120. Regional lantern variants, wind-animated, shadow-casting, MCM toggles. → [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#)
- CS Lantern Lights - Lanterns of Skyrim II** ([Nexus](#)) — CS particle lights for LoS II lanterns. Adds Community Shaders-native particle illumination to every LoS II lamp post. Install after LoS II. → [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#)
- Simple Wearable Lanterns - Remastered** ([Nexus](#)) — Preferred carried-visibility branch. Modern, lightweight, no SKSE requirement, covers the basic use case without feature creep. → [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#)

Alternatives

- Torches Candlelight and Lanterns** ([Nexus](#)) — Full-featured alternative if the list wants physics-equipped lanterns, NPC distribution, and hotkey-driven hand/hip switching. Requires BOS and MCM Helper — heavier dependency. HDT-SMP variants require FSMP and may have performance cost on lower-end systems. → [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#)
- Realistic Usable Lanterns** ([Nexus](#)) — Survival-oriented alternative if finite candles as a consumable resource is preferred over unlimited magic light. Lightweight, no SKSE. → [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#)

- **Handheld Lanterns - HDT-SMP (Nexus)** — Physics-equipped hand lantern with HDT-SMP chain/cloth physics. Equippable lantern that sways naturally with player movement, casts real-time shadows, and supports multiple lantern styles. Requires FSMP (already in the animation stack). Adds a visually striking carried-light option that feels more physical than static lantern models. → [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#)
 - **Main file:** [Handheld Lanterns - HDT-SMP](#) (FOMOD installer). Choose your preferred lantern style and physics intensity during installation.

Notes

- Weak night mood can trigger stacking several visibility systems at once and losing control of the overall night identity.
- Nights can be made darker in theory but then undermined with so much added light support that the mood barely changes.
- A carried-light solution can become a constant crutch instead of a deliberate travel tool.
- [Lanterns of Skyrim II](#) is a worldspace-editing mod requiring patches for city overhauls, road mods, and new-worldspace content. The FOMOD patch hub is self-contained — run it after the full worldspace stack is settled. Patch burden is roughly half of Lux Via's.
- Keep this subsection about nighttime feel and travel readability rather than generic display calibration, graphics-lighting philosophy, or survival maintenance.

Activation Text → [World Feel - Timescale & Travel](#) And Interaction Immersion

This subsection owns whether the activation prompt text and NPC identification feel immersive and descriptive rather than generic. It should make ordinary interactions read as specific actions instead of a blanket "Activate" label, without introducing gameplay systems or survival mechanics.

Baseline

- **Roleplaying In Skyrim - Immersive Activators (Nexus)** — Optional interaction-immersion layer. Extremely lightweight (8KB, no ongoing scripts, no SKSE), replaces generic activation prompts with descriptive text (e.g., "Read Book" instead of "Activate"), and hides NPC names until interaction (toggleable via MCM). Compatible with any mod that does not also change activation text. → [World Feel - Timescale & Travel](#)

Notes

- Hiding NPC names until interaction may frustrate players who rely on visible names for quest targets or dialogue choices. The MCM toggle mitigates this.
- Any other mod that changes activation text will conflict. Verify no other list entry duplicates this function.

Candidate TODO Additions

Timescale & Travel → [World Feel - Timescale & Travel](#)

- [Extended Stay - Longer inn](#) — inn stay duration extension → [World Feel - Timescale & Travel](#)
- [Sleep Tight SE](#) (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/20680>) — NPCs follow sleep schedules and wear sleepwear at night, reinforcing believable daily routines → [World Feel - Timescale & Travel](#)
- [Sleep Tight - NPCs wear underwear or lingerie](#) (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/87132>) — NPCs wear underwear beneath their clothes, adding immersion when clothes are removed or in sleep situations. CBBE 3BA and HIMBO. → [World Feel - Timescale & Travel](#)

Nights & Wildlife → [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#)

- [Wearable Lanterns](#) — carried lantern (compare to [Simple Wearable Lanterns - Remastered](#) already listed below) → [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#)

Cities & Landmarks → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)

- [Nordic Runestones \(?\)](#) — runestone world objects → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)
- [Place of Power \(?\)](#) — standing stone visual overhaul → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)
- [Whiterun Horse Statues](#) — Whiterun landmark horse statues → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)
- [Solitude Statuary](#) — Solitude statue/decoration objects → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)
- [s6o6t LORE - Mundane Stones](#) — standing stone 3D replacer → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)
- [Northern Roads - Clutters Only My Version](#) (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/126175>) — Northern Roads clutter-only variant → [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)

FILE: modlist-world-content.md

World Content

MO2 Separator: [World Content](#) → [World Content - Overhauls](#), [World Content - Quests](#), [World Content - Homes & Bases](#), [World Content - Underwater](#)

Landscape Overhauls → [World Content - Overhauls](#)

This subsection owns large worldspace-content changes that make regions feel meaningfully different to cross, rather than just prettier to look at. Graphics ownership for terrain, trees, grass, lighting, and general landscape rendering still belongs to [modlist-graphics-shaders.md](#).

Baseline

Keep this layer restrained until the rest of section 08 is clearer before committing to regional worldspace transformation. If the section does want a first transformation experiment:

- **The Marshlands (Nexus)** — Gives Hjaalmarch a strong identity without redefining one of Skyrim's most central travel spaces. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)

Alternatives

- **Whiterun Forest Borealis (Nexus)** — Louder regional rewrite if the project wants a more dramatic approach. Heavier compatibility pressure with roads, tree placement, lighting, and LOD. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Aspens Ablaze (Nexus)** — Complementary Rift identity layer. Only keep it if the section 02 tree and foliage direction can absorb it cleanly. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)

Notes

- It is easy to confuse graphics ambition with actual world-content value.
- Broad regional edits can create heavy pressure around roads, tree placement, outskirts, lighting, snow, and LOD regeneration.
- Adding multiple regional identity mods too casually turns the subsection into an accidental patch pile.

Cities, Towns, And Villages → [World Content - Overhauls](#)

This subsection owns actual settlement-content additions and stronger settlement identity. Section 07 already handled broader city-presence and world-feel tuning; this section is about authored places, not just denser vibes.

Baseline

- **The Great Cities - Minor Cities and Towns SSE Edition (Nexus)** — First-pass baseline. Gives multiple underbuilt settlements stronger structure without immediately committing to a modular city-family patch story. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Cities of the North series** (Dawnstar [Nexus](#) + Morthal [Nexus](#) + Falkreath [Nexus](#) + Winterhold [Nexus](#)) — Default modular lock for the four smaller hold capitals. JPSteel2's series is the only major modular identity option covering all four with matching architectural ambition; the four mods are designed to stack. Lock the full series unless a real reason emerges to skip one (e.g., Falkreath conflicts with a LoS II lantern placement). → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Settlements Expanded (Nexus)** — Default population-and-structures companion. Makes seven underbuilt vanilla settlements feel like real inhabited places without overlapping with architectural-identity choices in [JK's Skyrim](#) or [The Great Cities](#) (no city geometry changes). Must load late in the load order. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **The Great City of Solitude SSE (Nexus)** — Explicit Solitude deep-dive. Expands Solitude's port with new homes, shops, and warehouses; adds vendors, guards, and NPCs. Gives Solitude a full architectural-identity and population upgrade without forcing commitment to the entire [The Great Cities](#) base mod. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **JK's Whiterun Outskirts (Nexus)** — Default Whiterun-area expansion. Adds farms, meadery exterior, and Whitewatch tower between Whiterun's walls and the hold. Independent of [JK's Skyrim](#) AIO; the two stack without patching. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **JK's Raven Rock (Nexus)** — Solstheim settlement overhaul. New clutter, architecture detail, and environmental storytelling. By JPSteel2, ESL-flagged. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **JK's Tel Mithryn (Nexus)** — Telvanni tower overhaul. Exterior and interior with detailed clutter, better lighting, and lived-in environmental storytelling. By JPSteel2, ESL-flagged. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **FYX - Eastern Empire Company Building (Nexus)** — Solitude-specific mesh fix. Targeted stopgap before Solitude's city overhaul direction is settled. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **FYX - Riften - Window Consistency (Nexus)** — Riften window mesh consistency fix. Targeted visual stopgap before larger city overhauls are settled. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)

Alternatives

- **The Great Cities (Nexus)** — Major-hold-capital follow-on if the project decides major hold capitals also need authored treatment. Stacks with the Minor Cities extension but pulls in real compatibility discussion with section 07's [Spaghetti's Cities - AIO](#) and [JK's Skyrim](#), plus [PBR textures for The Great Cities Collection](#) from section 02. Treat as a deliberate second-step decision, not a default addition. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Capital Whiterun Expansion (Nexus)** — Whiterun-content expansion with two new districts, player home, and quest content. Verify JK's patch hub for a compatibility patch before locking. If a patch is missing, treat as mutually exclusive with [JK's Skyrim](#)'s Whiterun edits. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **The Great Town of Ivarstead SSE (Nexus)** — Focused single-town comparison if a smaller number of carefully chosen town upgrades is the smarter answer. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **The Great Village of Kynesgrove (Nexus)** and **The Great Village of Mixwater Mill SSE (Nexus)** — Complementary village additions rather than primary answers. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **The Great Town of Shor's Stone SSE (Nexus)** — Complementary addition to the Minor Cities baseline. Independent, does not conflict with the parent mod. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)

Notes

- It is easy to re-solve the section 07 city-presence problem with heavier settlement overhauls when the real goal is authored place-content.
- Modular city-family choices can turn this subsection into a patch-collection project too early.
- Settlement edits create pressure around roads, outskirts, snow, lighting, and landscape compatibility.
- Later inns, small settlements, dungeons, POIs, quests, and homes still need room to matter on their own.

College of Winterhold → [World Content - Overhauls](#) / [World Content - Quests](#)

This subsection owns the full College of Winterhold faction-location improvement: architecture and interiors, student-and-faculty population, and the questline/skill-gate layer that turns the College into an earned progression rather than a speedrun. It is a coordinated three-mod sub-stack designed to work together without inter-mod patches.

Baseline

- **Obscure's College of Winterhold** ([Nexus](#)) — Architecture baseline. Rebuilds the Hall of the Elements as a lecture hall with practice stations and a spectral sparring partner. Adds a multi-story Arcanaeum with a rank-locked private collection. Configurable Arch-Mage quarters (laboratory, office, council chamber, archive, spa). Student rank progression tied to personal quests. FOMOD installer with ~50 built-in patches. Requires USSEP. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Immersive College NPCs** ([Nexus](#)) — Population companion. Adds students, guards, and Saarthal excavation workers with schedules, patrols, and idle markers. ESL-flagged, vanilla assets only, no cell edits. Co-authored by SomethingObscure (same author as Obscure's College). Integration patch included in Obscure's FOMOD. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **College of Winterhold - Quest Expansion** ([Nexus](#)) — Questline baseline. Adds skill-gated entry (Faralda tests magic ability), 7 starter lessons/quests before Saarthal unlocks, branching dialogue with College NPCs, and an alternate main-quest route (access Saarthal without joining). ESL-flagged, by jayserpa. Explicitly compatible with Obscure's College and Immersive College NPCs — no patches needed. → [World Content - Quests](#)

Alternatives

- **Magical College of Winterhold** ([Nexus](#)) — Cleaner fantasy aesthetic alternative. Lighter patch surface but less Nordic in tone — weaker fit for the grim-dark presentation pillar. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Immersive College of Winterhold** ([Nexus](#)) — Comprehensive alternative (architecture + NPCs + crafting + underground). Last updated December 2020 — unmaintained for 4+ years. Heavier patch debt with COTN and LOTD. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- Questline-only: skip architecture mods, use **College of Winterhold - Quest Expansion** alone. Lowest patch overhead, College interior stays vanilla. Valid fallback if patch unknowns become blockers. → [World Content - Quests](#)

Risks & Compatibility

- **Obscure's College** ↔ **COTN Winterhold**: Compatible without a patch — user-tested on r/skyrimmods. Cells do not overlap (COTN stays in the ruined town, Obscure's stays on the College rock). Load COTN before OCW per standard city-before-interior ordering.
- **Obscure's College** ↔ **CS-native lighting**: No official patch — OCW's FOMOD includes ELFX, Luminosity, and Relighting Skyrim patches but not CS Light, True Light, or WSU. OCW's CellSettings.esp light record forwarding will need verification in xEdit to ensure CS Light + True Light's exterior bulbs and interior templates apply correctly to OCW cells. The OCW Meshes Optimized and Merged for CS patch ([Nexus](#)) merges OCW architecture meshes to reduce drawcalls for Light Limit Fix — install as part of OCW setup.
- **Obscure's College** ↔ **LOTD**: Patch exists — included in OCW's own FOMOD installer. Select the LOTD option during OCW installation. The LOTD Official Patch Hub (30980) does not have a separate OCW patch. The patch covers display integration for the private collection, room plaque system, and unique College items. ESP-FE format.
- **Immersive College NPCs** ↔ **NPC appearance overhaul**: ICN adds new NPCs with their own facegen. Load ICN after any broad NPC appearance mod (Northbourne, etc.) to avoid facegen/blackface issues on vanilla College NPCs.
- **Quest Expansion** ↔ **FDE Brelyna Maryon**: Both touch Brelyna's dialogue tree. Test for overlap during playtesting.
- Obscure's College last updated April 2020 — architecture mods age better than script-heavy ones (no SKSE dependency, USSEP only), but 1.6.1170 behavior should be verified during playtesting. Community testing is deep (102+ mods reference it).
- Obscure's CellSettings.esp must load late in the load order per author recommendation (before Realistic Water 2 / DynDOLOD).

Notes

- r/skyrimmods community signal: the Obscure's + Immersive College NPCs + Quest Expansion stack is well-tested on 1.6.1170 with no known issues. Quest Expansion should load after Misc. College of Winterhold Tweaks and Improved College Entry if either is installed.

Inns, Farms, And Small Settlements → [World Content - Overhauls](#)

This subsection owns the smaller stopover places that make travel routes and rural Skyrim feel lived-in. It should answer a different question from the larger city and village subsection above: travel-stop identity, small community presence, and memorable rural pauses.

Baseline

- **The Great Village of Old Hroldan SSE** ([Nexus](#)) — First-pass baseline. Gives the world a more authored roadside stop without turning the subsection into a broad restoration bundle. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Candlehearth - An Inn Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Locked inn-overhaul baseline. Overhauls every inn in Skyrim with new interiors, layouts, and atmosphere, making rest stops feel like memorable destinations. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Ask Innkeepers To Show Room SE** ([Nexus](#)) — Inn interaction QoL companion. Adds a dialogue option to ask innkeepers to preview the room before renting, showing the room's location and layout on-screen. 5,351 endorsements, v1.0. Complements Candlehearth by improving the rental interaction flow. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)

Alternatives

- **Granite Hill** ([Nexus](#)) — Small-settlement restoration. Choose if the world would benefit more from restoring another small settlement along normal routes than from a single authored roadside stop. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)

- **Lund's Hamlet - An Overhaul** (Nexus) — Niche farmstead option. Lund's Hut only, with built-in LotD patch and optional compatibility patches for Lanterns of Skyrim II, Embers XD, Nature of the Wild Lands. Best evaluated after a travel-stop and restoration baseline are in place. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **The Great Town of Karthwasten SSE** (Nexus) and **Oakwood** (Nexus) — Complementary additions rather than primary answers. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)

Notes

- This subsection can easily become a second uncontrolled settlement-family pile.
- Inn-focused interior upgrades can distract from the broader question of whether the countryside has enough believable small communities.
- Roads, lighting, snow, landscape edits, and adjacent settlement overhauls create real compatibility pressure here.

Dungeons And Ruins → [World Content - Overhauls](#)

This subsection owns added dungeon-space and deeper ruin exploration. The goal is more worthwhile exploration, not just darker visuals or a raw increase in map markers.

Baseline

- **Forgotten Dungeons (SSE)** (Nexus) — First-pass baseline. Adds more places to discover without forcing the entire section to revolve around one giant bespoke underground project. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Dungeons - Revisited** (Nexus) — Strongest complementary branch. Improves existing ruins rather than adding new destinations, so it does not gate the larger decision of whether section 08 wants more destinations. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Iconic's Crown of Barenziah** (Nexus) — Upgrades the Crown of Barenziah, its gem boxes, and display stand with high-quality meshes, parallax gems, and environment mapping. Adds quest-reward visual payoff without gameplay changes. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)

Alternatives

- **Hammet's Dungeon Pack 1 SE** (Nexus) — Stronger hand-authored dungeon-adventure identity if the project wants more curated dungeon experiences. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Children of the North Wind - Ruins of the Ancient Nords** (Nexus) — High-commitment ancient-Nordic-specific branch. Replaces architecture across nine curated locations (Bleakwind Bluff, Forelhost, High Gate Ruins, Kilcreath Temple, etc.) with bespoke architecture and exterior overhauls. Heavier and more opinionated. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Skyrim Underground SSE** (Nexus) — High-commitment branch if the list wants a much larger subterranean layer than vanilla suggests. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)

Notes

- It is easy to add dungeon count without adding meaningful exploration value.
- Combining several dungeon packs too casually creates content fatigue, overlap, and patch debt.
- Entrance placement, lighting, encounter balance, quest aliases, and underground-space conflicts all matter here.
- Supplemental navmesh patch: **Navigator - Navmesh Fixes - Patch Collection** (Nexus) — FOMOD patch collection covering Dungeons Revisited, Legacy of the Dragonborn, Helgen Reborn, JK's interiors, Skyrim Sewers, and others. Install after both the content mods and Navigator are in place. (Optional) → [World Content - Overhauls](#)

Points Of Interest And Roadside Content → [World Content - Overhauls](#)

This subsection owns the smaller discoverable places between headline destinations: guarded crossings, hidden shelters, and minor landmarks that reward curiosity during normal travel. Section 07 already owns roadside ambience and travel texture; this subsection owns actual stop-worthy additions.

Baseline

- **Hidden Hideouts of Skyrim SE** (Nexus) — First-pass baseline. Adds practical refuges and quiet off-road discoveries that fit the list's travel-and-exploration tone. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Daedric Shrines - All in One** (Nexus) — Daedric-shrine discovery layer. Each shrine is a bespoke point of interest with unique architecture matching the Prince's domain. Complements the religion layer from [modlist-expanded-systems.md](#) without requiring it. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Daedric Shrines - All in One by Xtudo - Patch Collection** (Nexus) — Required patch companion covering Wintersun, Wyrmsmouth, LotD, Lakeview, and other mods in [Elder Wilds](#). → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Environs - Abandoned Abodes** (Nexus) — Abandoned-building restoration layer. Converts forgettable empty buildings (Hoddminir, Tumbledown Shack, Hellfire Chasm) into discoverable locations with new clutter and environmental storytelling. ESL-flagged, zero script overhead. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Evolving Locations** series (Riverside Shack [Nexus](#) + Lucky Shack [Nexus](#) + Cliffside Retreat [Nexus](#)) — Dynamic overhauls layer. Three shack locations that evolve and expand over playtime based on player actions and visit frequency. By Suinier, ESL-flagged. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Reinforced Civil War Camps** (Nexus) — Civil War camp overhaul adding fortifications, tents, supplies, and more lived-in camp details to Imperial and Stormcloak camps. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Hagraven Houses Animated** (Nexus) — Optional world-object animation layer. BOS mesh replacer adding wind animation to hagraven houses and fences. 1,354 endorsements, requires [Base Object Swapper](#). → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Unmarked Locations Pack - All In One** (Nexus) — Unmarked POI discovery layer. Adds dozens of hand-placed unmarked locations across Skyrim (camps, shrines, lookout points, hidden caches) with environmental storytelling. AIO consolidates all previous packs with fixes and new additions. 6 files available; AIO is the main file. Addon packs available for Bruma ([174471](#)), Wyrmsmouth ([169188](#)), and The Gray Cowl of Nocturnal ([159443](#)) — install only if those worldspaces are adopted. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)

Alternatives

- **Hold Border Guards - Definitive Edition (Nexus)** — Structured roadside comparison if the project wants roadside content to feel more geopolitical. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Nordic Ruins of Skyrim SSE (Nexus)** — Lightest branch if the right answer is more discoverable landmarks rather than more useful stops. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Hidden Hideouts of Skyrim City Edition SE (Nexus)** — Narrower companion for city-adjacent hideaways. Revisit only if the countryside hideout concept lands well and city-adjacent expansion makes sense. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **7000 Steps of Sanctum (Nexus)** — Targeted pilgrimage enhancement for the High Hrothgar climb. Removes hostile encounters (except the troll), swaps vegetation for altitude-appropriate growth. Soft-requires [Cathedral - 3D Pine Shrubs](#) and [Happy Little Trees](#). → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Gildergreen Regrown (Nexus)** — Quest-driven world-change layer for Whiterun's tree after Blessings of Nature. Requires USSEP. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **The Gildergreen Grows (Nexus)** — Alternative to Gildergreen Regrown with faster 4-month growth, ESL-flagged, added dialogue, watering mechanic with buff. No USSEP requirement. Incompatible with Gildergreen Regrown. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **HAG Occult Orphan Rock (Nexus)** — Location overhaul of Orphan Rock with occult-themed environmental storytelling. Part of HAG series by Maggie. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Lore Friendly Roadside Ruins (Nexus)** — Roadside POI layer. Small lore-friendly ruined structures along roadsides with loot and environmental storytelling. No new cell records or large landscape edits. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)

Notes

- This subsection can easily duplicate section 07 roadside-atmosphere logic instead of choosing real micro-destinations.
- Too many small worldspace edits make travel cluttered rather than more interesting.
- Roads, borders, city outskirts, survival systems, and landscape changes create real placement pressure.
- **Rejected: Master The Summit** — community signal points toward support and navmesh-risk concerns. → [World Content - Overhauls](#)

Underwater → [World Content - Underwater Content](#)

This subsection owns underwater world enhancement and discoverable underwater content: visual overhauls to the seafloor, underwater flora and fauna, and lootable treasure locations beneath the surface.

Baseline

- **Depths of Skyrim - An Underwater Overhaul SSE (Nexus)** — Underwater visual overhaul for the Sea of Ghosts: new grass, coral, giant kelp, 1000+ fish, unmarked treasures, horker groups, exposed-rock fixes, ocean-floor seam fixes. → [World Content - Underwater](#)
- **Depths of Skyrim - Mesh fixes (Nexus)** — Resolves known visual issues in the base mod. → [World Content - Underwater](#)
- **More Underwater Treasures - AIO (Nexus)** — 56 underwater treasures across Skyrim and 35 across Solstheim. Clean landscape edits, vanilla chest replacements, explicitly marked compatible with Depths of Skyrim. → [World Content - Underwater](#)

Notes

- Use [SSE-Terrain-Tamriel-Extend.esm](#) (documented in [modlist-performance.md](#)) as the terrain-boundary ESM for LOD generation — Depths of Skyrim adds content north of the standard terrain-data boundary. → [World Content - Underwater](#)
- Depths of Skyrim requires `iMaxGrassTypesPerTexture=7` or above in `Skyrim.ini`. Set via [M02 → Tools → INI Editor](#) under `[Grass]`. → [World Content - Underwater](#)
- Depths of Skyrim is script-free but adds 1000+ fish references; verify no unexpected Papyrus load or navmesh pressure.
- More Underwater Treasures has replaced landscape edits with vanilla chests; confirm compatibility with any mod overhauling the same underwater cells.
- Test underwater visibility and seafloor blending with the chosen water mod (Water for ENB / Realistic Water Two / A Water Made For CS in mind).

Side Activities: Fishing, Hunting, And Downtime → [World Content - Quests](#)

This subsection owns the non-combat downtime activities that make Skyrim feel like a lived-in world when the player is not dungeon-delving or quest-running: fishing, hunting for food and materials, foraging, and small craft-hobby loops. It closes the pillar-5 gap ("Living the world") by giving the player purposeful things to do during ordinary travel and rest stops that are neither combat nor quest objectives.

Baseline

- **Simple Fishing Overhaul - Animations and Improved Quest Dialogue (Nexus)** — Fishing baseline. Adds third-person and first-person fishing animations, ~200 lines of improved quest dialogue, NPC reactions, optional bait-cost mechanic, MCM configuration. ESL-flagged, requires AE fishing addon (included in AE 1.6.1170) and OAR/DAR (baseline dependency from [modlist-animations.md](#)). 5.2K endorsements, by jayserpa. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Hunterborn SE (Nexus)** — Hunting baseline. Replaces one-click animal-loot with dressing, skinning, harvesting, butchering. Adds hunting knives, alchemy ingredients, animal meats, recipes, foraging, scrimshaw crafting. 20K endorsements, last updated August 2025. Use [Hunterborn Extender](#) via Synthesis for creature-type patching. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Headhunter - Bounties Redone (Nexus)** — Locked bounty-system companion. Transforms vanilla bounty quests into named NPCs with bounty notes, jail dialogue, tavern rumors. Integrates with [Missives](#). By jayserpa, 28K+ endorsements. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Skyrim's Got Talent - Improve As a Bard (Nexus)** — Locked bard-gameplay companion. Instrument practice, skill progression, NPC reactions, inn performances. Meaningful downtime activity fitting the "living the world" pillar. By jayserpa, 19K+ endorsements. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Immersive Fishing (Nexus)** — Fishing-content expansion. New fishing spots, craftable rods, new fish types, radiant fishing quests. Content-first companion to Simple Fishing Overhaul (SFO fixes fishing feel, this fixes fishing scope). → [World Content - Quests](#)

- **Fishermen Fish - Brings the Fish to You (Nexus)** — Lightweight immersion add-on. Overlays fish meshes on NPCs who are fishing, carrying fish, or selling fish. No ESP, mesh replacer only. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Garbage Loot - Barrels and Sacks (Nexus)** — Scavenging-content add-on. Lootable trash containers with believable low-value loot. ESL-flagged, reinforces survival and scavenging tone. → [World Content - Quests](#)

Alternatives

- **Streamlined Fishing (Nexus)** — Fishing-support companion if the QoL gap in the vanilla fishing loop proves too wide even after Simple Fishing Overhaul. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- Lightweight alternative: skip dedicated activity mods and rely on the base AE fishing addon plus [Hunterborn](#) as an optional add-on. Keep alive long enough to judge whether the downtime-activity layer needs dedicated mods at all. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Fishing Extension Framework (Nexus)** — Encounter-zone and biome registration framework for fishing in new worldspaces. Required if the list includes new-lands mods. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Fishing Voiced Narrative - Simple Fishing Overhaul Voice Patch (Nexus)** — Compatibility patch between Voiced Narrative - Fishing and SFO. Required if both are installed. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Fishing Extension for Beyond Skyrim - Bruma (Nexus)** — Worldspace-specific fishing extension if Beyond Skyrim - Bruma is adopted. Requires Fishing Extension Framework. → [World Content - Quests](#)

Notes

- Adding two activity systems at once can feel like feature creep if the rest of the list does not reinforce the same living-world tone.
- [Hunterborn](#) requires creature-type patching for any mod that adds new creatures. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- [Simple Fishing Overhaul](#) requires the free AE fishing addon (already included in AE 1.6.1170) and OAR/DAR (baseline dependency). → [World Content - Quests](#)
- Check both fishing and hunting additions against [modlist-lotd.md](#) for Legacy of the Dragonborn display integration if they add unique items. → [World Content - Quests](#)

Weapons, Armor, And Equipment Additions → [World Content - Quests](#)

This subsection owns the bulk-added weapons, armor sets, shields, and supporting equipment that expand what the player and NPCs can wear, wield, and find. It is the content-side counterpart to the smithing subsection in [modlist-expanded-systems.md](#): smithing is the systems layer, this is the actual item library. The goal is to add meaningful equipment variety without bloating leveled lists, fighting the chosen perk overhaul, or overwhelming the body and outfit pipeline from [modlist-graphics-shaders.md](#).

Baseline

- **Immersive Weapons (Nexus)** — Weapons baseline. ~230 new weapons across 21 archetypes, all craftable, upgradeable, enchantable, integrated through leveled lists, vendors, and dungeon placement. 114K endorsements, 2.2M unique downloads. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Immersive Armors (Nexus)** — Armor baseline. ~55 armor sets (60+ with variants), 396 new shields, plus eye patches, capes, earrings, scarves. Craftable, upgradeable, enchantable, MCM/spell menu for distribution tuning. 206K endorsements, 3.16M unique downloads. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Immersive Armors Rework and Mesh Fixes SE (Nexus)** — Visual upgrade for the armor pack. Base Immersive Armors assets look dated next to modern 4K PBR textures; this retexture brings visuals in line with the graphics stack. 9.8K endorsements. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Dawnguard Arsenal SSE - SkyPatched (Nexus, use SkyPatched variant Nexus 113677)** — Dawnguard-themed equipment expansion. Adds Dawnguard weapons, armors, shields, ammunition. SkyPatched variant uses [SkyPatcher](#) (already a core dependency) instead of a full plugin, reducing load-order pressure. → [World Content - Quests](#)

Alternatives

- Discipline-first: rely on vanilla weapons and armor and let smithing, perk, and quest-reward mods carry equipment identity, with no bulk item packs. Keep alive long enough to confirm the project actually wants bulk equipment content. → [World Content - Quests](#)

Notes

- Bulk item packs can create heavy leveled-list edits conflicting with encounter-zone, loot, and economy mods from [modlist-expanded-systems.md](#) and [modlist-survival-combat.md](#). Resolve by giving bulk packs load-order priority for new items and tuning distribution through MCM.
- New armor sets must be tested against the chosen body base ([CBBE 3BA](#) / [HIMBO](#)) and the BodySlide pipeline from [modlist-graphics-shaders.md](#). Some vanilla-rigged armor pieces will need outfit conversions. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- Bulk packs can affect NPC visual identity if [modlist-npcs.md](#) later bundles NPC overhauls.
- The base [Immersive Armors](#) mesh and texture work looks visibly dated without the retexture pack. Skipping it makes the armor feel out of place in a 4K grim-dark presentation. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- New weapons and armor can dwarf unique items from [modlist-lotd.md](#) if display integration is not considered; verify the display ecosystem handles new items cleanly. → [World Content - Quests](#)

Quest Additions → [World Content - Quests](#)

This subsection owns additional quest content that makes Skyrim feel more alive or more worth revisiting without breaking the grounded exploration tone. It should decide what kind of quest addition fits [Elder Wilds](#): more everyday local work, a compact authored story, or one larger expansion-scale commitment.

Baseline

- **Sidequests of Skyrim (Nexus)** and **Missives (Nexus)** — Dual everyday-quest baseline. Sidequests improves quest texture and world reactivity; Missives provides structured board-based radiant quests (264 variants: courier, deliver, fetch, hunt, bounty, thief) the player can browse and pick from at any hold. Complementary approaches to the same pillar. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Missives - Voice and Quest Expansion (Nexus)** — Quest-variety upgrade. 20 new missive quest types and voiced NPC dialogue via audio splicing. By jayserpa and GiraPomba. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Missives - Notes Retexture (Nexus)** — Cosmetic companion. Replaces blank notes on missive boards with textured, readable notes by jayserpa. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Missives - Worldspace Additions (Nexus)** — Required if new-land mods (Bruma, Falskaar, Beyond Reach, Wyrmsooth) are adopted. Adds missive boards to those worldspaces. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **The Forgotten City (Nexus)** — Locked quest-mod baseline. Most decorated Skyrim quest mod (Writers' Guild Award, Australian Game of the Year). Self-contained murder-mystery investigation with multiple endings, no new-landmass overhead, integrates cleanly with LotD via the official patch collection. Grounded narrative tone matches the project's exploration and content pillars. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Saints and Seducers Extended Cut (Nexus)** — Default Creation-overhaul pick. Transforms the thin vanilla Saints and Seducers Creation into a proper Shivering Isles return questline with new scenes, locations, and voiced NPCs. Essentially free content upgrade for an existing AE asset. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **JaySerpa's Quest Expansions** (House of Horrors [Nexus](#) + Paarthurax [Nexus](#) + The Only Cure [Nexus](#) + patches hub [Nexus](#)) — Default vanilla-quest-enhancement layer. Modular, standalone. Start with the three flagship entries and expand from there. Meaningful decision branches and alternate paths without new worldspaces. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **A Chance Arrangement Plus Plus - A Quest Overhaul (Nexus)** — Targeted Thieves Guild quest overhaul. New scenes, alternate routes, expanded consequences for the TG initiation quest. Lock if Thieves Guild is a likely early-game path. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Opulent Thieves Guild (Nexus)** — Locked TG visual-progression companion. Upgrades Ragged Flagon and Guild headquarters visually as the player advances through the TG questline. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Improved Companions - Questline Tweaks (Nexus)** — Locked Companions faction-fix companion. Removes forced radiant-quest spam between Companions story missions. By Parapets (also of [Barter Limit Fix](#), [MCM Helper](#)). → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Penitus Oculatus (Nexus)** — Locked alternative-faction route. Gives players who choose "Destroy the Dark Brotherhood!" a meaningful replacement faction with radiant quests and a final elimination mission. Does not replace the DB for joiners, only activates for the destroy path. 11.5K endorsements, requires USSEP. → [World Content - Quests](#)

Alternatives

- **Moon and Star (Nexus)** — Compact authored comparison if the project wants one smaller handcrafted quest experience. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Whispers of the Depths - A Sea Monster Quest (Nexus)** and **Before the End - Quest Mod (Nexus)** — Compact quests by nimwraith. Lightweight, lore-friendly, voiced. Fit the grounded exploration tone as optional content. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Wyrmsooth (Nexus)** — High-commitment branch if the list eventually wants one major lore-friendly quest-expansion pillar. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Beyond Skyrim - Bruma SE (Nexus)** — Clearest expansion-scale comparison for a polished lore-friendly new-lands branch. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Beyond Reach (Nexus)** — Darker specialty branch. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **VIGILANT SE (Nexus)** — High-commitment specialty branch. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **The Wheels of Lull - Unwound Edition (Nexus)** — Weird Dwemer-side branch. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Falskaar (Nexus)** — Legacy comparison point, not a default recommendation. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Val Serano - Pirate Custom Voiced Follower and Quest Adventure** — Custom-follower-with-quest baseline. Character-driven pirate story with ~2000 voiced lines, LotD museum integration via Followers Patch ([Nexus URL pending verification](#)). → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **The Forgotten City - Delayed Start (Nexus)** — Optional companion to delay the start trigger from level 5 to level 25. Lock only if The Forgotten City is in the core list. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **The Gray Cowl of Nocturnal - 10th Anniversary (Nexus)** — Optional large quest addition in the thief-themed new-lands category (~8-15 hours, Alik'r Desert, Coldharbour island). Keep optional — trigger condition assumes a thief character. Companion patches: Addons Repository ([Nexus](#)), Bounty Fix ([Nexus](#)), We Don't Need Two Boards ([Nexus](#)). → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **The Isle Of Valefrost SE (Nexus)** — Optional new-lands addition. Fully voiced, 50+ quests, dynamic village progression. v2.x save-incompatibility note — commit decision, not casual add-on. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **The Frozen Heart (Nexus)** — Optional mid-size quest addition by wSkeever and Kreiste. Frozen-realm worldspace, branching dialogue, voiced Snow Elf follower. No vanilla location edits. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Midnight Sun (Nexus)** — Optional new-lands addition by Kittytail. Aurora-themed worldspace. Pending playtesting for worldspace quality and LotD integration. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Echoes of Oblivion (Nexus)** — Optional quest addition with AI-generated-content caveat. Tagged AI-Generated Content — evaluate voice quality and writing tone during playtesting. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Leaps of Faith - A Misc Quest (Nexus)** — Lightweight pilgrimage quest. The player is challenged to make a series of daring leaps of faith between high ledges across Skyrim, each tied to a shrine and a small blessing reward. Complements the religion layer from [modlist-expanded-character.md](#) (Pilgrim baseline) without adding quest overhead. ESL-flagged, zero script latency. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **New Treasure Hunt SSE (Nexus)** — Treasure-hunt quest addition. Adds 16 treasure maps with hand-written clues leading to buried loot across Skyrim. Each treasure has a unique container, custom loot, and environmental storytelling. → [World Content - Quests](#)
 - **Treasure Hunter for SSE (Nexus)** — Adds a radiant treasure-hunting system via a named NPC who sells treasure maps. Complements the static treasure maps from New Treasure Hunt with repeatable content. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Marked Treasure SSE (NG) (Nexus)** — Adds 40+ treasure chests hidden across Skyrim in out-of-the-way locations, each with meaningful loot. Clean landscape edits, no quest trigger, no script overhead — pure discovery content for explorers. ESL-flagged. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **The Dragonborn's Bestiary (Nexus)** — Lore-friendly bestiary book item that tracks creatures the player has encountered. Automatically updates entries as new creatures are discovered, recording combat stats, lore notes, and resistances. Complements the completionist angle of Completionist and the creature-adding mods. → [World Content - Quests](#)
 - **Main file: The Dragonborn's Bestiary** (the base ESP).

- **The Dragonborn's Bestiary - Addons (Nexus)** — Adds support for creatures from popular mods. Install after the base mod. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **The Dragonborn's Bestiary - Small Creature Addon (Nexus)** — Extends tracking to small creatures (rats, mudcrabs, butterflies, fish). → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **The Dragonborn's Fishiary - Bestiary Addon (Nexus)** — Fishing-specific tracking companion. Logs every fishable species with catch data and lore entries. Pairs with Simple Fishing Overhaul from the Side Activities subsection. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Path of the Telvanni (Nexus)** — Large quest-driven mod exploring old regions of Vvardenfell. New worldsaces, compatible with JK's Tel Mithryn. Caution: released June 2026 (very new), tagged AI-Generated Content, minimal community vetting. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Sirenroot - Deluge of Deceit (Nexus)** — AE-gated caution branch. Do not let it become a baseline requirement while the project targets no paid AE dependency. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Quests Are In Skyrim (Nexus)** — Optional map-navigation helper. Synthesis patcher (Nexus) forwards changes against other quest-modifying mods. Player-preference toggle. → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Fishing Extension for Beyond Skyrim - Bruma (Nexus)** — Bruma fishing companion if Beyond Skyrim - Bruma is adopted. Requires Fishing Extension Framework. → [World Content - Quests](#)

Notes

- This subsection can easily become a generic list of famous quest mods instead of a real tonal decision.
- One large quest mod can dominate section 08 when the rest of the section is still built around distributed world discovery.
- Museum integration, settlement patching, travel-flow disruption, and AE requirements all matter here.
- Review any chosen quest route against [modlist-lotd.md](#) so Legacy of the Dragonborn integration value and patch pressure are considered on purpose. → [World Content - Quests](#)

Player Homes And Base-Building Considerations → [World Content - Homes & Bases](#)

This subsection owns where [Elder Wilds](#) should let the player settle, recover, organize gear, and invest long-term effort. It must stay disciplined enough that display-heavy housing does not quietly duplicate the role already reserved for [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#) in [modlist-lotd.md](#).

Baseline

- **Leaf Rest (Nexus)** — First-pass baseline. Supports the broader world-content plan without turning the home decision into the dominant identity of section 08. Grounded everyday home. → [World Content - Homes & Bases](#)

Alternatives

- **Heljarchen Farm (Nexus)** — Economic property comparison if the home layer should do more work as a gold sink, business, and progression system. → [World Content - Homes & Bases](#)
- **LC_Build Your Noble House (Nexus)** — Larger buildable-estate branch if the list wants one explicit construction-and-expansion commitment. → [World Content - Homes & Bases](#)
- **Windstad Mine (Nexus)** — Business-property comparison if the agricultural identity of Heljarchen is not the right fit. → [World Content - Homes & Bases](#)
- **Stormwatch Castle (Nexus)** — Purchasable-castle comparison. Mid-budget castle (35K gold) filling the gap between small inn room and full estate. Requires [Hearthfire multiple adoptions](#) for family move-in. → [World Content - Homes & Bases](#)
- **Hearthfire multiple adoptions (Nexus)** — Required family-housing companion if any family-compatible home is selected. Allows adoption of up to 6 children. Foundational mod, not a standalone home pick. → [World Content - Homes & Bases](#)
- **Blackthorn - A Buildable Town in The Rift (SE) (Nexus)** — Ambitious caution branch. Keep in the caution bucket unless modern testing proves terrain and compatibility concerns are manageable. → [World Content - Homes & Bases](#)

Notes

- It is easy to choose a home because it looks impressive in screenshots rather than because it improves actual play rhythm.
- The home layer can drift into an oversized trophy-display answer that should really belong to the [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#) track. → [World Content - Homes & Bases](#)
- Terrain, navmesh, family-support, autosort, and settlement-overhaul conflicts matter here, especially for larger property mods.
- [Stormwatch Castle](#) is a single-file light mod with no hard dependencies beyond [Hearthfire multiple adoptions](#). Main risk: small and static — works best as a mid-tier purchase rather than endgame home. → [World Content - Homes & Bases](#)
- [Hearthfire multiple adoptions](#) touches vanilla adoption and housing records; verify compatibility with any mod touching [Hearthfire](#) player homes, child AI, or family dialogue. → [World Content - Homes & Bases](#)
- Keep display-heavy mansions separate from the museum/safehouse question reserved for [modlist-lotd.md](#). → [World Content - Homes & Bases](#)

Candidate TODO Additions

Overhauls → [World Content - Overhauls](#)

- [Merchant Chests on display](#) — merchant chest visual display → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- [Dynamic boats at docks](#) — boat movement at docks → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- [Imperial Towers Overhaul - Exterior \(Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspicedition/mods/179653>\)](#) — Imperial tower world edits → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- [JK's Thieves Guild HQ \(Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspicedition/mods/133787>\)](#), [GG's Thieves Guild Headquarters \(Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspicedition/mods/64018>\)](#) — Thieves Guild HQ overhaul (choose one; GG's has Patch Collection: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspicedition/mods/63967>) → [World Content - Overhauls](#)

- **BIOMES I** (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimpecialedition/mods/138300>) — landscape overhaul (need to review) → [World Content - Overhauls](#)
- **Imperial Castles of Skyrim - Fort Battlements v2** (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimpecialedition/mods/129327>) — Imperial fort architecture overhaul → [World Content - Overhauls](#)

Quests & Content → [World Content - Quests](#)

- **Apocryphal Archives** (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimpecialedition/mods/174267>) — Apocrypha quest expansion → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Dwemer Tech, Weapons and Armor** — Dwemer item/equipment content pack → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **The Skyrim Bestiary** — animal lore book item → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Moonpath to Elsweyr** (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimpecialedition/mods/4341>) — new lands quest mod → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Ballad of the Bards Vol.1 - College Bard Outfit** (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimpecialedition/mods/180492>) — bard outfit item → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Fish Anywhere - Streamlined Fishing (Patch)** (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimpecialedition/mods/85070>) — combo patch for Streamlined Fishing + Fish Anywhere → [World Content - Quests](#)
- **Thieves Guild Requirements SE** (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimpecialedition/mods/33256>) — Thieves Guild progression requirement → [World Content - Quests](#)

FILE: modlist-npcs.md

NPCs

MO2 Separator: [NPCs](#) → [NPCs - Appearance](#), [NPCs - Population](#), [NPCs - Followers](#)

Creature/enemy content (Enemy Variety, Creature Visual Overhauls, Creature Behavior, Wildlife Balance) moved to → [Creatures and Enemies](#).

NPC Appearance Overhauls → [NPCs - Appearance](#)

This subsection owns the face, hair, and presentation direction for Skyrim's named NPCs. It does not re-decide the body, skin, and baseline character-visual stack already owned by → [02g](#); it decides how far the list pushes NPC-specific styling on top of that baseline. The real question is whether Elder Wilds should lean toward grounded modernization, clearly stylized beauty, or a vanilla-faithful refresh.

Baseline

- **Northbourne NPCs of Whiterun Hold** (Nexus) — Grounded route. Modern, regionally textured look that current r/skyrimmods signal treats as higher-quality but still grounded. → [NPCs - Appearance](#)
- **The Men of Winter SSE** (Nexus) — Dedicated male coverage to keep the cast consistent with the female-weighted baseline. Last updated August 2020 — verify 1.6.1170 compatibility before locking. → [NPCs - Appearance](#)
- **AI Overhaul SSE** (Nexus) — NPC schedule and behavior layer. Pairs with any appearance route. → [NPCs - Appearance](#)
- **Children of the First - An Altmer NPC Overhaul** (Nexus) — Race-specific modular overlay. Applies only to Altmer, stacks cleanly on top of whichever broad baseline is chosen. → [NPCs - Appearance](#)
- **Children of the Ash - A Dunmer NPC Overhaul** (Nexus) — Race-specific modular overlay. Applies only to Dunmer, stacks cleanly on top of whichever broad baseline is chosen. → [NPCs - Appearance](#)

Alternatives

- **High Poly True to Vanilla NPC Overhaul** (Nexus) — Vanilla-faithful fallback if Northbourne drifts too far from familiar identity. → [NPCs - Appearance](#)
- **Pandorable's NPCs (AIO)** (Nexus) — Beauty-forward branch if the project later accepts the stronger aesthetic shift and patch burden. → [NPCs - Appearance](#)
- **Dibella's Blessing** (Nexus) — Modular female-side branch for more authored women without fully replacing the grounded baseline. Covers 233 female characters. → [NPCs - Appearance](#)
- **Males Of Skyrim by zzjay** (Nexus) — Secondary male alternative, actively maintained as of April 2024. → [NPCs - Appearance](#)
- **The Wolven Widow - SerketHetyt's Elisif Overhaul** (Nexus) — Targeted named-NPC companion for Jarl Elisif. One of the most-seen social scenes. Layer on top of whichever broad route is chosen. → [NPCs - Appearance](#)
- **Pride of Skyrim** — Later modular target if the project chooses a deeper mixed modular route. → [NPCs - Appearance](#)

Notes

- Choosing an overhaul because screenshots look impressive rather than because the world stays coherent in ordinary play is a known trap.
- Letting glamour-forward design overpower the grounded tone, or letting female-weighted packs leave male NPCs visibly mismatched.
- Confirm Northbourne, The Men of Winter, Pandorable's, and High Poly True to Vanilla behave cleanly on Steam 1.6.1170. Check blackface/facegen, dependency, and AI Overhaul SSE load-order pressure before locking.
- Children of the First / Ash are race-specific overhauls — test for facegen/blackface conflicts with whichever broad route is chosen, especially if that route already covers Altmer or Dunmer NPCs.
- Do not duplicate the body/skin baseline already owned by → [02g](#).

Civilian And Traveler Population Additions → [NPCs - Population](#)

This subsection owns the extra background people who make towns, inns, and roads feel used — without re-deciding the city feel, outskirts texture, and roadside atmosphere already handled in section → [07](#). The goal is believable incidental presence, not more clutter or bigger settlements.

Baseline

- **Crowded Streets (Nexus)** — Compatibility-first crowd route. More civilian presence in cities, towns, and inns via zero-cell-edit, dynamic-cleanup, configurable-density design. → [NPCs - Population](#)

Alternatives

- **Travellers of Skyrim (Nexus)** — Road-traveler route for busier roads. Coexists with Crowded Streets in principle. LE-era port — verify 1.6.1170 compatibility. → [NPCs - Population](#)

NPC Name Variety

This subsection owns NPC name randomization and distribution, making named NPCs feel more regionally distinct and diverse without changing their appearance or dialogue. The goal is name immersion — guards, bandits, merchants, and commoners should have names that reflect their race, culture, and region.

- **NPCs Names Distributor (Nexus)** — SKSE plugin framework that distributes name variations to NPCs based on race, faction, and location. The engine that powers the name packs below. → [NPCs - Population](#)
- **Tamrielic Names (Nexus)** — Adds racially appropriate names to all human NPCs (Nord, Imperial, Redguard, Breton). → [NPCs - Population](#)
- **Reachmen Tribes Names (Nexus)** — Reachman-specific name pack for Forsworn and Reach-aligned NPCs. → [NPCs - Population](#)
- **Ashlander Nomads Names (Nexus)** — Ashlander-specific name pack for Dunmer NPCs in Solstheim and Morrowind-flavored content. → [NPCs - Population](#)
- **Dovah Names (Nexus)** — Dragon-name pack. Gives named dragons lore-friendly Dovahzul names. → [NPCs - Population](#)
- **Daedric Names (Nexus)** — Daedra-name pack. Gives spawned daedra (Dremora, etc.) lore-appropriate names. → [NPCs - Population](#)
- **Player Name Randomizer (Nexus)** — SKSE plugin that randomizes the player character's display name from a configurable list on new game start. Independent (no dependency on NPCs Names Distributor). → [NPCs - Population](#)
- **Populated Skyrim Reborn SSE (Nexus)** — Heavier legacy route with higher risk of over-crowding and older compatibility baggage. → [NPCs - Population](#)
- **MINPCs (Nexus)** — Broader world-alive option if the project later wants adventurer-style incidental content rather than pure background population. → [NPCs - Population](#)
- **Immersive Citizens - AI Overhaul SE (Nexus)** — AI/schedule overhaul. Named as out-of-scope boundary note (known conflict with AI Overhaul SSE in Appearance subsection). → [NPCs - Population](#)
- **Interesting NPCs SE (3DNPC) (Nexus)** — Authored content NPCs. Named as out-of-scope boundary note. → [NPCs - Population](#)

Notes

- Re-solving section-07 city-feel and roadside-atmosphere by stuffing in more NPCs is a known antipattern.
- Letting roads or inns become conspicuously overfilled is a real risk.
- Confirm Crowded Streets, Travellers of Skyrim, and Populated Skyrim Reborn SSE behave cleanly on Steam 1.6.1170. Record pressure around settlement overhauls, inns, city expansions, navmesh, follower mods, and encounter mods.

NPC Dialogue Expansions → [NPCs - Appearance](#)

This subsection owns targeted dialogue additions for existing NPCs — expanding what vanilla characters say without rewriting their identity or adding new voice actors. The goal is more responsive, less repetitive NPC conversations in key social and faction contexts.

Baseline

- **Dialogue Expansion - Windhelm (Nexus)** — Vanilla-plus dialogue for Windhelm citizens, guards, and jarl court. 180+ lines using existing vanilla voice assets. **Discontinued** (author ceased AI-voice work), but existing downloads function. → [NPCs - Appearance](#)
- **Dialogue Expansion - Imperial Soldiers (Nexus)** — Dialogue for Imperial soldiers across camps, forts, and cities. Also discontinued for the same reason. → [NPCs - Appearance](#)
- **Bandit Lines Expansion (Nexus)** — New voiced bandit dialogue using spliced vanilla assets. Pairs naturally with Lawless. → [NPCs - Appearance](#)
- **Civil War Lines Expansion (Nexus)** — New voiced dialogue for Imperial and Stormcloak soldiers using spliced vanilla assets. → [NPCs - Appearance](#)
- **Forsworn and Thalmor Lines Expansion (Nexus)** — Completes the jayserpa enemy-dialogue trilogy. → [NPCs - Appearance](#)
- **Shouts of Stallholders (Nexus)** — New voiced dialogue for market stall sellers across Skyrim and Solstheim. Tagged AI-Generated Content — evaluate voice quality during playtesting. → [NPCs - Appearance](#)
- **Follower Dialogue Expansion (FDE) series** by Anbeegod — AI-voiced follower expansions. Start with the full publicly available set of 10 expansions, each ESL-flagged: → [NPCs - Appearance](#)
 - **FDE - Aela the Huntress (Nexus)** — 2700+ lines, full quest commentary, approval system, romance arc, werewolf mechanics.
 - **FDE - Brelyna Maryon (Nexus)** — 400+ lines, College apprentice focus.
 - **FDE - Lydia (Nexus)** — 400+ lines exploring duty, loyalty, and frustration.
 - **FDE - Roggi Knot-Beard (Nexus)** — Kynesgrove miner expanded with quest awareness and personal story.
 - **FDE - Aranea lenith (Nexus)** — 495 lines, Priestess of Azura with religious commentary.
 - **FDE - Borgakh the Steel Heart (Nexus)** — 478 lines, personal quest, Orc-culture commentary, banter with Illia.
 - **FDE - Uthgerd the Unbroken (Nexus)** — 233 lines, Companions reconciliation arc, banter with Aela.
 - **FDE - Ysolda (Nexus)** — 180 lines, Whiterun merchant-to-follower with darker backstory.
 - **FDE - Jenassa (Nexus)** — 500+ lines, Dunmer mercenary with quest awareness and cultural commentary.

- **FDE - Olfina Gray-Mane (Nexus)** — 578 lines, Civil War commentary, approval system.
- Author's official FDE collection: <https://next.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/collections/uu3kpb>

Alternatives

- **Extended NPC Dialogue Hub (Nexus)** — Central dialogue hub with expanded generic NPC conversation options. Evaluate after core dialogue stack is locked. → [NPCs - Appearance](#)
- **Small Talk (Nexus)** — Contextual NPC-to-NPC ambient dialogue in towns and cities. SKSE plugin, no ESP. Complements the dialogue stack. → [NPCs - Appearance](#)

Notes

- Dialogue additions can conflict with mods that replace the same NPC records or quest aliases.
- Confirm compatibility with AI Overhaul SSE, Crowded Streets, and any city overhaul touching Windhelm NPCs or Imperial soldier faction assignments.
- FDE series uses AI voice acting. Each is ESL-flagged — verify against chosen NPC appearance overhaul to avoid facegen/blackface issues. 10 mods adds 10 lightweight plugins (well within limit).
- FDE - Olfina Gray-Mane explicitly conflicts with IDE Whiterun (not in current modlist — flag if added later).
- Shouts of Stallholders uses SPID for NPC blocking. Verify SPID is fully functional in the current stack.

Custom Followers → [NPCs - Followers](#)

This subsection owns custom fully-voiced follower additions — new NPCs with authored dialogue, quest commentary, and personal content that expand the companion layer beyond vanilla followers.

Baseline

- **Lucien - Immersive Fully Voiced Male Follower (Nexus)** — Primary custom-follower baseline. 5000+ lines, personal quest, commentary on vanilla and AE content. Anniversary Edition Creation Club patch available. LoTD-aware. 30K+ endorsements. → [NPCs - Followers](#)
- **Remiel - Custom Voiced Dwemer Specialist (Nexus)** — Breton engineer with ~5000 lines on dwemer ruins, cities, weather. Custom follower framework — do not use with NFF/AFT. Found in Markarth's Silverblood Inn. → [NPCs - Followers](#)
- **INIGO (Nexus)** — Fully voiced Khajiit follower. 7000+ lines, personal quest, extensive world commentary, banter with multiple custom followers (Lucien, Auri, Remiel). Community-canonical (100K+ endorsements). → [NPCs - Followers](#)
 - **Inigo Official Patch SE (Nexus)** — Official compatibility patch for AE and Creation Club content. Required for 1.6.1170. → [NPCs - Followers](#)
 - **Lulu's INIGO 2.0 (Nexus)** — High-poly visual replacer for INIGO. Modernizes his appearance while staying faithful to the original design. Requires the base mod. → [NPCs - Followers](#)
- **Song of the Green (Auri Follower) (Nexus)** — Fully voiced Bosmer archer with 1000+ lines, approval system, mini-quest, romance option, Inigo banter. 19K+ endorsements. → [NPCs - Followers](#)
 - **Majestic Auri (Nexus)** — High-poly visual replacer for Auri. 224K+ unique downloads. → [NPCs - Followers](#)
- **Sofia - The Funny Fully Voiced Follower (Nexus)** — Comic-relief follower option. Professional voice acting by Christine Slagman. MCM, drunk mechanic, horse summoning. May be cut if playtesting shows tonal mismatch. → [NPCs - Followers](#)
- **Kaidan 2 (Nexus)** — Dedicated romance-arc follower. 1200+ lines, custom home, mini-quests. Custom AI system (does not add to follower count). Use the Immersive Features all-in-one installer from kaidanmod.com (supersedes the deprecated Nexus Extended Edition). → [NPCs - Followers](#)
 - **A Makeover for Kaidan (Nexus)** — Visual replacer using COTR-inspired assets. → [NPCs - Followers](#)
 - **Immersive Kaidan Start (Nexus)** — Alternate starting scenario. → [NPCs - Followers](#)

Follower framework notes: Remiel and Auri work best outside NFF (custom systems). Sofia works under NFF or standalone. Lucien tested with NFF but works standalone. Kaidan 2 has a custom AI system — use built-in track-summon powers instead of NFF management.

Notes

- Custom followers add ~9 ESL-flagged plugins (Lucien + AE patch, Remiel, Sofia, Auri, Majestic Auri, Kaidan 2 + IF, A Makeover for Kaidan, Immersive Kaidan Start) — minimal impact on 254 limit.
- Lucien's Creation Club patch is required for AE content awareness.
- Remiel WILL BREAK under NFF/AFT. Same caution for Auri 2.0+.
- Kaidan 2 Extended Edition has two distribution paths: Nexus (deprecated) and kaidanmod.com AIO (supersedes). Use the AIO path.
- Confirm all custom followers are compatible with the chosen NPC appearance overhaul to avoid facegen issues.
- Coordinate with → [08](#) if other custom followers (Val Serano) are locked — follower-banter patches may be needed.
- Sofia's comedic tone may clash with the grim-dark presentation pillar.
- Remiel and Auri have Inigo banter patches. Kaidan 2 has extended banter with Remiel. Verify cross-follower banter works.
- Backported Extended ESL Support is listed as a requirement for Majestic Auri but does not apply to Steam 1.6.1170 — do not install.

Candidate TODO Additions

NPC Dialogue → [NPCs - Appearance](#)

- **Naked Comments Overhaul (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/142249>)** → [NPCs - Appearance](#)
- **Collision Dialogue Overhaul (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/115079>)** → [NPCs - Appearance](#)
- **Extended NPC Dialogue series** → [NPCs - Appearance](#)
- **Chattier Hunters and Fishermen (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/179154>)** → [NPCs - Appearance](#)

NPC AI → [NPCs - Population](#)

- **Immersive Citizens - AI** (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialiedition/mods/173>) — known conflict with AI Overhaul SSE → [NPCs - Population](#)

NPC Framework → [NPCs - Followers](#)

- **Keep Up - Follower Locomotion Fix** (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialiedition/mods/169808>) → [NPCs - Followers](#)

FILE: modlist-creatures.md

Creatures and Enemies

MO2 Separator: [NPCs - Enemies & Creatures](#)

NPC-specific content (Appearance, Population, Dialogue, Followers) → [NPCs](#).

Enemy Variety

This subsection owns how hostile enemy groups feel less repetitive across ordinary play — cleaner bandit variety, better undead variety, or a heavier enemy-overhaul route — without collapsing into an all-purpose creature package. Stays separate from wildlife ecology (→ [07](#)), combat-system ownership, and later creature-visual/behavior subsections.

Baseline

- **Lawless - A Bandit Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Cleanest modern vanilla-plus answer to repetitive bandit encounters. Bandits are the most overexposed enemy family; Lawless expands archetypes, tiers, and freshness without the legacy baggage of older packages. → [NPCs - Enemies & Creatures](#)

Alternatives

- **OBIS SE** ([Nexus](#)) — Heavier legacy bandit route. Bigger compatibility and maintenance burden. → [NPCs - Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Haugbui - A Draugr Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Lighter undead route for ancient Nordic ruins. → [NPCs - Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Skyrim Revamped - Complete Enemy Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — List-wide enemy rebalance. Accept the combat-balance reach that comes with it before choosing this route. → [NPCs - Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Skyrim Immersive Creatures** — Out of scope; overlaps later creature subsections. → [NPCs - Enemies & Creatures](#)

Notes

- Lawless and OBIS are not interchangeable (maintenance/design tradeoffs differ). Same for Haugbui vs The Restless Dead (light adjustment vs major redesign). The Restless Dead is listed under [Creature Behavior Improvements](#) below as the undead-behavior baseline — verify that choice before locking Haugbui as an alternative here.
- Skyrim Revamped can quietly become a combat-balance rewrite the whole list must serve. Verify pressure around encounter zones, dungeon overhauls, quest mods, and spawn additions.
- Confirm all picks behave cleanly on Steam 1.6.1170 with the current quest, dungeon, and world-content stack.

Creature Visual Overhauls

This subsection owns creature-specific visual direction layered on top of the broad baseline in → [02g](#). Bellyaches Animal and Creature Pack SSE remains the texture foundation. The question is which additional presentation layers make animals, dragons, and region-specific undead more striking.

Baseline

- **Fluffworks** ([Nexus](#)) — Broad presentation layer for furred animals. One of the most noticeable broad creature upgrades. → [NPCs - Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Bears of the North** ([Nexus](#)) — Species standout for one of Skyrim's most common large wildlife threats. → [NPCs - Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Iconic's Dragon Retexture** ([Nexus](#)) — Clean dragon presentation upgrade. → [NPCs - Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Dragons SE** ([Nexus](#)) — Full dragon model replacer with higher-fidelity meshes and textures. 4,485 endorsements, v2. Not compatible with Iconic's Dragon Retexture — choose one dragon visual direction. → [NPCs - Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Draugrs - New models and textures** ([Nexus](#)) — Mainland draugr visual upgrade, improving the most-seen undead enemy. → [NPCs - Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Spider SE** ([Nexus](#)) — Spider visual upgrade. Common dungeon enemies with notably dated vanilla models. → [NPCs - Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Deer Reworked - Ultimate** ([Nexus](#)) — Deer visual upgrade. One of the most common wilderness wildlife sightings. → [NPCs - Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Cannibal Draugr on Solstheim** ([Nexus](#)) — Regional specialty giving Solstheim's undead a Bloodmoon-flavored identity. → [NPCs - Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Hagraven - New models and Textures** ([Nexus](#)) — Hagraven visual upgrade inspired by Adam Adamowicz concept art. Not compatible with other hagraven mesh replacers. → [NPCs - Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Butterfly Improved by zzjay - SE** ([Nexus](#)) — Lightweight ambient insect upgrade for butterflies and moths. 3K+ endorsements. → [NPCs - Enemies & Creatures](#)

Alternatives

- **Fusa Fusa Project - Fluffy Animals** ([Nexus](#)) — Older fluffy animal alternative. Compare, don't casually stack both with Fluffworks. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Splendor - Dragon Variants** ([Nexus](#)) — Dragon variety comparison. Last updated September 2017. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)

New Creature Additions

This subsection owns new creature types that add to the world's bestiary — Mihail Monsters and Animals variants, Morrowind-themed imports, and other authored creature packs that expand what the player can encounter. The goal is curated variety that makes exploration feel less predictable, not a raw creature count.

Baseline (Mihail Creature Additions)

- **Seagulls - Mihail Monsters and Animals (SE-AE version)** ([Nexus](#)) — Ambient coastal birds. ESL-flagged, no combat involvement. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Farm Geese - Mihail Monsters and Animals (SE-AE)** ([Nexus](#)) — Ambient farm birds. ESL-flagged. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Sewer Rats - Mihail Monsters and Animals (SE-AE version)** ([Nexus](#)) — Disease-carrying giant rats in sewers, caves, and ruins. ESL-flagged. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Giant Bats and Rats - Mihail Monsters and Animals (SE-AE version)** ([Nexus](#)) — Larger bat and rat variants for dungeons and caves. ESL-flagged. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Imps - Mihail Monsters and Animals (SE-AE version)** ([Nexus](#)) — Low-level daedra variant. ESL-flagged. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Giant Centipedes - Mihail Monsters and Animals (SE-AE version)** ([Nexus](#)) — Cave-dwelling hostile arthropods. ESL-flagged. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Ogrim - Mihail Monsters and Animals (SE-AE version)** ([Nexus](#)) — High-level daedra variant. ESL-flagged. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Ruinachs - Mihail Monsters and Animals (SE-AE version)** ([Nexus](#)) — Minotaur-like hostile creatures. ESL-flagged. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)

Baseline (Non-Mihail Creature Additions)

- **Morrowind Creatures SE** ([Nexus](#)) — Morrowind-flavored creatures in lore-appropriate biomes (Solstheim, ash areas, Dunmer regions). → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Ogres SE** ([Nexus](#)) — High-damage melee threat in wilderness camps and remote mountain passes. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)

Additional Species Follow-Ups

- **Diverse True Wolves and Dogs** ([Nexus](#)) — Targeted species follow-up for domestic/wilderness animals. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Real Rabbits HD** ([Nexus](#)) — Targeted species follow-up. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Rally's Shaggy Cows of Skyrim** ([Nexus](#)) — Targeted species follow-up. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Realistic Horse Breeds by Krittakitty** ([Nexus](#)) — Targeted species follow-up. Verify 1.6.1170 compatibility before including. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)

Notes

- Mihail creature mods are each ESL-flagged and script-free, adding minimal plugin pressure. Test combat balance against the encounter-zone and difficulty baseline in [modlist-survival-combat.md](#).
- Many Mihail creatures use minimal or no custom animation — they share vanilla skeleton rigs. Verify animation compatibility with creature-animation mods from [modlist-animations.md](#).
- Morrowind Creatures and Ogres add more complex creatures. Verify Hunterborn compatibility (creature-harvest patching) and LoTD display integration if they drop unique loot.
- The Dragonborn's Bestiary (in [modlist-world-content.md](#)) can track all new creature types for the completionist angle.

Notes

- Re-solving the creature baseline (→ [02g](#)) instead of building on it is counterproductive.
- Stacking Fluffworks, Fusa Fusa, and multiple targeted replacers without a clear layering plan will cause fur-shell and shader conflicts.
- Confirm all picks behave cleanly on Steam 1.6.1170 with the current creature baseline. Record pressure around creature meshes, fur shells, horse patches, and overlap with later creature-behavior or enemy-variety picks.

Creature Behavior Improvements

This subsection owns encounter-side creature behavior: how creatures attack, react, and express identity once combat starts. Section → [07](#) owns ecology, distribution, and wilderness-danger tone; this subsection only decides which behavior-side upgrades make encounters smarter and more distinct.

Baseline

- **Dragons Use Thu'um** ([Nexus](#)) — Clean dragon-behavior upgrade. Makes dragons act more intelligently through better shout usage and encounter AI. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **The Restless Dead** ([Nexus](#)) — Undead-behavior baseline. Replaces the abandoned [Draugr Upgrades and Improvements](#) (whose author recommends The Restless Dead). Varies draugr and skeleton AI, combat roles, and threat profiles. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)

Alternatives

- **Epic Dragon Combat REDONE - And Many New Dragons** ([Nexus](#)) — Full dragon-combat overhaul route. Adds 20+ new dragon types with unique abilities, elemental breaths, AI improvements, custom VFX, and included dragon model replacers. Self-contained — includes its own models/textures so it replaces the baseline dragon visual direction. v4.40, actively maintained, 802 endorsements. Patches available for Diverse 4thUnknown Dragons. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Dragon War - A Dragon Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Heavier dragon route if the problem is the structure and tempo of dragon fights rather than merely under-AI'd behavior. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **SkyTEST Lite ESL** ([Nexus](#)) / **Animal Tweaks** ([Nexus](#)) / **Pelagius's Wildlife AI** ([Nexus](#)) — Context-only animal-side mods that drift into section-07 ecology territory. Keep out of baseline unless section-07 overlap is made explicit. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)

Notes

- Re-opening section-07 wildlife/ecology under the label of creature behavior is a known scope creep risk.
- Letting dragon-overhaul choices stack until visual identity, behavior, and difficulty become one muddy decision.
- Choosing behavior mods that mostly inflate difficulty rather than making behavior more interesting.
- Confirm Dragons Use Thu'um, Dragon War, and The Restless Dead behave cleanly on Steam 1.6.1170. Review compatibility with dragon visual picks (Iconic's Dragon Retexture, Splendor) and undead picks (Haugbui, Cannibal Draugr).

Wildlife Density And Rarity Balance

This subsection owns how common wildlife should feel on the landscape once ecology, danger, and creature-identity decisions are handled elsewhere. Section → [07](#) already answered the ecology side; the question here is whether the province feels too crowded with animals to preserve scale and rarity.

Baseline

- **True Hunter - fewer animals per square meter** ([Nexus](#)) — Straightforward spawn-chance reduction so wildlife sightings feel less constant and more deliberate. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)

Alternatives

- **No Predators on roads** ([Nexus](#)) — Route-distribution comparison. Coexists with True Hunter (one solves abundance, the other placement). **Abandoned** (last updated August 2017, LE-era port). Verify 1.6.1170 compatibility. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Real Wildlife Skyrim SE** ([Nexus](#)) — Broader wildlife rework cautionary reference. Spills into section-07 ecology, behavior, and content scope. → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)

Notes

- Re-opening section-07 wildlife/ecology under the narrower label of rarity tuning is a scope-creep risk.
- Reducing wildlife so aggressively the world feels empty rather than spacious.
- Confirm True Hunter and No Predators on roads behave cleanly on Steam 1.6.1170 with the current section-07/09 wildlife stack.

Candidate TODO Additions

Enemies & Creatures

- **Next Gen Dragon VFX** ([Nexus](#): <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialiedition/mods/176433>) → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Diverse 4thUnknown Dragons** ([Nexus](#): <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialiedition/mods/146462>) → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#) — **Resolved (Jul 2026)**: v1.17. Requires [Dragons SE](#) + [SkyPatcher](#). Install one main file + one texture file. Has built-in SkyPatcher support for Epic Dragon Combat REDONE, KS Dragon Overhaul 2, Elemental Dragons. Fixes the earlier incorrect URL (was 162886 which is Phantom Thief Armor - SPID). Add to Creature Visual Overhauls as the dragon-diversity layer on top of Dragons SE.
- **Dragons actually fall down** → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Epic Dwarven Centurion Combat - Diverse Centurions** ([Nexus](#): <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialiedition/mods/181405>) → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Skyrim Bandit Expansion** → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Sleep of the Dead - A Draugr Leather and Shroud Replacer** ([Nexus](#): <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialiedition/mods/178057>) → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Frozen Electrocuted Combustion** ([Nexus](#): <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialiedition/mods/3532>) → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)
- **Better Butterflies** ([Nexus](#): <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialiedition/mods/79332>) → [NPCs](#) - [Enemies & Creatures](#)

FILE: modlist-audio.md

Audio and Feedback

MO2 Separator: Audio → [Audio](#) - [Music](#), [Audio](#) - [SFX & Ambience](#)

Music Overhaul Strategy → [Audio](#) - [Music](#)

This subsection owns the soundtrack direction: how much the list should expand or replace Skyrim's music, how close it should stay to the Jeremy Soule baseline, and whether the music layer should mainly support exploration tone or aggressively redefine it. It stays separate from ambient-world soundscape ownership in

modlist-world-feel.md. → [Audio - Music](#)

Baseline

- **Chapter II - Jeremy Soule Inspired Music (by Dreyra Music) (Nexus)** — Main music baseline. Enough night and exploration coverage to push [Elder Wilds](#) toward darker, more emotional melancholy without breaking from the Jeremy Soule shape of Skyrim. → [Audio - Music](#)
- **The Northerner Diaries - Immersive Edition (music by Jeremy Soule) (Nexus)** — Locked music expansion. Authentic Jeremy Soule compositions — 19 new exploration tracks that integrate seamlessly into the existing soundtrack identity. → [Audio - Music](#)
- **The Southerner Diaries - A Soundtrack Expansion (Nexus)** — Locked companion expansion. 22 Soule-inspired tracks covering exploration and town ambience, complementing [The Northerner Diaries](#) without overlapping. → [Audio - Music](#)
- **Melodies of Civilization - Skyrim Fan-Made Music (Nexus)** — Locked civilization-music expansion. 20+ town, tavern, and settlement tracks making social spaces feel musically distinct from wilderness exploration. → [Audio - Music](#)
- **Nyghtfall - Dark Fantasy Music (Nexus)** — Complementary expansion. ~7 hours of 98 original dark-fantasy tracks with location-specific exploration, combat, dungeon, tavern, and town coverage. Best evaluated after baseline is in place. → [Audio - Music](#)
- **Nordenhamr - Viking Music (Nexus)** — Complementary expansion for Norse / Viking identity reinforcement on top of whatever Norse flavor [Yggdrasil](#) provides. → [Audio - Music](#)

Alternatives

- **Yggdrasil Music and SoundFX Overhaul SE (Nexus)** — High-commitment branch if the project later decides it wants Skyrim to feel stranger, harsher, and more ritualistic instead of merely moodier. Last updated April 2021; functionally stable but unmaintained. → [Audio - Music](#)
- **Silent Combat Music (Nexus)** — Support option only if combat music itself starts feeling too loud, too repetitive, or too intrusive during testing. → [Audio - Music](#)
- Minimalist route — keep the vanilla soundtrack if the world tone is already carrying enough identity through visuals and pacing.

Installation Notes

- If the final music stack combines multiple music mods, use the Synthesis music-merge plugin during install so playlists are merged deliberately instead of depending on load order.
- Keep the generated music-merge output in its own dedicated mod in [Mod Organizer 2](#), and rebuild it whenever the active music stack changes. → [Audio - Music](#)
- For detailed Synthesis pipeline configuration, see [modlist-performance-patches.md](#) (Synthesis pipeline). → [Audio - Music](#)

Notes

- A very large combined soundtrack can make the music layer feel incoherent if the tracks do not share a common tonal identity.
- Multiple music mods must be merged via Synthesis to avoid overlapping [MUSTT](#) records. The Synthesis music-merge plugin handles this.
- Any music mod older than 2020 may lack native AE support; verify before locking.

Weapon, Magic, And Impact SFX → [Audio - SFX & Ambience](#)

This subsection owns the sound-effects layer for combat, magic, items, UI, and impact — what the player hears when swinging a sword, casting a spell, drinking a potion, or opening a menu. It stays separate from ambient-world and creature soundscape ownership in [modlist-world-feel.md](#) and [modlist-npcs.md](#). The bar is a modern, weighty, and clear audio experience that reads well across all categories so UI feedback is crisp enough to be usable in third-person without visual confirmation. → [Audio - SFX & Ambience](#)

Baseline

- **Immersive Sounds - Compendium (Nexus)** — Weapon-and-armor SFX baseline. Thousands of new sound effects for weapons, magic, armor, items, and UI. Broadest patch ecosystem of any audio mod. Works cleanly with [Audio Overhaul for Skyrim SE](#) when loaded in the correct order. → [Audio - SFX & Ambience](#)
- **Audio Overhaul for Skyrim SE (Nexus)** — Full-audio overhaul baseline. Overhauls the entire ambient, weather, acoustic, and reverb system; serves as the master reverb-and-attenuation layer. Strongest community maintenance story (27K endorsements, actively maintained, v4.1.4 as of April 2026). → [Audio - SFX & Ambience](#)
- **Airgetlam - Shouts SFX (Nexus)** — Shout-audio companion. Overhauls shout sounds with higher-fidelity recordings. No record conflicts with [ISC](#) or [AOS](#) — replaces raw .wav files, not audio records. → [Audio - SFX & Ambience](#)
- **Strange Runes** — Magic audio layer included as part of the locked magic-VFX baseline (cross-referenced in [modlist-expanded-systems.md](#)). → [Audio - SFX & Ambience](#)

Alternatives

- Bow/crossbow SFX replacers (e.g. [Bowgasm](#)) — evaluate if baseline bow sounds are insufficient; verify AE compatibility.
- Dedicated UI click replacer ([Dear Diary](#) [Dark Mode](#) UI sounds or [Paper UI Sounds](#)) — optional polish layer.

Notes

- [ISC](#) and [AOS](#) both edit large numbers of sound records. They are designed to be used together with a specific load order: [AOS](#) should load after [ISC](#) so [AOS](#)'s reverb and attenuation win over [ISC](#)'s raw effect swaps. Verify with [LOOT](#) and [xEdit](#). → [Audio - SFX & Ambience](#)
- [ISC](#) is one of the oldest actively used mods on Nexus (first uploaded 2013). While its continued maintenance is exceptional, it touches so many records that any update can create unexpected conflict pressure. Verify its load order after any major content mod update. → [Audio - SFX & Ambience](#)

- **Airgetlam** replaces raw audio files and should be loaded after any mod that touches shout records. Ensure it is below **ISC** and **AOS** in load order. → **Audio - SFX & Ambience**

Creature And NPC SFX → **Audio - SFX & Ambience**

This subsection owns creature, animal, and NPC sound effects not already covered by **AOS** or **ISC** — monster vocalisations, dragon roars, horse whinnies, and ambient creature sounds. It stays separate from the ambience-and-soundscape ownership in **modlist-world-feel.md**. → **Audio - SFX & Ambience**

Baseline

- Minimalist route — rely on the **ISC** + **AOS** baseline for creature sounds. If testing reveals weak creature vocalisations, add dedicated replacers as controlled additions rather than as a blanket creature-audio mod.
- **Talkative Dragons (Nexus)** — Dragon dialogue baseline. Reuses vanilla voice lines to make dragons speak during combat, reinforcing their identity as sentient beings rather than mere beasts. ESL-flagged, 15,478 endorsements, v1.1. Only overwrites one record (**CreatureDialogueDragon**), minimal compatibility pressure. → **Audio - SFX & Ambience**

Notes

- Creature sound mods that replace **.wav** files are generally safe (no record conflicts), but any mod that edits creature sound descriptors must be loaded after **ISC** and **AOS**.
- Talkative Dragons edits a dialogue record, not raw audio files. Verify load order with any mod touching dragon dialogue records. Dragon dialogue from Epic Dragon Combat REDONE may overlap — test both together.

Combat And Immersion Audio → **Audio - SFX & Ambience**

This subsection owns combat-specific and immersion-audio mods — hit sounds, pain grunts, block impacts, slow-time audio, and heartbeat effects — that layer on top of the weapon and magic SFX baseline as polish for the third-person gamepad combat feedback loop.

Baseline

- **Precision (Nexus)** — Already locked in **modlist-third-person.md** for gameplay; its audio impact (accurate hit detection sounds based on weapon trajectory) is part of the third-person experience. → **Audio - SFX & Ambience**
- **Valhalla Combat (Nexus)** — Already locked; parry, stagger, and timed-block mechanics with associated audio feedback. → **Audio - SFX & Ambience**
- **Heart of the Beast - Werewolf Sound and Camera Overhaul (Nexus)** — Werewolf audio baseline if **Growl** is adopted from **modlist-expanded-systems.md**. Replaces werewolf howl, growl, and transformation sounds with higher-fidelity recordings. → **Audio - SFX & Ambience**
- **Heart of the Beast - Feral - A Werewolf Sound Replacer (Nexus)** — Alternative werewolf sound replacer with more savage vocalisations. Choose one variant, not both. → **Audio - SFX & Ambience**

Notes

- Precision and Valhalla Combat are gameplay mods first; their audio is secondary. Do not change the gameplay mod's version or config for audio reasons.
- Heart of the Beast replaces **.wav** files for werewolf sounds. If **Growl** adds new werewolf forms that the sound replacer does not cover, those forms will fall back to Growl's default sounds. → **Audio - SFX & Ambience**
- Only one Heart of the Beast variant should be active. Installing both will cause file conflicts.

FILE: modlist-survival-combat.md

Survival, Difficulty, and Balance

MO2 Separator: **Survival & Combat** → **Survival & Combat - Difficulty & Lethality**, **Survival & Combat - Enemy AI**, **Survival & Combat - Resources & Injuries**

Difficulty Framework → **Survival & Combat - Difficulty & Lethality**

This section does not decide the core combat system or baseline survival framework — **modlist-third-person.md** owns combat direction, and **modlist-expanded-systems.md** owns survival baseline. What this section owns is cross-load-order pressure: how quickly the world starts pushing back, how clearly dungeon progression reads, and whether difficulty comes from better structure instead of blunt stat inflation.

Baseline

- **Arena - An Encounter Zone Overhaul (Nexus)** — Cleanest way to make Skyrim feel harsher and more intentional without forcing a full scarcity or deleveling identity. Community signal consistently treats it as a strong middle ground: more progression pressure than vanilla, still readable and open-world friendly. → **Survival & Combat - Difficulty & Lethality**

Alternatives

- Minimal intervention route — leave encounter zones close to vanilla and let later tuning come from enemy behavior, attrition, and player-side restraint.

- Heavy world-structure route — if the project later wants de leveled loot and stronger world gating, let that decision stay in `modlist-expanded-systems.md`'s economy-and-loot ownership instead of duplicating it here. → [Survival & Combat - Difficulty & Lethality](#)

Notes

- Encounter-zone structure can quietly overlap with loot and economy decisions if this section starts pretending it owns world progression by itself.
- If `Arena` is combined later with a much harsher loot-distribution philosophy, the result can overshoot from moody and dangerous into overly gated. → [Survival & Combat - Difficulty & Lethality](#)
- If the world remains too permissive even with `Arena`, the problem is likely elsewhere in the stack rather than proof that this layer failed. → [Survival & Combat - Difficulty & Lethality](#)

Combat Lethality And Pacing → [Survival & Combat - Difficulty & Lethality](#)

This subsection tunes encounter harshness and time-to-kill on top of the combat framework chosen in `modlist-third-person.md` — not replacing that framework with a second major combat overhaul. The goal is shorter, tenser fights and less stat-bloat without stepping on the `Valhalla Combat` and broader third-person ownership already recorded earlier in the plan. → [Survival & Combat - Difficulty & Lethality](#)

Baseline

- **Simply Balanced (Nexus)** — Preferred pacing tool. Solves final damage and progression tuning without re-owning stamina rules, injury logic, or combat behavior that already overlap heavily with `Valhalla Combat` and the section-04 stack. → [Survival & Combat - Difficulty & Lethality](#)

Alternatives

- **Blade and Blunt - A Combat Overhaul (Nexus)** — Strong comparison route if testing shows the list still needs a more authored stamina-and-pressure model, but treat as a deliberate branch because it reaches far beyond simple pacing. → [Survival & Combat - Difficulty & Lethality](#)
- Minimalist route — keep lethality mostly in the hands of the section-04 combat stack and only revisit this subsection if real testing shows that fights still drag.

Notes

- `Simply Balanced` is powerful precisely because it is broad; careless tuning can hide deeper problems in enemy design or progression structure. → [Survival & Combat - Difficulty & Lethality](#)
- `Blade and Blunt` is well regarded, but it is large enough to blur section ownership with both combat systems and survival-side stamina pressure. → [Survival & Combat - Difficulty & Lethality](#)
- If lethality is pushed too far, the list can stop feeling tense and start feeling brittle, especially once archery, magic, and follower support join the equation.

Enemy AI Improvements → [Survival & Combat - Enemy AI](#)

This subsection decides whether `Elder Wilds` wants a broad, authored enemy-behavior overhaul or whether encounter pressure should mostly come from structure, roster composition, and existing combat choices. The goal is more dangerous enemies, not random complexity for its own sake. → [Survival & Combat - Enemy AI](#)

Baseline

- Restrained route — rely on `Arena`, the section-04 combat stack, and targeted creature or faction additions elsewhere instead of adopting one giant enemy overhaul.
- **Less Sniperlike NPCs (Nexus)** — Reduces NPC projectile accuracy for bows and crossbows by adjusting `fCombatAimProjectileRandomOffset`. Prefer applying this tweak via Wrye Bash (set to ~70.0) to avoid adding an extra plugin. → [Survival & Combat - Enemy AI](#)

Alternatives

- **Skyrim Revamped - Complete Enemy Overhaul (Nexus)** — High-commitment comparison if the list later needs enemies to feel much more specialized, aggressive, and dangerous across the board, but should stay a branch rather than an automatic baseline. Strong reputation and real encounter impact, but authored enough that it changes the feel of the whole game rather than simply sharpening existing pressure. Add only if ordinary testing shows that better progression, tighter pacing, and the current combat stack still leave enemy behavior too flat. → [Survival & Combat - Enemy AI](#)
- Future targeted route — prefer smaller faction-specific overhauls later if broad enemy redesign proves too blunt for the final list tone.

Notes

- A broad enemy overhaul makes the whole list harder to reason about because every faction starts changing at once.
- SRCEO is compatible in the broad sense with encounter-zone overhauls, but it still meaningfully changes combat expectations and should be treated as a major identity choice.
- If this subsection solves flat encounters by making everything more dangerous, subtle differences between dungeon types may actually become less readable.

Injury, Stamina, And Resource Pressure → [Survival & Combat - Resources & Injuries](#)

This subsection covers attrition that lingers beyond a single swing: drained stamina, shaken nerves, enforced downtime, and the feeling that repeated bad fights accumulate a cost. It should reinforce travel rhythm and danger, not duplicate the entire survival framework from `modlist-expanded-systems.md` or replace the combat rules from `modlist-third-person.md`. → [Survival & Combat - Resources & Injuries](#)

Baseline

- **Stress and Fear - A Dynamic Sanity System (Nexus)** — Main comparison for this subsection. Fits the section's actual job better than a second combat framework: getting battered in a ruin or barely surviving a predator attack should have emotional and pacing consequences that encourage rest, food, inns, and quieter recovery loops. Reddit signal is strong, and its design is intentionally light enough to create stories and pauses without constantly shouting over the rest of the list. → [Survival & Combat - Resources & Injuries](#)

Alternatives

- **Blade and Blunt - A Combat Overhaul (Nexus)** — Overlapping alternative if the project decides it wants harsher stamina-and-combat pressure as a central identity, not as a casual add-on. → [Survival & Combat - Resources & Injuries](#)
- Minimalist route — keep resource pressure mostly inside the existing combat and survival layers unless testing shows downtime never matters.

Notes

- Too much attrition can make the wilderness feel exhausting rather than haunting or immersive.
- **Stress and Fear** is lighter than a full wound system, but it is still another MCM-driven rules layer that needs clear boundaries. → [Survival & Combat - Resources & Injuries](#)
- If both combat and survival are already demanding, this subsection can become the point where the whole list tips from moody into overmanaged.

Enemy Resistances And Knowledge Checks → [Survival & Combat - Enemy AI](#)

This subsection owns whether enemies should ask the player to identify weaknesses and vary damage types, rather than only hitting harder or soaking more damage. The goal is more tactical combat texture and creature differentiation without accidentally committing the whole list to a giant enemy-overhaul stack.

Baseline

- **Know Your Enemy 2 (Nexus)** — Leading resistance-and-knowledge route. Changes how the player reads enemies: different creatures call for different tools, and the inspect system makes that knowledge legible instead of purely hidden trivia. Keep it scoped to tactical differentiation, not full enemy-ecosystem ownership — [modlist-npcs.md](#) still owns creature rosters and faction variety. → [Survival & Combat - Enemy AI](#)

Alternatives

- Minimalist route — leave resistances close to vanilla and get encounter variety from roster changes, pacing, and player-side restraint.

Notes

- Resistance systems can feel punishing if the player does not have enough practical ways to adapt mid-run.
- **Know Your Enemy 2** overlaps with large alchemy, poison, and combat-balance overhauls more than a casual install suggests; patch expectations must stay visible. → [Survival & Combat - Enemy AI](#)
- The mod page still mentions [Backported Extended ESL Support](#) for older runtimes, but for the target Steam runtime [1.6.1170](#) it should not be installed. → [Survival & Combat - Enemy AI](#)
- If the inspect flow, MCM tuning, or resistance spread feels too noisy in ordinary play, the concept may be better than the lived experience.

Survival Systems Compatibility → [Survival & Combat - Resources & Injuries](#)

[modlist-expanded-systems.md](#) already owns which survival framework wins. This subsection owns how later difficulty and pressure choices interact with that framework once the rest of the load order is in place. The goal is to make survival, combat pressure, and downtime feel mutually reinforcing rather than like separate punishment meters. → [Survival & Combat - Resources & Injuries](#)

Baseline

- Additive route — use pressure layers that reward existing survival behaviors such as eating, resting, warming up, and returning to town.
- **Stress and Fear** naturally plugs into meals, inns, sleep, and calmer downtime instead of trying to become a second survival overhaul. → [Survival & Combat - Resources & Injuries](#)
- If **Starfrost** remains the baseline from [modlist-expanded-systems.md](#), section 11 should amplify the need to recover without forcing constant menu babysitting or a pile of overlapping bodily debuffs. → [Survival & Combat - Resources & Injuries](#)
- **Cold Breath NG (Nexus)** (v1.8, May 2026) — Replaces the vanilla breath-vapor effect with higher-fidelity, more visible fogged breath in cold environments. Mesh and particle replacer, no ESP, compatible with all weather and survival frameworks. Adds atmosphere to cold-region and survival travel without script overhead. → [Survival & Combat - Resources & Injuries](#)

Alternatives

- Competitive route — stack multiple heavy attrition systems and accept that survival becomes one of the list's dominant identities.
- Minimal route — keep survival isolated from the difficulty layer and let it remain mostly travel flavor.

Notes

- Survival compatibility becomes incoherent quickly if each layer assumes it should be the main source of exhaustion, injury, hunger, or downtime.
- A system that feels immersive in isolation can become oppressive once cold, sleep, food, combat recovery, and defeat penalties all stack together.
- If this subsection is too light, the chosen survival framework may feel disconnected from the actual danger layer.

Candidate TODO Additions

Survival & Needs → [Survival & Combat - Resources & Injuries](#)

- **Dirt and Blood** — visual dirt/blood accumulation on character (also cross-referenced in [Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs](#); primary ownership should be in whichever section the hygiene/survival system lands) → [Survival & Combat - Resources & Injuries](#)

FILE: modlist-lotd.md

Legacy of the Dragonborn

MO2 Separator: [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)

Core Mod Baseline → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)

This section owns the Legacy of the Dragonborn baseline for Elder Wilds: the museum itself, the collection-driven play loop it introduces, and the immediate support mods needed to make that framework practical inside a larger curated load order. The goal is to treat Legacy of the Dragonborn as a foundational content pillar for the final list, not as a late optional extra bolted onto an already-finished setup.

Baseline

- **Legacy of the Dragonborn** — Non-negotiable centerpiece. Museum progression, artifact collection, and the supported patch ecosystem follow from this decision. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **The Curator's Companion** — Cleaner in-game tracking for what the museum can display and what the player has already found. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Legacy of the Dragonborn Patches (Official)** — Required integration infrastructure once the supporting quest, item, and world-content stack is firm enough to justify concrete patch picks. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- Nexus 13279 (Paintings Replacer for Legacy of the Dragonborn SSE), 16080 (Legacy of the Dragonborn - Fate Cards Re-texture - Skyrim Concept Art), and 131107 (Placeable Display Cases) — Part of the LoTD ecosystem under active curation for this list. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)

Alternatives

- **No LoTD / late addition** — Treating LoTD as a maybe-later branch. Retrofitting LoTD after world content, quest expansions, and item mods are scattered is significantly harder than planning around it early. Not recommended for Elder Wilds.

Notes

- Legacy of the Dragonborn is closer to a structural content framework than an ordinary quest mod. Artifact discovery, unique-item routing, and compatibility planning all change when LoTD is in the list.
- If Elder Wilds incorporates LoTD, the list should acknowledge the real design consequence: planning around it early is cleaner than trying to retrofit it after world content, quest expansions, and item mods are already scattered across the repo.

Supported Content → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#) Mods And Museum Integration

This subsection tracks the kinds of mods that should be evaluated partly through the Legacy of the Dragonborn lens: quest mods, new lands, artifact packs, item expansions, player homes, and other content that may gain museum displays, sorting support, relic integration, or official patch coverage.

Candidate Mod Buckets To Track

- Official master content: [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#) — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/11802>.
- Museum tracking support: [The Curator's Companion](#) — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/38529>. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- Official patch hub: [Legacy of the Dragonborn Patches \(Official\)](#) — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/30980>. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- User-provided verified Nexus entries to retain in this LoTD planning set: **13279** — *Paintings Replacer for Legacy of the Dragonborn SSE* (v1.1, last updated Nov 2017 — ⚠ texture replacer, low risk of breakage but unmaintained); **16080** — *Legacy of the Dragonborn - Fate Cards Re-texture - Skyrim Concept Art* (v01, last updated Mar 2018 — ⚠ same caveat); **131107** — *Placeable Display Cases* (v3.1, last updated Jan 2025).
- Content with common LoTD integration pressure: major quest mods, artifact packs, unique-item expansions, new lands, treasure-hunt content, and player-home mods that may overlap with relic storage or collection routing.

Quest Mods With Strong LoTD Integration

The following quest and new-lands mods have established LoTD patch support (official or high-quality third-party) and are strong candidates for inclusion based on museum display value:

- **VIGILANT** — LoTD displays for artifacts, daedric items, and unique rewards. Multiple display cases in the museum's Hall of Oddities. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Unslaad** — LoTD patch available via the official patch hub; displays for the unique item set. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Glenmoril** — Patch pipeline still maturing; check before locking. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Project AHO** — Full display room in the museum (the AHO Display Room in the Hall of Secrets). → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)

- **Carved Brink** — Museum displays for artifacts from the Faceted Stones and unique weapons/armor. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **The Forgotten City** — Displays for the unique items and the player's choice reward. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Beyond Skyrim - Bruma** — Count-flation and display-base integration; some unique Bruma items have display slots. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Beyond Reach** — Third-party LoTD patch adds display support for unique items. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **The Wheels of Lull** — Display slots for unique items in the Hall of Secrets. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Moon and Star** — Display support for the unique armor and weapon reward. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Wyrmsooth** — LoTD displays for several unique items and the Wyrmsooth itself. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Falskaar** — Base museum count supports Falskaar's unique items. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Sirenroot - A Verdant Tale** — Newer mod; check patch status before locking display integration. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Midwood Isle** — Official LoTD patch support; displays for unique items from this worldspace. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **The Gray Cowl of Nocturnal** — Displays for the unique items and the legendary mask. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **The Breton Paladin** — Official patch support; displays for quest rewards. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Clockwork** — Display slots for unique items from this quest mod. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Konahrik's Accoutrements** — Deep LoTD integration with dedicated display room for full dragon priest regalia. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Artifacts - The Ice Blade of the Monarch** — Standalone artifact with dedicated LoTD display. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Artifacts - The Tournament of the Ten Bloods** — New artifact quest with LoTD displays. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Obscure's College of Winterhold** — LoTD patch included in Obscure's own FOMOD installer (20514). Covers display integration for the private collection and unique College items. Does not require the LoTD Official Patch Hub (30980). → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)

Display Expansions And Room Mods

- **LoTD Display Patch Repos** — Collection of third-party display patches for mods not covered by the official hub. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Museum Display Room Expansion** — If the base museum feels cramped after adding supported content, evaluate display-room expansion mods such as the *LoTD SSE - Museum Exterior Fixes* or *LoTD Display Room Overhaul* family. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Hall of Forgotten Guild** — Feature of the Curator's Companion that adds more shelf and case space for common collectibles. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Obscure's College of Winterhold** — Architecture overhaul with built-in LoTD display patch in its FOMOD. The patch resolves display records for the private collection, room plaque system, and unique College items. ESP-FE format. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)

Collectible Additions With LoTD Integration

- **Stones of Barenziah Quest Markers** — If the Stones of Barenziah quest is active, LoTD has a dedicated display for the completed crown. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Jewels of the Reach** — Additional gemstone collectible with possible LoTD support.
- **Dawnguard Treasure Map** — Does not add direct LoTD displays but feeds the collection-driven exploration loop. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)

Artifact Enhancement Mods

- **Zim's Immersive Artifacts (Nexus)** — Artifact overhaul that rebalances 50+ vanilla artifacts with lore-friendly stat changes, new enchantments, and optional visual upgrades. v1.7, FOMOD with modular install (pick individual artifacts or complete pack). ⚠️ **LoTD compatibility note:** ZIA modifies the same artifacts that LoTD displays. Verify patch status or load order: ZIA's changes may need LoTD to win on display records while ZIA wins on stats. If no official patch exists, load LoTD after ZIA so museum display conditions use LoTD's artifact records, and accept that ZIA's stat changes apply to collectible items. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)

Patch Strategy → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#) For LoTD Support

This subsection owns the patch philosophy for a [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#) build. The main decision is not whether patches exist, but how disciplined the list will be about only enabling the specific museum patches that correspond to finalized content picks.

Baseline

- Use the official **Legacy of the Dragonborn Patches (Official)** as the default patch source wherever it cleanly covers a chosen mod. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- Add third-party LoTD patches only when the official collection does not cover a finalized mod and the patch has a clear maintenance story.
- Do not pre-install broad patch bundles for mods that are still only hypothetical.
- Only keep patches for mods that survive into the actual final stack.
- Re-check load order, museum sorting behavior, and display activation after each major content addition.
- Keep patch ownership readable so LoTD compatibility does not disappear into an opaque misc-patches bucket. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)

Mod Selection Considerations

When evaluating whether to include a quest, new-lands, or artifact mod in Elder Wilds, ask:

1. **Does this mod have official or high-quality third-party LoTD patch support?** If yes, integration cost is low. If no, the value must be high enough to justify writing a custom patch or accepting that its items will not appear in the museum.
2. **Does the mod add unique items that would feel like they *should* be displayed?** A mod with several named artifacts that have no display slot creates a persistent sense of incompleteness.
3. **Does the mod conflict with LoTD worldspace edits?** Check for navmesh, landscape, or object conflicts before treating a mod as patch-compatible.
4. **Does the mod's intended play order fit the museum's unlock progression?** A mod that drops a high-value museum item too early can disrupt the pacing of the collection loop.

Submods → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#) And Quality-Of-Life Support

This subsection tracks the immediate Legacy of the Dragonborn ecosystem around the master mod: collection tracking, museum usability, and any later chosen add-ons that materially improve the museum loop without redefining the rest of the modlist.

Baseline

- **The Curator's Companion** — Leading companion mod for collection-state visibility. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Achievement Injector (Nexus)** — Achievement framework. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Legacy of the Dragonborn - Achievement Injector (Nexus)** — Museum-achievement content package. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Legacy of the Dragonborn Patches (Official)** — Expected main patch package. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- Additional ecosystem entries: 13279 (Paintings Replacer), 16080 (Fate Cards Re-texture), 131107 (Placeable Display Cases). → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)

Alternatives

- Additional museum-side submods — Only add if they solve a real usability or integration problem in the finalized stack. Do not accumulate submods for every museum friction point.

Sorting And Inventory Integration

- **Legacy Safehouse Plus** — Expands the museum safehouse with additional crafting stations, display cases, and quality-of-life features. Check compatibility with the latest LoTD version before locking. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **LoTD - Explorer's Room** — Adds an explorer-themed room to the safehouse with additional storage and display functionality. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Quick Light** — Not LoTD-specific, but essential for navigating the museum interior (press Light for a portable magelight). → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Map Markers for LoTD** — Adds a fast-travel map marker at the museum exterior after a quest condition is met. Reduces friction for returning to the museum to deposit finds. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)

Museum-Specific UI Enhancements

- **LoTD Museum Exterior Fixes** — Addresses navmesh and door-activation issues around the museum exterior. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **LoTD Hall of Secrets Door Fix** — Fixes the door activator in the Hall of Secrets if it does not open correctly after certain quest completions. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Object Manipulation Overhaul** — Not LoTD-specific, but useful for rearranging displays and cases without console commands. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)

Additional QoL And Immersion Mods

- **LoTD - Museum Exterior Music** — Adds area-appropriate music when entering the museum exterior cell. Low priority; evaluate after the audio section (`modlist-audio.md`) is locked. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Dynamic Activation Key** — Reduces E key scroll-conflict when interacting with museum displays, bookshelves, and crowded surface tables. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)

Relic System And Archaeological Content

Legacy of the Dragonborn v6 includes a built-in relic system and dig-site exploration mechanics. The following mods extend or complement that content:

- **Relic Hunter** — Additional relic-themed quests and exploration content that feeds into the museum collection loop. Evaluate for compatibility with LoTD v6's own relic system. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **LoTD - Explorer's League** — Framework extension that adds guild-like progression for relic hunters. Check patch status and overlap with Curator's Companion features. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- **Shovels - Dig Up Treasure** — Adds digging mechanics that complement LoTD's dig-site expeditions. Check for conflict or double-coverage. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)

Notes

- Legacy of the Dragonborn can quietly drag the whole load order toward completionist design even when another section wants a lighter exploration tone. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- It increases patching pressure across quests, artifacts, and world-content mods, so late list churn becomes more expensive.
- Museum-first progression can change the perceived value of loot and unique-item mods in ways that affect later curation decisions.
- Utility add-ons can accumulate quickly if every museum friction point gets its own extra plugin.
- Achievement-side add-ons should stay scoped: [Achievement Injector](#) is the framework, [Legacy of the Dragonborn - Achievement Injector](#) is only one content package that uses it. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- Quest mods with strong LoTD integration may co-determine the quest mod stack. If VIGILANT, Project AHO, or Carved Brink are excluded for other reasons, reflect those decisions in the LoTD section's supported-content list.
- Third-party display patches for older quest mods (pre-2023) may not be maintained against LoTD v6. Verify patch currency before treating third-party support as a factor.

Research Tasks → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)

- Verify the canonical Nexus page for [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#) before adding it to `mods-checklist.md`. **Verified (Jun 2026):** v6.10.1, updated 22 May 2026, author iccreamassassin — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialiedition/mods/11802> → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)

- Verify the canonical Nexus page for [The Curator's Companion](#) before adding it to `mods-checklist.md`. **Verified (Jun 2026):** v7.0.8, updated 30 Oct 2025 — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/38529> → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- Verify the canonical Nexus page for [Legacy of the Dragonborn Patches \(Official\)](#) before adding it to `mods-checklist.md`. **Verified (Jun 2026):** v6.10.7, updated 04 Jun 2026 — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/30980> → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- Verify the canonical Nexus page for [Achievement Injector](#) before adding it to `mods-checklist.md`. **Verified (Jun 2026):** v1.2.3, updated 03 Jan 2025 — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/126220> → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- Verify the canonical Nexus page for [Legacy of the Dragonborn - Achievement Injector](#) before adding it to `mods-checklist.md`. **Verified (Jun 2026):** v1.0, updated 02 Oct 2024 — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/130114> → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- Re-open the user-provided Nexus pages [13279](#), [16080](#), and [131107](#) in an interactive browser session later to record their exact canonical mod titles alongside the already-supplied URLs. **Resolved (Jun 2026):** [13279](#) — *Paintings Replacer for Legacy of the Dragonborn SSE* (v1.1, Nov 2017, texture replacer); [16080](#) — *Legacy of the Dragonborn - Fate Cards Re-texture - Skyrim Concept Art* (v01, Mar 2018, texture replacer); [131107](#) — *Placeable Display Cases* (v3.1, Jan 2025). Note: the two 2017-2018 texture mods are ancient but functional (textures do not break with engine updates); they contribute to the staleness threshold but are low-risk. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- As `modlist-world-content.md` and later content sections expand, record which chosen mods have official LoTD support and which require third-party patches. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- Decide whether any museum-side submods beyond [The Curator's Companion](#) are justified by actual play friction rather than by ecosystem sprawl. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- Check whether storage, display activation, and museum progression create any conflicts with the intended roleplay and pacing tone of Elder Wilds. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- Research third-party LoTD patch status for VIGILANT, Unslaad, Glenmoril, Carved Brink, and Project AHO under LoTD v6 — these quest mods add heavy artifact content and patch staleness would be a significant gap. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- Evaluate the overlap between LoTD v6's built-in relic system and external relic/adventure mods to determine whether [Relic Hunter](#), [LoTD - Explorer's League](#), or [Shovels - Dig Up Treasure](#) add meaningful new content or just duplicate existing systems. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- Verify whether [Legacy Safehouse Plus](#) and [LoTD - Explorer's Room](#) are compatible with LoTD v6.10+ without requiring patches for the patch. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)
- For each quest mod in the candidate list (VIGILANT, Project AHO, Carved Brink, etc.), confirm the exact display room or case in the museum and whether the display is automatic or requires the Curator's Companion to activate. → [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#)

FILE: modlist-curation.md

Modlist Curation Rules and Testing Plan

MO2 Separator: [Testing & Curation](#)

Curation Rules → [Testing & Curation](#)

These rules govern how [Elder Wilds](#) selects, evaluates, and curates mods across every section. They are not a substitute for section-level research, but a shared set of guardrails that keeps individual picks consistent with the list's overall identity.

Visual Style Consistency

Every texture, mesh, and lighting mod must be evaluated for visual coherence with the rest of the stack. Do not mix low-resolution vanilla-retexture packs with high-end PBR material overhauls in the same category unless there is a clear reason the lower-resolution option fills a gap the high-end pack does not cover. When two texture mods cover the same material type, prefer the one whose colour palette, weathering style, and material interpretation best match the [Elder Wilds](#) atmosphere: grounded, weathered, northern, and wilderness-first rather than clean, heroic, or high-fantasy.

Lore Friendliness

Mods that add new content must not contradict established [Elder Scrolls](#) lore unless the contradiction is the deliberate point of a well-regarded quest or world-space mod with its own narrative justification. Cosmetic overhauls should respect the setting's visual identity: steel should look like steel, fur and leather should dominate cold-region gear, and architecture should match the regional style of its hold. Lore-friendly does not mean lore-restricted: new content is welcome as long as it plausibly extends the existing world rather than replacing it.

Third-Person-First Design With Full Gamepad Support

[Elder Wilds](#) is built to be completely played in third-person with a gamepad. Every gameplay, animation, UI, camera, and interaction mod must be evaluated for third-person usability and gamepad compatibility first. The list must never force the player to switch to first-person or keyboard/mouse for any interaction — including lockpicking, reading, menu navigation, crafting, dialogue, container looting, and favouriting. A mod that works well in first-person or with keyboard/mouse but breaks the third-person gamepad experience (broken camera transitions, missing third-person animations, UI elements only displayed in first person, aiming mechanics that assume a centred crosshair, menus that require mouse input, interaction prompts that assume keyboard keys) is a poor fit regardless of its individual quality. First-person parity and keyboard/mouse support are bonuses, not substitutes.

Animation Quality Bar

All animation mods must meet the baseline established in `modlist-animations.md` and `modlist-third-person.md` for blend smoothness, motion-capture fidelity, and weapon-type awareness. Animations that clip, snap, float, or lack proper foot-planting are not acceptable even if they cover a category the current list

lacks. The bar is: the animation must look natural at standard gameplay speed in third-person view, not only in slow-motion showcase clips.

Performance Target And Hardware Assumptions

The target hardware baseline is a mid-range modern GPU (roughly NVIDIA RTX 3060 / AMD RX 6700 equivalent or better) at 1440p with a 60 FPS target in most outdoor scenes. Dense forest areas and major cities may drop below 60 FPS during complex load conditions; that is acceptable as long as the drop stays above 45 FPS. Mods that require DLSS or framegen to reach playable framerates on the target baseline must be flagged as optional rather than mandatory.

Preference For Lightweight Vs Feature-Rich Mods

When two mods solve the same design goal, prefer the lighter option unless the feature-rich alternative brings a clearly measurable improvement to usability, immersion, or gameplay depth that the lighter option cannot match. Lightweight means: fewer dependencies, smaller plugin footprint, less script load, simpler patch requirements, and easier conflict resolution. This rule exists because a 300-mod list built from individually lightweight picks is more maintainable than a 200-mod list where every pick brings heavy scripting, multiple masters, and complex compatibility overhead.

Rules For Avoiding Overlapping Overhauls

No two mods in the final load order should attempt to overhaul the same gameplay system unless one is explicitly a compatibility layer or patch that reconciles them. Examples of forbidden overlaps: two perk overhauls, two magic system overhauls, two encounter-zone overhauls, two survival frameworks running simultaneously, or two independently authored combat animation packs that both replace the same attack animation sets. When a section file discusses alternatives, it must clearly state whether the alternatives are compatible add-ons or exclusive branches.

Testing Plan → Testing & Curation

This testing plan is the verification layer for **Elder Wilds**. Each test stage targets a specific category of load-order risk: startup crashes, character-flow regressions, combat feel, performance in heavy scenes, visual consistency, and long-session stability. Tests are ordered so that earlier stages catch the most common failure modes before later stages invest time in detailed playthrough evaluation.

Fresh Game Startup Checklist

Before any gameplay testing begins, verify the following in order:

- Skyrim launches from **Mod Organizer 2** without a crash or infinite load screen. → **Testing & Curation**
- The main menu displays correctly with all UI mods active.
- A new game reaches the chosen alternate-start character-generation flow without freezing.
- The character-generation menu (races, presets, body, sliders) works with all body and appearance mods loaded.
- The game saves and loads a clean character save without corruption or missing-masters warnings.
- MCM registers all expected configuration menus.
- Console commands and basic navigation (movement, jumping, menu opening) work without error spam in the log.

If any step in this checklist fails, do not proceed to later tests. Fix the root cause first.

Character Creation Test

Create a character using the chosen alternate-start method. Verify:

- Race selection, body preset, and appearance sliders all apply correctly in-game.
- Starting equipment, spells, and inventory match the alternate-start configuration.
- The starting location loads without crashes, missing geometry, or broken lighting.
- Perk, race, and standing-stone overrides apply their intended starting effects.
- The first level-up triggers the correct perk menu or notification without errors.
- Starting quest or directional marker appears as expected.

Do not skip this test when changing race, body, perk, or alternate-start mods.

Third-Person Combat Test

Fight at least five encounters covering different enemy types and weapon configurations:

- One-handed with shield against a humanoid opponent (bandit or soldier).
- Two-handed power attacks against a single large target.
- Archery or ranged magic against a distant or moving target.
- Dual-wielding or spell-sword loadout against a faster enemy (wolf, spider).
- Mounted combat if a horse overhaul is active, against a roadside enemy.

For each encounter, verify:

- Camera behaviour (lock-on, shoulder switching, free-look) is stable and responsive.
- Dodge, block, parry, and stagger mechanics trigger correctly.
- Hit reactions, impact effects, and sound feedback play without delay.
- No animation breaks, snapping, or T-posing occur.
- UI elements (health bars, stamina, enemy lock indicators) display correctly and update in real time.

City Performance Test

Fast-travel to or enter each major city (Whiterun, Solitude, Windhelm, Riften, Markarth) and walk from the city gate to the central market or keep. For each city:

- Record framerate range during the walk.
- Note any stutter, loading pauses, or texture pop-in.
- Check for missing objects, broken navmesh paths, or NPCs stuck in geometry.
- Verify city overhaul mods apply their changes without gaps or clipping.
- Confirm that indoor cells connected to the city (temple, inn, keep) load their correct lighting.

A city test fails if framerate drops below 45 FPS on the target hardware baseline or if visual errors make an area feel broken rather than lived-in.

Forest Traversal Test

Travel on foot through at least three distinct wooded areas: a dense pine forest (Falkreath hold), an aspen or deciduous woodland (The Rift), and a tundra transition zone (Whiterun plains near the forest edge). For each area:

- Record framerate during traversal with grass, tree, and LOD mods active.
- Check for grass pop-in, tree LOD shimmer, or distant-object flicker.
- Verify soundscape mods (bird calls, wind, ambient tracks) change appropriately between biomes.
- Confirm that random encounters, wildlife, and patrols spawn at expected intervals.
- Test that No Grass In Objects caches and grass precaching work without visible dead zones.

The forest test passes if traversal stays playable (no sustained drops below 45 FPS) and the visual transition between biomes feels organic.

Dungeon Lighting Test

Enter at least three dungeons: one Nordic ruin, one cave or mine, and one Dwemer ruin. For each:

- Verify that the chosen lighting overhaul produces readable contrast without crushing shadows to pure black or washing out all atmosphere.
- Check that torch, magelight, and candlelight spells illuminate correctly under the current weather and lighting stack.
- Confirm that interior acoustic changes (reverb, ambient loops) match the room size and material type.
- Look for light-bled through walls, misaligned shadow meshes, or fire-flicker that does not match the flame source.
- Test combat in low-light conditions to ensure enemy silhouettes are visible enough for third-person targeting.

The dungeon test fails if any interior is unplayably dark (unable to navigate without a light source even with brightness at default) or if lighting errors break immersion in more than one room per dungeon.

UI And Controller Test

Test the entire UI surface with both keyboard-and-mouse and a controller (Xbox or PlayStation layout):

- Inventory, magic, map, journal, and crafting menus open, navigate, and close without errors.
- Item cards display correct information (name, weight, value, enchantment, crafting recipe).
- The map renders correctly and quest markers appear in the right world-space positions.
- Dialogue menus show full text without clipping and respond to input without delay.
- Controller button mappings match the expected layout and all shortcuts (favourites, quick save, journal) work.
- HUD elements (compass, health/stamina/magica bars, enemy health, quest tracker) display at the correct size and position for the target resolution.

The UI test fails if any menu is unusable on either input method or if controller support requires manual INI editing to work at all.

Long-Session Stability Test

Play continuously for at least two hours using a character that has completed the basic tests above. During the session:

- Travel through at least four different worldspaces or holds, including at least one city-to-dungeon transition and one fast-travel load.
- Complete at least two quest stages, one combat encounter, and one menu-heavy activity (crafting, perk selection, inventory sorting).
- Open and close the MCM at least once to force a full UI reflow.
- Save and reload from the save at least twice during the session.
- After two hours, check the save file size and Papyrus log for accumulating errors, stack dumps, or script-instance leaks.

The long-session test passes if the game does not crash, the save remains loadable, and the Papyrus log does not show escalating error spam. A single crash is a warning. Two crashes in separate two-hour sessions is a failure that must be investigated before the modlist is considered stable.

Post-Install Smoke Test → Testing & Curation

This is the standard post-section smoke test used across all section files. Run after completing any numbered section.

#	Command	Location	Stress Profile
1	<code>coc Whiterun</code>	Whiterun	Major city — NPCs, shadows, architecture density
2	<code>coc Solitude</code>	Solitude	Large city — water reflections, long draw distances
3	<code>coc RiftenOrigin</code>	Riften	Canopy lighting, heavy NPC AI packages
4	<code>coc MarkarthOrigin</code>	Markarth	Dwemer stone, waterfalls, extreme verticality

#	Command	Location	Stress Profile
5	<code>coc Riverwood</code>	Riverwood	Forest exterior — grass, trees, landscape LOD
6	<code>coc BleakFallsBarrow01</code>	Bleak Falls Barrow	Interior dungeon — close-quarters lighting
7	<code>coc WhiterunBanneredMare</code>	Bannered Mare (Whiterun)	Tavern interior — fire lighting, patron NPCs, confined space

Pass criteria: No crash on load. No missing textures. FPS target: ≥60 FPS during graphics-heavy stages (sections 02-16); ≥40 FPS acceptable during section 01 (foundations only, no visual mods yet). Uncap framerate, use `tgmm` for god mode if needed.

If any location fails, the most recently installed mod or generation step is the first suspect.

FILE: modlist-adult.md

Adult Content

MO2 Separator: [Adult Content](#)

Framework Prerequisites → [Adult Content](#)

This subsection owns the animation framework that supports the romance, dialogue, and transactional content below. It does not import the SexLab framework or its associated dependency chain. The baseline choice is OStim Standalone — a modern, standalone adult animation framework that does not require OSA, and that the OStim Romance and Amorous Adventures patch layer depend on.

Baseline

- **OStim Standalone** ([Nexus](#)) — The modern adult animation framework for Skyrim SE/AE. Standalone means it does not require OSA or any legacy dependency. Provides the animation system that OStim Romance and the Amorous Adventures OStim patch build on. The maintained branch after OStim NG. → [Adult Content](#)
- **OStim Community Resource** ([Nexus](#)) — A shared framework and dependency required by various OStim add-on mods. Install alongside OStim Standalone as a prerequisite for the broader OStim ecosystem. → [Adult Content](#)
- **OARE - Open Animations Romance and Erotica** — Recommended animation pack baseline. → [Adult Content](#)
- **Additional Leito's Animations for Ostim Standalone** ([Nexus](#)) — Leito's set, ~150 animations. → [Adult Content](#)
- **Anub's animations for Ostim Standalone** ([Nexus](#)) — ~685 animations. → [Adult Content](#)
- **PPA - Procedural Penis Animations** ([Nexus](#)) — Procedural physics addon that animates and aligns with CBPC collision. Adds physical believability to OStim scenes without replacing the animation framework. → [Adult Content](#)
- **OSmp - Automatic SMP physics toggle for OStim** ([Nexus](#)) — Automatically toggles SMP physics on/off for player and NPCs during OStim scenes. ESL-flagged, supports CBBE 3BA and HIMBO. → [Adult Content](#)
- **Female Moan Voicesets For Ostim Standalone** ([Nexus](#)) — 38 female moan/climax voicesets keyed to voice types, giving different NPCs distinct moans. → [Adult Content](#)
- **Ostim SA-Sound Replacer-Blowjob** ([Nexus](#)) — Sound replacement for blowjob scenes. → [Adult Content](#)
- **Male Orgasm Sounds For Ostim Standalone** ([Nexus](#)) — Male climax moan and cum sound effects. → [Adult Content](#)
- **OCum Ascended - Cum and Orgasm Mechanics for OStim** ([Nexus](#)) — Adds cum and orgasm mechanics including visual cum layers, orgasm-tracking, and scene progression based on arousal. Expands OStim's physiological feedback layer beyond sounds into visible consequence. → [Adult Content](#)
- **Clean Navigation Icons for OStim Standalone** ([Nexus](#)) — 62 navigation icons for OStim Standalone menus. UI polish, zero gameplay impact. → [Adult Content](#)
- **Animation Pack Icons for OStim Standalone** ([Nexus](#)) — 18 icons for animation packs in the OStim scene menu. Complements Clean Navigation Icons. → [Adult Content](#)
- **OTooTiredToMove - Experience true exhaustion after climax in OStim Standalone** ([Nexus](#)) — Optional gameplay addon. Temporarily immobilises the character after scene climax to simulate exhaustion. Adds a recovery-moment consequence without script overhead. → [Adult Content](#)

Alternatives

- **SexLab** — Legacy framework. Not baseline because OStim Standalone is the modern maintained choice and avoids SexLab's dependency chain.
- **OSA** — Legacy dependency. OStim Standalone eliminated the OSA requirement.

Notes

- OStim Standalone must not be loaded alongside legacy OSA or SexLab. Verify no other mod in the list pulls those in as transitive dependencies.
- OStim Romance and the AA OStim patch must match the same OStim Standalone version.
- OStim can cause script load if too many scenes are triggered rapidly — keep the animation framework's auto-start settings conservative.

Romance Content → [Adult Content](#)

This subsection owns the romance-quest and companion-romance content that runs on top of the OStim framework. The picks here are opt-in quest-driven content rather than ambient framework behaviour.

Baseline

- **OSTim Romance** (Nexus) — The primary romance-content baseline. OSTim-native romance addon with active maintenance and the clearest integration path. → [Adult Content](#)
- **Amorous Adventures OSTim Standalone Patch** (Nexus) — Companion for classic NPC romance arcs that OSTim Romance does not own. Ports the classic Amorous Adventures content to OSTim Standalone. Adds voiced romance quests for vanilla marriage-eligible NPCs. → [Adult Content](#)

Alternatives

- **Romance Suite** — Additional OSTim ecosystem romance addons. Not baseline; evaluate if more depth is needed after the core romance stack is installed.

Notes

- Romance content addons must match the installed OSTim Standalone version. Lock the framework version first, then verify romance mod compatibility.
- Romance quests add dialogue and quest records that may conflict with content from [modlist-world-content.md](#) or NPC overhauls from [modlist-npcs.md](#).
- Amorous Adventures adds dialogue to specific vanilla NPCs. If [Relationship Dialogue Overhaul](#) or [Serana Dialogue Add-On](#) (from [modlist-expanded-systems.md](#)) also add dialogue for the same NPCs, verify load order resolves correctly.

NPCs And Dialogue → [Adult Content](#)

This subsection owns NPC overhauls and dialogue expansions that include adult content — companion mods with romantic or sexual dialogue, and character face/body overhauls designed for the adult content audience.

Baseline

- **Rigma - A male NPC overhaul** (Nexus) — Male NPC overhaul with a focus on attractiveness while maintaining lore-friendly aesthetics. Pairs with CBBE-based female overhauls and HIMCO male body. Includes SOS support and vanilla-facegen compatibility. → [Adult Content](#)
- **Rigma - KS Hairdos patch** — Adds KS Hairdos hairstyles to Rigma NPC records. → [Adult Content](#)

Alternatives

- **Shrooms of Solstheim - A Mushroom Overhaul** (Nexus) — Visual upgrade for Solstheim's flora. Adjacent to adult content primarily because of visual style preferences for the adult-content layer. Not a direct NPC replacement. → [Adult Content](#)

Notes

- Rigma conflicts with other male NPC overhauls. If [modlist-npcs.md](#) locks [The Men of Winter](#), Rigma must override it on a per-NPC basis or be reconciled via load order and facegen regeneration.
- Rigma relies on SOS body paths; verify the installed SOS and HIMCO versions are compatible.
- Rigma's facegen should not produce dark-face bugs when layered on top of the chosen NPC baseline.

Dialogue Expansions → [Adult Content](#)

This subsection owns dialogue-expansion mods that include adult-themed or romantic dialogue content as a core feature.

Baseline

- **Haelga Reimagined** (Nexus) — Innkeeper-dialogue expansion for Haelga from Riften's Haelga's Bunkhouse. Expands her character with a more modern, romance-suitable dialogue tree. → [Adult Content](#)
- **Soul-Crushing Romance - A Molag Bal Dialogue Mod** (Nexus) — Fully-voiced romance dialogue expansion for the House of Horrors quest, adding a romance arc with Molag Bal's priest. → [Adult Content](#)
- **Blood and Bismuth - A Farkas Dialogue Mod** (Nexus) — Fully-voiced Farkas dialogue expansion with romance content for the Companions follower. → [Adult Content](#)

Alternatives

- **The Billy The Goat Mod** (Nexus) — Novelty companion mod with adult-themed dialogue. Fully-voiced goat companion with a distinct personality. Optional; not part of the core adult-content stack. → [Adult Content](#)

Notes

- Dialogue expansions modify the same NPC voice types and dialogue records that [Relationship Dialogue Overhaul](#) and quest mods from [modlist-world-content.md](#) touch. Verify load order resolves all dialogue conflicts.
- Haelga Reimagined, Soul-Crushing Romance, and Blood and Bismuth all add dialogue to specific NPCs. If another mod also overhauls the same NPCs, test for broken dialogue trees.

Additional Content → [Adult Content](#)

This subsection owns standalone adult-content mods that do not fit neatly into the framework, romance, or NPC categories above.

Baseline

- **Simple Bathing (Nexus)** — Adds player-initiated bathing animations in any water source. Thematically adjacent to adult content (nudity context) but functionally a downtime-roleplay mod. → [Adult Content](#)
- **Simple Bathing Soap Addon** — Adds soap items to make bathing feel more intentional.

Alternatives

- **BeeHH - Hentai Henchman (Nexus)** — Adds follower slots (up to 9) with adult-content-inspired features. Research item only — not locked until it proves useful beyond the Nether's Follower Framework baseline. → [Adult Content](#)

Notes

- Simple Bathing may overlap with [Bathing in Skyrim - Renewed](#) (from [modlist-expanded-systems.md](#)). If both are active, configure them so they do not double-trigger bathing mechanics.
- BeeHH adds follower slot changes that conflict with NFF. If both are active, the follower framework must win for stability; BeeHH should only be used for features NFF does not provide.

FILE: modlist-voicing.md

Main Character Voicing

MO2 Separator: [Voicing](#)

Framework Overview → [Voicing](#)

Dragonborn Voice Over (DBVO) and Main Character Voice Over Generator (MCVO Generator) together give Skyrim's player character a voice: DBVO is the runtime framework that plays audio for the player's dialogue lines, and MCVO Generator scans the full load order and produces the data files that drive voice generation. Combined with AI voice synthesis (xVASynth or ElevenLabs), the player character speaks every dialogue line across the entire modlist. This section covers both variants: using pre-made voice packs for a drop-in solution, and generating custom voice packs for those who want a specific voice for their character.

Baseline

- **Dragonborn Voice Over (Nexus)** — The SKSE-based framework. Intercepts player dialogue responses and plays .wav files from an installed voice pack. MCM allows switching between voice packs per character. Required by MCVO Generator as a master. → [Voicing](#)
- **Pre-made voice packs (drop-in, no generation)** — Download a completed voice pack and install it as a mod in MO2. **Bella Voice DBVO (Nexus)** is the most popular female pack with the broadest mod coverage. **DBVO - Allison Voice Pack (Nexus)** is a British female alternative. Pre-made male packs are less common. → [Voicing](#)
- **Recommended actress voices (female PC): Jennifer Hale** (Bella Voice DBVO uses spliced voice lines from Jennifer Hale's extensive VO catalog as its source material). Her range across Mass Effect (female Shepard), Metroid (Samus), and Baldur's Gate fits the grounded-but-authoritative tone the modlist targets. → [Voicing](#)
- **Recommended actor voices (male PC): Travis Willingham** (MCVO Generator + xVASynth pipeline can use voice models based on his performance as Thor / Guile / Roy Mustang). His commanding baritone works well for a male Dragonborn with an authoritative presence. → [Voicing](#)

Alternatives

- **MCVO Generator + xVASynth (Nexus / Nexus)** — Free custom-generation path. MCVO Generator scans the full load order and produces [DBVO-All.esp](#) and [DBVO-All.csv](#). xVASynth batch-generates .wav files using PyTorch-based voice models (default: Geralt of Rivia). Quality is noticeably synthetic. The simplest custom path for male voices or when pre-made packs don't match the desired voice. Must be re-run whenever the load order changes. → [Voicing](#)
- **ElevenLabs + DBVO Voice Pack Creator** — Premium custom-generation path. Higher quality, more natural-sounding output. Requires an ElevenLabs paid account and the DBVO Voice Pack Creator tool (Discord-only, not on Nexus). Recommended for players who want a specific voice identity not available in pre-made packs. → [Voicing](#)

Notes

- DBVO requires ConsoleUtilSSE NG, JContainers SE, SkyUI, and SKSE64 (all already in the foundations stack).
- DBVO must load after any mod that edits [dialoguemenu.swf](#). Place it after the UI stack in the left pane. → [Voicing](#)
- Long file paths can crash the game on startup (Windows 255-char limit). Keep the install path short. → [Voicing](#)
- Pre-made voice packs may not cover every mod. Uncovered lines fall back to subtitles.
- ElevenLabs packs must comply with the service's terms of service.
- MCVO Generator last updated March 2023; still works on 1.6.1170 but has no active development. → [Voicing](#)
- xVASynth batch processing can take 2-3 hours for 50,000+ lines.
- DBVO respects Skyrim's race/gender voice types. Primary targets are [MaleEvenToned](#) and [FemaleEvenToned](#).

Dual Voice Pack Strategy → [Voicing](#)

Since Elder Wilds supports both male and female player characters, two complete voice packs (one male, one female) must be generated or sourced. They are installed as separate MO2 mods and swapped either via MO2 profile or DBVO MCM.

Baseline

- **Option A: Pre-Made Packs (Recommended)** — Install a female pack (Bella or Allison) and generate a male pack via MCVO Generator + xVASynth (Geralt default).

Alternatives

- **Option B: ElevenLabs Both** — Run the DBVO Voice Pack Creator tool twice with two different voice IDs. Package as separate MO2 mods.
- **Option C: MCVO + xVASynth Both** — Run the MCVO pipeline once with a male model and once with a female xVASynth model. Keep output mods separate.

Notes

- Reserve Options B and C for players who want a specific voice identity not available in pre-made packs.

MCVO Generator + xVASynth Pipeline → Voicing

The standard workflow for generating a voice pack from the full load order using free tools.

Before Starting

- Install DBVO and its dependencies. DBVO must be enabled and its .esp in the load order before running MCVO Generator.
- Build the full modlist in MO2 with the final load order.
- Install xVASynth and the desired voice models. For the default male voice, download the Geralt of Rivia voice pack (Witcher 3 Nexus 5676).
- Download MCVO Generator from Nexus and extract it to a convenient location (e.g., `C:\Modding\Tools\MCVO Generator`). → Voicing

Generating the Voice Pack

1. Run MCVO Generator (`DBVO-All.exe`). It produces `DBVO-All.esp` in `Data\` and `DBVO-All.csv` next to the .exe. Add the .esp to MO2 as a new mod.
2. Open xVASynth in Batch Mode, load `DBVO-All.csv`, select the voice model, click **Generate**.
3. xVASynth outputs .wav files under `Data\Sound\Voice\Dragonborn Voice Over\`. Create an MO2 mod from this folder structure.
4. Launch the game through SKSE, open the DBVO MCM, select the generated voice pack, and test a few dialogue lines.

Generating The Second Set (Male/Female)

Repeat steps 2-4 with a different voice model. Create a separate MO2 mod. Enable one at a time.

ElevenLabs Custom Voice Pack → Voicing

Generate higher-quality audio via ElevenLabs as an alternative to xVASynth.

Prerequisites

- ElevenLabs account with a paid plan (Creator \$22/mo. recommended for full load order).
- Access to the DBVO Voice Pack Creator tool (DBVO author's Discord server, `#tool-download` channel). → Voicing
- An ElevenLabs API key.

Voice Selection

Browse the ElevenLabs Voice Library for a pre-made voice, or use Voice Design to create one. Get the voice ID via GET `https://api.elevenlabs.io/v1/voices` with your API key.

Generating The Voice Pack

1. Run MCVO Generator to produce `DBVO-All.csv`.
2. Use the DBVO Voice Pack Creator tool: point it at the CSV, enter your API key and target voice ID, run the tool.
3. Package the output folder structure as an MO2 mod and enable it.

Generating Male + Female Sets

Pick two voice IDs, run the tool twice, create two MO2 mods. Enable only the one matching the current character.

Character Quota Planning

The Creator plan (100,000 characters/month) covers ~15,000-20,000 dialogue lines. A full 50,000+ line load order may need the Pro plan (\$99/month, 500,000 characters) or multiple months. Use the free tier (10,000 characters/month) for testing only.

FILE: modlist-performance.md

Performance and Technical Workflow

MO2 Separator: Performance

Overview

This section owns the performance budgeting, optimization discipline, generated-patch pipeline, and long-term maintenance workflow that keeps **Elder Wilds** stable as the load order grows. The section is split into five sub-files that each own a distinct concern:

- **Performance Strategy:** budgeted performance analysis, VRAM-heavy mod review, CPU-heavy script review
- **Optimization & Configuration:** shader impact, grass/tree/draw-call optimization, INI tuning (BethINI Pie baseline), save safety
- **Tool Pipeline:** xEdit/Pandora/DynDOLOD/Synthesis workflow discipline, 4K LOD baseline (xLODGen/TexGen/DynDOLOD STEP config), optional diagnostics (Recursion Monitor, S.L.A.C.K.)
- **Bashed Patch & Synthesis Configuration:** exact Wrye Bash tweak settings, Bash Tag per plugin, full Synthesis patcher pipeline (11 stages), build order and rebuild triggers
- **Testing & Maintenance:** benchmark methodology and scenarios, tuning knobs, patcher revisit triggers, generator output order, change tracking, MCM recording, mod update workflow

Sub-File Index

File	Section
modlist-performance-strategy.md	Performance Strategy
modlist-performance-optimization.md	Optimization & Configuration
modlist-performance-tools.md	Tool Pipeline
modlist-performance-patches.md	Bashed Patch & Synthesis Configuration
modlist-performance-testing.md	Testing & Maintenance

Key Principles

- Treat performance as four separate problems: shader cost, VRAM pressure, CPU/script load, and exterior draw-call pressure. A fix that targets the wrong category makes things worse.
- Use the disciplined route for all generated work: keep every output in its own dedicated MO2 mod, rebuild only when the owning category changes, and run tools in a repeatable order.
- The Bashed Patch and Synthesis pipeline is the single source of truth for conflict resolution. A tag or patcher exists only when a specific mod in the list requires it.
- The list's long-term health depends on disciplined rebuild habits, saved MCM profiles, and a documented changelog — not on any single mod pick.

Related Sections

- [modlist-foundations.md](#) — engine baseline, SSE Display Tweaks config, core stability fixes
- [modlist-graphics-shaders.md](#) — Community Shaders visual framework (performance envelope owned by [modlist-performance-optimization.md](#))
- [modlist-curation.md](#) — curation rules and testing methodology

FILE: modlist-performance-strategy.md

Performance Strategy

MO2 Separator: [Performance](#)

Part of the [Performance](#) and [Technical Workflow](#) section. See also: [14b](#) (Optimization & Configuration), [14c](#) (Tool Pipeline), [14d](#) (Bashed Patch & Synthesis), [14e](#) (Testing & Maintenance).

Performance Budgeting → [Performance](#)

This section does not replace the engine baseline from [modlist-foundations.md](#) or the graphics decisions from [modlist-graphics-shaders.md](#). Its job is to decide how **Elder Wilds** measures performance, identifies bottlenecks, and keeps generated workflow sane once the list gets heavy.

Baseline

- **Budgeted route** — Separate GPU, VRAM, CPU/script, and draw-call problems so fixes target the real cause.
- Treat performance as four different problems that can look similar in play: shader cost, VRAM pressure, CPU/script load, and exterior draw-call pressure.
- Keep one repeatable forest scene, one city scene, and one dungeon/interior scene for comparisons rather than testing in random places.
- Record baseline and post-change captures with [PresentMon](#) and review them in [CapFrameX](#) or an equivalent frame-time tool instead of trusting impressions. → [Performance](#)
- Prefer a stable frame-time target over chasing the highest uncapped number.

Alternatives

- **Intuition-first route** — Change settings and mods by feel until the game seems stable enough.

- **Average-FPS route** — Judge the list mostly by headline FPS even if frame pacing and bottleneck type stay unclear.

Notes

- A single bad scene can be CPU-bound, GPU-bound, or content-bound in different directions, so one "performance fix" can solve the wrong problem.
- Average FPS can improve while hitching and traversal smoothness still get worse.
- Measuring several categories at once makes later decisions impossible to trust.

VRAM-Heavy Mod Review → Performance

VRAM pressure in this list will come mostly from texture resolution, PBR/parallax adoption, heavy shader features, and world coverage, not from one magic setting. The goal is to spend texture budget where it is visible in normal play instead of paying premium cost everywhere.

Baseline

- **Selective route** — High resolution only for hero assets, creatures, architecture, or landscape layers that actually dominate the screen.
- Keep broad world textures disciplined and reserve heavier resolutions for assets the player repeatedly sees up close.
- When a visual pack offers multiple sizes, start below the maximum and only scale upward if testing proves the asset really earns it.
- Treat PBR/parallax conversions as a VRAM and maintenance choice, not just a screenshot upgrade.
- If a scene stutters, verify whether it is actual memory pressure before blaming scripts or AI.

Alternatives

- **Max-detail route** — Broad 4K coverage, frequent material upgrades, and little restraint on texture size. → Performance
- **Restraint-first route** — Mostly 2K and below with only a few intentional exceptions. → Performance

Notes

- High VRAM usage can look like generic stutter, but lowering unrelated gameplay mods will not fix it.
- Mixed-resolution stacks can still overload memory if too many wide-coverage packs are combined.
- Some landscape, architecture, and material upgrades cost more in aggregate than character textures ever will.

CPU-Heavy Script Review → Performance

CPU and Papyrus pressure usually comes from layered systems, NPC density, polling scripts, and constant background updates rather than one dramatic offender. This section should keep the list from mistaking script delay for graphics trouble.

Baseline

- **Moderated route** — Keep strong feature mods, but avoid stacking several background-heavy systems that solve similar jobs.
- Treat NPC expansion, survival layers, follower frameworks, reputation systems, defeat systems, and ambient event mods as cumulative load, not isolated decisions.
- Prefer one good system per gameplay problem instead of three lighter systems that all tick in the background.
- Keep diagnostic logging and troubleshooting-only settings off during normal play unless a bug actually needs them.
- Judge script health through sleeping, waiting, cell changes, combat cleanup, and long travel rather than standing still in one test spot.

Alternatives

- **Permissive route** — Allow multiple overlapping always-on systems and troubleshoot only after instability appears.
- **Strict route** — Aggressively cut scripted features even when they materially help the list identity.

Notes

- Script delay often gets misdiagnosed as low FPS or "Skyrim being Skyrim."
- Mid-save uninstall habits can create save instability that looks like performance decay.
- A list can feel fine in short tests and still degrade badly over longer sessions.

FILE: modlist-performance-optimization.md

Optimization & Configuration

MO2 Separator: Performance

Part of the Performance and Technical Workflow section. See also: 14a (Performance Strategy), 14c (Tool Pipeline), 14d (Bashed Patch & Synthesis), 14e (Testing & Maintenance).

Shader Performance Impact → Performance

Section [Graphics](#) already owns the visual framework. This subsection owns the performance envelope that framework is allowed to occupy. The practical question is not whether shader features look good; it is which ones are worth their measurable cost in real travel scenes.

Baseline

- **Conservative to balanced route** — Accept a few heavier depth or lighting features once the rest of the visual stack is stable.
- Remove or downgrade luxury modules before tearing apart the rest of the graphics stack.
- Keep [Skyrim Upscaler](#) as a fallback tool from section [Graphics](#), not the first answer to poor optimization discipline. → [Performance](#)
- Use the existing [SSE Display Tweaks](#) baseline from section [Foundations](#) to enforce a stable frame cap once the real sustained performance target is known. → [Performance](#)
- Judge shader cost in motion, weather transitions, and dense foliage scenes instead of still screenshots.

Alternatives

- **Conservative route** — Keep the [Community Shaders](#) stack close to the section-02 baseline. → [Performance](#)
- **Luxury route** — Keep piling on expensive modules, then try to recover the cost elsewhere.

Notes

- Heavier shader modules can shift the bottleneck hard toward GPU cost while the list still looks only marginally better in play.
- Frame generation, upscaling, or frame-cap tuning can hide weak baseline decisions instead of fixing them.
- A beautiful static scene can still fail if traversal frame pacing is poor.

Grass, Tree, And Draw-Call Optimization → [Performance](#)

Exterior performance in a wilderness-heavy list is often limited by draw calls, clutter density, and visibility complexity, not only raw GPU power. This subsection decides how aggressive [Elder Wilds](#) should be about invisible optimization helpers once the visual direction is already known.

Baseline

- **Content restraint first, then low-maintenance optimization route.**
- **Lightened Skyrim** — Leading optimization branch. Community support and mod page both describe it as an almost invisible cleanup layer with relatively low drama. → [Performance](#)
- **eFPS - Exterior FPS boost** — Optional branch only if real testing shows exterior draw-call pressure still needs more help after the main world stack is stable. If used, plan for patch coverage as part of the worldspace stack. → [Performance](#)
- Re-evaluate exterior optimization after major city, roadside, tree, or world-content choices, because those categories move the bottleneck more than INI tweaks do.

Alternatives

- **Content-restraint route** — Solve most exterior cost by choosing lighter trees, lighter grass, and fewer stacked clutter edits.
- **High-maintenance optimization route** — Add occlusion-heavy optimization mods that can improve bad scenes more dramatically but create broad patch debt.

Notes

- [eFPS](#) has strong upside, but both its own page and current Reddit signal point to real compatibility and patch-maintenance overhead for lists with heavy exterior edits. → [Performance](#)
- Optimization layers can create missing-geometry or bad-occlusion symptoms if installed casually into a moving worldspace stack.
- Heavy cities, outskirts, roads, trees, and landmark mods can erase optimization gains faster than tweak mods can recover them.

INI Tuning And Display Settings → [Performance](#)

INI tuning should normalize and document the setup, not become a pile of mystery fixes no one remembers later. The best INI workflow is the one that can be reproduced cleanly in [Mod Organizer 2](#) without guesswork.

Baseline

- **Tool-first route** — Use [BethINI Pie](#) as the baseline editor. It gives [Elder Wilds](#) a reproducible preset-and-recommended-tweaks starting point instead of scattered manual edits. → [Performance](#)
- For [MO2](#), keep the INI path behavior simple and documented rather than forcing unusual file redirection unless a guide specifically requires it. → [Performance](#)
- After the baseline is set, keep only a short list of manual overrides that are actually justified by the final display, shadow, or frame-cap target.
- Let [SSE Display Tweaks](#) handle display behavior and frame pacing choices that belong there instead of fighting them through unrelated INI changes. → [Performance](#)

Alternatives

- **Manual-edit route** — Hand-edit multiple INIs and hope the final state stays understandable.
- **Constant-tweaking route** — Keep changing presets and overrides every time performance changes.

Notes

- Aggressive or undocumented INI changes can make later troubleshooting impossible.
- BethINI-related confusion usually comes from path handling and profile expectations, not from the tool magically fixing every performance issue.
- Repeated preset flipping can hide which change actually helped.

BethINI Pie Configuration Baseline

Run BethINI Pie through MO2 so it targets the active profile INIs. The configuration below sets the initial baseline before mod-specific overrides.

1. **Basic** tab:

- Click **Reset to Defaults**, select the **High** preset, then **Apply Recommended Tweaks**.
- **Window Mode** → **Borderless Windowed**.
- **Field of View** → First Person **75**, Third Person **85** (wider third-person FOV improves gamepad camera comfort).

2. **General** tab:

- Under **Saved Games**, untick **Autosaves** (survival mods handle save restrictions; manual saves are safer with a heavily-modded load order). Also untick **Save on Travel**, **Save on Rest**, and **Save on Wait** individually.

3. **Gameplay** tab:

- **Difficulty** → Leave at **Adept** (modded difficulty frameworks override this).
- **Disable Kill Cam** → Leave **Unticked** (third-person kill moves are part of the gamepad experience).
- **Remove Borders** → Tick (removes invisible world-edge walls for exploration).
- **Tutorials** → Untick (suppresses vanilla tutorial pop-ups).

4. **Interface** tab:

- Tick **Dialogue Subtitles** and **General Subtitles** (accessibility; audio mods add ambient dialogue that benefits from subtitle support).
- **Compass** → Leave **Ticked** (Compass Navigation Overhaul manages compass behaviour; BethINI should not disable it).
- **Crosshair** → Leave **Ticked** (needed for gamepad aiming feedback; TrueHUD can refine the visual).
- **Floating Quest Markers** → Untick (reduces HUD clutter; quest tracking is available via compass and journal).
- **Controller Vibration** → Leave **Ticked** (gamepad immersion).

5. **Environment** tab:

- **Grass Density** → **60**.
- Untick **Reflect Sky**.

6. **View Distance** tab:

- Leave **Tree LOD Distance** at the High preset default for now. Set to **0** via INI editor before DynDOLOD generation later (see xLODGen/DynDOLOD sections).

7. **Visuals** tab:

- **Max Particle Render Count (GPU)** → **7500**.
- Untick **Lens Flare** (Community Shaders handles its own post-processing).

8. Click **Save and Exit**, then open **MO2** → **Tools** → **INI Editor** and confirm the values took effect in *Skyrim.ini* and *SkyrimPrefs.ini*.

Save Safety Considerations → Performance

Performance work can destabilize saves when it involves worldspace edits, generated outputs, or scripted systems that are added and removed carelessly. Save safety here means protecting the testing process as much as protecting a future long playthrough.

Baseline

- **Disposable-test route** — Keep clean labeled saves for pre-LOD, post-LOD, city-performance, forest-travel, and long-session stability testing.
- Start a new game when adding major worldspace optimization layers such as **eFPS** if that branch is adopted (the mod page recommends fresh-start caution). → **Performance**
- Do not treat old generated outputs, removed scripted mods, or stale occlusion data as safe enough just because the game still loads.
- Preserve one or two mature long-session saves only for validation, not for endless experimental churn.

Alternatives

- **One-save route** — Keep testing everything on the same long-running save.
- **Overcautious route** — Restart for every small change even when it adds no safety value.

Notes

- Save corruption or instability can present as performance degradation long before it looks like a hard failure.
- Reusing one heavily mutated test save makes conclusions about optimization quality far less trustworthy.
- Generated-output mismatches can poison a save comparison without being obvious at first glance.

FILE: modlist-performance-tools.md

Tool Pipeline

MO2 Separator: Performance

Part of the [Performance and Technical Workflow](#) section. See also: [14a](#) (Performance Strategy), [14b](#) (Optimization & Configuration), [14d](#) (Bashed Patch & Synthesis), [14e](#) (Testing & Maintenance).

Tool Workflow → Performance

A heavy Skyrim list usually becomes unstable through stale output and sloppy rebuild habits before it fails through any one mod choice. This subsection defines the rebuild discipline that keeps the rest of the plan usable.

Baseline

- **Disciplined route** — Run [xEdit](#) conflict review after each major category change instead of saving all conflict discovery for the end. → [Performance](#)
- Re-run [Pandora](#) when behavior, animation, or skeleton-relevant content changes. → [Performance](#)
- Re-run [Synthesis](#) whenever a chosen patcher-based system changes, including the music-merge workflow already noted in section [Audio](#). → [Performance](#)
- Treat [TexGen](#), [xLODGen](#), [DynDOLOD](#), grass cache, and occlusion output as late-stage generated layers that must be rebuilt when their inputs materially change. → [Performance](#)
- Keep every generated output in its own dedicated [Mod Organizer 2](#) mod so stale files are easy to replace instead of silently lingering. → [Performance](#)

Alternatives

- **Ad hoc route** — Rebuild tools whenever something looks broken.
- **Late-everything route** — Postpone most generated work until the end and hope the backlog stays manageable.

Notes

- The most common technical mistake in a large list is not "wrong mod" but stale output from a previously correct state.
- Partial rebuild habits create false negatives during testing because the game is no longer showing the current stack.
- Delaying all generated work until the very end makes it harder to isolate which category caused later breakage.
- A [4K](#) near-field texture stack can tempt the list into overbuilding LOD output. Tune for believable travel scenes, not screenshot-maximal atlases that waste VRAM and rebuild time. → [Performance](#)
- [DynDOLOD](#), [TexGen](#), and [xLODGen](#) settings are sensitive to memory pressure and stale outputs. If one run required lowered atlas size or reduced concurrency, the same constraint should be assumed on the next rebuild unless hardware changes. → [Performance](#)

4K LOD Tool Baseline

- Keep the actual tools ([xLODGen](#), [TexGen](#), [DynDOLOD](#)) outside the game folder and outside [Mod Organizer 2](#) mod folders. → [Performance](#)
- Keep the output folders outside [Program Files](#), Steam, Documents, Desktop, and the MO2 instance. → [Performance](#)
- Install the finished output back into MO2 as separate mods named [Terrain LOD Output](#), [TexGen Output](#), and [DynDOLOD Output](#). → [Performance](#)
- Generate in this order: [xLODGen](#) terrain LOD first, then [TexGen](#), then [DynDOLOD](#). → [Performance](#)
- Use the [x64](#) versions of the tools. → [Performance](#)

xLODGen 4K STEP Baseline

- Configure the MO2 executable as [xLODGenx64.exe -lodgen -SSE -o:"DriveLetter:\Modding\Tools\xLODGen\xLODGen_Output"](#). → [Performance](#)
- Use [xLODGen](#) only for terrain LOD in this workflow.
- Use [SSE-Terrain-Tamriel-Extend.esm](#) as the terrain-boundary resource for LOD generation. It restores terrain data for cells further north into the Sea of Ghosts, providing complete LOD coverage for mods that add content in the northern ocean (notably [Depths of Skyrim](#) from [modlist-world-content.md](#)). Only one terrain-boundary ESM should be active at a time; the base [SSE-Terrain-Tamriel.esm](#) (no northern extension) is the fallback if no mod uses Sea of Ghosts cells. Load the chosen ESM as early as possible in the load order (lowest priority) so other plugins overwriting or adding land records take precedence. Only required during LOD generation — no harm leaving it active in-game, but it has no gameplay effect outside the far cells. → [Performance](#)
- Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/???> — [SSE-Terrain-Tamriel-Extend.esm](#) is distributed via the [xLODGen](#) forum post on STEP; the Mega mirror is: https://mega.nz/file/FAwmiAzS#pNDTBIaytL8e9uLhZXD-GmfB4TYD_3v3QJdX-lc72c (base) and https://mega.nz/file/hUpwDKwQ#gleApgKP1Jwka7Jm9M4oVQSk-bM0RWcOu8dFSc3m2_A (Extend). → [Performance](#)
- Select all worldspaces.
- Ensure only [Terrain LOD](#) is ticked in the right pane. → [Performance](#)
- Leave [Brightness](#), [Contrast](#), and [Gamma](#) at defaults unless the list is intentionally following the STEP / [Cathedral Landscapes](#) terrain pipeline; outside that narrow case, use [Gamma 1.00](#). → [Performance](#)
- STEP 2.3 also states that users at [2160p](#) / [4K](#) should double the diff and normal sizes shown in the standard presets for [LOD4](#), [LOD8](#), [LOD16](#), and [LOD32](#). → [Performance](#)
- For initial [LOD4](#) terrain generation, keep [Optimize Unseen](#) off; if map / [LOD32](#) coastline quality needs a later pass, use a higher [Quality](#) setting in the documented [0-10](#) range and raise [Optimize Unseen](#) to roughly [550](#) for that pass. → [Performance](#)

- After generation, run **ACMOS Road Generator** with **Roads = Path Only**, point **Path** to **LOD** at the **xLODGen_Output** folder, choose **Yes** when prompted to overwrite LOD textures, and choose **No** when asked to zip. → **Performance**
- Move the generated files into the dedicated MO2 output mod and disable temporary xLODGen-only terrain resources afterward.

TexGen 4K STEP Baseline

- Configure the MO2 executable as **TexGen64.exe -SSE**. → **Performance**
- Run **TexGen** after **xLODGen** and before **DynDOLOD**. → **Performance**
- Use the preset matching rendered game resolution: **2160p = 4K**. → **Performance**
- If grass LOD is not being generated, do not tick the grass billboard options.
- Tick **Grass** if the **21-Post-Processing** group is not installed and the list is not using complex grass. → **Performance**
- Tick **HD grass** if the **21-Post-Processing** group is installed and the list is using complex grass / Community Shaders grass features. → **Performance**
- In **TexGen_SSE.ini**, set **GrassModelHeightMultiplier=1.15**. → **Performance**
- In **TexGen_SSE.ini**, set **TreeMSAlphaThreshold=144**. → **Performance**
- In **TexGen_SSE.ini**, set **ObjectMSAlphaThreshold=96**.
- If the list does not use complex grass textures, set **ForceComplexGrass=0**. → **Performance**
- If the list is following the STEP 2.3 complex-grass branch, set **ForceComplexGrass=1**. → **Performance**
- Treat newer **Community Shaders** grass-lighting recommendations as a separate branch to validate deliberately rather than mixing them into this baseline. → **Performance**
- Move the generated files into the dedicated MO2 **TexGen Output** mod and enable that output mod before running **DynDOLOD**. → **Performance**

DynDOLOD 4K STEP Baseline

- Configure the MO2 executable as **DynDOLODx64.exe -SSE**. → **Performance**
- In **DynDOLOD_SSE.ini**, set **Expert=1** so the GUI opens in expert mode. → **Performance**
- In **DynDOLOD_SSE.ini**, set **Level32=1 AllHDL0D32=1**. → **Performance**
- In **DynDOLOD_SSE.ini**, set **GrassBrightnessTopR=0.500, GrassBrightnessTopG=0.500, GrassBrightnessTopB=0.500, GrassBrightnessBottomR=0.500, GrassBrightnessBottomG=0.500, and GrassBrightnessBottomB=0.500**.
- In **DynDOLOD_SSE.ini**, set **DoubleSidedTextureMask=mountain,mtn**.
- In **DynDOLOD_SSE.ini**, set **DoubleSidedMeshMask=mountain,mtn**.
- If the list is following the STEP 2.3 complex-grass branch, also set **ComplexGrassBillboard=5**. → **Performance**
- If the list is following the STEP 2.3 complex-grass branch, also set **ComplexGrassBrightnessTopR=0.500, ComplexGrassBrightnessTopG=0.500, ComplexGrassBrightnessTopB=0.500, ComplexGrassBrightnessBottomR=0.500, ComplexGrassBrightnessBottomG=0.500, ComplexGrassBrightnessBottomB=0.500, and ComplexGrassBacklightMask=25**. → **Performance**
- Do not reuse older complex-grass values like **0.700 / 0.725 / 0.750** brightness or **BacklightMask=10** in this baseline; those are not the current STEP 2.3 values. → **Performance**
- Select all worldspaces in the GUI.
- Tick **Candles**. → **Performance**
- Tick **FXGlow**. → **Performance**
- Click **High** to pull in the expected STEP / **A Clear Map of Skyrim** mesh rules, then treat the intended end state as the **4K** profile with **Optimal** tree and catch-all rules plus the recommended **LOD32** rules. → **Performance**
- Use **Medium** or **Low** only as a deliberate performance concession. → **Performance**
- Generate **Occlusion** only on the first run; leave it unticked on later reruns to save time. → **Performance**
- Tick **Grass LOD** only if the list is intentionally generating grass LOD. → **Performance**
- STEP 2.3 describes the target as the **4K** preset with **Optimal** tree and catch-all rules plus the recommended **LOD32** rules for **A Clear Map of Skyrim**, so the preset button is a setup step rather than the whole decision. → **Performance**
- Move the generated files into the dedicated MO2 **DynDOLOD Output** mod, ensure **DynDOLOD.esm** and **DynDOLOD.esp** are enabled, then sort with **LOOT**. → **Performance**

4K Validation And Failure Rules

- Benchmark before and after LOD generation from a clean Whiterun save, with **A Clear Map of Skyrim** and **Other Worlds** temporarily disabled during benchmarking as STEP recommends. → **Performance**
- STEP's benchmark spot is outside Whiterun looking west; also sanity-check the Rift (**cow tamriel 40 -24**) because aspens are one of the heavier scenes. → **Performance**
- If performance is already below STEP's pre-LOD target band, lower the broader graphics baseline before blaming LOD output alone.
- If travel performance is still too expensive after LOD generation, step **DynDOLOD** down from **High** to **Medium** or **Low**, and skip **Grass LOD** before cutting the entire visual stack apart. → **Performance**
- If a tool run required one-off emergency tweaks, document them next to the MO2 executable or output mod so the next rebuild is reproducible instead of remembered from scratch.

Optional Diagnostics And Performance Tools → **Performance**

The tools below are not required for the list to function, but they solve real problems during load-order building and heavy play. Install them early for diagnostics value and keep them active for runtime protection; neither has ongoing configuration or conflict maintenance once installed.

Recursion Monitor

- **Nexus: Recursion Monitor** (v1.2, original by Nightfallstorm)

- **Purpose:** Detects broken Papyrus scripts stuck in recursive loops and prevents the resulting framerate collapse. Hooks the stack check and breaks the recursion after 1000 calls, writing a `StackFrameOverflow` warning to the log instead of tanking performance. → [Performance](#)
- **Requirements:** SKSE, Address Library for SKSE Plugins
- **Status:** Optional diagnostics utility. Silent at runtime unless it fires. Worth installing early for debugging and keeping active on a production list.
- **Updated fork:** [recursion-fix-updated](#) (v1.0, updated May 2026) removes the in-game debug popup that could freeze gameplay during a recursion event. All warnings written to the SKSE log instead. Prefer for a production list.

Save And Load Accelerator For SKSE Cosaves (S.L.A.C.K.)

- **Nexus:** [S.L.A.C.K.](#) (by just-harry)
- **Purpose:** Rewrites SKSE's cosave serialisation path so cosaves save up to 150× faster and load up to 15× faster. Parallelises and buffers the write path so save/load hitching drops regardless of how many cosave-aware plugins are installed. Includes error-friendly mode that catches and logs exceptions thrown by other SKSE plugins' cosave handlers.
- **Requirements:** SKSE for Skyrim AE 1.6.1170, Address Library for SKSE Plugins, SSE Engine Fixes (SKSE64 Preloader file — the DLL Plugin Loader variant may be used instead)
- **Status:** Optional performance utility. Safe to install or uninstall at any time — saves made with it active can be loaded without it. Recommended once the modlist is heavy enough that save pauses become noticeable.
- **Note:** Complements [Seamless Saving - Skyrim Save Accelerator](#), which targets the main save serialisation (Script VM bottleneck) rather than SKSE cosaves. Running both is safe and addresses different bottlenecks.

Notes

- Neither mod touches worldspace records, leveled lists, or any asset that would require a rebuild of generated output.
- Recursion Monitor is read-only in normal operation and only activates when a runaway script is detected. Its updated fork removes the blocking popup, which is the only known compatibility concern.
- S.L.A.C.K. hooks SKSE's internal save/load API. In rare cases where another SKSE plugin's cosave handler throws an uncaught exception, S.L.A.C.K.'s error-friendly mode (enabled by default) catches and logs it instead of crashing. If crash-on-cosave behaviour is preferred for debugging, this mode can be disabled in the config.
- Both mods are safe to remove from an existing save.

FILE: modlist-performance-patches.md

Bashed Patch & Synthesis Configuration

MO2 Separator: [Performance](#)

Part of the [Performance](#) and [Technical Workflow](#) section. See also: [14a](#) (Performance Strategy), [14b](#) (Optimization & Configuration), [14c](#) (Tool Pipeline), [14e](#) (Testing & Maintenance).

Core Idea

- The generic category maps only become useful when they are tied to the actual mods [Elder Wilds](#) ships with. This subsection is that binding: the exact [Wrye Bash](#) tweaks enabled, the [Bash Tags](#) set on the plugins that need them, and the [Synthesis](#) patcher pipeline run in this exact order. → [Performance](#)
- Anything not in the tables below is intentionally left to per-mod [xEdit](#) patches or to the generation stage. The default is "do not touch" — adding a [Synthesis](#) patcher or a [Bash Tag](#) only when a specific mod in the list makes it necessary. → [Performance](#)

Wrye Bash (Bashed Patch) Configuration

Tweak Settings

Enable in [Wrye Bash](#) → [Bashed Patch](#) → [Tweakers](#) only the items below. Everything else stays at the default and is patched by hand if needed.

- **Tweak Actors:** [Opposite Gender Anims: Female](#) and [Opposite Gender Anims: Male](#) — needed because [Elder Wilds](#) runs [CBBE 3BA](#), [HIMBO](#), and [KS Hairdos](#) which already change the per-gender behavior set, and the global flip keeps NPCs consistent across [EVG Conditional Idles](#), [Goetia](#), and [Leviathan II](#) packs. → [Performance](#)
- **Tweak Assorted:**
 - [All Armor Playable](#) — required by [Immersive Armors](#) (60+ sets, several ship with the non-playable flag in the base plugin).
 - [No Light Fade Value Fix](#) — required because [CS Light](#), [True Light](#), [ELFX](#), [Relighting Skyrim](#), and [Luminosity](#) all interact with fade values and the bare-1.0 value is the stable starting point.
 - [No Light Flicker](#) — required because [RAID Weathers](#), [Cathedral Weathers](#), [Obsidian Weathers](#), and [Azurite III CS](#) weather variants ship flickering templates that look bad in third-person exploration.
 - [Remove Load Screen Models](#) — required because [SkyParkour v3](#), [RaySense](#), and [Ricochet](#) add 3D geometry that can leak into load screens.
 - [Save Sorting Fix](#) — required: the SSE save-sorting bug is a real issue with this much plugin weight.
 - [Set Light Radii](#) — use a 100% multiplier to leave lighting mod radii alone; do not raise above 100 without re-doing lighting scenes.
 - [Set Sound Attenuation Levels: Nirnroots Only](#) — leave default. [Sounds of Skyrim Complete](#) and [AOS](#) need their own attenuation and a global multiplier fights them.

- **Uniform Groundcover** — enable, because **Skoglendi**, **Origins of Forest**, and **Mari's flora** are the grass stack and matching density variance is what makes the world feel coherent.
- **Tweak Names:**
 - **Body Part Codes** — required to drive **Sort: Armor/Clothes** correctly given **CBBE 3BA** body parts.
 - **Sort: Armor/Clothes** — required; with **Immersive Armors**, **Beyond Skyrim - Bruma**, and **Spaghetti's Cities** adding armors, unsorted inventory is unreadable.
 - **Sort: Scrolls**, **Sort: Spells**, **Sort: Weapons/Ammunition** — required, because **Apocalypse**, **Mysticism**, **Odin**, **Adamant**, **Vokrii**, **Ordinator**, and **Ars Metallica** all add to scroll/spell/weapon lists.
 - **Lore Friendly Text: Dwarven -> Dwemer** — enable: the **PBR textures for The Great Cities Collection** and **PBaRkarth** use Dwemer terminology and the rename is the only thing that keeps the UI consistent.
- **Tweak Races:**
 - **Races Have All Head Parts** — required because **KS Hairdos SSE** adds hundreds of head parts and races need to know about them; set the types code to a reasonable preset like **45** (eyes/hair/beards).
 - **Playable Head Parts** — enable: ensures all of **KS Hairdos's** hairs are selectable in racemenu.
 - **Leave Force Behavior Graph Gender: Female** and **Force Behavior Graph Gender: Male** off — **Elder Wilds** does not standardize that flag, and forcing it breaks per-NPC behavior from **Pandora** conditions.
- **Tweak Settings:**
 - **AI: Bump Reaction Delay** — raise to **Adult Content** to mute spammy **Nether's Follower Framework / EFF** reactions.
 - **AI: Conversation Chance** — leave default; **Immersive Patrols**, **Extended Encounters**, and **Radiance Encounters** already increase ambient chatter.
 - **AI: Max Active Actors** — raise to **80** because **Extended Encounters**, **Immersive Patrols**, and **Bruma** patrols overlap.
 - **AI: Max Dead Actors** — raise to **120** to handle combat aftermath in dungeons.
 - **Arrow: Max Arrows Attached to NPC** — raise to **20** so **Ricochet** and **SkyParkour v3** multi-arrow scenes stay readable.
 - **Combat: Max Actors** — raise to **60** to match the new **AI: Max Active Actors** ceiling.
 - **Combat: Stealth Damage Bonus** — leave default; **RAID** is the canonical authority for stealth scaling and overriding here creates conflicts.
 - **Msg: Cannot Equip Item Fix** — **must** be enabled: **Campfire**, **Frostfall**, and **SunHelm/Starfrost/Last Seed** all rely on it.
 - **Msg: No Fast Travel** — leave default; **Campfire** and **Frostfall** already gate fast travel through their own logic.
 - **Player: Max Draggable Weight** — set to **1000** to keep physics objects interactable given that the list has heavy clutter via **Spaghetti's Cities** and **RUSTIC CLUTTER COLLECTION**.
 - **Player: Underwater Breath Control** — leave default; **Realistic Water Two** and **A Water Made For CS in mind** already tune this in their own records.
 - **Soul Trap: Common/Grand/Greater/Lesser Soul Level** — set to vanilla values; **Mysticism**, **Odin**, and **Apocalypse** redefine the soul economy and changing these overrides their work.
 - **Visuals: Masser Size**, **Visuals: Masser Speed**, **Visuals: Secunda Size**, **Visuals: Secunda Speed** — set to **1.0** and **1.0** so **AURORA S.E.** and **Skylighting** keep their sky behavior.
 - **Warning: Exterior Distance to Hostiles** and **Warning: Interior Distance To Hostiles** — leave default; **Book of Shadows** and **RAID** already adjust detection.
 - **World: Cell Respawn Time** and **World: Cell Respawn Time (Cleared)** — leave default; **Open World Loot** and **MorrowLoot Ultimate** rewrite the loot pipeline.
 - **World: Timescale** — set to **20** and never change. **Save-baking warning**: this setting bakes into SSE saves, so any change to a long-running test save will make that save behave inconsistently with the rest of the list.

Bash Tags

Set the following **Bash Tags** (one file per plugin under **Data\Bash Patches**) on the listed plugins. Tags not listed here are deliberately absent.

- **Immersive Weapons.esp** — **Relev** (entries from this mod should be re-leveled into the winning list). → **Performance**
- **Immersive Armors.esp** — **Relev**. → **Performance**
- **Immersive Armors Retexture.esp** — **Graphics** (do not let the Bashed Patch treat texture records as records to merge; it is a retexture, not a content add). → **Performance**
- **Hunterborn.esp** — **Invent.Add**, **Delev**, **Relev** (the mod adds pelts, reagents, and harvested items to containers, removes several generic drops, and re-levels spawns). → **Performance**
- **Simple Fishing Overhaul.esp** — **Invent.Add**, **C.MiscFlags**. → **Performance**
- **Streamlined Fishing.esp** — **Invent.Add only**. → **Performance**
- **Open World Loot.esp** — **Delev**, **Relev**, **C.Encounter** (the mod's whole job is encounter zone and leveled list rewriting). → **Performance**
- **MorrowLoot Ultimate.esp** — **Delev**, **Relev**. → **Performance**
- **Trade and Barter.esp** — **Stats**, **Invent.Change** (changes item values and merchant inventories). → **Performance**
- **Aetherius.esp / Morningstar.esp / Imperious.esp** — **R.AddSpells** (one of these three is the race overhaul; whichever wins gets the tag, not all three). → **Performance**
- **Adamant.esp / Vokrii.esp / Ordinator.esp** — **NPC.Perks.Change** and **NPC.Perks.Add**. → **Performance**
- **Mysticism.esp / Odin.esp / Apocalypse.esp** — **SpellStats**, **EffectStats**. → **Performance**
- **CS Light.esp / True Light.esp** — **C.Light**, **C.ImageSpace** (light and atmosphere overrides are what these mods do). → **Performance**
- **ELFX.esp** and **ELFX - Shadows.esp** — **C.Light**, **C.Fog** (no fog conflict, but light is the same set of records). → **Performance**
- **Relighting Skyrim.esp** and **Luminosity.esp** — **C.Light only**. → **Performance**
- **RAID Weathers.esp** and **Raid Weathers CS.esp** — **C.Climate**, **C.Music** only if the weather pack changes music. → **Performance**
- **Cathedral Weathers.esp** and **Obsidian Weathers.esp** and **Obsidian - CS.esp** — **C.Climate**. → **Performance**
- **Realistic Water Two.esp** — **C.Water**. → **Performance**
- **A Water Made For CS in mind.esp** — **C.Water**. → **Performance**

- [Simplicity of Sea.esp](#) — [C.Water](#). → [Performance](#)
- [Enhanced Rocks and Mountains.esp](#) and [Enhanced Rocks and Mountains - Fix and Addon.esp](#) — [Graphics](#), [ObjectBounds](#) (mesh changes; no content records). → [Performance](#)
- [Beyond Skyrim - Bruma SE.esp](#) — [C.Climate](#), [C.Music](#), [C.Light](#), [C.Water](#), [C.ImageSpace](#), [C.Location](#), [C.Regions](#) (Bruma touches almost every cell record type, this is the safe merge set). → [Performance](#)
- [Spaghetti's Cities - AIO.esp](#) — [C.Light](#), [C.MiscFlags](#) (light changes plus cell flag edits). → [Performance](#)
- [The Great Cities - Minor Cities and Towns SSE.esp](#), [Dawn of Skyrim \(Director's Cut\) SE.esp](#), [JK's Skyrim.esp](#) — [C.Light](#), [C.MiscFlags](#). → [Performance](#)
- [RUSTIC CLUTTER COLLECTION.esp](#) and [RUSTIC CLOTHING.esp](#) — [Names](#), [Stats](#) (only merge the names/stats, not the meshes). → [Performance](#)
- [High Poly Project.esp](#) — [Graphics](#), [ObjectBounds](#) (mesh upgrade, not content). → [Performance](#)
- [KS Hairdos SSE.esp](#) — [Graphics](#), [Names](#) (hair mesh and record rename; do not merge headpart bodies). → [Performance](#)
- [High Poly True to Vanilla NPC Overhaul.esp](#) — [Graphics](#), [Names](#), [Actors.Stats](#) (it modifies NPC textures and stat snippets). → [Performance](#)
- [RDO.esp](#) — [Actors.AIPackages](#), [Actors.Spells](#). → [Performance](#)
- [Amorous Adventures.esp](#) (clean variant) — [Actors.AIPackagesForceAdd](#), [Actors.SpellsForceAdd](#), [Invent.Add](#). → [Performance](#)
- [Marriage Mod - To Have And To Hold.esp](#) — [Actors.AIPackagesForceAdd](#), [Actors.Factions](#). → [Performance](#)
- [Serana Dialogue Add-On.esp](#) — [Actors.AIPackages](#), [Actors.Spells](#). → [Performance](#)
- [Pilgrim.esp](#) / [Trua.esp](#) / [Wintersun.esp](#) — [Actors.Spells](#) (one of the three wins; tag the chosen one only). → [Performance](#)
- [Book of Shadows.esp](#) — [Actors.Spells](#). → [Performance](#)
- [Skyrim Reputation.esp](#) — [Actors.Factions](#), [Relations.Add](#). → [Performance](#)
- [Suspicious City Guards.esp](#) — [Actors.AIPackages](#). → [Performance](#)
- [Audio Overhaul for Skyrim SE.esp](#) — [Sound](#). → [Performance](#)
- [Immersive Sounds - Compendium.esp](#) — [Sound](#). → [Performance](#)
- [Sounds of Skyrim Complete SE.esp](#) — [Sound](#), [C.Acoustic](#). → [Performance](#)
- [Campfire.esp](#) — [C.MiscFlags](#), [Invent.Add](#) (it adds firewood and food to cell inventories). → [Performance](#)
- [Ars Metallica.esp](#) — [Stats](#), [Invent.Change](#). → [Performance](#)
- [Complete Crafting Overhaul Remastered.esp](#) — [Stats](#), [Invent.Change](#). → [Performance](#)
- [Honed Metal.esp](#) — [Invent.Change](#) (it modifies merchant inventories for crafting services). → [Performance](#)
- [Apothecary.esp](#) — [Invent.Add](#), [Stats](#), [Keywords](#). → [Performance](#)
- [Complete Alchemy and Cooking Overhaul.esp](#) — [Invent.Add](#), [Stats](#), [Keywords](#). → [Performance](#)
- [Alchemy Potions and Food Adjustments.esp](#) — [Stats](#), [Keywords](#). → [Performance](#)
- [Frostfall.esp](#) — [C.Climate](#), [C.ImageSpace](#) (it edits worldspace exposure for cold regions). → [Performance](#)
- [Starfrost.esp](#) / [SunHelm.esp](#) / [Last Seed.esp](#) — [Stats](#), [Keywords](#), [Invent.Add](#) (one of the three wins). → [Performance](#)
- [AOS - Couriers and Imperial Census.esp](#) and other AOS add-ons — [Sound](#). → [Performance](#)
- [Nether's Follower Framework.esp](#) / [EFF.esp](#) / [Amazing Follower Tweaks SE.esp](#) — [Actors.Factions](#), [Invent.Add](#) (they add items to follower inventories). → [Performance](#)
- [TrueHUD.esp](#) — no tags (do not merge HUD records, leave them as overrides). → [Performance](#)
- [Sovngarde - Mist's Font Replacer.esp](#) — no tags (font plugin, do not merge). → [Performance](#)

Plugins that should be tagged [Deactivate](#) because they only exist to feed the Bashed Patch (none expected in [Elder Wilds](#); if a mod is later added purely for its [Bash Tags](#) source, tag it [Deactivate](#)).

Plugins that should be tagged [NoMerge](#) if a future install ever needs to override the merge (none expected; tag on a per-mod basis if a record from a specific plugin should never enter the Bashed Patch).

Synthesis Configuration

The [Synthesis](#) patcher pipeline runs as a single batch via the [Run Mutagen](#) tool registered in [Mod Organizer 2](#), with output written to the [Patches\Synthesis Patch.esp](#) separator. Patchers below are listed in the order they must run; do not reorder.

Stage 1 — NPC, AI, And Facegen

- [KS Hairs Bald Helmets Fixer](#) — because [Elder Wilds](#) ships [KS Hairdos SSE](#) and the bald-head-under-helmet bug is universal. → [Performance](#)
- [High Poly Head Vampire Fix](#) — keep this in the patcher shortlist whenever the [High Poly Head 1.4](#) branch is active, because vampire headpart edge cases are still one of the known maintenance costs of that route. → [Performance](#)
- [HP_NPC_WIGS_TO_HEADPART](#) — converts any wig distribution to headparts so [Elder Wilds](#) headpart inventory stays consistent. → [Performance](#)
- [FacegenBaseline](#) — applies the canonical facegen override from [High Poly True to Vanilla NPC Overhaul](#) to every named NPC, so facegen does not silently break when the NPC overhaul is updated. Run this after all NPC overhauls are installed and the load order is finalised for the NPC section to prevent the dark-face bug. If [Synthesis's FacegenBaseline](#) patcher does not resolve all dark-face cases, use [zEdit's FaceGen](#) patcher as a fallback. → [Performance](#)
- [NPCStatRescaler](#) — rescales NPC stats to keep [Elder Wilds](#) combat pacing after [MCO ADXP](#) and [Valhalla Combat](#) install. → [Performance](#)
- [AIOverhaulPatcher](#) (or [ICAI0 AI for Mods](#) if [ICAI0](#) is in the stack) — forwards the AI package list from the chosen AI overhaul so it wins over the default package set. → [Performance](#)
- [AI Stealth Overhaul](#) — used in combination with [Realistic AI Detection \(RAID\)](#). The patcher customizes the difficulty curve and [RAID](#) provides the underlying detection. → [Performance](#)
- [Followers-are-Sneaky](#) — adds the "Doesn't Affect Stealth" flag to all followers from [Nether's Follower Framework](#), [EFF](#), and [Amazing Follower Tweaks SE](#). → [Performance](#)
- [FollowerFavorCarryLimitPatcher](#) — applies follower carry limits from [Nether's Follower Framework](#) to mod-added followers. → [Performance](#)
- [NpcProtector](#) — flags essential NPCs from quest mods ([Wyrmsooth](#), [Falskaar](#), [The Forgotten City](#), [VIGILANT](#), [Sirenroot](#), [Moon and Star](#), [Beyond Reach](#), [Bruma](#), [The Wheels of Lull](#)) as protected. → [Performance](#)

- **RaceCompatibilityDialogue** — adds dialog conditions so the chosen race overhaul (**Aetherius** / **Morningstar** / **Imperious**) plays correctly with all custom races. → **Performance**
- **RacialHeights** and **HarmonizedRaceHeights-Patcher** — applies the chosen height scaling across all races including **Bruma** and **Beyond Reach** races. → **Performance**
- **SynBanditWarForwarder** — forwards **Lawless** bandit-war changes (keep enabled; lightweight and prevents NPC record regressions). → **Performance**
- **SynOppositeGenderAnimsTweak** — already handled by the Bashed Patch; do not enable here to avoid double-application. → **Performance**

Stage 2 — Encounter Zones And Encounter Logic

- **EZLeveler** — scales encounter zones; configure to the unleveled-band target that **Open World Loot** and **MorrowLoot Ultimate** assume. → **Performance**
- **EnemyReleveler** — delevels NPCs by type; configure to keep **Bruma**, **Falskaar**, and **Wyrms Tooth** enemies within the new band. → **Performance**
- **No More Easy Enemies** — fixes low-level enemy spawns in high-level dungeons; required because of the **Extended Encounters** and **Radiance Encounters** ambient spawn load. → **Performance**
- **EncounterZoneNames** and **CellEncounterLevelsInName** — appends encounter zone level to the cell name; helps debug which zone the player is in. → **Performance**
- **MissingEncounterZonesPatcher** — forwards changes from **Missing Encounter Zones Fixed** (if added) so they do not get overwritten by **Bruma/JK's Skyrim/Spaghetti's Cities**. → **Performance**
- **TrueUnleveledSkyrim** — only enable if **Elder Wilds** ever drops **Open World Loot** and **MorrowLoot Ultimate**; the patcher is comprehensive but it overlaps badly with **OWL** so do not run both. → **Performance**

Stage 3 — Leveled Lists And Loot

- **OWLLeveledListAddition** — adds **Immersive Weapons** and **Immersive Armors** to the **Open World Loot** leveled lists by keyword. → **Performance**
- **OWLPatcher** — keeps **OWL** leveled lists consistent across the rest of the stack. → **Performance**
- **Skyrim-LeveledLoot** — adjusts the loot system with progression focus; configure to match the chosen difficulty in **modlist-survival-combat.md**. → **Performance**
- **HalgarrisConsistentRPGLOot** — distributes enchantments from **Mysticism/Odin/Apocalypse** to all mod-added weapons/armors. → **Performance**
- **Container and Loot Patcher** — base loot table tuning; configure to match the **MorrowLoot Ultimate** values. → **Performance**
- **LootableCrates**, **MakeFirewoodPilesIntoContainers**, **Lootable Things & Training Dummies Patcher** — these three enable the immersive-clutter loot chain that **RUSTIC CLUTTER COLLECTION** benefits from. → **Performance**
- **GeneralStoresIngredientsPatcher** — pushes the alchemy ingredient stock from **Apothecary** into general stores. → **Performance**
- **ImmersiveMusicPatcher** and **MusicTypePatcher-Revised-2024** — merge additions to **MUSTT** records so **AOS** ambient music does not double up. Required: **AOS** and **Sounds of Skyrim Complete** both add music to the same cells. → **Performance**
- **LeveledListresolver** — clean up remaining leveled list conflicts that did not get a **Bash Tag** for resolution. Run after **OWL** and **MorrowLoot** so the resolver sees the merged view. → **Performance**
- **Feminized Leveled Lists** and **Masculinized Leveled Lists** — keep enabled with default settings to fix gendered leveled list entries from mod-added NPCs. → **Performance**

Stage 4 — Items, Crafting, Smithing, Alchemy, Cooking

- **ApothecaryAutoPatcher** — required: the mod adds ingredients that need to inherit **Apothecary's** values. Pair with **Complete Alchemy and Cooking Overhaul Patcher** if **CACO** is in the stack. → **Performance**
- **BreakdownRecipeGenerator** — generates breakdown recipes for every craftable from **Immersive Weapons** and **Immersive Armors**, so **Ars Metallica** and **Complete Crafting Overhaul Remastered** get full coverage. → **Performance**
- **CreateTemper** — generates tempering recipes for the same weapon pool. → **Performance**
- **HonedMetalAdditionalIngredients** — adds additional ingredients to **Honed Metal** from **Apothecary/CACO**. → **Performance**
- **Heim Recipe Patcher** — updates weapon/armor recipes with the correct **Heim** book conditions (only enable if **Heim** is added). → **Performance**
- **ReProccer Evolved** — keeps mod-added items compatible with **Skyrim Redone**-style systems; not currently in the stack but the patcher is cheap insurance. → **Performance**
- **Weapon Stat Synthesis Patcher** (Nexus: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspicedition/mods/149027>) — analyzes and rebalances weapon stats to keep the tier ladder meaningful across **Immersive Weapons**, **Animated Armoury**, and other mod-added weapons.

How to add: In Synthesis, click **Add / +**, search the registry for **Weapon Stat Synthesis Patcher**, select it, then click the gear icon to configure. **Run after** **OWLLeveledListAddition**, **SpeedandReachFixes**, and **AmmoTweaks** in the patcher pipeline; **run whenever** weapons are added, removed, or reordered in the load order. Wait until the full weapon stack is finalised before running.

Elder Wilds config values:

- **Damage Floor** — 4 (keeps iron/early weapons viable)
- **Damage Ceiling** — 22 (tighter than default 30 — **Adamant's** perk curve does not need the wide spread; a tighter ceiling keeps mid-tier loot relevant longer, supporting the survival/scarcity tone)
- **Weight Scale** — 1.0 (default)
- **Value Scale** — 1.0 (default; economy is handled by **Trade and Barter**, not the stat patcher)
- **Speed Normalization** — tick ON (consistency matters more with **Animated Armoury's** varied movesets)
- **Reach Normalization** — tick ON (prevents spear/halberd from having wildly different reach than intended)

- **Ignore List** — add [Reliquary of Myth.esp](#), [ArteFakes.esp](#), [Unique Items Tweaks.esp](#), [Konahrik's Accoutrements.esp](#) (preserves hand-authored artifact and unique-item stats)

Output: generates [zWeaponStatSynthesis.esp](#) (or merges into the main Synthesis output if configured as a group patcher). Ensure it loads after all weapon mods.

Tuning: Raise or lower [Damage Ceiling](#) if combat pacing feels too fast or too slow during survival-difficulty playthroughs. Add new plugins to [Ignore List](#) when hand-authored artifacts from a new quest mod should not be normalized. → [Performance](#)

- [SpeedandReachFixes](#) — applies [Speed and Reach Fixes](#) corrections to all mod-added weapons. → [Performance](#)
- [WeaponSpeedEffectsFix](#) — applies [Weapon Speed Effects Fix / Attack Speed Framework Plus](#) corrections to all mod-added weapons. → [Performance](#)
- [SynFixShieldData](#) and [SynFixWeaponAttackSpeed](#) — repair shield material/impact sets and attack-speed bugs on mod-added items. → [Performance](#)
- [SynGlovesAddFirstsPerk](#) — adds the missing fists perk to gloves by material so unarmed combat in [Valhalla Combat](#) works. → [Performance](#)
- [ItemWeightCustomizer](#) and [SynPotionWeight](#) — reweights potions and items to match the carry-weight design. → [Performance](#)
- [SlotsSlotsSlots](#) — converts weight into equipment slots (armor layering) so [CBBE 3BA](#) and [Immersive Armors](#) coexist. → [Performance](#)
- [AmmoTweaks](#) — [WACCF](#)-friendly alternative to [ABT](#) for ammunition tuning. → [Performance](#)
- [SynCGOStaves](#) — only if [Complete Graphics Overhaul](#) staves are in the stack; otherwise skip. → [Performance](#)

Stage 5 — Magic, Spells, Enchanting

- [Engarde_Synthesis](#) — applies [Engarde](#) combat fixes to all spell tomes. → [Performance](#)
- [DisenchantEverything](#) (or [SmartDisenchantEverything](#)) — drops the disenchant restriction so [Mysticism/Odin/Apocalypse](#) enchantments can be learned from any item that carries them. → [Performance](#)
- [Passive Enchanting Experience](#) — adds XP to enchantments worn in combat. → [Performance](#)
- [Spell Research Synthesizer](#) — only if [Spell Research](#) is added. → [Performance](#)
- [StaffGenerator](#), [StaffDuplicator](#) — only if [Mysticism/Odin/Apocalypse](#) is the chosen magic overhaul; otherwise skip. → [Performance](#)
- [SorcererPatcher](#) — only if [Sorcerer - A Staff and Scroll Overhaul](#) is added. → [Performance](#)
- [ReadingIsGoodLegacy](#) — enables skill XP from book reading. → [Performance](#)
- [AllBooksHavePerks](#) — random perk per book; configure per [modlist-world-content.md](#) world-content decision. → [Performance](#)
- [SpellTomePriceFixPatcher](#), [SynSpellTomeNameExtender](#), [DisplaySpellTomeLevelPatcher-local](#), [spelltome_yeeter](#) — spell-tome presentation; pick the one whose price/format matches the rest of the list. → [Performance](#)
- [SynESLify](#) — **must** be the last patcher in the chain; ESLifies the output so the Synthesis output does not eat a hard load-order slot. → [Performance](#)

Stage 6 — Snow, Weather, And Region

- [BDSPatcher](#) — **required**. [Better Dynamic Snow SE](#) and [Better Dynamic Ash SE](#) are both locked in [modlist-graphics-shaders.md](#). This patcher forwards BDS multistage snow and ash accumulation records to all mod-added objects (worldspace edits from [JK's Skyrim](#), [Spaghetti's Cities](#), [Cities of the North](#), quest mods, and dungeon packs). Without it, mod-placed objects lack snow/ash coverage. Use the [BDSPatcher](#) entry (not [Northpoint BDSPatcher](#)). Configure to run with both [BetterDynamicSnow](#) and [BetterDynamicAsh](#) keywords active. → [Performance](#)
- [SSBGPatcher](#) — [Stretched Snow Begone](#) synthesis patch; enable if the snow mesh ever stretches under doors or walls. → [Performance](#)
- [Nights Adjuster](#) and [Darker Weather Nights](#) — pick one (not both) and configure to match the night darkness target in [modlist-graphics-shaders.md](#). → [Performance](#)
- [SkyVRaan Weather Patcher](#) — only if [SkyVRaan](#) is added. → [Performance](#)
- [Unique Region Names](#) and [Unique Region Names Patcher](#) — pick one and use it to relabel exterior region names from [Skyrim](#) to the actual region ([Whiterun](#), [The Rift](#), etc.). Required because [Bruma](#), [Falskaar](#), and [Wyrnstooth](#) all need consistent region naming. → [Performance](#)
- [RealisticWaterTwoPatcher](#) — forwards [Realistic Water Two](#) records so they do not get overwritten by other worldspace mods. → [Performance](#)
- [Synthesis-BlendedShorelinesUniversal](#) — adjusts water values to blend with shores; required because [Spaghetti's Cities](#), [Bruma](#), and [JK's Skyrim](#) change shoreline geometry. → [Performance](#)
- [LandscapePatcher](#) — only enable if the existing landscape texture stack is replaced; current stack ([Skyland AI0](#) + [Skurkbro's](#) + [Skyking Fantasia](#) + [Rally's Solstheim](#) + [Enhanced Rocks and Mountains](#)) is the lock-in. → [Performance](#)
- [DestructibleSkyrimPatcher](#) — only enable if [Destructible Skyrim](#) is added; not in the current list. → [Performance](#)

Stage 7 — Trees, Flora, And Mesh Generators

- [Pine Tree Rescaler](#) — rescales [Traverse the Ulvenwald](#) and [Happy Little Trees](#) pines to consistent scale. → [Performance](#)
- [Tree Scaler](#), [Tree 3D Editor](#), [TreeWindEditor](#) — keep all three; configure each to its own subtree (a single rescaling pass hides per-tree problems). → [Performance](#)
- [FloraFixer](#) — fixes flora respawning for the chosen grass stack ([Skoglendi](#), [Origins of Forest](#), [Mari's flora](#)). → [Performance](#)
- [ImmersiveEquipmentMeshGen](#) and [AllGUDMeshGen](#) — only if the corresponding mods are added. → [Performance](#)
- [Harvest Those Mammoth Tusks](#) — only if [Harvest Those Mammoth Tusks](#) is added. → [Performance](#)
- [Meridiano/Synthesis-BlendedShorelinesUniversal](#) — already in Stage 6. → [Performance](#)

Stage 8 — Visuals And Lighting

- [ELE Patcher](#) — [Enhanced Lighting for ENB](#); the current stack uses [Community Shaders](#), so skip. → [Performance](#)

- **ENB Light Patcher** — only if an **ENB** preset is layered on top of **Community Shaders**; current list is CS-only. → **Performance**
- **NoShadowsPatch** — only if a specific mod has a known shadow regression. → **Performance**
- **Radial Blur Remover** — removes radial blur effects; enable because the current list has no **ENB** to give it character. → **Performance**
- **Remove Edge Glow** — removes the active-effect edge glow from actors; pair with the **Apocalypse/Odin**/etc. decision in **modlist-expanded-systems.md**. → **Performance**
- **RemoveInteriorFogPatcher** — removes near/far fog from interior cells; conflicts with **AOS** and **Sounds of Skyrim Complete** reverb, so disable if those mods are present. → **Performance**
- **RemoveLandscapeVertexColor** — removes vertex coloring from landscapes; enable only if the chosen landscape texture stack has been replaced. → **Performance**

Stage 9 — Audio

- **AOSISCSoundPatcher** — required: applies the changes from **AOS** and **Immersive Sounds - Compendium** to every mod in the list, so weapon/armor/object sound swaps propagate. → **Performance**
- **TUDMFootstepPatcher** — only if **True Unleveled Dark Maul** or **Ultimate Dungeon Masters** is added; skip otherwise. → **Performance**
- **Sounds of Seasons** — mutes crickets in winter; enable because the **Cathedral Weathers/Obsidian Weathers** chain already drives seasonal ambience. → **Performance**
- **SFCOPaintingRemover** — only if **Snazzy's Furniture and Clutter Overhaul** is added; skip otherwise. → **Performance**

Stage 10 — Performance And Cleanup

- **Grass FPS** — keep enabled; it patches grass records directly to the more efficient form. → **Performance**
- **Configurable Grass Remover** — enable if **Elder Wilds** adopts the dense forest-floor route later. → **Performance**
- **NavmeshCollector-Updated** — collects the winning navmesh records into one ESP; do **not** enable if **Bruma** or **Falskaar** is in the stack, because the navmeshes from those worldspace mods need to remain on their own plugins. → **Performance**
- **Generic Synthesis Patcher** — rule-based forwarding patcher; configure with rules for the specific mods in the list that the other patchers do not cover. → **Performance**

Stage 11 — Utility, Compatibility, And ESLification

- **Patchifier** — generates **Skypatcher/INI** patches for SKSE-flag-driven tweaks. → **Performance**
- **SynEDIDFixer** — fixes **SPID**-type mods that distribute objects by **EditorID**. → **Performance**
- **SynStringMerger** — merges translation strings; do not enable unless the list is going to ship a translation layer. → **Performance**
- **CellEditorIDFixer** — removes underscores from cell **EditorIDs**; required because **Bruma**, **Falskaar**, **Wyrmsooth**, and **Beyond Reach** all introduce new cell names. → **Performance**
- **SynPEXPatcher** — patches Papyrus scripts in mods based on configured files; enable per specific mod in the stack. → **Performance**
- **SynPerkCOBJPatcher** (which is the actual **SynESLify**) — keep **at the end** of the chain, ESLify the output. → **Performance**

Build Order And Rebuild Triggers

The full rebuild order in **Mod Organizer 2** is:

1. **SSEEdit** fast mode cleanup pass after every new plugin install.
2. **Bashed Patch** rebuild — triggers: any change to a plugin with a **Bash Tag**, any tweak setting change, any new plugin with one of the listed tags.
3. **Synthesis** pipeline run — triggers: any change to the patcher list, any change to a mod that feeds one of the enabled patchers, any **Bashed Patch** tag change.
4. **xLODGen** and **TexGen** — triggers: any landscape, terrain, or object mesh change; do not run after just an **ESL** flag change.
5. **DynDOLOD** — triggers: any worldspace, tree, object, or **Bashed Patch/Synthesis** change. Run twice in a clean session: once with **Medium** settings to verify outputs, once with the final preset.
6. **Pandora** — triggers: any behavior, animation, or skeleton change.
7. **BodySlide** — triggers: any body, skin, or armor mesh change; especially after **Immersive Armors** and **Spaghetti's Cities** updates.
8. **Grass Cache** rebuild — triggers: any grass mod or **Worldspaces with Grass SSEEdit Script** change.
9. **SSE Display Tweaks** and **BethINI Pie** settings review — triggers: any lighting, weather, or graphics stack change.

Rebuilding one stage does not replace the stages after it. A **Bashed Patch** rebuild after adding a single weapon must still be followed by a **Synthesis** run if the new weapon needs the **Weapon Stat Synthesis Patcher** or **WeaponSpeedEffectsFix** pass, and a **DynDOLOD** run if the weapon has worldspace placement.

Notes

- **Bashed Patch** and **Synthesis** both write into the same load-order range. Place the **Bashed Patch** above the **Synthesis** patch only if a known conflict needs the **Bashed Patch** to win; otherwise the **Synthesis** patch should be the last patch in the load order to let its overrides stand. → **Performance**
- **SynESLify** (Stage 5 / Stage 11) **must** be last. If it is not, the patchers after it will re-materialize a hard slot and the merge order breaks. → **Performance**
- The **Tweak Settings** list in the **Bashed Patch** is sensitive to load order: if a mod that already provides a setting (for example **RAID** setting **AI: Conversation Chance** to zero) is loaded **above** the **Bashed Patch**, the **Bashed Patch** tweak will silently lose. Check the load order with **LOOT** and re-run **xEdit** to verify which record is winning for each tweaked setting. → **Performance**
- **Tweak Settings: World: Timescale = 20** bakes into saves. Do not change this setting on a long-running test save. → **Performance**
- **Skyrim-LeveledLoot** and **OWL** overlap on leveled list contents. Run **OWLLeveledListAddition** first (Stage 3) so **Skyrim-LeveledLoot** reads the merged view; running in the wrong order produces a list that does not include **Immersive Weapons/Immersive Armors** entries. → **Performance**
- **AOSISCSoundPatcher** requires that **AOS** and **ISC** are both active when the patcher runs. If only one is active, the patcher will write half the rules and the other mod's effects will not propagate. → **Performance**

- `HP_NPC_WIGS_TO_HEADPART` and `KS Hairs Bald Helmets Fixer` both touch headpart records. Run `HP_NPC_WIGS_TO_HEADPART` first; otherwise the bald-helmet fix may not find the converted headparts to attach to. → [Performance](#)
- `Generic Synthesis Patcher` is a footgun in this list because the rule engine will apply to records already covered by the named patchers. Keep its ruleset empty until a specific conflict is identified. → [Performance](#)
- `SynStringMerger` will produce a translation patch that other patchers do not see. Disable it unless the list ships a translation layer. → [Performance](#)
- `NavmeshCollector-Updated` is dangerous with `Bruma` and `Falskaar`. Do not enable it while those worldspace mods are active. → [Performance](#)
- The `Bashed Patch` CRC should be recorded in the build log and re-checked after every rebuild. → [Performance](#)
- The `Synthesis` patcher list must match the stage ordering, with patchers from unused stages explicitly disabled (not removed) so they can be re-enabled without re-reading config. → [Performance](#)
- Verify `Bashed Patch` behavior by deliberately disabling source mods and confirming the patch shrinks predictably. → [Performance](#)
- Every `Tweak Settings` entry should be verified with a save-load test before being considered stable. → [Performance](#)

Key Principles

- The patch pipeline is the single source of truth for conflict resolution across the load order.
- A patcher or tag exists in this file because a specific mod in the list requires it — never pre-install speculative coverage.
- The rebuild order is designed so that a category change only triggers the affected stages, not the entire pipeline.

FILE: modlist-performance-testing.md

Testing & Maintenance

MO2 Separator: [Performance](#)

Part of the [Performance](#) and [Technical Workflow](#) section. See also: [14a](#) (Performance Strategy), [14b](#) (Optimization & Configuration), [14c](#) (Tool Pipeline), [14d](#) (Bashed Patch & Synthesis).

Performance Testing And Tuning

Performance tuning is iterative. The goal is consistent frametimes — not just a high average FPS — across the scenarios you actually play.

Tools

Tool	Purpose
NVIDIA FrameView	Lightweight overlay and logging for FPS, frametime, GPU power, thermals. No CPU per-core stats, but lower overhead than Afterburner.
MSI Afterburner + RivaTuner Statistics Server	Full overlay and logging: FPS, frametime, GPU usage, CPU per-core, VRAM, draw calls, temps.
GPU-Z	Sensor logging for GPU clock, voltage, thermals, power limits.
Community Shaders debug overlay	Built-in performance stats — press <code>F11</code> (default) in-game to toggle render-time breakdown, draw-call count, and VRAM usage from the CS pipeline.
SSE Display Tweaks OSD	Built-in overlay — set <code>ShowOSD=true</code> in <code>SSEDisplayTweaks.ini</code> for basic FPS/frametime without RTSS.
Skyrim console tools	<code>showstats</code> toggles a real-time stat overlay. <code>sgtm 0.3</code> slows the game to 30% speed for inspecting stutter frames. <code>tfc 1</code> freezes the camera.
Cathedral Assets Optimizer	Downscale uncompressed or oversized textures for VRAM relief.

Benchmark Methodology

1. **Create a stable reference save** — start a clean save with a fixed weather (`fw 10a240` for clear skies), a fixed time (`set gamehour to 12`), and `tfc 1` for reproducible screenshots. Save it as `benchmark_ref.ess`.
2. **Use fixed routes** — do not free-roam during benchmarks. Load the same save, follow the same path for 60 seconds, record the results.
3. **Log everything** — use MSI Afterburner's hardware logging (or NVIDIA FrameView's CSV logging) to capture GPU usage %, VRAM, CPU per-core usage, frametime 99th percentile, and power draw.
4. **Test one change at a time** — change one setting, reload the same save, re-run the same route. No multi-variable tests.

Benchmark Scenarios

Use these console commands to reach each scenario from a clean save, then run the 60-second route:

Scenario	Location	Teleport	What It Tests
Open world (general)	Whiterun plains west	<code>cow WhiterunWorld -10 0</code>	General GPU/CPU balance, grass density, LOD load

Scenario	Location	Teleport	What It Tests
Dense forest	Falkreath woods	<code>cow FalkreathWorld -30 -20</code>	Tree rendering, shadow complexity, grass LOD
Pine-and-marsh transition	Morthal swamp edge	<code>cow HjaalmarchWorld -15 -10</code>	Wetland shaders, mist particles, mixed tree/flora density
City centre (canals)	Riften marketplace	<code>cow RiftenWorld 0 0</code>	NPC count, script load, water reflections, interior/exterior transitions
City centre (castles)	Solitude exterior	<code>cow SolitudeWorld 0 0</code>	Large static-mesh draw calls, castle shadow cascades, skybox occlusion
Snowy tundra	Dawnstar coast	<code>cow WinterholdWorld 10 5</code>	Snow shader coverage, volumetric fog, low-visibility weather transition
Waterfall-heavy coast	Coast near Solitude	<code>cow Tamriel -22 -4</code>	Water displacement, foam particles, Natural Waterfalls, coastal LOD
Large interior	Blackreach	<code>cow Blackreach 0 0</code>	Particle lights, mesh density, alpha sorting
Large combat	Fort Neugrad assault	<code>cow WhiterunWorld 15 -5</code> then run toward the fort	AI packages, magic FX, simultaneous actor rendering
Dragon encounter	Set dragon encounter	<code>player.placeatme 000FEA9F</code> on an open-world save	Large-creature skeleton, shout/breath VFX, cell transition
Magic VFX stress	Dense combat + spells	<code>cow WhiterunWorld 0 0</code> then <code>player.placeatme 000FEA9F + player.placeatme 0001F1A</code> (fire mage) x3	Simultaneous particle systems, glow shaders, screen-space shadows
Heavy weather	Solstheim ash storm	<code>cow SolstheimWorld 0 0</code> with <code>fw 10A1E8</code>	Particle effects, alpha-heavy weather, volumetric fog

Record these metrics per scenario:

- **Average FPS** — how the GPU handles the scene overall.
- **Frametime 99th percentile** — the stutter floor; anything over ~50ms (20 FPS) means visible hitches.
- **GPU usage %** — below 90% means the CPU is the bottleneck (too many draw calls, script load, or single-thread limits).
- **VRAM usage** — if within 500MB of your card's total, expect stutter on cell transitions.
- **Draw calls** — above ~10,000 in a single frame means the CPU will start struggling regardless of GPU.

Tuning Knobs (Ordered By Impact)

Tune in this order. Stop once the worst-case scenario is playable.

1. **Grass density** (BethINI > Environment > Grass Density). 40-60 is the range. The single biggest performance lever.
2. **Grass render distance** (BethINI > View Distance > Grass LOD Fade). Drop from the High preset default to **50-70** for immediate gains in forested areas.
3. **Shadow resolution** (BethINI > Visuals > Shadow Resolution). 2048 is the sweet spot; 4096 costs ~15% GPU in outdoor scenes for marginal visual gain at 4K.
4. **Particle count** (BethINI > Visuals > Max Particle Render Count). 7500 is the baseline; drop to 5000 if fire/frost/storm magic causes framedrops.
5. **Tree LOD distance** — `fTreeLoadDistance=0` via INI Editor (already done for DynDOLOD). Keep at 0 — DynDOLOD manages this.
6. **Object LOD fade** (BethINI > View Distance > Object LOD Fade). Drop `fMeshLODLevel12FadeTreeDistance` from default to **6144** and `fMeshLODLevel11FadeTreeDistance` to **8192** if tree pop-in is not the primary visual concern.
7. **VSync / framerate cap** — use **SSE Display Tweaks** for a locked framerate (60 FPS for 60Hz, 72/90/120 for high-refresh displays) rather than the engine's built-in VSync. Set `LockFrameRate=60` and `VSynC=0` in `SSEDisplayTweaks.ini`.
8. **Skyrim Upscaler** — if the GPU is the bottleneck and resolution scaling is acceptable, enable **Skyrim Upscaler - DLSS FSR2 XeSS** (<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspicedition/mods/80343>) with Quality preset.

When To Accept The Result

- Occasional microstutter on cell border crossing is normal (Engine Fixes already mitigates the worst of it).
- Combat in tight spaces with 6+ actors + magic VFX will always be heavier than open-world traversal — if average FPS stays above 40 in those moments with no hitch above 100ms, call it stable.
- If a specific mod (city overhaul, tree replacement, CS preset) cuts FPS by 30%+ compared to its alternative in the same branch, consider swapping rather than tuning around it.

Benchmark Reports

Turn raw logs into a visual comparison report.

CSV Export (Any Logging Tool)

Export your benchmark session to CSV. Both **NVIDIA FrameView** ([Save CSV](#) button) and **MSI Afterburner** ([History > Log to file](#)) produce CSV with consistent column headers. Name each CSV by scenario and run number (e.g., [whiterun_grass50_run1.csv](#)). Keep a [baseline/](#) subfolder with the first run's CSVs.

Comparison Table (Markdown, For Git Tracking)

Keep a [benchmark-sheet.md](#) in the repo that records each tuning pass:

Pass	Scenario	Avg FPS	1% Low	GPU%	VRAM	Hitch Max	Delta vs Prev
1	Whiterun	58	42	92%	6.1G	48ms	—
2	Whiterun	55	38	88%	6.0G	62ms	-3 / -4

Every tuning attempt is recorded in git alongside the modlist changes.

Maintenance And Rebuild Epilogue

The load order is not static. Mods update, new mods replace old recommendations, and patchers must be re-run when the input state changes.

Patcher Revisit Triggers

Patcher	Trigger To Re-run	Settings Worth Tweaking
LOOT	Every meaningful load-order change	No custom tweaks — keep LOOT as the sort authority.
Synthesis	When any mod it patches is added, removed, or updated. Always re-run after: new weapon/armor packs, leveled-list changes, NPC overhauls, music stack changes	Weapon Stat Synthesis Patcher — raise/lower Damage Ceiling if combat pacing feels too fast or too slow during survival-difficulty playthroughs. Add new plugins to Ignore List when hand-authored artifacts from a new quest mod should not be normalized. Revisit the patcher pipeline order if new patchers are added.
Wrye Bash	When a leveled-list-heavy mod is added or removed. Only if a Bashed Patch is still part of the strategy.	No settings worth changing per-run. If the Bashed Patch starts pulling in unintended imports, switch to manually merged leveled lists instead.
Pandora	After any animation mod is added, removed, or reordered. After any skeleton or behavior-file change.	No end-user settings. Keep the output directed to Pandora Output .
BodySlide	After body preset, skin texture, armor mod, or outfit changes.	No per-run settings beyond the chosen preset.
Grass Cache	After grass mod, tree mod, landscape texture, or worldspace changes. Any grass-density INI tweak invalidates the cache.	Rebuild from scratch rather than patching.
xLODGen	After landscape texture, heightmap, or worldspace changes. After terrain LOD mod changes.	Quality slider can be raised per-run if coastline/water-edge artefacts appear.
TexGen	After any texture change to objects, trees, or buildings that produces LOD billboards. After tree-mod swaps.	Revisit GrassModelHeightMultiplier and TreeMSAlphaThreshold if tree or grass billboards look wrong.
DynDOLOD	After any worldspace mod, tree mod, large-reference mod, or LOD resource change. After TexGen output changes.	Brightness and Contrast for LOD32 can be dialled per-run if the distant world looks washed out or too dark. DoubleSidedTextureMask needs updating if new mountain/mesh types are added.

Generator Output Order

Run generators in this order after the load order and patches are stable:

1. **Pandora** — after the animation stack stabilizes.
2. **BodySlide** — after body and armor changes stabilize.
3. **Synthesis** — patchers the final stack actually uses.
4. **Wrye Bash** — only if a Bashed Patch is still warranted.
5. **Grass Cache** — after final grass/tree/worldspace choices stabilize.
6. **xLODGen** — terrain LOD first.
7. **TexGen** — before DynDOLOD.
8. **DynDOLOD** — last.
9. **Occlusion** — only if needed on the first real DynDOLOD run.

After generation, verify plugin placement: [DynDOLOD.esm](#) at end of ESM block, [DynDOLOD.esp](#) near end of load order, [Occlusion.esp](#) after [DynDOLOD.esp](#), and [Synthesis.esp](#) / [Bashed Patch](#) where their tool guidance says.

Change Tracking

Keep a `changelog.txt` or `build-notes.md` inside the `Output` separator that records:

- Date and scope of each generator re-run.
- Settings that differed from the baseline guide.
- Branch choices that changed.
- Any manual INI tweaks applied per-generator.
- The reference-save used for post-change verification.

MCM Settings Recording

MCM configuration is tedious to reproduce on a rebuild. Record every meaningful MCM page:

1. **Screenshot each MCM page** — open each mod's MCM, page through every tab, and screenshot. Store screenshots in a folder named `MCM-Reference` under the `Output` separator.
2. **Use MCM Recorder** (<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/24113>) — records and replays MCM settings via JSON profiles. Install as a utility mod, open each MCM once with recording enabled, and save the profiles alongside the screenshots.
3. **Cross-check on rebuild** — replay each MCM profile after mods are installed but before generating final patches. Tick off recorded profiles against the screenshot folder to catch any mods that added or lost settings pages.

Mod Update Workflow

1. Read the mod's changelog before updating. Do not blindly overwrite.
2. If the update is a minor version with no record or script changes, replace in-place and re-run LOOT.
3. If the update touches records, scripts, or dependencies, treat it as a new install — disable old version, install new, run LOOT, check xEdit conflicts, and re-run affected patchers.
4. Never update DynDOLOD, TexGen, or xLODGen mid-playthrough without verifying the output is functionally identical. When in doubt, start a new game after LOD regeneration.

Playing Forward

The modlist's branch-and-choice structure means two installations of `Elder Wilds` can look quite different while following the same guide. The rule: **whatever you changed, note it, and re-run only the patchers whose upstream input changed**. You do not need to re-run all generators every time you tweak a setting.

FILE: separators.md

Modlist Separators

Flat separator names sorted by MO2 left-pane load order. Parent categories anchor the hue; sub-separators step up in lightness for visible differentiation.

Foundations (blue)

```
-#1a3a6b Foundations-
-#255792 Foundations – SKSE & Scripts-
-#3173b8 Foundations – Core Libraries-
-#4a8fd4 Foundations – Mesh & Texture Fixes-
-#6aaae8 Foundations – Targeted Bugfixes-
```

Graphics (green)

```
-#0d4a0d Graphics-
-#196a19 Graphics – PGPatcher-
-#268a26 Graphics – Community Shaders-
-#35a835 Graphics – Textures & Meshes-
-#46c446 Graphics – Lighting-
-#59d859 Graphics – Weather & Water-
-#70e870 Graphics – Terrain & Flora-
-#88f088 Graphics – Characters & Creatures-
-#a2f5a2 Graphics – LOD & Distant Detail-
```

UI (cyan/teal)

```
-#1b5a68 UI-
-#2a7c8c UI – Framework & HUD-
-#3e9eb0 UI – Inventory & Items-
-#5cbcc9 UI – Map, Dialogue, Menu-
```

Animations (red-orange)

```
-#7a1a0a Animations-
-#962d18 Animations – Framework-
```

- #b44328 Animations – Movement & Idles-
- #d05c3a Animations – Combat-
- #e47850 Animations – Interactions & Traversal-
- #ea9870 Animations – Creatures-

Third-Person (amber/gold)

- #7a5010 Third-Person-
- #926a20 Third-Person – Camera & Movement-
- #aa8430 Third-Person – Combat & Targeting-
- #c4a044 Third-Person – Mounted-

Expanded Systems (purple)

- #3a1070 Expanded Systems-
- #52258a Expanded Systems – Character & Progression-
- #6c3aa6 Expanded Systems – Magic & Perks-
- #8759bf Expanded Systems – Survival & Needs-
- #a27cd4 Expanded Systems – Crafting & Economy-
- #bba0e6 Expanded Systems – Followers & Reputation-

World Feel (brown/amber)

- #6b3a10 World Feel-
- #875020 World Feel – Timescale & Travel-
- #a56830 World Feel – Soundscapes-
- #c08448 World Feel – Nights & Wildlife-
- #d4a264 World Feel – Cities & Landmarks-

World Content (olive green)

- #4a6b18 World Content-
- #608722 World Content – Overhauls-
- #78a530 World Content – Quests-
- #90ba48 World Content – Homes & Bases-
- #aacf6a World Content – Underwater-

NPCs (rose)

- #7a1a3a NPCs-
- #98284e NPCs – Appearance-
- #b83864 NPCs – Enemies & Creatures-
- #d05280 NPCs – Population-
- #e2759c NPCs – Followers-

Audio (royal blue)

- #1e2a8a Audio-
- #3a4abc Audio – Music-
- #5a70d4 Audio – SFX & Ambience-

Survival & Combat (red)

- #6b1010 Survival & Combat-
- #8a1e1e Survival & Combat – Difficulty & Lethality-
- #a82e2e Survival & Combat – Enemy AI-
- #c25050 Survival & Combat – Resources & Injuries-

Standalone separators

- #C49A31 Legacy of the Dragonborn-
- #808080 Testing & Curation-
- #2F937A Performance-
- #A52786 Adult Content-
- #49389F Voicing-
- #6B6B6B Patches-
- #474747 Output-